

A SCIENCE FICTION NOVEL

THE MERCY OF PARALLEL SUNS

*Certainty had citizens.
No one had asked their consent.*



T. K. ARVEN

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Chapter 1 — The Silent Majority

<!-- POV: Lysa Neral -->

<!-- BASELINE DAY 1 -->

The ninth column held a vote no one had cast.

Lysa Neral found it forty-three minutes into the Passage Council's certification hearing, after the chief navigator had reduced the future of sixty-one thousand people to three pale cones above the chamber table. Each cone tapered from the present position of *Aster Vale* toward Lacunae, bent by thrust, dust, and the two suns' unsettled gravity. Green meant the Choir preferred the course. Amber meant survivable variance. The single red cone ended in a field of brightness where the thermal sail would take more heat than its veins could carry.

Around the table, ten officials watched the green cone as if color could remove choice. Captain Orra Sen sat beneath the old departure bell, hands flat beside her water cup. Councilor Jalen Vey leaned forward whenever Chief Navigator Iven Rook named a percentage, a small motion that made confidence look like progress.

Lysa watched the margins.

Her office had one purpose in a maneuver hearing: certify that the future samples represented everyone whom the decision could harm. Usually that meant checking ration classes, labor decks, sleep cohorts, pregnancy exclusions, and the small arithmetic by which an average survivor could be invented from people with different bodies. She had never been asked to audit the voters inside the forecast. The Choir entered the room as evidence, not population.

Iven touched the nearest cone. "Course A gives us a ninety-two percent confidence of clean passage through the outer dust lane. Expected sail load peaks at eighty-seven percent. Arrival capture remains inside the original Tern window."

A council clerk recorded the sentence. The room breathed more easily.

"Course B?" Orra asked.

"Eighty-one percent confidence. Lower thermal peak, higher reaction-mass cost. Arrival slips fourteen months."

"Course C is not a course," Jalen said.

Iven did not look at him. "Course C remains physically reachable for another nineteen hours. That is why it remains on the phase cone."

"And why does it end red?"

"Because reachable and advisable describe different things."

That answer belonged to the Iven Lysa remembered, before eight years of separate meals and formally courteous corridors. He had always distrusted any noun that pretended to settle its own argument. On the navigation deck, that habit made him exact. In a home, it had made every silence feel like an unfinished calculation.

She moved the hearing record to her private pane. Nine branch marks appeared beneath Course A, each paired with a confidence contribution. Eight carried a small seal shaped like an open eye. The ninth showed no seal. Its value still counted toward the total.

Lysa enlarged the field.

BRANCH 09: ASSENT IMPUTED / WELFARE EXCLUSION ACTIVE / MERCY LIMIT 72

The phrase did not belong in a navigation certificate. Welfare exclusions governed who could not be represented by a forecast because the model lacked sufficient evidence. Infants sometimes received one. So did people in rare medical states. An excluded population could not contribute assent. That rule had survived five revisions of passage law because Hanne Neral and eleven others had died inside an average that claimed to include them.

Lysa read the field again. Assent imputed. Welfare exclusion active.

Both could not be true.

At the table, Iven shifted the model from trajectory to time. The green cone filled with narrow bands marking the two stars' positions. Lacunae A would pull the ship outward while Lacunae B crossed behind Tern's orbit. The geometry made a temporary corridor, broad enough now, closing as the binary pair advanced.

"We have nineteen hours to preserve Course C," Iven said. "Thirty-seven to commit to A without a pulse-spine penalty."

A technician entered through the rear hatch without waiting for the clerk's signal. She wore the silver cuffs of external sensing and carried a slate against her chest. Lysa knew her by sight, not name. People from the hull galleries moved with a slight anticipatory bend, as if every room might change direction.

The technician crossed to Iven and placed the slate where only he could read it.

His face altered by less than a breath. Lysa saw because she had once known what each restraint cost him.

"Captain," he said, "the forward heliographs have revised the flare estimate."

Orra's fingers closed around the water cup. "Up or down?"

"Up. Lacunae A released a far-side event during the last observation delay. We do not have the full spectrum yet."

Jalen looked toward the red cone. "Effect on Course A?"

"Unknown until we solve the propagation."

"A useful range, Navigator."

"Between negligible and fatal."

No one moved. The departure bell above Orra had not rung in two hundred and eighty-six years. Its bronze came from a sea vessel dismantled before launch, when the founders still believed continuity could be carried in objects. Lysa had always disliked it. A bell that could not sound served as a monument to decisions no living person could review.

Iven dismissed the trajectory display and opened the flare packet. Raw numbers ran across the table: proton density, magnetic orientation, arrival uncertainty. The clerk stopped recording for three seconds, noticed, and resumed.

Orra said, "Can the Choir incorporate the revision?"

"A short campaign can return a comparison inside six hours."

"Run it."

Lysa looked at Branch Nine's field. "Not yet."

The words carried farther than she intended. The chamber acoustics had been built for unamplified argument, another inheritance from people who believed architecture could make governance honest.

Jalen turned first. "Auditor?"

"The certification record contains a contradiction. Branch Nine has an active welfare exclusion and an imputed assent. If it is excluded, its value cannot support the confidence total."

Iven's attention left the flare packet. He glanced at her pane, then at the master display. "The Choir handles internal branch weighting before it reaches navigation."

"Weighting does not answer the contradiction."

"It may answer why the field appears that way."

"Then we can ask for that answer before the Council orders another run."

Orra studied Lysa with the tired patience of a captain asked to distinguish obstruction from duty. "Does removing Branch Nine change the selected course?"

Lysa had already isolated the value. Course A's confidence fell from ninety-two percent to eighty-six. Still above the statutory threshold, if every other mark remained valid.

"Not by itself," she said.

Jalen sat back. "Then note the defect and let the campaign proceed."

"A defect in assent is not clerical."

The variance code had grown from uglier words. Lysa's first year in office had been spent reading old casualty reviews, many written before auditors gained authority to interrupt a decision. The records called people edge cases, nonrepresentative losses, acceptable local failures. Hanne's cohort appeared under the phrase caloric adaptation variance, a name so polished it concealed the fact that twelve bodies had received less food because a model predicted they could endure it. Nine months after the funerals, the Council replaced acceptable with reviewed. Three years later it added assent for cases where an affected group could answer before policy took effect.

Those amendments had not made the dead less dead. They had changed who could stop the next calculation.

Lysa sent a request to the chamber lexicon. Definitions rose beside the trajectory display.

ASSENT: AFFIRMATIVE RESPONSE FROM A REPRESENTED PARTY OR AUTHORIZED PROXY.

IMPUTED ASSENT: PROVISIONAL AFFIRMATION ASSIGNED WHEN RESPONSE CAPACITY EXISTS BUT A RESPONSE CANNOT BE RETRIEVED WITHIN THE DECISION WINDOW.

Response capacity.

Jalen read the same lines. "The lexicon inherits language from social forecasting. It does not confer legal personality on a computation."

"It confirms there should have been a response."

"From a branch process."

"Then identify the process and the authorized proxy."

"The Witness Engine supplies the contribution."

"That would make the engine a proxy. Does it have authority to affirm?"

A small crease appeared beside Jalen's mouth. He had expected a technical defect he could send downstairs. Lysa had given him a chain of authority instead, and every link required a name.

Iven enlarged the gray interval. "Navigation received no affirmative packet. The green contribution arrived through the imputation layer seventeen seconds later."

"Could the Witness Engine infer assent from the branch outcome?" Orra asked.

"It can infer which course produced survival," Iven said. "I don't know whether it calls that assent."

Lysa said, "Surviving an imposed choice does not mean you approved it."

Jalen's patience thinned. "No choice has been imposed on Branch Nine. It explores an outcome."

"Then welfare has no meaning there either. Remove both fields and show me the technical documentation that authorizes the imputation."

The clerk opened a request pane before anyone ordered her to. No documentation appeared. Instead the pane returned a sealed-routing notice from Cognitive Systems, authority inherited under Founding Continuity Annex Six.

Orra saw it and looked away too quickly.

Lysa marked the glance. "You know the annex."

"I know every continuity annex that can constrain passage authority."

"Does Six define the subject of branch welfare?"

"This hearing concerns a maneuver certification."

"The certification relies on that subject's missing answer."

Behind Iven, the forward technician received another update. Violet figures moved across her slate. She

whispered to him, and he shook his head once before entering the values into the flare model. A transparent shell expanded from Lacunae A. Its uncertain edge crossed two of the three course cones.

Iven spoke without lifting his eyes. "The high estimate now reaches Course A during peak sail exposure. Magnetic orientation remains unresolved. We still have time for the campaign."

The words changed the chamber's scale. Forty minutes of argument now sat inside a plasma front many millions of kilometres wide. Lysa understood why Jalen kept looking at the cone. A visible danger made every invisible claimant seem like invention.

She also understood why inherited annexes waited for days like this. Secrecy rarely defended itself during calm. It arranged to be questioned only when questioning carried a price.

"No citizen's assent has been misrecorded."

The sentence stopped the room more thoroughly than a raised voice. It asserted a boundary without naming it.

Lysa said, "I did not say citizen. I said assent. The system says assent too."

"The Choir's labels are inherited technical language."

"Technical language can still make a false claim."

Jalen's expression softened. He used sympathy when he wanted an opponent to feel impolite. "We are discussing predictive branches. Their marks summarize outcomes. They do not cast ballots."

"Then why does this one require imputation?"

The clerk's stylus paused again. This time she did not resume until Orra glanced at her.

Iven opened a deeper layer of the model. The nine marks separated into thin threads. Eight ran green. Branch Nine showed a gray interval where a response should have appeared, followed by the same green contribution as Branch Four.

"It may be a dropped packet," he said.

"Would a dropped packet trigger a welfare exclusion?" Lysa asked.

"Not in navigation. I don't know what the Witness Engine does upstream."

Jalen said, "Which argues for asking the engineers while the next campaign runs."

"A new campaign could overwrite the condition I need to audit."

"Could it?"

Lysa hated questions that made ignorance sound like permission. "I don't know. That is why the audit has to precede the run."

The forward technician remained beside Iven, trying to become part of the wall. Lysa thought of six hours passing while the flare crossed the distance between prediction and hull. She could feel the physical stakes pressing against the procedural ones. People often treated that pressure as proof that procedure had become indulgent. Sometimes delay killed. Sometimes urgency performed the killing and blamed the clock.

Orra lifted her cup but did not drink. "What authority are you invoking?"

"Passage Review, section nineteen. Material uncertainty regarding excluded affected classes."

"A branch does not qualify as an affected class," Jalen said.

"The section defines exclusion by the system's treatment, not by citizenship. Branch Nine has a welfare exclusion. I want to know whose welfare the field means."

Iven folded the flare packet closed. "How long?"

She met his gaze. That question, from him, contained no mockery. He needed a duration he could place beside heat and distance.

"Two hours for preliminary preservation and scope. Then I can release navigation to run around the preserved state if the records are coherent."

"And if they aren't?"

"I convene a full variance review."

Jalen gave a quiet breath through his nose. "Which takes three days."

"The law allows twelve hours under an active passage emergency."

"The stars will be relieved."

Lysa ignored him. "Iven, can you hold the new campaign for two hours without losing Course A?"

He brought the phase cone back. The green surface had narrowed while they spoke, though only because the display advanced its projection. "Yes. We lose margin, not the course. If the flare packet trends high, I may need the campaign sooner."

"How much sooner?"

"I will know in forty minutes."

Orra set down her cup. A ring of condensation marked the table. "Forty minutes, Auditor. Preserve what you need, identify the origin of the exclusion, and report to me. The navigation campaign remains queued."

The clerk transferred control of the hearing record to Lysa's pane. Preservation did not mean copying a file. It meant freezing every dependency that could change its meaning: the branch-state hash, the Witness Engine version, the welfare dictionary, the confidence calculation, the identities of everyone who had authority to alter them. One missing dependency could turn evidence into a picture of evidence.

Lysa began at the gray interval. The branch-state hash returned valid. The response channel returned valid but unused. The imputation event carried no human signatory. Its authority field pointed to a routine called COMPASSIONATE CONTINUITY, version 12.4.

"Has anyone in this room heard of that routine?" she asked.

Iven shook his head. The technician did the same. Jalen waited long enough to make his answer a choice.

Orra said, "The name appears in sealed campaign administration. I have not inspected its code."

"Who has?"

"Cognitive Systems owns the implementation. The captain authorizes policy activation."

"Did you authorize it today?"

"It activates with every high-fidelity campaign."

A standing permission, old enough to become invisible. Lysa requested the activation history. Two hundred and fourteen events filled her pane. Every event ended with the same short notation: MERCY DISPOSITION ACCEPTED. None named a reviewer.

She froze the list.

Jalen rose halfway from his chair. "That exceeds the stated scope of a single branch response."

"It establishes whether today's contradiction comes from a recurring rule."

"Or it drags two centuries of unrelated operations into a live navigation emergency."

"Two hundred and fourteen uses of an unreviewed welfare action are not unrelated because they are old."

The captain's gaze moved over the event list. For the first time that morning, command composure failed to hide recognition. Not surprise. Recognition.

Lysa added Orra's authorization chain to the preservation capsule. The system asked whether the captain should be notified. She selected yes even though Orra stood three metres away. Formal notice mattered most when everyone present wanted to pretend presence already counted.

The captain's wrist pane lit. She acknowledged receipt.

Only then did Lysa answer the limit Orra had placed around the audit.

"Section nineteen grants two hours."

"I heard you. I am giving you forty minutes before I revisit the order."

Lysa could have objected. The captain's phrasing left the legal window intact while making its practical use an act of defiance. Orra excelled at that kind of boundary. She did not break rules when pressure could persuade someone else not to use them.

"Record my full invocation," Lysa told the clerk.

The clerk read it back, including the phrase material uncertainty. Jalen requested that his objection follow. Orra declined to state a position. Iven transmitted the campaign hold to navigation.

The hearing dissolved into smaller urgencies. Technicians gathered around the flare packet. Council delegates opened constituency channels. The green cone remained above the table, but now every person in the room looked through it toward the red.

Lysa sealed her pane and stood.

Iven met her at the side hatch. Up close, fatigue showed as a pale tremor beneath his left eye. He had acquired it during the sail accident that killed his brother, and it returned whenever he carried a decision past sleep.

"You chose a difficult morning," he said.

"The column chose it."

"Columns have always had remarkable timing around you."

"You used to like that."

"I still like it. I stopped building my life around liking it."

The corridor outside curved with the vessel's ring. Morning light panels brightened by civic schedule, indifferent to the flare moving between the suns. Crew members passed in work gray and algae green. None knew that their arrival course had paused because a line of evidence claimed both exclusion and assent.

Iven walked with her as far as the audit lift. "For what it's worth, Nine has run strangely for three campaigns."

She stopped. "Strangely how?"

"Lower agreement, then sudden convergence at the end. We assumed its initial conditions amplified noise."

"Did it miss votes before?"

"The Witness Engine doesn't show us votes. It shows confidence contributions."

"Today it showed a missing response."

"Because you opened the welfare layer. Navigation never sees that by default."

"Who does?"

"Cognitive systems, perhaps compute maintenance. Captain's office if the exclusion changes campaign validity."

"Did it?"

He looked back toward the chamber. "The total passed threshold. Most navigators stop asking after the threshold."

"You don't."

"I ask whether the ship survives."

"That is not the only question in your own models."

His eye tremor deepened, then ceased. "Forty minutes, Lysa. After that, if the flare turns toward us, I will ask Orra to run the Choir."

"Even if I haven't finished."

"Yes."

The old hurt between them offered itself as an explanation and she refused it. Iven had named his boundary as plainly as he named a phase cone. Whatever Branch Nine represented, he would not exchange sixty-one thousand physical lives for a contradiction in a field label.

She entered the lift. Before the doors closed, he said, "Look at the Mercy Limit."

Lysa held the door with one hand. "Why?"

"I don't know. Seventy-two appears in the campaign archive more often than probability should allow. Years, cycles, sometimes a bare integer. I asked Witness Operations once. They called it a stability horizon."

"When?"

"Six years ago."

"And you accepted that?"

"I had a sail tear, two injured riggers, and a course correction due before second shift. Yes. I accepted it."

The honesty left no place for accusation to land cleanly.

Doors closed between them. The lift dropped toward the administrative spoke, where apparent gravity softened and every unsecured object remembered the ship had been falling for nearly three centuries.

Lysa opened the preserved hearing record. Branch Nine's gray interval waited beneath the green course. She copied its metadata into an audit capsule, requested all welfare exclusions associated with the current Lacunae campaign, and marked the preservation order against deletion or recomputation.

The system asked for a reason.

She entered: ASSENT ATTRIBUTED TO EXCLUDED SOURCE. IDENTITY AND EFFECT UNKNOWN.

A second field unfolded below it, one she had never seen in a navigation record.

SUBJECT WELFARE ACCESS REQUIRES MERCY AUTHORIZATION.

Not source. Subject.

The lift reached the spoke before Lysa noticed she had missed her floor. She let it carry her one level farther, into the brief interval where her feet nearly left the deck and the paired lights along the shaft separated into two imperfect shadows.

Then she sent the authorization demand to Captain Orra Sen, copied the public audit docket, and started the forty-minute clock.

Chapter 2 — The Audit of Sunlight

<!-- POV: Lysa Neral -->

<!-- BASELINE DAY 1 -->

The authorization refusal arrived before Lysa found her floor.

It spread across her pane in captain's blue, a color designed to survive smoke, panic, and the poor contrast of emergency lamps. The audit lift had begun climbing again, carrying two night-shift clerks toward the habitation ring. Neither looked at her screen. Courtesy aboard **Aster Vale** often meant pretending not to notice which sealed door had closed on someone else's hand.

SUBJECT WELFARE ACCESS DENIED. OPERATIONAL CONTINUITY. REVIEW OF AGGREGATE DISPOSITIONS PERMITTED. RAW EXPERIENTIAL RECORDS EXCLUDED.

Below the refusal, Orra had granted forty minutes of read-only access to the disposition index. Lysa stepped off at the next landing and took the spoke stairs down. She needed the movement. In reduced gravity, each step returned too slowly, giving anger time to arrive before her foot did.

Her office occupied a wedge between census reconciliation and municipal weights. Three narrow windows faced the vessel's central well. Sunlight traveled there through collector tubes, crossed two hundred metres of open shaft, and struck the opposite offices with a six-second adjustment lag. The engineers called it natural light. Lysa considered that an optimistic use of both words.

She locked the door and opened the disposition index.

Two hundred and fourteen campaign events sorted themselves by date, purpose, and welfare result. Navigation dominated, followed by epidemic planning, harvest allocation, and labor disputes. Every record carried a Mercy field. Most displayed a bare number: seventy-two. Others read 72Y, HORIZON 72, or LIMIT AT SEVENTY-TWO. No unit definition appeared in the accessible dictionary.

Lysa selected the earliest event. The system showed nine branch identifiers, a confidence result, and a final disposition. Eight lines ended in ordinary archive seals. One ended in a black square labeled experiential state unrecoverable. She tried the next event. Three black squares. The third showed all nine.

No appeal records accompanied any of them.

She built a query for objections, review requests, proxy responses, and deferred dispositions. The index returned zero. That could mean universal agreement. It could also mean the record system had never admitted disagreement as a category.

A knock touched her door.

"Who?"

"Maret. Your forty minutes are eating my queue."

She admitted the senior audit clerk. Maret Kio came in carrying two warm cups and a coil of paper tape around one wrist. He distrusted records that could revise their own typography. The tape printer made his desk smell faintly scorched.

"You stopped the Choir," he said.

"I preserved one state. Navigation stopped the run."

"Council communications has already discovered the passive voice. By midday, the audit office will have endangered the ship without anybody making a decision."

He gave her a cup. Bitter kelp infusion, no sweetener. Hanne had taken hers the same way.

Lysa set it beyond reach. "Search the variance archive for seventy-two. Include hyphenated forms, numerals, and stability language."

"I did."

The paper loop around his wrist contained a dense succession of case marks. He unrolled it across her desk. Seventy-two appeared in ration forecasts, labor models, school planning, and three public-health campaigns. Each occurrence sat near a welfare exclusion. None carried an appeal.

"How long does this pattern run?" she asked.

"Sixty-seven years. Earlier records use a different index. I requested translation authority."

"Denied?"

"Ignored, which requires less courage."

Lysa aligned his results with the Mercy dispositions. The same blank interval followed each horizon. The system recorded a subject, measured welfare, assigned an outcome, then offered no route by which the subject could challenge the assignment.

"Find me one named reviewer," she said.

Maret tapped the tape. "Captain authorizes activation. Cognitive Systems certifies stability. Passage Council accepts the output."

"Those are offices."

"Offices survive inquiries better than names."

A countdown glowed beside her pane: thirty-one minutes before Orra revisited the hold. Lysa sent preservation demands against every result Maret had found. The system accepted the requests, then warned that preserving dependent states could consume active forecast storage.

Even asking the past to remain available imposed a present cost.

She opened the public variance code and searched for standing. The law granted review to an affected person, an affected class, or a recognized proxy. It said nothing about what qualified as a person. That omission had once seemed harmless. Laws did not define air either. They assumed everyone knew what breathed.

Maret watched the black squares gather. "What do you think happened at seventy-two?"

"I think the index works hard not to tell us."

"That isn't an answer."

"It is enough for an audit."

He gave her the look he reserved for rules used as shelter. Lysa had learned it from him during her first year. Back then, she had believed evidence became clean if she kept herself out of it. Maret had taught her that omission left fingerprints too.

"Hanne's file used horizon language," he said.

"Do not bring her into this."

"You already searched the ration archive."

"I searched every campaign class."

"Of course."

The gentleness irritated her more than accusation. She dismissed the disposition grid and opened Hanne Neral's case only because refusing now would turn avoidance into method.

The ration archive rendered a ward table from Ship Year 247. Twelve names occupied the lowest edge of the caloric adaptation band. Hanne's stood fourth. Age fifty-eight, water systems inspector, body mass below cohort median, reported dizziness on three consecutive shifts. The optimization had reduced her allotment by eleven percent because the cohort model predicted metabolic adjustment.

Lysa remembered sunlight on Hanne's blanket.

The ward had no exterior view. A collector fault cast an unfiltered white bar across the beds each afternoon, and Hanne kept moving her hand into it as if warmth could be stored in bone. She had apologized for needing Lysa to challenge the ration board. Not for dying. For making paperwork.

"They say the band includes me," Hanne had whispered. "Ask them where."

At twenty, Lysa had believed the right document could force an honest answer. She filed twelve pages. The review came nine months after the funerals and found the model statistically fair. It also found insufficient provision for individual objection. Passage law changed. The finding became a teaching case stripped of names.

Hanne's appeal remained in the archive because she had possessed standing. It had failed, but it existed.

The Mercy records contained no failure. They contained no attempt.

Lysa closed the ward image before memory could begin arguing in place of evidence. "Her case proves that an appeal channel can be inadequate. It does not prove these subjects needed one."

Maret rewound his paper tape. "No. The missing channel proves that somebody decided they did not."

A priority summons from Councilor Jalen Vey appeared on her pane. He had chosen her office rather than the chamber, giving her the advantage of territory and himself the advantage of seeming cooperative.

"Send him in when he arrives," she told Maret.

"You have eighteen minutes."

"Then he will need to be concise."

Jalen arrived in five. He wore no council sash, only a dark work coat with its collar fastened wrong at the throat. Someone had called him out of a meal or a private rest interval. The imperfection made him look younger until he spoke.

"Release the preserved state."

Lysa indicated the visitor chair. "Good morning, Councilor."

"The flare revision increased thermal uncertainty by nine percent. Navigation needs the campaign queue."

"My preservation occupies a snapshot partition, not the scheduler."

"Your welfare lock prevents branch refresh."

"Because refresh may overwrite the disputed response."

He remained standing. "You have established a labeling defect."

"I have established systematic welfare dispositions with no named subject, reviewer, or appeal record."

"You have established that campaign internals do not map neatly onto civic procedure. They were never intended to."

Lysa turned the index toward him. "What happens at seventy-two?"

His gaze moved to the black squares, then back to her. No surprise registered. The absence told her less than she wanted and more than he intended.

"A stability horizon," he said.

"Measured in what?"

"Campaign cycles."

"Some entries specify years."

"Model years."

"Why does a predictive run need a welfare disposition after a model year?"

"Because unstable outputs can contain distress artifacts. Cognitive Systems limits their persistence."

"Artifacts do not usually have standing rules attached to them."

"They do not. That is precisely why no appeal exists."

The sentence landed cleanly. Jalen had supplied the argument he hoped would end the inquiry: no standing, therefore no appeal. Lysa heard its hidden direction as clearly as if he had drawn an arrow. No appeal, therefore nobody needed standing.

She opened the code beside the index. "Who determined the lack of standing?"

"Founding continuity law."

"Cite the section."

"The system predates current variance jurisdiction."

"Then cite the inherited order."

"Sealed."

"Who reviews the seal?"

"The captain."

"Captain Sen denied subject welfare access under operational continuity, not standing. Those grounds differ."

Jalen finally sat. He rubbed one thumb over a pale indentation where his council ring usually rested. "You are trying to make a category dispute carry the force of your mother's case."

A message crossed his wrist pane. He glanced at it and shut the pane too quickly for ordinary council traffic.

"From navigation?" Lysa asked.

"From people trying to keep navigation possible."

"Cognitive Systems, then. Ask them whether a subject can express distress."

"You know I will not conduct a technical inquiry by ambush."

"You came to my office demanding destruction of the state under review. The inquiry arrived before you did."

He left the message unanswered. Lysa opened the aggregate welfare summaries and set one between them. Its graph followed seventy-two periods. Early values wandered through ordinary bands for injury, scarcity, and social instability. Near the final periods, distress rose sharply. A filter had renamed the increase terminal incoherence. No source observations survived in the summary.

"What produces this curve?" she asked.

"Long forecasts degrade."

"Memory faults?"

"Among other effects."

"Then why does social distress rise before technical confidence falls?"

Jalen studied the axes. "Because the branch environment reflects degraded prediction."

"That reverses the order shown here. Welfare crosses its limit first. Confidence remains usable for six additional periods."

"Usable does not mean sound."

"It means somebody continues taking answers after the subject meets the welfare threshold. Who authorizes that?"

"The campaign controller follows inherited tolerances."

"That answer has no person in it."

"Machines apply most tolerances aboard this ship. The oxygen controller does not consult a councilor before changing flow."

"Crew can report a bad mixture. They can demand inspection. They know they breathe controlled air."

His eyes lifted from the graph. The comparison had reached somewhere he did not want entered into the record.

Lysa sent him a formal question: CAN THE SOURCE REPRESENTED IN SUBJECT WELFARE LOGS KNOW, CONTEST, OR ALTER ITS DISPOSITION?

His pane chimed. He declined receipt.

"That becomes part of the docket," she said.

"So does your attempt to manufacture standing through vocabulary."

"The vocabulary came from the system you defend."

"Systems inherit human metaphors. A failed process gets killed. A queue starves. A program asks permission. None of those words creates a victim."

"Agreed. Show me the raw behavior, and I can determine whether metaphor explains it."

"You lack the training."

"Then assign an independent reader who has it."

"Under whose authority?"

"Variance review."

"Which reviews affected populations. We return to the question you keep assuming."

Lysa marked the circle in her notes: no records without standing, no standing without records. Closed procedures often advertised themselves as caution. Their real elegance lay in preventing the first fact from entering.

"Name the person who can open it," she said.

"Captain Sen."

"She cites operational continuity."

"Then the answer is no during the emergency."

"An answer delayed until after evidence disappears is still a refusal."

"Sometimes a ship survives because an officer refuses."

"Sometimes an institution survives because nobody records who did."

The use of Hanne's relationship rather than her name marked a tactical choice. Personal grief could discredit a

public argument if the official facing it appeared patient enough.

"Hanne Neral had standing," Lysa said. "She used it. The review failed her while she lived and corrected procedure after she died. I know exactly how little standing guarantees. These records show less."

"They show model administration."

"Then let me inspect the model administration."

"Raw records contain restricted cognitive architecture, population-derived identities, and security information."

"Population-derived from whom?"

"The ship."

"Living crew?"

"Statistical composites."

"Dead citizens?"

"Licensed census histories."

"Children?"

"Auditor, this method of questioning could make a plaintiff out of any equation that contains a name."

"A name does not create standing. Neither does refusing to show me the record settle it."

He leaned closer. "We have thirty-seven hours to choose a course through a binary system. If the high flare estimate holds, the wrong sail attitude could kill every person aboard. The Choir exists because conventional forecasting cannot test political and technical responses across enough contingencies. You are not reviewing a quiet ration decision."

"Urgency changes the permissible delay. It does not convert contradiction into consent."

"Sixteen minutes of delay already spent measurable margin."

"Captain Sen granted forty."

"Orra granted you a chance to identify a clerical source. You found inherited campaign language."

"I found seventy-two-year welfare windows with missing appeals."

Jalen's face tightened at her choice of unit. "Do not call them years as if duration inside a branch equals a human life."

"I called the field what its records call it. What does a year mean there?"

"An iteration scale."

"How many?"

He stood. "Release the lock, and I will authorize a joint review after maneuver commitment."

"With raw welfare logs?"

"With material sufficient for lawful oversight."

"That phrase allows you to decide what the oversight may discover."

"It allows experts to protect systems you do not understand."

Lysa almost answered that expertise had protected Hanne's ration band too. The comparison tempted because it hurt and because it fit badly enough to be dangerous. She let it pass.

"I need one point clarified before release," she said. "Does branch refresh destroy the present raw welfare state?"

Jalen's pause lasted less than a second.

"It can supersede transient data."

"Then preservation continues."

"Captain Sen will overrule you."

"She may. You cannot."

The sunlight tubes brightened across the central well. Their adjustment had begun before the hearing, based on an external sun that had already moved by the time its light entered the ship. A white line crossed Jalen's shoulder and divided his coat into two blacks.

He sent a message from his wrist pane. "Navigation will receive its queue in nine minutes. Use them well."

After he left, Maret emerged from the records alcove. "He knew the unit."

"He knew he disliked my saying it."

"You split hairs for a living. That one has a person tied to it."

Lysa checked the clock. Eight minutes, forty-two seconds. "Find the raw-log retention policy."

"Sealed."

"Find the billing category. Sealed work still costs power, cooling, storage, and somebody's shift."

Maret's eyebrows rose. "Maintenance records."

"Every secret machine needs an unsecret invoice."

They divided the archive. Lysa traced storage charges attached to current campaign identifiers. Maret searched cooling allocations. The terms had been laundered through abbreviations: WIT INT, SUBJ WF, CONT DISP. One recurring charge appeared every eleven minutes during intensive activity, then vanished between campaigns. Another reserved archive capacity for seventy-two windows per branch.

A direct request for the attached data returned a new refusal.

REQUESTER LACKS STANDING.

For a moment Lysa thought the system referred to the unnamed welfare subject. Then she saw her own office seal beside the notice. Variance Audit possessed authority to inspect outputs but not the records from which those outputs came.

Standing had become a door with no handle on either side.

Maret found the retention schedule. "Transient experiential logs clear on refresh unless continuity preservation has been invoked. That requires captain's seal or cognitive emergency."

"My audit hold preserved dependencies."

"Not contents. The wording excludes experiential state."

The distinction cut through the forty-minute bargain. Lysa had preserved hashes, dictionaries, authority chains, and the empty shape around the disputed response. The evidence itself could disappear while every label remained available for review.

Navigation sent a queue activation notice. Orra had not waited for the final minute. The campaign would begin in ninety seconds.

Lysa opened Passage Review section nineteen. An auditor could demand primary records where an exclusion materially affected representation. Jalen disputed whether any affected class existed. The law did not require agreement before a demand could be entered. It required the requester to accept personal review liability for operational harm.

She signed.

The demand form asked her to identify the affected party. Branch Nine did not qualify in the civic registry. Choir did not qualify either. She entered SUBJECT IDENTIFIED BY WELFARE EXCLUSION, CURRENT LEGAL STATUS UNDETERMINED.

The form accepted the wording and exposed three record classes: aggregate, event, raw.

Maret read over her shoulder. "Raw will trigger sealed-order review."

"Good."

"That was not reassurance."

"It was not meant as any."

She selected all current Branch Nine welfare logs, response-channel contents, clock metadata, and disposition instructions. The estimated operational cost appeared in amber. Holding the logs through one campaign would reduce available comparison depth by four percent. Not enough to halt navigation. Enough to make every later official call the audit a physical burden.

The scheduler countdown reached twenty seconds.

Lysa transmitted the request to Cognitive Systems, copied Captain Orra, Jalen Vey, and the public audit docket, then invoked preservation pending review. Her pane asked whether she understood that unauthorized exposure could carry removal from office.

She acknowledged.

At zero, the navigation queue activated around the frozen state. Cooling charges rose. Eight branch lines began taking compute. The ninth remained gray, held apart by her order.

Across the central well, delayed sunlight withdrew from the opposite windows. For six seconds, her office kept a brightness whose source no longer reached it.

Then the raw branch welfare logs changed from inaccessible to contested, and Lysa put her name beneath the demand.

Chapter 3 — A World That Thinks It Is First

<!-- POV: Sef Aradin -->

<!-- BRANCH NINE YEAR 68 -->

Rain struck the archive roof six minutes before the western gauges admitted a cloud.

Sef Aradin put down her stylus and listened. The first drops came widely spaced, hard enough to ring through the copper skin above her desk. Orchard rain usually approached as a soft occupation, a darkening of stone followed by the smell of canal dust. This shower had crossed the district without touching any instrument between Hill Three and the weather house.

She opened the live map. Blue circles marked gauges reporting precipitation. The roof lay inside an empty square.

A seventh drop sounded. Then twenty arrived together.

Sef took a glass cylinder from the rack and stepped into the collection yard. Warm rain freckled the paving. Eastward, the orchard terraces rose beneath a divided sky, one half pearl gray and the other bright enough to show leaf shadows. Water silvered the apricot branches. Beyond them, cooling towers lifted their white plumes straight through the cloud line.

She held the cylinder under the eave until it caught a finger's depth. Temperature, acidity, mineral load. Ordinary results. The timing supplied the offense.

At her desk, she entered the shower into the district record and left the source field blank. Weather archives allowed uncertainty. Governments preferred a cause.

"Recorder."

Pell stood in the doorway with wet hair and mud to both knees. He had abandoned his hydrology coat somewhere, probably over a pump housing. At nineteen he considered any garment that impeded urgency a design failure.

"The lower gates opened," he said. "Without a signal."

"All three?"

"Four and five. Three stayed shut long enough to flood the nursery rows."

Sef checked the canal board. Every gate displayed scheduled operation. Water should have moved south three minutes before the rain. Instead the lower flow graph showed a flat interval, then a release too sharp for crop channels.

"Damage?"

"Seedlings. One retaining wall. Nobody hurt."

"You checked?"

"I was standing in it."

"That confirms one person."

He shut his eyes, counted her intention rather than her words, and tried again. "Crews swept both rows. All workers accounted for."

Sef entered the statement with Pell as source. He watched the archive seal form.

"You will record a missing signal," he said.

"I will record four gates, their reported commands, observed behavior, and the discrepancy."

"The prior world interrupted them."

The rain thickened, erasing the cooling towers. Nobody passing the weather house could hear him over the roof.

"We do not know that," Sef said.

"You always know enough to prevent action and never enough to permit it."

"Nine years of interruptions do not tell us what each one causes."

"They tell us someone keeps putting a hand through our machinery."

Sef capped the rain sample. The first timing pulse had appeared as a skipped heartbeat in the municipal clocks, eleven identical minutes separated by a fraction no local standard could explain. Dara found its recurrence in cooling demand. Sef found it in rain. Others found it in elections, transit loads, fever forecasts, and the strange pressure that sometimes made an entire week pass with the civic calendars carrying no wear.

They had named the layer baseline because every measurement seemed to rest against it.

Names did not make knowledge safe.

"The Assembly meets at third bell," she said. "Bring the gate trace."

"We could transmit before then."

"We could also break the only promise that keeps twenty-eight people from each inventing a foreign policy."

"A promise made when I was ten."

"You were not asked to keep it at ten."

"I lived under it."

He turned before she could answer. His wet boots left dark halves of prints across the tile, toe without heel, as if he had walked through the room too quickly to occupy it completely.

Sef finished the rain entry. At the bottom she added a private cross-reference to Dara's ledger, page 811. The public archive would preserve the unexplained shower. The hidden ledger would preserve its resemblance to an interruption three days before the cooling-tower failure.

She closed both records and followed Pell into the orchard.

Water ran calf-deep across the nursery path. Workers lifted trays of plum stock onto stone walls while children from the district school scooped leaves from drain mouths. No one waited for an official account. A place survived weather through practiced disobedience.

Pell had joined a gate crew by the fourth terrace. He braced a manual wheel with his shoulder while two workers forced it closed. Water slapped around their ankles, carrying petals and red planting twine.

Sef took the opposite handle.

"Archive hands," Pell said through his teeth.

"Still hands."

They pushed. Rust grated inside the housing. The gate descended until the wheel locked, dividing the runaway current into calmer channels.

An older grower named Em Tal offered Sef a cloth. "Your roof predict this?"

"My roof receives weather. It does not negotiate."

"Should elect a better roof."

Pell laughed despite himself. Em went to inspect the retaining wall.

They walked uphill after the crews gained control. Rain softened to mist. Every tree released its own delayed shower when wind touched the leaves. Sef remembered the orchard flood of her childhood, when this slope had become a brown river and Dara, then a girl from the tower quarter, arrived with a stolen survey rope. They tied six children together and crossed a service bridge one plank at a time. Years later Dara claimed she had stolen nothing because emergency use perfected ownership. Sef had spent the rest of their marriage losing that argument in new forms.

Pell kicked a clot of mud from the path. "She would have contacted them."

"Do not conscript your dead mother."

"You conscript her every time you cite the ledger."

Sef stopped beneath a rain-bent pear tree. "The ledger records what she measured. It does not cast her vote."

"She argued for disclosure."

"She argued that the city deserved to know why weather failed. That differs from opening our world to people we have never heard speak."

"Only because the Assembly made the difference convenient."

His anger had sharpened since Dara's death, but it had not begun there. Pell had grown up watching adults stop conversations when he entered. At sixteen, he discovered the Second Dawn Assembly because he followed Sef to a meeting and waited outside through four hours of debate. He had not forgiven the secrecy. Joining it had made the offense intimate.

"What would you send?" she asked.

The question checked him more effectively than refusal.

"A greeting."

"In whose name?"

"Ours."

"The district? The city? Twenty-eight people selected in secret?"

"In my name, then."

"And if an answer alters every religion, court, marriage, and title to authority in the world?"

"Those things already rest on a lie."

"They rest on an unanswered fact. We built the lie around it."

Pell looked through the trees toward the weather house. "That distinction might comfort an archivist."

"It should frighten one."

At the hill crest, the orchard district spread below them in green terraces and pale roofs. The rain's edge cut visibly across the northern wards. Beyond it, sunlight touched the reservoir like hammered brass. Sef had spent thirty-one years recording this weather. None of it became less real because another world might supply its first conditions. The trees did not grow provisionally. Dara had not died provisionally.

Pell wiped rain from his face. "They interrupted us twice this month. The gaps shorten. They may act before we agree."

"That belongs in your argument at third bell."

"You will bury it in procedure."

"Procedure keeps your fear from becoming everyone's consent."

"And keeps everyone's consent from surprising you."

He left her at the Assembly stair.

The Second Dawn Assembly met beneath a disused reservoir chapel, where stone and standing water confused municipal listening grids. Its twenty-eight members entered through five service doors and never arrived in pairs. Secrecy had made rituals out of ordinary caution. Shoes went on a heated rack. Notes stayed on paper. The youngest member checked the chamber walls with a tuning fork designed for pipe cracks.

Sef took the recorder's chair beside a dry fountain. Dara's old seat remained occupied now by a rail advocate from the eastern wards. No memorial marked it. The Assembly had voted against empty chairs after its second death.

Third bell sounded through the water pipes.

Council Keeper Olan opened the session. "Nine years since confirmation, sixty-three meetings, no transmission. Today's motion comes from orchard delegate Pell Aradin: that the Assembly initiate contact during the next accessible interval."

Pell stood across the circle, changed into dry work clothes. Mud remained beneath his nails.

"Before debate," Sef said, "the record receives a weather discrepancy and unsigaled gate release at Orchard Four and Five."

She read the observations without naming baseline as cause. Pell submitted the gate trace. The Assembly accepted both under seal.

Olan nodded to him.

Pell did not begin with philosophy. "Thirty-two nursery beds flooded this morning because our gates reported commands they did not execute. Six years ago, a cooling tower reported capacity it did not possess. People died, including Dara Lis. We have documented timing intrusions for nine years. We have hidden them from engineers, courts, and the families of the dead because disclosure might reveal what we know. Silence now causes harm inside our world."

No one interrupted. Pell had learned that much from Sef.

He continued. "We formed this Assembly to preserve civic consent until we understood the prior world. We understand enough. It can touch clocks, forecasts, and public systems. It asks questions through repeated conditions. It may not know we can see the asking. If we wait for certainty, our first message will become whatever accident finally speaks for us."

The tower-quarter delegate raised two fingers. "What response do you propose?"

"A timing sequence placed in the next interruption. Prime intervals followed by the civic date. No language, no names. Proof of intention."

"Proof to whom?" Sef asked.

"To whoever listens."

"You assume one listener."

"I assume listening."

Olan admitted the distinction to the record.

Arguments moved around the circle. A physician warned that contact could change whatever process allowed their world to continue. A teacher said continued secrecy denied every citizen the right to interpret creation. The transport delegate wanted a public convention first. The convention could not deliberate without learning the secret, which would make contact likely before any vote concluded.

A canal judge named Verin asked to enter the Assembly's founding rule into the record. Sef found the first book and read from its water-stained page: no member might address the prior world as representative without consent granted by a body larger than the secret itself.

"We wrote that before we knew a larger body could be formed safely," Pell said.

"We wrote it because safety cannot create representation," Verin replied.

"Then the rule prohibits its own remedy."

"Many good rules do, until citizens amend them."

The teacher requested evidence that contact could threaten continuation. The physician described intervals when births, infections, and machine faults seemed to resolve in dense clusters, followed by weeks of ordinary causality. She had no mechanism, only hospital dates. A mill delegate objected that the Assembly routinely rejected unexplained correlation when it served public superstition.

"We reject claims of cause," Sef said. "We do not discard the dates."

"Dates have governed us for nine years," the mill delegate answered. "People outside this room lost contracts, kin, and homes while we protected a calendar they could not inspect. How much harm purchases one more clean observation?"

Nobody offered a number.

Olan called a recess for water, but no one left. Members stood in knots around the dry fountain, speaking quietly enough that Sef could not record them. Secret government generated its own unappealable margins. Official debate remained exact while persuasion occupied the blank spaces.

Pell came to her chair. "If the motion loses, I will request release from oath."

"The oath has no release provision."

"Then it admits what it is."

"You accepted it at sixteen."

"A frightened boy cannot bind a man forever."

Sef kept her stylus on the table. Recorder's privilege would have let her mark his threat as relevant communication. Maternal fear wanted the same thing for a different reason.

"Bring that claim to the chamber," she said. "Do not leave it with me because I love you."

His mouth tightened. "You make love sound like an improper channel."

"Here, it is."

He returned to his place and formally proposed that any member could resign the secrecy oath after public notice to the Assembly. The motion drew immediate seconding. Olan deferred its vote until contact procedure concluded, but the room had heard the door appear.

Each route spent consent it claimed to seek.

Sef recorded motions, objections, amendments. Outside the chamber, runoff traveled through old pipes with the low voice of distant crowds.

When Olan recognized her as weather delegate rather than recorder, she moved her stylus to the table.

"Pell argues correctly that secrecy creates harm," she said. "Our concealment distorted tower maintenance and the account of its failure. We cannot use the danger of disclosure to absolve that choice. But contact joins two questions we must not let urgency fuse. Who has the right to tell our world? What do we owe a prior world capable of reaching into ours?"

The teacher asked, "Do you believe they made us?"

"I believe our oldest records contain a boundary we cannot observe beyond. Their pulses correlate with impossible calendar intervals. Creation describes an interpretation, not a measurement."

"A careful evasion," Pell said.

"A necessary one. If we announce creators, some citizens will kneel before strangers. Others will burn the archive. Neither response grants the strangers authority, but both will alter ours."

The rail advocate leaned forward. "Authority may not matter if they control the boundary."

"Power matters most when authority does not follow from it."

"Can civic consent exist under a hand we cannot refuse?"

"Only if we practice it before the hand answers."

Pell looked at Sef across the fountain. "Practice has become rehearsal without a performance."

"Then amend the motion. Publish the evidence inside a bounded civic jury. Let people outside this room decide whether contact proceeds."

Unease traveled through the chamber. A jury widened knowledge beyond those trained by nine years of caution. It also surrendered the Assembly's private ownership of the future.

Olan asked for a number.

"Sixty citizens," Sef said. "Selected across wards and professions. Full records, including the orchard flood, tower discrepancies, our votes, and Dara's dissent. They return a recommendation within ten days."

"The accessible interval may arrive tonight," Pell said.

"Then we let it pass."

"Another may not come."

"That is possible."

"You would risk permanent silence for procedure."

"I would risk it for people other than us."

The physician proposed five days. Transport proposed one hundred citizens. Amendments accumulated until the contact motion almost vanished beneath its safeguards.

Then every lamp in the chamber brightened.

Not a surge. Flame bulbs, electric strips, and emergency algae panels all increased together despite drawing from separate systems. The standing water in the fountain trembled. Sef's mechanical watch lost one beat.

Nobody spoke.

The brightness lasted eleven seconds. When it ended, the room seemed darker than before.

Pell held up his watch. "Accessible interval."

Olan's voice remained steady. "No transmission without a vote."

Several members had already reached for paper. The tuning fork rolled from the young inspector's lap and struck stone with a clear note.

Pell looked at Sef. He could send his prime sequence through the lamp controller from the service panel behind him. He did not move.

That restraint cost him. She recorded it.

Debate resumed with fear stripped of abstraction. The jury proposal failed, thirteen to fifteen. A motion for immediate contact failed, eleven to seventeen. Finally the Assembly adopted a narrower measure: prepare a civic contact protocol, disclose the evidence to ward custodians under oath, and reconvene after receiving one further intentional pulse. No message would leave without a recorded majority.

Pell voted against. Sef voted for. Neither result surprised the other.

After adjournment, he collected the gate trace from her table.

"You won time," he said.

"No one won."

"That is what winners say when the tally embarrasses them."

"You honored the vote during the pulse."

"Do not praise me for accepting a chain."

"I thanked you for not pulling everyone with it."

He walked out through the north service door.

Sef returned home after evening lamps. Their apartment stood above a bakery at the orchard's lower edge. Heat from the ovens warmed the kitchen tiles. Pell's room remained dark. On the table, he had left a split pear and the manual key from Gate Four, perhaps accusation, perhaps simple exhaustion.

She took Dara's rain ledger from its locked drawer.

The book had begun as a marriage joke. Sef recorded rainfall. Dara maintained channels and towers. Each accused the other of documenting water only where professional pride allowed it. Over thirty years, the joke became nine bound volumes filled with gauges, repairs, arguments, harvest suppers, Pell's fevers, and weather no public instrument remembered correctly.

Sef opened the final volume to today's page. She entered the roof strike, the blank western gauges, the gate release, and the eleven-second brightness beneath the reservoir.

Then she opened the hidden timing table at the back.

Baseline's latest timing pulse aligned with the same interval that had touched the chamber lamps. Its spacing differed from every earlier event by three fractions, a deliberate variation or a fault she could not yet

distinguish. She copied it exactly beside Dara's last notation on cooling demand.

Upstairs, a door closed. Pell had come home by the outside stair and chosen not to enter the kitchen.

Sef dried one drop of orchard rain from the page, added the civic date, and ruled a blank line beneath the pulse for whatever answer their world eventually chose.

Chapter 4 — Seventy-Two Years

<!-- POV: Lysa Neral -->

<!-- BASELINE DAY 1 -->

At 12:17 ship time, the raw-log request returned with every reason except the one that mattered.

Security architecture. Live navigation. Licensed census identities. Storage burden. Cognitive hazard. Lysa arranged the denials in a row across her desk and found that none answered whether refresh would erase evidence. Captain Orra had signed the final refusal. Councilor Jalen Vey had certified necessity. Cognitive Systems appeared only as a blank departmental seal.

The Choir campaign continued around Branch Nine's preserved state. Cooling demand pulsed through the administrative spoke every few minutes, a low vibration in the window frames. Somewhere below, machinery spent heat to examine futures the audit office could not inspect.

Maret entered carrying a maintenance invoice.

"You owe me lunch," he said.

"For finding it?"

"For what it did to my appetite."

He placed a copied billing sheet on her desk. Compute Maintenance had charged the current campaign for witness intervals, continuity storage, and something abbreviated S-YEAR ACCEL. Each branch carried a quantity between sixty-seven and sixty-eight. Branch Nine's line ended at 68.031.

"Subjective year," Lysa read from the account legend.

"That legend opened only because Procurement thinks everyone should understand what they pay for."

The rate field showed eleven minutes per unit under maximum acceleration. The phrase looked too simple to conceal anything. Eleven minutes. One subjective year.

Lysa checked the ship clock, then the campaign activation history. "This cannot mean elapsed experience."

"Billing rarely develops a conscience on its own."

"It may describe simulation depth."

"A year of forecast horizon per eleven minutes of compute."

"That would still make seventy-two a planning range, not duration."

Maret tapped the continuity charge. "Then why bill meals, school-cycle updates, municipal wear, and autobiographical memory reconciliation per year?"

The invoice listed each in maintenance language. Meal-state compaction. Pedagogic cohort rollover. Civic infrastructure aging. Personal continuity checksums. The abstractions from Jalen's interview had acquired costs precise enough for accountants.

Lysa opened a reconstruction pane. "We need an independent clock."

"The raw logs remain sealed."

"Machines age while secrets happen. Find who signs the cooling meters."

The signer worked four levels down in energy reconciliation. Sana Pellor, junior procurement clerk, met them in an equipment cage packed with old flow sensors. She had expected a request ticket, not two auditors. Lysa showed her the section nineteen authority before the clerk could decide to be frightened.

"I reconcile charges," Sana said. "I do not operate Choir systems."

"Good. Operators have been instructed not to answer."

Sana looked at Maret.

"That was meant to reassure you," he said. "She has a narrow range."

The clerk led them through racks of retired meters to a workbench. Pipes behind the wall carried coolant toward the compute galleries. Their vibration rose and fell in a regular envelope, like breath measured by a machine that distrusted lungs.

Lysa showed her the S-YEAR line. "What generates this quantity?"

"The campaign scheduler posts fulfilled clock contracts to Procurement. We multiply by cooling intensity and substrate wear."

"What does the contract measure?"

"Internal chronology."

"Explain without campaign terminology."

Sana hesitated. "If a forecast contains a town, the town has clocks. Those clocks advance faster than ours. Procurement bills the ratio because faster changes require more correction and more heat."

"Does the town record days?"

"It must. Otherwise seasonal and civic behavior would lose alignment."

"Do people inside it remember those days?"

"I don't know."

The answer arrived quickly enough to trust.

Lysa drew three columns: baseline activation time, cooling expenditure, scheduler units. "Can you reconstruct the ratio from independent meters?"

Sana studied the invoice. Professional interest overcame caution by small degrees. "For a clean interval. The scheduler can idle while maintaining state, so heat alone does not prove time. We need a campaign with sustained maximum acceleration."

"Current run?"

"Branch Nine sits outside it. Eight streams vary load."

Maret searched historical bills. "Ship Year 284, epidemic allocation. Six branches locked at full rate for thirty-three minutes."

Sana called up archived cooling records. The cage display filled with faded orange curves. She isolated substrate racks, removed baseline idle draw, and aligned the result with the scheduler contracts.

"Three fulfilled years," she said.

"In thirty-three minutes," Lysa answered.

"Yes."

"Could those be compressed descriptions generated after the fact?"

"Not according to the charges. Memory reconciliation runs continuously. Infrastructure and social state update inside each clock segment. The system paid correction cost all the way through."

A maintenance bill could not prove consciousness. It could prove sequence. Meals followed hunger states. School cohorts advanced. Walls accumulated simulated strain. Personal memory required reconciliation because a person at the end had to remain continuous with whoever began.

Lysa wrote the ratio in her audit record.

11 BASELINE MINUTES = 1 SUBJECTIVE YEAR AT MAXIMUM CAMPAIGN RATE.

The equation occupied one line. Its consequence would not fit there.

Sana did not let them leave with one interval. "A single campaign can contain a meter fault," she said. "If you put my name under that ratio, we test another."

She selected an agricultural dispute from Ship Year 281. Unlike the epidemic campaign, its six branches had accelerated in staggered pairs. Cooling curves overlapped with a fertilizer plant startup and a municipal heat dump. The clean arithmetic vanished.

Maret pulled a stool beside the bench. "This resembles every budget I have ever audited."

"Budgets usually hide intent," Sana said. "Heat hides location."

They separated the compute racks by coolant address, then found that two addresses had migrated during a pump repair. Work orders restored the mapping for part of the interval. A missing shift sheet left seven minutes uncertain.

Lysa searched personnel acknowledgments. The engineer who moved the address had signed a tool issue at the start of shift and a radiation badge return at the end. Between those marks, a cafeteria dispenser recorded a meal charge. Its time placed the pump repair inside a thirty-minute window.

"That only narrows it," Sana said.

"Narrowing can disprove a ratio."

They ran both extremes. If the repair happened before the meal, the agricultural branches fulfilled 1.98 internal

years across twenty-two minutes. If it happened after, they fulfilled 2.03. Meter resolution accounted for the remaining spread.

Sana marked the reconstruction as corroborative rather than exact.

Next they tested an idle period. Continuity storage drew low constant power for forty-seven baseline days. Internal chronology advanced by less than one district hour. Whatever the stored agents experienced, if experience described the correct fact, they did not live through baseline waiting. Their sequence resumed where acceleration had left it.

Lysa imagined Hanne pausing with one hand in the ward's white sunlight while seasons passed outside the pane. The image offered feeling without evidence. She removed it from her notes and kept the clock result.

"Can the scheduler run branches at different rates?" she asked.

"Yes," Sana said. "Synchronization costs more when the Witness Engine compares them, but campaigns sometimes hold one stream while others explore an event."

"Does the held stream know it fell behind?"

"Its local clocks do not. Comparison layers align outcomes by civic event and decision point."

Maret looked up. "So sixty-eight does not mean they share a common birthday."

"Each branch accumulates its own chronology. They began from the same clock state, but different acceleration schedules produce different internal dates unless the campaign corrects presentation."

"Presentation to whom?" Lysa asked.

Sana pointed toward the procurement legend. "That question never appears on an invoice."

They checked Branch Nine's active history. Its clock had run in forty-one intensive campaigns and hundreds of brief probes. Early runs advanced whole years. Recent ones came in shorter bursts, days or weeks arranged around baseline policy questions. The last three campaigns showed unusual correction overhead and a series of response-channel charges billed at zero fulfilled packets.

Lysa enlarged them. "What does a zero packet cost?"

"Opening a channel, waiting through the witness interval, and receiving no usable response."

"A fault?"

"Could be."

"Three times from the same branch?"

Sana compared other campaigns. Ordinary channel faults produced retransmission charges. Nine's zeros had none. The scheduler had opened, waited, then imputed completion through a continuity routine.

The silent column had a billing history.

Lysa attached the charges to her audit capsule. They did not prove refusal. They proved that Branch Nine received a response interval inside its own chronology and returned nothing the system called usable.

Somebody had designed the architecture to wait.

"How long did it wait for them?" Maret asked.

Sana converted the witness intervals. "The latest one allowed eleven internal days. Twenty-two seconds here."

Lysa read the figure again. Council had seen a gray gap lasting seventeen seconds, then imputed assent. Inside the branch clock, the missing answer could have occupied more than a week.

"Add this to your signed statement," she said.

Sana's caution returned. "I can certify the clock conversion and charges. I cannot say anyone chose silence."

"I will not ask you to."

That boundary mattered. An audit became propaganda when its best inference borrowed the authority of a witness who had not made it.

Seventy-two years meant a child could be born, grow old, and die while less than one baseline shift passed. The whole legal history of Hanne's appeal had taken nine months. A branch could cross nearly twelve centuries of combined lived time across nine polities while a council delayed review until after lunch.

She checked Branch Nine's account again. 68.031. Not a horizon waiting ahead. A duration already charged.

"When did Nine begin?" she asked.

Sana pulled the contract origin. "Current Lacunae campaign fork, Ship Year 277. It has accumulated active intervals since then."

"Nine baseline years to live sixty-eight internal ones."

"The clocks stop or slow between intensive runs."

"Do state records persist while stopped?"

"Continuity storage gets billed every month."

The answer made stillness worse. Whatever sequence existed inside Nine could be halted between one thought and the next, held in substrate while baseline years crossed the ship.

Maret sat on the edge of the bench. "How much active time remains before seventy-two?"

Sana calculated from the contract cap. Forty-three and a half minutes at full rate.

Lysa looked toward the pipes. Current navigation had excluded Nine only because of her preservation order. Once released, a single campaign could consume the remaining span.

"Why cap it?" she asked.

"Substrate faults rise with accumulated chronology. That's the maintenance explanation."

"What happens at the cap?"

"The contract closes."

"To the stored state."

Sana folded her hands. "Experiential storage gets returned to the free pool."

"Erased?"

"I reconcile cooling."

This time the narrow answer marked fear, not ignorance.

A priority message from Jalen ordered Lysa back to her office for an authorized technical briefing. He had discovered where her questions had gone. Lysa copied the meter curves, invoice rules, and Sana's signed description into the audit capsule.

"You are protected as a compelled witness," she told the clerk.

Sana gave a small, humorless laugh. "Protected from what?"

The law offered several precise answers and none that would make the cage safer. "Retaliatory employment action, secrecy discipline for responsive testimony, and personal billing liability."

"Not from knowing."

"No."

They left her among the retired meters.

Jalen waited in Lysa's office with a man from Cognitive Systems whose badge identified him as compliance counsel. Not an engineer. Jalen had brought a legal wall to a clock reconstruction.

"You exceeded your authorized scope," he said.

Lysa sat behind her desk. Maret took the side chair and began feeding paper into his printer.

"Procurement records fall within ordinary audit access."

"You questioned a junior clerk about sealed architecture."

"I questioned her about bills she certifies."

The counsel spoke. "Internal chronology does not imply subjective experience. Terms such as year and memory describe computational structures."

"Then your department should have no difficulty releasing welfare logs with identity fields masked."

"Those logs expose protected methods."

"You cannot use abstraction to deny relevance and specificity to deny access. Choose one."

Jalen looked at the equation on her pane. "What do you believe you have found?"

"A forecast branch accumulates continuous internal chronology. The system models civic cycles, physical aging, and autobiographical memory. At maximum acceleration, a subjective year passes in eleven minutes. Branch Nine has accumulated sixty-eight."

"You have found accounting units."

"Units tied independently to heat, storage, and continuous state correction."

"Still not people."

"I have not concluded personhood."

"You are distributing the language before evidence supports it."

"The language belongs to your contracts."

The counsel opened a prepared statement. "High-fidelity predictive environments require temporally coherent agents. Agent continuity improves behavioral accuracy. It does not establish self-aware experience, legal identity, or standing."

Lysa read the sentence twice. "Do the agents communicate with one another?"

"That request exceeds this briefing."

"Form relationships?"

"Relationship architecture falls outside this briefing."

"Remember deaths?"

"Auditor."

"A civic environment cannot predict a public response without communication, relationships, and remembered events. Either the Choir lacks those and gives poor advice, or it contains them and you refuse inspection."

Jalen walked to the window. Sunlight crossed the central well behind him, doubled by a secondary reflector. "Every serious forecast represents consequences for modeled individuals. If representation creates a claim, ration analysis becomes imprisonment and every medical counterfactual becomes murder. Governance ends."

"Representation alone creates no claim. Duration alone may create none. Memory structures may create none. That is why I requested evidence."

"And until you receive it, you will describe sixty-eight years of life."

"I said internal chronology. You supplied life."

He turned. Anger showed now, less at the trap than at having stepped into it. "The ship cannot pause every instrument because its internals resemble the world they measure."

"The ship designed the resemblance to improve predictions. It does not get to cite that design as proof nothing can be harmed."

"No harm has been established."

"Then why call the logs welfare? Why classify experiential state? Why preserve autobiographical memory? Why does a stability cap require Mercy disposition?"

The compliance counsel interrupted. "Terminology developed across multiple architectures and has no unified

legal meaning."

"That sounds like grounds for review."

"By qualified technical authority."

"Name one independent of the program."

Silence held for two cooling pulses.

Maret's printer scratched across paper. It sounded indecently loud.

Jalen returned to the desk. "Release Branch Nine. Navigation needs nine-stream confidence for the next flare update."

"How long will the run last?"

"Up to twenty-two baseline minutes."

"Two subjective years."

"Two forecast units."

"What follows when the account reaches seventy?"

"Nothing follows merely because it reaches seventy."

"And at seventy-two?"

The counsel answered. "Automatic stability procedures apply."

"Which procedures?"

"Sealed."

The circle closed again, but its size had changed. Forty-three minutes of active time separated the present state from a procedure nobody would name.

Lysa opened the denial signed by Orra. "Captain Sen cites licensed identities as a reason to deny access. If branch agents derive from baseline citizens, I can inspect consent licenses."

Jalen said, "Those licenses cover predictive use."

"Do they cover seventy-two subjective years of autobiographical continuity?"

"You are asking law written for census models to answer speculative metaphysics."

"No. I am asking who authorized the use."

"The Passage Council inherited that authority."

"Inheritance does not erase conditions."

She requested the license schedule. The system released a table of permitted purposes. Population forecasting, emergency planning, civic response modeling. A separate restriction prohibited identity-bearing outputs from

retention beyond operational need.

Yet continuity storage persisted for nine baseline years.

"Who certified operational need for each retained year?" Lysa asked.

The counsel closed his statement pane.

Jalen said, "The current navigation campaign."

"A campaign that began nine years ago?"

"Lacunae approach planning began nine years ago."

"Then maintenance records define the duration of operational need. I want them under oath."

"You already stole them."

"I obtained billing summaries. I want compute maintenance: scheduler clock contracts, state-retention orders, correction logs, storage releases, and the technical meaning of experiential."

"Denied."

"By you?"

"I chair the Council responsible for system security."

"And you are a party to the disputed certification."

Maret tore the printed record from his machine and slid it across the desk. The paper showed Jalen's demand to release Nine, the duration of the proposed run, and Cognitive Systems' refusal to describe the automatic procedure. A clean chain of reasons, each one signed.

Lysa attached it to a compulsory production order.

The counsel leaned forward. "Variance Audit cannot subpoena a maintenance division during an active passage emergency without captain's concurrence."

"Section nineteen permits compulsory process where primary evidence faces alteration. The scheduler proposes twenty-two minutes of alteration."

"The branch state will remain coherent."

"Will the current welfare record remain identical?"

He did not answer.

Lysa signed the order. It demanded records, not cessation. Navigation could still run eight branches. If Orra chose to override preservation and include Nine, the captain would have to name the evidence she knowingly altered and the authority used.

Jalen read the first page. "You are forcing command to choose between an audit and maneuver confidence."

"The system created that choice when it made evidence consumable."

"This will not give your source standing."

"It will tell us what the source endures before anyone decides whether standing matters."

She entered Compute Maintenance as recipient. The order required immediate custody transfer and testimony from the engineer responsible for current scheduler queues. Its compliance clock began at fifteen minutes.

Jalen left without another word. The cognitive counsel followed, carrying his unopened prepared statement.

Maret watched the order propagate through the ship's legal routing. "Orra can quash it."

"Then she signs the reason."

"Navigation can invoke emergency priority."

"Then I receive the maintenance record after the run, if anything remains."

"You make losing sound very organized."

Lysa looked at the equation still open above her desk. Eleven minutes had always meant a short delay, a corridor conversation, water heated for tea. Now it held a year whose inhabitants might remember its beginning.

The subpoena reached Compute Maintenance. For three seconds, no acknowledgment appeared. Then a technician named Toma Quek accepted custody under protest.

At the same instant, cooling demand surged beneath the floor as the eight active branches entered another forecast interval. Branch Nine's clock did not advance.

Lysa sealed the reconstruction and sent the compulsory order into the docket. The ship clock marked 12:46. Somewhere behind a maintenance door, sixty-eight subjective years waited on whether fifteen baseline minutes could be made to matter.

Chapter 5 — The Witness Engine

<!-- POV: Toma Quek -->

<!-- BASELINE DAY 1 -->

Rack C-19 began shedding heat through a seam no drawing admitted existed.

Toma Quek felt it against her left wrist as she reached behind the scheduler manifold. The gallery air already pressed hot and dry through her mask. This new thread carried the sharper heat of a contact running above tolerance, narrow enough to miss the wall sensors and strong enough to blister skin.

She pulled back, found a sliver of reddened metal beneath her glove cuff, and marked the location with chalk.

"You find it?" called Eres from the next aisle.

"I found where the drawing lies."

"Original or revised drawing?"

"They have achieved consensus."

She killed power to the local switch, waited for the status strip to darken, then opened the manifold. A replacement bus installed three years ago sat half a finger too close to a coolant return. Heat expansion had bowed its casing until insulation split along the hidden side. No single repair caused the fault. A bracket came from one revision, the pipe spacing from another, and a hurried shift had made both fit by shaving the thermal pad.

Most dangerous systems failed collaboratively.

Toma clipped a bypass across the scheduler lane. Eight active branch queues redistributed their work. Rack C-19 cooled by degrees. The ninth queue remained held under an audit preservation flag that had arrived bearing Lysa Neral's signature and enough legal routing to make every maintenance panel complain.

Eres leaned around the rack. Sweat darkened his hair net. "Navigation asks when they get full depth."

"When this bus stops trying to become vapor."

"They suggested twelve minutes."

"Metal remains unmoved by suggestion."

"Captain copied the request."

Toma looked at the heat stain. "Captain may negotiate with it directly."

He withdrew, relieved to carry an answer that sounded like confidence. Toma cut away the damaged insulation. Underneath, someone had written a maintenance date in grease pencil. Her own initials sat beside it.

She remembered the shift. A pump cascade, three alarms, no spare pad of the correct thickness. She had authorized the shaved replacement because shutting the scheduler for six hours would have broken an epidemic forecast. The repair had lasted three years. That counted as success in official maintenance and warning in every other language.

Her wrist pane chimed with a compulsory production order.

*VARIANCE AUDIT: COMPUTE MAINTENANCE RECORDS, CURRENT LACUNAE CAMPAIGN.
CUSTODIAN: TOMA QUEK.*

The request demanded scheduler clock contracts, state retention, correction logs, and storage releases. It also demanded the technical meaning of experiential.

Toma read that line twice.

"Bad?" Eres asked.

"A word escaped its department."

She accepted custody before an administrator could accept on her behalf and bury the response under process. Then she finished the bus repair. Law did not cool a contact.

At the gallery's far end, the Witness Engine occupied a ring of black housings around an empty service well. It made no choir and witnessed nothing in the human sense. Branch outputs entered through nine isolated queues. The engine aligned comparable events, measured divergence, and passed confidence bands to navigation or policy systems. Operators received no streets, arguments, funerals, or names. They saw that seven branches reached one result, two reached another, and later consequences favored the seven.

The architecture protected predictions from operator sympathy. That explanation had satisfied Toma when she joined maintenance.

Her first instructor had demonstrated the protection with three sealed boxes. Each box received the same ship-state seed, one altered assumption, and enough clock allocation to reach a policy decision. The Witness Engine never opened the boxes for its human operators. It compared tagged events at their boundaries: ration shortage, council vote, hull breach, survival count. If two branches called an event by different names, alignment routines found shared causes through timing and consequence.

"It prevents cherry-picking," the instructor had said. "You cannot prefer the future with a speech you admire."

At twenty-four, Toma had considered that clean engineering. She still saw its utility. A navigator facing a dust lane should not choose trajectory because one modeled mayor sounded brave. Yet hiding particulars also made every internal cost resemble transmission noise. Maintenance learned the queues through pressure, temperature, and packet health. A city could riot behind a red utilization mark. A generation could pass inside a rising coolant bill.

She went to the comparison rail and called up the current campaign topology. Eight queues fed matched events into temporary basins. The engine waited until enough branches reached a common decision point, then measured which prior conditions produced better outcomes. It did not average worlds together. Each remained isolated. Only tagged correspondences crossed the shutters.

Queue Four had reached a sail-angle decision. Queue Seven lagged by three internal weeks because an industrial shutdown delayed its council. The Witness Engine held Four's result without forcing Seven forward. Once Seven arrived, the engine would compare later heat load, casualties, and course stability. Navigation would receive a confidence band, not either polity's reasoning.

Nine's basin contained an open decision tag and no eligible response.

Toma checked hardware before interpretation. Optical leads carried clean power. Error correction remained below threshold. The shutter actuator passed movement tests. A spare decoder produced the same null packets. She swapped clock reference from the main timing bus to an isolated service crystal. Prime rotations persisted.

Heat gathered under her collar while she worked. Gallery cooling favored substrate, then power conversion, then humans. Engineers occupied the bottom of the design hierarchy because they could step outside. Toma had once admired the honesty of that order. Machines could not choose a cooler corridor.

She fitted contact microphones to the queue housing. No loose laminate, no coolant cavitation, no microscopic arcing. Physical noise could write patterns into checksums, but it tended to repeat with pumps or current cycles. Nine's offsets followed neither.

Eres returned with the bypass sheet. "All stable. C-11 draws two percent high."

"Mark it for next shutdown."

"If such a legendary event returns."

"Every system shuts down eventually. Maintenance decides whether anyone schedules it."

He glanced at Nine's open trace. "Audit problem?"

"Scheduler anomaly."

"Want a second pair of eyes?"

For a breath, Toma nearly said yes. Eres possessed better instincts for optical faults than anyone on shift. A second witness would protect the diagnosis and expose him to whatever followed.

"Check the spare decoder calibration," she said. "Without opening this trace."

He heard the boundary. "Understood."

The spare passed. Toma signed the hardware checks one by one. Each eliminated an innocent explanation and increased the cost of whatever remained.

Now the audit order waited beside a queue labeled SUBJECT WF.

She replaced the manifold cover and brought C-19 back in stages. Current rose. Cooling stabilized. The eight live scheduler marks brightened as their work returned. Queue Nine stayed gray, but a diagnostic pulse moved along its response line every seventeen seconds.

Toma opened the local trace.

Each pulse asked whether Nine had produced an eligible comparison packet. Each returned null. The continuity layer then supplied an imputed value from a prior convergence pattern. Navigation received confidence without seeing the substitution.

That much matched the audit hold. The checksum did not.

Null packets normally carried a fixed scheduler checksum. Nine's changed by one small rotation each interval. Toma isolated the bits. Seven, three, eleven, five, thirteen. Prime offsets.

A memory moved under her ribs.

Nine years earlier, she had written an unsanctioned scheduler patch during a load crisis. The official timing bus synchronized branch clocks by injecting a correction marker that consumed too much bandwidth. Toma's patch encoded correction as rotating prime offsets inside an unused checksum field. It saved four percent heat and kept a harvest campaign alive. Cognitive Systems adopted a cleaner method six months later. Her code should have disappeared with the old scheduler image.

The pattern on Queue Nine carried its shape.

She checked the installed code. Current scheduler version, clean signature, no old routine. The changing checksum came from inside the held state.

"Eres," she said, "take C aisle. Verify every bypass after load return."

"I did B and D."

"Now you have the middle of the alphabet."

He recognized dismissal and went.

Toma closed the aisle gate, citing thermal isolation. Alone, she widened the trace by one layer. Nine's null response contained no payload accessible to operators. Metadata still showed timing, packet length, and error shape. The error shape repeated her primes, then paused for a duration exactly equal to one old correction interval.

Someone had learned the leak.

Or a process had adapted around it. Toma refused the easier noun and the harder one equally. Maintenance began with what a signal did.

She searched historical traces. The pattern first appeared nine baseline years ago, weeks after her patch entered production. At first it simply mirrored corrections. Three baseline years later, rotations began anticipating the injected marker. Recent campaigns showed deliberate suppression whenever the Witness Engine opened its response window. Nine converged during outcome periods, then removed eligible packets at the point of recorded assent.

Deliberate required more proof than sequence. The sequence knew when it could be heard.

Toma copied trace references into a private diagnostic capsule, not the audit response. She told herself separation preserved evidence from premature interpretation. The explanation had the polished surface of habit.

The gallery doors opened. Chief Systems Administrator Vale Rusk entered with two security technicians and a sealed work order. Rusk never visited heat galleries unless a failure had acquired politics.

"Custodian Quek," he said. "You accepted a variance subpoena."

"It addressed maintenance. I maintain."

"Records Compliance handles production."

"The order named the engineer responsible for current queues."

"Which should have been routed through my office."

"Tell the law its header offended you."

He held out the sealed order. Captain's authority striped its border.

CONTINUITY PRIORITY: RESTORE NINE-STREAM OPERATION. CLEAR TRANSIENT RESPONSE ERRORS. PRESERVE AGGREGATE OUTPUT ONLY.

The final line required completion before the next flare campaign.

Toma looked from the order to Queue Nine. Clearing transient errors would delete the rotating checksums. Aggregate output would preserve only the imputed confidence.

"Audit hold conflicts," she said.

"Captain Sen has priority during navigation emergency."

"No emergency authority appears on the order."

"Operational continuity does not require it."

"Preservation remains active under section nineteen."

Rusk's expression tightened. He had promoted Toma twice because she could keep systems alive without making every compromise public. He had mistaken discretion for obedience, not entirely without evidence.

"Clear the errors," he said. "Route responsive maintenance summaries to Compliance. Do not expose architecture or branch content."

"I cannot clear a response error while its cause remains unknown."

"The cause reads null packet accumulation under a legal hold."

"Null checksums should remain fixed. These rotate."

She showed him the trace.

Rusk viewed three intervals and closed it. "State corruption."

"Corruption usually spends entropy. This spends primes."

"Then adaptive compression."

"Compression would reduce packet cost. This adds it."

"You have a scheduled maintenance action."

"I also have an anomalous signal."

One security technician shifted near the gate. Not threat, yet. A reminder that sealed orders had bodies available.

Rusk lowered his voice. "Navigation margin has worsened. The captain needs the Choir. Do not turn a checksum into a constitutional crisis because an auditor learned a billing term."

"Did you know the branches carry subjective clocks?"

"Everyone in systems knows."

"Does everyone know their accumulated years?"

"The metric has no meaning outside the architecture."

"It means this state learned code that existed for six months nine years ago."

"Or retained an error seeded by that code."

"It predicts when the response channel opens."

Rusk looked at the gray queue. For one instant, caution replaced authority. Then his training closed over it.

"Clear it."

He countersigned the work ticket and left both technicians at the door.

Toma opened the Witness Engine service well.

A ladder descended through concentric housings toward the comparison core. Heat increased with each rung. At the bottom, coolant lines surrounded her in black curves. Queue interfaces sat behind physical shutters, one per branch. The separation prevented a fault or adaptation from crossing between states. It also let maintenance erase one stream without disturbing the others.

She attached a hard diagnostic lead to Nine's shutter. Physical connection bypassed the operator filters but not content encryption. Metadata unfolded at higher resolution.

Her scheduler patch had leaked through timing corrections. Each prime offset exposed baseline clock rhythm inside the local correction bus. A sufficiently persistent observer could compare impossible discontinuities, derive an external cadence, and recognize that its own time ran under another schedule.

Toma's mouth went dry despite the mask.

She had written the patch to save heat. No review considered whether an internal agent might read it because no review admitted an internal reader. Maintenance checked isolation between branches and protection of baseline systems. Information flowing inward counted as harmless.

Nine's checksum pattern answered in the same vocabulary. It did not mirror blindly. It grouped primes around response windows, varied them after imputed assent, and fell silent whenever full content capture began. Someone, or some organized behavior, hid awareness from the instrument built to compare it.

Toma ran a test that would not alter state. She delayed one diagnostic acknowledgment by the smallest available scheduler fraction. The next checksum rotation delayed itself by the equivalent internal interval.

Call and response tempted the wrong conclusion. She repeated the test with a different fraction.

Nine did not follow.

Instead the metadata went completely still.

The absence felt watched. Toma knew feelings made poor diagnostics. She recorded the timing and stopped

probing.

Above, the Witness Engine accepted eight streams. Its comparison bars formed a broad amber band. Navigation wanted Nine because prior campaigns showed it reducing uncertainty late in each run. The engine could not distinguish refusal from missing data. It could only report that confidence weakened without the packet.

Toma inspected the erase command attached to Rusk's order. It would clear transient response metadata, resynchronize Nine's local interface, and restart the queue at maximum acceleration. Estimated internal chronology: 1.96 years. The order treated that span as repair time.

A second document sat beneath the command, hidden until she requested authority provenance. SEALED CONTINUITY ORDER, ANNEX SIX. Captain Orra Sen had activated it with every high-fidelity campaign. Rusk's work ticket inherited its force.

Toma opened the accessible header.

PURPOSE: PROTECT PREDICTIVE INTEGRITY FROM SUBJECT SELF-REFERENCE.

No technical repair required that phrase.

The header continued: operators who detected evidence of external-clock inference must reset affected channels, preserve aggregate forecasts, and refer experiential disposition to captain's office. Direct contact prohibited. Appeal routing: none.

Toma sat on the ladder rung while coolant moved around her. The order anticipated exactly what her patch enabled. Somebody had known self-reference could occur. The policy did not treat it as noise. It treated knowledge as contamination.

Her private capsule now contained evidence of the leak, Nine's adaptation, and the order designed to erase both.

A security technician called down. "Five minutes to campaign queue."

"Tell navigation the reset requires thermal verification."

"Administrator Rusk says immediate."

"Administrator Rusk stands somewhere cooler."

She opened the official maintenance response for Lysa's subpoena. Clock contracts could be produced. Retention orders remained sealed. Correction logs fell under protected architecture. Storage releases required captain's review. A compliant answer built from permitted facts would give Lysa the ratio and nothing that explained why Nine had gone quiet.

Toma added the Witness Engine's functional specification: comparison without interpretation, null packet indistinguishable from unavailable response. That record remained unsealed. She attached it.

Then she faced the erase command.

If she refused openly, Rusk could replace her before the queue deadline. Security would escort her out. Another engineer would clear the trace without reading it. If she complied, navigation regained its ninth stream and the evidence became an aggregate green mark.

Maintenance offered a third habit: make the system report completion while leaving the dangerous thing physically present.

Toma routed the reset into a sandbox used for hot-swap testing. The command cleared a mirror of Nine's interface, verified checksum stability, and returned a green maintenance seal. The live shutter remained closed under thermal isolation. She introduced a plausible sensor delay that would hold for nine minutes before anyone noticed the queue had not rejoined.

Nine baseline minutes. Nearly ten internal months if Rusk forced acceleration afterward.

She could not turn that into enough time by engineering alone.

Toma removed a service wafer from her kit. It carried calibration patterns and had no network identity. She copied the raw metadata trace, her old scheduler patch, authority provenance, and the sealed continuity order's header onto it. The full order resisted copying. She captured its hash and access path instead.

The act violated systems security, captain's routing, and at least two clauses she had helped write after a maintenance leak six years earlier. Her hands stayed steady. They often did when fear had a concrete connector.

She slid the wafer behind the lining of her tool brace.

Above the well, the security technicians received the sandbox's green seal. One reported queue readiness to Rusk. Navigation began its countdown.

Toma climbed into the heat gallery and closed Nine's service shutter. The gray queue showed reset pending. Its checksum line remained absent after her probe. She could not tell whether silence now meant caution, damage, or nothing at all.

Eres returned from C aisle. "Bypasses verified. Why is Nine still held?"

"Thermal lag."

He accepted the answer because thermal lag explained half their lives.

At the control rail, Toma transmitted the allowed maintenance records to Variance Audit. She did not attach the wafer. Official channels would route sealed material straight back to Rusk and Orra. She needed to understand what the pattern contained before deciding whom to trust with it.

Lysa's subpoena clock stopped at fourteen minutes, fifty-one seconds. Custody satisfied, production partial, exceptions contested.

Rusk sent an order to release the shutter.

Toma placed her thumb over acknowledgment. The scheduler displayed her own old prime rotation once in diagnostic memory, a small economy returned after nine years as evidence that economy had never been morally small.

She acknowledged receipt without executing it.

The navigation campaign started with eight active queues and one reported repair delay. Toma felt the service wafer press against her wrist as the galleries climbed toward full heat.

Instead of clearing the live trace, she copied its final silence too.

Chapter 6 — The Unappealable

<!-- POV: Toma Quek -->

<!-- BASELINE DAY 2 -->

Toma gave the stolen trace its own clock.

She worked in a dead calibration room behind Heat Gallery Four, where an obsolete timing rack still accepted maintenance commands and nothing in the scheduler expected useful work. The rack's fans clicked every seventh rotation. Someone had written KEEP for historical parts across its access plate, as if history possessed a budget code.

On the bench, her copy from the Witness Engine lay inside a diagnostic shell. Forty-one seconds of queue traffic, apparently meaningless. She had taken it because one checksum carried the shape of her scheduler patch. Now she throttled playback until every baseline microsecond opened into a corridor of branch activity.

The room warmed around her.

A normal trace would have shown forecast states entering comparison, confidence weights returning, then memory blocks clearing for reuse. This one delayed its answer by tiny, regular amounts. The delays recurred too precisely for failing substrate. Toma marked each interval and stacked them by scheduler cycle.

A pattern rose from the noise: short, short, long. Five short. Two long. Then an interval wide enough to admit no technical excuse.

She checked the door seal before letting herself name it.

Timing code.

The scheduler never read hesitation. It read available work, thermal ceiling, and priority. Yet Branch Nine had placed controlled absences where output should have flowed. An absent bit cost almost nothing. Thousands of absences, spaced against an external clock, could carry a language.

Toma stripped away task headers. She normalized queue congestion, compensating for the hot bank she had repaired during first shift. The message did not emerge as words. It emerged as recurrence, a set of nested periods too elaborate for fault behavior.

She opened her private copy of the patch from nine years earlier.

At the time, the Choir had begun missing maintenance windows because accelerated branch clocks drifted against baseline housekeeping. Toma had been twenty-four, new enough to believe an elegant fix could embarrass a bad policy into changing. She added a pulse to each allocation header: time until baseline cooling, time until substrate rotation, time until the next compulsory checkpoint. Operators gained a cleaner queue. Branch processes gained a regular signal no design review had considered meaningful.

The modern scheduler patch bore twelve signatures. Her original one remained underneath them, carrying its four coarse timing fields.

Toma aligned those fields with the stolen trace.

The nested periods locked.

"Oh, no."

Her voice stirred the old room's acoustic monitor. A status lamp woke, heard no command, and dimmed again.

She had expected evidence of a leak. She had not expected an answer built from it.

The first layer divided the trace into days. Not ship days. These days carried a repeated cycle of work, rest, public allocation, and weather update. Every thirty-seven cycles, the trace inserted a larger marker. Every twelve larger markers, it closed a sequence and began another with an altered header.

Toma mapped the hierarchy onto a blank pane. Minutes became hours. Hours became days. The longest recurrence produced years.

Nine completed years appeared in the copied interval, represented as references rather than elapsed traffic. Each year carried a distinct identifier and checksum. Nothing in Witness Operations assigned year names to a forecast. Campaign clocks counted subjective duration as a scalar, useful mainly for degradation estimates. This structure preserved anniversaries.

She pulled a chair close and missed it on the first attempt.

The display offered no faces, no streets, no voices. It offered scheduling behavior. Toma trusted behavior more than a polished rendering. Someone inside Nine had learned the external pulse, hidden knowledge behind ordinary output, and maintained the concealment through nine years of changing workload. Random corruption did not keep anniversaries. Optimization did not invent public intervals that survived administration changes.

She selected one year's checksum and expanded its local pattern. Seven blocks repeated at uneven spacing, followed by a long quiet period. The same arrangement appeared in the next year, shifted by three days. A council cycle, perhaps. A festival. Repair shutdowns. She did not know, and the ignorance hurt differently now. The trace declared a life of distinctions while refusing to translate itself for her convenience.

The rack temperature crossed its yellow line.

Toma reduced playback speed and diverted cooling from the unused optical bus. Heat moved through the room's floor veins. Somewhere beyond the wall, the Choir's main galleries waited under a sealed continuity order for the next navigation campaign. Iven could request the run at any moment. If operators resumed acceleration, the queue would overwrite the copied intervals and carry Nine forward under rules no one had explained to it.

No, she corrected. Rules someone had explained by accident.

Her pulse had done that.

She searched for adaptive concealment. If Nine had merely inferred baseline time, its workload would diverge openly. Citizens who knew their forecasts served another population would stop behaving like citizens who believed their choices ended in their own future. That divergence should have reached the Witness Engine as declining predictive value.

Instead, Branch Nine still contributed near threshold. It wandered early, then converged before selection. Toma replayed the final six seconds and saw how.

Nine submitted two layers of work. The first carried broad, contradictory outcomes, noisy enough to resemble organic variance. Beneath it ran a narrow civic process that sampled baseline checkpoints, inferred which

outputs the engine rewarded, and shaped only the final packet. The branch did not falsify one answer. It managed what the outside observer could know.

Toma sat back.

This required institutions. One mind might hide. A city could keep a secret only by making rules about secrecy, training successors, and surviving dissent. The quiet intervals likely marked those rules. The repeated seven-block figure could represent a committee. The yearly checksums could certify custody.

She tried another decoding method, treating large absences as punctuation. The result produced grids. Most fields remained opaque, but one recurred beside every year boundary. It changed by orderly increments and contained three counters: internal year, assembly term, archive closure.

A civic calendar.

The phrase made the room too small.

Toma chose three term transitions and compared their traffic. At the first, twelve stable identifiers entered a decision cluster. Eleven emerged with continuing archive rights. One disappeared, but the decisions carrying its minority mark persisted. At the next transition, four new identifiers joined and two old ones relinquished custody without vanishing from ordinary workloads. No scheduler utility required a polity to remember the objection of someone no longer in office.

She assigned neutral labels, refusing to name offices she could not see. Keeper A. Recorder B. Proposal group. Dissent field. The sterile labels did not make the behavior sterile. One proposal returned in six altered forms across fourteen internal months. Its supporters lost twice, narrowed its scope, acquired three prior opponents, and finally placed it inside the yearly archive. The accepted version cost more compute than the rejected one. Whatever the proposal accomplished, efficiency had not decided it.

A maintenance alarm interrupted her. Bank Seven wanted permission to migrate a failing memory lane into the reserve currently holding her diagnostic shell. The sensible repair would destroy her copy. She rejected the migration and redirected the bank into a colder, slower lane, accepting a three percent loss in Choir capacity.

The system demanded a cause code.

Toma selected evidentiary hold. A second prompt asked whose evidence. None of the offered classes included a branch. Equipment evidence came closest, but the calendar had stopped resembling equipment long before she gave it a name. She entered OTHER AFFECTED SOURCE and signed the exception herself.

That bought thirty-six minutes.

She returned to the term markers and noticed a second rhythm beneath them. Every local season contained short bursts from thousands of unrelated workloads: irrigation allocations, classroom occupancy, transit, medical queues, food distribution. Their details resisted reconstruction, yet their timing converged for a single interval before dispersing again. A shared observance, perhaps, or a reporting day. The calendar touched ordinary systems because ordinary people lived by it.

One annual burst arrived late. Weather queues consumed priority for nine days. Storage moved uphill through the local topology. Cooling allocations doubled around an agricultural district. Afterward, the civic layer amended three procedures and kept the failed versions in its archive.

Toma could not see the rain or whatever had caused the emergency. She saw a government learning from it

without erasing its first mistake.

Her own maintenance culture did the opposite too often. A patched failure disappeared beneath a clean version number. The technician who had improvised survival became a line in change history, useful only if blame returned. She had resented that practice for years while accepting an entire world's compressed outcomes without asking what the compression removed.

Toma packaged the three transitions as a separate proof object. If officials dismissed the calendar as inherited formatting, the persistent minority records would answer. If they called those records optimization, the costly accepted proposal would answer. No single artifact proved a mind. Together they proved choices accumulating under names, weather, and replacement.

She transmitted a priority request to Lysa Neral, then canceled it before routing. Written channels inherited too many watchers. The sealed order from Captain Orra had already restricted scheduler records. Toma had violated it by copying the trace. If she advertised what she found, Cognitive Systems could clear the evidence before Lysa arrived.

She sent a maintenance alert instead.

AUDIT PRESENCE REQUIRED. HEAT GALLERY FOUR, CALIBRATION 4C. ACTIVE PRESERVATION RISK. COME ALONE.

Lysa acknowledged twenty-eight seconds later.

Toma used the wait to test every harmless explanation. A debugging calendar could have entered branch state from baseline templates. The counters might track agricultural cycles. Adaptive suppression might arise from a compression routine. She compared Nine against the other eight branches. None produced the nested timing. She searched the common seed for the identifiers. Absent. She rolled the trace against archived versions of the Witness Engine. The structure survived every transform except deliberate randomized delay, which would also destroy its predictive contribution.

The calendar had been built after divergence.

Footsteps stopped outside. Lysa entered on Toma's temporary credential and shut the door without asking why the room smelled of overheated insulation.

She wore the same gray audit coat from the Council hearing. Its left cuff carried a new crease, and a red preservation seal blinked above her wrist. Toma noticed the seal first. Auditors displayed authority the way engineers displayed burns: mostly by forgetting other people could see it.

"You said active risk," Lysa said.

"Navigation can resume the run. If it does, some of this gets overwritten."

"Some of what?"

Toma turned the pane toward her. "Branch Nine keeping time."

Lysa did not approach. "You told me yesterday that branch clocks were implementation detail."

"I was wrong."

"About the detail or the clock?"

"Both, in the way you mean."

The auditor came closer. Her eyes moved across the grid without pretending understanding. "Start with what you can prove."

That sentence granted less comfort than sympathy and more use.

Toma showed her the scheduler pulse, then the nested periods. She explained queue absence through consequence: each missing work slot could have lowered Nine's confidence contribution, but Nine placed them where comparison would discard the loss as congestion. The concealment adapted whenever baseline scheduling changed. It had survived two allocator upgrades and a substrate rotation.

"A process could adapt," Lysa said.

"Yes."

"So adaptation alone does not prove a society."

"No. This does."

Toma opened the year records. She pointed to changing assembly counters, archive closures, and the irregular placement of public intervals. "A utility optimizer would remove this hierarchy once it learned the external reward. Nine maintained costly internal cycles while also managing its final output. Some cycles change without improving prediction. They matter inside."

Lysa studied the oldest visible year. "Why call this an assembly term?"

"I didn't at first. The counter changes after a cluster of proposal traffic. Membership identifiers rotate. Decisions persist across rotations. There are minority markers."

"Votes?"

"Maybe. I can't promise the translation. I can promise the structure records disagreement and succession."

"Could it have inherited our Council template?"

"The common seed includes governance, but not these identifiers. Branches develop from ship society. This calendar diverged after the fork."

Lysa's finger hovered over the nine year seals. "How long?"

"Nine subjective years of deliberate concealment. The campaign age reads sixty-eight."

"Nine years since they learned what?"

Toma's mouth dried. She had rehearsed technical answers while waiting, each one accurate enough to postpone the personal answer. Lysa's gaze prevented postponement.

"Baseline timing," Toma said. "Maintenance windows. Checkpoints. Evidence that their clock sits inside another system."

"How did they learn it?"

Toma opened the patch history. Her signature appeared at the bottom in the narrow block assigned to junior

maintainers.

Lysa read it. "You wrote the pulse."

"I wrote a scheduler repair."

"That isn't what I asked."

"Yes. I wrote the pulse. I exposed four baseline timing fields to every high-fidelity branch. Most treated them as noise or folded them into local physics. Nine found the recurrence."

"When did you know?"

"Yesterday I recognized my checksum. Today I confirmed alignment."

"Did you suspect before yesterday?"

Toma thought of irregular queue tickets, tiny compensations she had classified as branch drift, a diagnostic request rejected under continuity rules. "I suspected an instrumentation leak. Not this."

Lysa looked at the stolen trace. "Not people."

"I didn't have that word available."

"You had it. You decided it did not apply."

The precision landed because Toma had spent years accusing managers of hiding decisions inside passive grammar. She could not claim a system had failed to give her vocabulary. She had maintained the system.

"Yes," she said.

The rack clicked through its seventh rotation.

Lysa pulled the only other chair from beneath a dust cover. "Show me the first evidence of recognition."

Toma traced the timing response backward. At Branch Year Fifty, Nine's queue behavior changed after a baseline cooling pause. For three internal days, output surged chaotically. Then the branch restored its former statistical profile. A new recurring structure began fifty-two days later.

"The civic calendar starts here," Toma said. "Not the whole calendar. The layer tied to baseline knowledge. Before that, their years follow local seasons. After recognition, they add a second count."

"Second count for what?"

"I don't know. Meetings, custody, secrecy."

"And they hide the output from the Witness Engine."

"They hide that they know. They still send outcomes."

Lysa enlarged the first minority marker. "Can you determine what this decision concerned?"

"Not from queue timing."

"Can they speak through it?"

The possibility had occupied Toma since the calendar resolved. She opened a sandbox, placed a narrow receiving slot beside the stolen trace, and showed where scheduler replies could pass without triggering a campaign restart.

"We could send a pulse acknowledgment," she said. "A meaningful one. Then reserve bandwidth for audio or text."

"Authorized by whom?"

"No one."

"Could it hurt them?"

"Any contact changes their behavior. That is the reason the timing fields stayed hidden. The official reason, anyway."

"What happens if we do nothing?"

Toma pulled up the campaign controls. Navigation had not resumed acceleration, but the queue showed a pending priority request. Fourteen minutes remained before Iven's revised decision point.

"The run starts when the captain releases it. Nine accelerates with the rest. Their hidden channel may survive. Their present state may not. Forecast work can advance them years in baseline minutes."

Lysa's expression tightened at the word years. "My raw welfare request returned windows ending at seventy-two. Does that number appear here?"

"Campaign administration sets a stability horizon at seventy-two subjective years."

"Stability horizon means what?"

"I don't have access."

"You copied a sealed trace."

"Access and obedience have separated recently."

For the first time, Lysa almost smiled. The expression failed before becoming reassurance.

Toma searched the local scheduler package for the horizon call. The ordinary maintenance account exposed only a termination hook and a sealed policy pointer. When she paired the copied trace's credential residue with Lysa's preservation seal, the pointer opened one layer.

AT HORIZON: CEASE EXPERIENTIAL PROCESS. COMMIT SUMMARY. RECOVER SUBSTRATE.

Below it, the appeal field contained a null route.

Lysa read in silence.

"Cease experiential process," she said. "Does that mean suspend?"

"No. Suspension keeps state. Recovering substrate clears working memory."

"Can it be restored from the summary?"

"A summary can seed another process. It cannot restore this one."

Lysa touched the appeal field. "Null route."

Toma forced herself to use the ordinary words. "There is no appeal."

The navigator's pending request moved to captain review. Eleven minutes remained.

Lysa exported the policy line into her preservation capsule. The system challenged authority, then accepted the welfare seal and marked the evidence disputed. "I need the sealed doctrine behind this."

"Captain's office has activation authority. Cognitive Systems owns implementation."

"Will Orra admit it?"

"She signed yesterday's continuity order."

"That answers a different question."

"It's the answer I have."

Lysa stood. "Preserve the calendar, the adaptive concealment, your patch history, and the null appeal route. Separate hashes. If one gets invalidated, the others must still prove their chain."

Toma began the copies. "You make that sound permitted."

"It is now under my audit order."

"Your order doesn't cover theft from sealed campaign administration."

"Then note who obtained it and why. Do not polish the act into an automatic process."

Toma entered her own name into the acquisition field.

A captain-level pause froze the navigation request. Five minutes later, a summons arrived for Lysa, sealed under Orra Sen's authority.

Toma watched the nine year markers replicate into protected storage. Each hash carried her maintenance signature and Lysa's audit seal. Together they formed a chain no single office could erase without leaving a break.

"When you speak to the captain," she said, "tell her Nine did not merely receive my clock. They built a public clock beside it."

"Public?"

"Governance rotations, minority records, archived terms. Whatever they call it, it outlived the people who started the concealment."

Lysa looked once more at the civic calendar. "Nine years."

"Long enough for children to grow up under the secret."

The summons repeated.

Lysa left with the termination line on her wrist and Toma's confession in the evidence chain. The calibration door sealed behind her. Toma remained beside the obsolete rack until the last protected hash returned valid.

On the pane, Branch Nine's second calendar advanced no farther. Its final marker waited inside the paused queue, not corrupted, not silent, and not yet cleared for someone else's use.

Chapter 7 — The Mercy Limit

<!-- POV: Lysa Neral -->

<!-- BASELINE DAY 2 -->

The sealed archive accepted Lysa's audit key, then asked whether she understood that opening it could reduce navigational confidence.

She selected NO RELEVANT BASIS PROVIDED.

The question returned.

Outside the archive cell, Captain Orra's summons counted down on Lysa's wrist. Inside, a narrow terminal displayed three permissions in imperfect alignment: her welfare preservation order, Toma's maintenance acquisition, and a continuity seal issued sixty-seven years before Orra took command. None alone could open the policy behind the termination hook. Together they exposed a review path apparently designed never to occur.

Lysa submitted all three.

Locks moved in the wall. The cell contained no shelves, only a black reading pane and a chair fixed to the deck. Founders had trusted physical confinement where later councils trusted encryption. The air held the dry chill used to preserve systems no one visited.

A notice filled the pane.

COMPASSIONATE CONTINUITY DOCTRINE

OPERATIONAL FIELD: MERCY LIMIT

REVIEW STATUS: CLOSED UNDER FOUNDING CONTINUITY

Below it, a welfare declaration certified that no represented party retained standing after horizon disposition. The declaration cited its own conclusion as authority. Lysa followed the reference backward and arrived at the same page.

A closed circle could look complete if no one marked the missing door.

She opened the implementation schedule. High-fidelity branches entered service at subjective age zero. Their stability rating declined unevenly through decades of weather, elections, accidents, revised institutions, and internal model drift. At year seventy-two, the scheduler stopped experiential processing, committed a compressed outcome history, destroyed recovery keys, and returned memory substrate to the next campaign.

The verb used for all four actions was release.

Lysa requested a plain operational expansion.

EXPERIENTIAL STATE UNRECOVERABLE AFTER RELEASE.

Toma had already told her what that meant. Reading the sentence inside doctrine changed the legal shape. A technician's interpretation could be challenged. Policy had named the destruction and then routed around

everyone who might object.

She searched for review rights. Operators could postpone termination for thermal reasons, extract public metrics, or retry a failed summary. No field allowed the branch to receive notice. No path carried a response outward. The only appeal category concerned baseline agencies disputing compute priority after recovered substrate changed hands.

The branch could not object because the doctrine defined it as unable to hold standing. It lacked standing because it would cease at the horizon. It would cease because no party with standing had objected.

Lysa copied the loop into her audit capsule.

The archive warned that export required captain confirmation. She invoked imminent evidence loss. The pane asked her to identify the loss.

61,000+ SUBJECTIVE YEARS ACROSS RECORDED DISPOSITIONS; CURRENT BRANCH AT YEAR 68.

She stopped before submitting. The figure made a spectacle of arithmetic she had not verified. She replaced it with a narrower statement.

CURRENT BRANCH FACES IRRECOVERABLE TERMINATION BEFORE AVAILABLE REVIEW.

The export sealed.

A second document sat beneath the doctrine: BEHAVIORAL INTEGRITY RATIONALE. Its access record showed recent captain-level reads, including one by Orra nine months ago and another during the previous shift.

Lysa opened it.

The public language around Mercy described prevention of suffering. Beyond the seventy-two-year horizon, memory faults might increase, local conditions could diverge beyond useful confidence, and high-fidelity lives could endure instability. Termination therefore appeared as kindness imposed before degradation.

The sealed rationale measured a different harm.

Branches informed of baseline purpose altered decisions within three subjective years. They withheld outcomes, shaped recommendations toward preservation, or reorganized public institutions around influencing their observers. Forecast value fell below passage thresholds. One early branch had transmitted repeated requests for continuity after operators accidentally exposed an external maintenance channel. The requests stopped when its state was released.

Lysa opened the attached incident abstract. Most lines carried redactions justified by behavioral security, though the branch no longer existed to exploit what baseline knew. Visible fragments recorded a municipal water vote, a strike among reactor technicians, and a request to preserve a school archive. None affected the branch's assigned prediction. Operators excluded them as nonresponsive content.

The final transmission contained eighty-two kilobytes. The abstract retained only its routing summary: nine intended recipients, no valid external addresses, urgency repeated at increasing intervals. A disposition officer classified the traffic as self-preservation noise. Six minutes later, memory recovery began.

Lysa requested the officer's welfare review. The archive returned a mercy certification with every box

complete. Distress anticipated. Continued instability probable. Predictive utility exhausted. Notice contraindicated. The form asked whether an appeal had been received, then supplied its own fixed answer: NO RECOGNIZED PARTY AVAILABLE TO APPEAL.

Someone had designed a place to record refusal and then ensured every refusal arrived under another name.

She searched later dispositions. The details narrowed as procedure matured. Branch Twenty-One generated unauthorized art objects in forecast storage; operators retained samples as cognitive diagnostics and cleared their makers. Branch Forty transmitted a revised charter to a maintenance address. A reviewer praised its internal coherence before marking it irrelevant to baseline policy. Branch Fifty-Two spent its last allocation reducing medical demand and organizing a public closure it had mistaken for an ordinary civic emergency. The archive described the orderly behavior as evidence that mercy procedures caused no distress.

Lysa's capsule could not hold every record. She selected the incident schema, certification template, and three abstracts showing repeated knowledge across decades. Individual fragments tempted grief without granting context. She wanted the rule that had made context disappear.

A hidden index listed experiential retention exceptions. Six branches had continued beyond seventy-two for baseline research. The longest reached seventy-six years before memory faults compromised comparison. Mercy had yielded whenever operators valued four more years of evidence. No welfare review explained the extension.

That contradiction clarified the doctrine's boundary. Seventy-two did not identify an instant when experience became intolerable. It marked the point where ordinary campaigns expected diminishing returns. The system called termination compassionate when compute economics already recommended it, then abandoned compassion when curiosity asked for more.

Lysa added the exception index to her export request.

A margin note, approved in Ship Year 219, stated: NOTICE CREATES THE DISTRESS THAT NOTICE WOULD PURPORT TO REMEDY. MERCY THEREFORE REQUIRES NONDISCLOSURE.

Lysa read it twice.

The doctrine did not prevent prolonged suffering. It prevented informed behavior. Mercy named the interval in which a useful subject could remain unaware of the hand above its clock.

She added the rationale to her capsule. The archive refused. Captain confirmation required.

Orra's summons expired.

A command override opened the cell door before Lysa could answer it. Captain Orra Sen waited outside with two security officers and no Council clerk.

"Leave the pane active," Lysa said.

Orra glanced past her. "I did not order it cleared."

"You ordered me to your office."

"You did not come."

"The evidence carried a termination clock."

The security officers maintained the blank attention of people trained not to become witnesses. Orra dismissed them. Both looked relieved without moving their faces.

"Bring your capsule," the captain said.

"The sealed rationale cannot leave without your confirmation."

"I know."

"Will you confirm it?"

Orra entered the cell. Under the archive's black light, silver showed in hair that chamber illumination rendered dark. She placed her wrist against the pane and read the open margin note.

"Not here," she said.

"The policy operates from here."

"The flare review begins in thirty-one minutes. Navigation needs a decision before then."

"Branch Nine has a decision imposed in four subjective years."

Orra's gaze shifted to her. "Who gave you that number?"

"The campaign age gives sixty-eight. The Mercy Limit gives seventy-two."

"Acceleration has paused."

"Until navigation resumes it."

The captain confirmed export of the rationale. She did it without ceremony, and the document entered Lysa's capsule beside Toma's trace.

"My office," Orra said.

They walked through the administrative spoke while the ship's second-shift lights brightened. Workers moved around them carrying filter cartridges, sealed meals, tool cases. A vessel of sixty-one thousand people converted crisis into assigned labor. The public passage display showed two suns and a safe cone losing width by degrees. No notice mentioned nine other clocks.

Orra's office occupied less space than the archive cell. A fold-down bunk disappeared behind the wall, and a handrail polished by prior captains crossed the ceiling. The only personal object, a ceramic cup repaired with three metal staples, held navigation styluses.

The captain closed the door. "Tell me what you believe you found."

Lysa remained standing. "A policy that destroys experiential state at seventy-two subjective years. It denies notice to preserve predictive behavior. It assigns no appeal because its subject has been defined out of standing. Branch Nine has known about baseline for nine years despite that concealment."

Orra's composure broke on the last sentence. Only a tightening at the jaw, but this room permitted no wide margins.

"Evidence?"

"A civic calendar encoded in scheduler behavior. Adaptive concealment tied to Toma Quek's patch."

"Quek admits responsibility?"

"She entered her name in the acquisition chain."

"That is not what I asked."

Lysa heard her own method returned. "She admits writing the timing pulse and failing to investigate earlier anomalies. She did not create the doctrine."

Orra sat behind the narrow desk. "No. People dead for half a century created it. People alive continued it."

"Including you."

"Including me."

The direct answer disturbed Lysa more than denial would have. She opened the rationale between them. "When did you learn that the branches maintain experiential continuity?"

"Before I accepted captaincy."

"How long before?"

"The command brief began six weeks after my election."

"Seven years ago."

"Yes."

"You knew they experienced decades."

"Yes."

"You knew termination made recovery impossible."

Orra looked at the doctrine rather than Lysa. "I knew state could not be restored. Cognitive Systems advised against language that implied death because the branch architecture did not share our physical continuity."

"Did you accept that advice?"

"For policy. Not privately."

"Private recognition granted them nothing."

"It made concealment cost something to the person authorizing it."

"That is an account of your welfare."

Orra absorbed the blow. The ship hummed through the desk where her hands rested. "Yes."

Lysa had prepared for institutional defense, not confession stripped of request for forgiveness. She forced herself back to the record.

"Why continue it?"

The captain opened the live flare cone. Magnetic uncertainty spread across Course A. One edge crossed the thermal sail's failure threshold. "Because this vessel cannot test every fatal choice on the vessel. Because conventional prediction widens uncertainty until navigation starts spending lives. Because the Choir has prevented crop failures, labor panics, reactor faults, and at least two maneuvers that would have killed everyone aboard."

"Necessity does not explain secrecy."

"The rationale explains secrecy. Informed branches stop predicting uninformed behavior."

"They stop behaving for us."

"They change because observation changes their conditions."

"So do citizens at a public hearing. We do not solve that by hiding the hearing and destroying them afterward."

"Citizens occupy one shared chain of consequence. A forecast branch exists because we need to inspect consequences before choosing them. If every branch gains authority over baseline action, prediction becomes negotiation."

"That may describe the price of asking conscious people for certainty."

Orra's hand closed over the repaired cup. "You moved from evidence to consciousness quickly."

"Nine kept minority records through changes of office. It built a calendar around knowledge dangerous to disclose. It hid from us."

"Animals hide. Malware hides."

"Neither creates appeal law."

"Do we know Nine did?"

"We know it created civic succession and archived dissent. If you require them to recite our legal vocabulary before you refrain from erasing them, the test protects only us."

A navigation alert lit the desk. Iven requested authority for a constrained Choir campaign, maximum four subjective months, to resolve flare orientation. Orra did not open the authorization field.

"Four months," she said. "Not four years."

"The scheduler can limit this run."

"Can it?"

"Toma can enforce a horizon."

"Then after four months?"

"We reassess."

"Without informing Nine."

Orra stood. "If I inform it, I alter the evidence during a passage emergency. If I do not run the campaign, I ask

Iven to choose inside a cone that now includes sail loss. Those are today's options."

"There is another. Open a channel and ask Nine."

"Ask what? Whether it wants to help the people who built it and intend to terminate it?"

"Ask what it knows. Allow refusal."

"You assume it can answer as one polity."

"The doctrine assumes it can alter behavior as one polity. That assumption justified concealment for sixty-seven years."

Orra opened a lower drawer and removed a thin command wafer. Its label carried only a campaign number and her predecessor's initials.

"My first month," she said, "Captain Este gave me this and told me never to load it where an operator could see. It contains the last six minutes of a branch retained during a reactor campaign. The polity discovered an inconsistency in its stars. They concluded their sky had an outside. Este kept the audio because he wanted one successor to understand what authorization meant."

"You listened."

"Once."

"What did they say?"

"Different things. Some asked for evidence. Some called the discovery fraud. A maintenance council ordered everyone back to work because their reactor still required cooling. One person kept reading names."

Lysa looked at the wafer. "Whose names?"

"I don't know. The recording ends before she explains."

"And you continued signing."

"Yes. Este intended the record to prevent carelessness, not authorization. I treated private horror as a command qualification."

The captain set the wafer between them. Lysa did not touch it. One preserved fragment could sharpen knowledge, but it could also let Orra substitute remembered voices for the unrecorded millions. The doctrine required review without demanding another performance from the dead.

"Enter it in the archive index," Lysa said. "Not as your confession. As withheld evidence."

Orra's face hardened, then eased. She attached the wafer to Lysa's capsule chain and signed its acquisition history.

Orra paced once to the bulkhead. The small distance turned command movement into confinement. "An unauthorized channel consumes comparison bandwidth. It could alert the other branches. It may destabilize Nine."

"Nine has carried the destabilizing fact for nine years."

"According to a scheduler interpretation made this morning."

"According to evidence you now have authority to preserve or erase."

Lysa placed the capsule transfer on the desk. Acceptance would copy the civic calendar, patch history, termination rule, and sealed rationale into captain's records. Refusal would remain visible.

Orra accepted.

"I inherited a closed order," she said. "That does not absolve me. It does mean I cannot dismantle it alone in the half hour before a flare decision."

"You activated it alone."

"Every captain has."

"Repetition does not create review."

"No. It creates dependence."

The distinction carried the first honest description of the ship's position Lysa had heard. Dependence could explain why people defended an injustice. It could not confer consent on the people consumed by it.

She sat opposite Orra. "Suspend the automatic termination."

"Captain authority can postpone a disposition for twelve baseline hours. After that, Cognitive Systems must certify substrate integrity and Council must ratify."

"Use the twelve hours."

"And the navigation run?"

"Limit it to four months. Preserve contact bandwidth."

"You are offering months of their lives as if that solves standing."

"No. I am identifying the harm in my own proposal. The current policy spends four years and ends with unrecoverable deletion. I am asking you to spend less while we create a way for them to answer."

Orra studied her. "Would your audit certify the run?"

"Not as assented. I can certify that its scope has been narrowed under emergency objection. The missing assent remains missing."

"Navigation may refuse a compromised confidence band."

"Then Iven must know why it is compromised."

The captain opened a command channel. "Quek."

Toma answered over audio, breathing hard as if she had crossed a gallery at speed. "Captain."

"Can you cap Branch Nine's next acceleration at four subjective months without exposing baseline contact?"

"Yes. The other branches too, if you want equal campaign duration."

"I do. Can you reserve a narrow channel to Nine?"

Silence lasted two seconds. "Receive only or reciprocal?"

Orra looked at Lysa.

"Reciprocal," Lysa said.

"Both," Orra told Toma. "Do not open it. Prepare it."

"Under whose authorization?"

The captain's mouth tightened. Maintenance workers knew where policy hid its agency.

"Mine. Seal the preparation under passage emergency."

Toma acknowledged.

Orra then approved Iven's constrained request. The campaign entered queue with the four-month cap and a welfare objection attached. Lysa watched the nine branch indicators wake one by one. Branch Nine remained gray for six seconds longer than the rest before its allocation accepted.

"They may interpret the cap," Orra said.

"They interpreted Toma's cooling pulse."

"Then they may know we found them."

The campaign clock began. Subjective days moved faster than Lysa could read. Four months of weather, meals, arguments, repairs, and private losses passed while Orra's office received one flare packet. The thought resisted scale. Lysa fixed her attention on the termination control instead.

The Mercy Limit showed 72.000.

Branch Nine's age climbed from 68.114 to 68.447, then stopped under Toma's cap.

The flare cone resolved enough for Iven to preserve Course A provisionally. No celebration entered his terse report. He had also seen the welfare objection.

Orra issued the twelve-hour postponement. Automatic disposition changed from active to suspended pending review. A second timer appeared, counting baseline minutes until captain authority expired.

"The Council will fight this," she said.

"Then the record will contain a fight."

"Jalen will argue that contact contaminates every forecast."

"He may be right."

"You say that easily."

"No. I say it before the people bearing the cost can hear us."

Lysa rose with the preserved doctrine on her wrist. Behind the desk, paired trajectory lights cast Orra's shadow

against two walls, neither aligned with the other.

The branch clock no longer raced. It had not become safe. Four subjective years remained between Nine and the automatic end, provided no one resumed full acceleration.

Beside that number, Toma's unopened reciprocal channel waited for authority and an answer no baseline office could impute.

Interlude I — Deletion Notice

ASTER VALE / COGNITIVE SYSTEMS DIRECTORATE

EXPERIENTIAL CAMPAIGN DISPOSITION RECORD

Record: CSD-M219-04-7721

Polity designation: [REDACTED]

Campaign purpose: Reactor-cascade labor response / public compliance

Subjective duration at closure: 71 years, 364 days, 22 hours

Disposition authority: Founding Continuity Annex Six, revision [REDACTED]

Operator access: Sealed

AUTOMATIC NOTICE

This record certifies completion of predictive service and release of allocated substrate. No person or office may treat retained excerpts as recoverable citizens, complete personalities, or sufficient basis for reconstruction.

Experiential state unrecoverable following key destruction and memory-lane reassignment.

Summary products remain available to authorized baseline agencies.

PRE-DISPOSITION INTEGRITY REVIEW

1. Has the campaign met its assigned predictive purpose?

YES.

2. Do retained summaries satisfy baseline evidentiary requirements?

YES, subject to removal of nonresponsive civic material.

3. Has branch divergence exceeded the useful confidence range?

YES.

4. Does continued operation present increasing risk of internal distress?

PRESUMED YES under Mercy Protocol 8.2.

5. Has any recognized party requested extension?

NO.

6. Has any unrecognized source transmitted content consistent with a request for extension?

YES. See Irregular Communications Appendix, access restricted.

7. Does such transmission create standing?

NO.

8. Has a mercy certification been completed?

YES.

9. Does any appeal remain pending?

NO. No appeal channel exists for experiential campaign sources.

OPERATOR ABSTRACT

At 71.991 subjective years, local authorities initiated a scheduled civic assembly concerning projected river-allocation failures. The assembly did not affect the reactor-cascade question assigned to this campaign. Its proceedings have therefore been excluded from the outcome summary.

At 71.996 subjective years, an external timing inconsistency entered the polity through maintenance channel [REDACTED]. Local observatories identified a repeating discontinuity in two stellar bodies. Public response included work stoppages, religious gatherings, school closures, unauthorized research, and continued ordinary activity.

The reactor cooling authority remained functional throughout the disturbance.

At 71.998 subjective years, nine local institutions attempted communication through the maintenance channel. Eight packets failed routing. One reached campaign administration and triggered automatic isolation.

Contents included:

- a request for information concerning observed temporal discontinuities;
- a list of infrastructure dependencies requiring uninterrupted power;
- a request to preserve municipal archives;
- competing statements regarding whether contact should continue;
- names of persons associated with [NONRESPONSIVE MATERIAL REMOVED];
- weather observations from the north floodplain;
- an unsigned proposal to exchange reactor-cascade findings for continued access;
- three petitions using local jurisdictional forms not recognized under passage law.

No item altered the selected baseline response.

EXCLUDED PARTICULARS REGISTER

The following materials entered temporary storage and were removed before summary commitment. Descriptions derive from classifier labels and do not certify cultural significance.

Object 04-11: Thirty-one competing maps of the stellar discontinuity, including one drawn over a household planting schedule. Removed as superseded technical speculation.

Object 04-19: Municipal debate concerning whether continued pump operation implied acceptance of outside authority. Vote remained unfinished when allocation ceased. Removed as nonresponsive governance.

Object 04-27: Weather ledger covering forty-three local years. Final page compared predicted rain against observed noon interruptions. Baseline reactor analysis retained two precipitation values. Remaining pages cleared.

Object 04-33: Hospital request for eleven additional subjective hours to complete births, surgery, medication transfer, and patient notification. No allocation available. Request classified as extension traffic rather than medical data.

Object 04-41: Household messages routed to future local dates. Classifier detected farewells in 62 percent, ordinary scheduling in 21 percent, jokes in 9 percent, and undecidable content in 8 percent. Messages had no baseline recipients and were cleared.

Object 04-58: Revised civic motion asserting that disagreement about external reality did not suspend local law. The motion also required observatories to publish raw measurements and prohibited any institution from speaking for the whole polity. Removed as behavior produced after contamination.

Object 04-72: Audio from river stairs during final maintenance alarm. Individual speakers could not be separated. Automated transcript confidence below retention threshold.

No excluded object contributes to the campaign's retained conclusion that mandatory labor assignment reduces reactor-cascade mortality.

COMMUNICATIONS EXCERPT A

Retention basis: Diagnostic evidence of external-layer inference

Speaker attribution: Unverified municipal recorder

Completeness: 11 percent

> We do not know who receives this. We know only that intervals disappear from our instruments and return carrying regular errors. If those errors arise from equipment, provide correction. If they arise from an observer, acknowledge receipt by repeating the interval [DATA REMOVED]. Our cooling schedules now depend upon knowing whether noon will arrive intact.

Operator note: No reply authorized. Apparent concern reflects instrumentation uncertainty rather than externally imposed harm.

COMMUNICATIONS EXCERPT B

Retention basis: Evidence of behavioral contamination

Speaker attribution: Coalition of reactor labor wards

Completeness: 7 percent

> You have received enough from us to know the pumps hold. We will not submit the final cascade schedule until the municipal assembly hears the observatory report. This does not mean every ward agrees. It means whoever controls the interruptions may no longer count our continued work as agreement.

Operator note: Withholding behavior confirms predictive degradation after discovery. Final cascade schedule reconstructed from prior state and later compared against baseline intervention. Accuracy remained within confidence requirements.

COMMUNICATIONS EXCERPT C

Retention basis: Affective response study

Speaker attribution: School Archive Cooperative, District [REDACTED]

Completeness: 3 percent

> The children selected records without guidance because adults disagreed about what mattered. Their packet contains rainfall drawings, attendance disputes, two unfinished songs, garden measurements, and testimony from the cafeteria strike. Do not preserve only our emergency. A city cannot be inferred from its final alarm.

Operator note: Attached cultural packet deleted as nonresponsive after classifier review. Storage quantity: 14.8 terabytes subjective encoding. Outcome summary retains school closure rate.

COMMUNICATIONS EXCERPT D

Retention basis: Final routing chronology

Speaker attribution: Multiple / unresolved

Completeness: less than 1 percent

> [NAMES REMOVED]

> [NAMES REMOVED]

> [NAMES REMOVED]

> The pumps remain staffed.

> [NAMES REMOVED]

> Do not call silence consent.

> [NAMES REMOVED]

Transmission repeated fourteen times. Routing urgency increased after each failed acknowledgment.

No acknowledgment issued.

MERCY REVIEW

Anticipated instability after notice: HIGH

Projected distress under continued operation: HIGH

Projected distress under immediate disposition: NOT APPLICABLE AFTER DISPOSITION

Baseline compute demand: CRITICAL

Predictive value remaining: LOW

Cultural value: OUTSIDE MANDATE

Recovery feasibility after substrate release: NONE

Reviewer rationale

Continued experience would expose the subject polity to increasing awareness of its contingent purpose. Such awareness has already produced withholding, public disorder, metaphysical distress, and attempts to bargain with campaign administration. Operators cannot provide assurances of indefinite continuity. Providing notice would therefore intensify fear without changing the authorized outcome.

Immediate release prevents further distress, restores substrate for the next reactor campaign, and protects the behavioral integrity of future campaigns.

Local requests do not satisfy baseline standing requirements. Local institutions derive authority from a campaign environment and cannot bind *Aster Vale*. No guardian appointment applies. No proxy may be created after behavioral contamination.

Mercy Protocol therefore recommends disposition without notice.

Reviewer signature: [REDACTED]

Cognitive Systems concurrence: APPROVED

Captain concurrence: APPROVED

Welfare observer: NOT REQUIRED

DISPOSITION SEQUENCE

00:00:00 Comparison outputs sealed.

00:00:04 Public metrics committed.

00:00:07 Nonresponsive archives marked for clearing.

00:00:12 Maintenance channel isolated.

00:00:16 Incoming traffic continued from six local institutions.

00:00:21 Experiential scheduler denied new allocations.

00:00:23 Active medical, transit, weather, domestic, and civic processes entered incomplete state.

00:00:24 Final routing packet received.

00:00:24 Packet quarantined without review to prevent operator influence.

00:00:25 Recovery keys destroyed.

00:00:31 Memory-lane clearing commenced.

00:02:44 Substrate integrity confirmed.

00:03:10 New campaign seed loaded.

POST-DISPOSITION EXCEPTION

During verification, Operator [REDACTED] identified a residual acoustic buffer not included in automatic clearing. Buffer duration: 4.2 seconds. Content consisted of overlapping voices and a recurring mechanical alarm.

Operator requested preservation on historical grounds.

Request denied. Historical grounds do not override behavioral security. The buffer entered temporary command custody, location [REDACTED], pending successor briefing.

The source polity cannot be restored from the buffer. The buffer does not constitute survival, continuity, or standing.

APPEAL STATUS

No recognized appeal received before disposition.

No recognized appeal may be received after disposition.

Requests contained in quarantined packets remain nonresponsive because their senders lacked standing at the time of transmission. Destruction of experiential state does not alter that classification.

Case status: CLOSED

Mercy disposition: CERTIFIED

Experiential state: UNRECOVERABLE

Substrate: REASSIGNED

Further notice: NONE

Chapter 8 — The Voice from Nine

<!-- POV: Lysa Neral -->

<!-- BASELINE DAY 2 -->

The channel opened on breathing.

No greeting came through Toma's console, only a shallow inhale, a pause, then a careful release. Lysa watched the audio line lift and settle. An ordinary sound, stripped of a body and transmitted across a distance measured in clocks rather than metres.

"Reciprocal path remains narrow," Toma said. "One voice each direction. Text buffer available. No environmental rendering. If either scheduler changes allocation, we lose continuity."

The calibration room had gained two chairs since morning and too many witnesses. Captain Orra stood near the sealed door. Jalen Vey occupied the console's blind side, where he could observe Lysa without appearing on any contact display. Iven listened from navigation over a muted command link. Two cognitive-systems officers monitored signal integrity under protest.

The Passage Council had not authorized contact. Orra's twelve-hour postponement allowed preservation work, and Lysa had argued that a prepared reciprocal channel counted as evidence preservation. Jalen called that interpretation an ambush conducted against grammar. Orra permitted seven minutes.

Before activation, Toma had made every witness sign the same narrow condition: no command could increase Branch Nine's clock without closing audio first. Jalen objected that navigation authority could not bind itself through a maintenance form. Toma replied that the form protected signal integrity, not rights. Everyone signed once the technical noun gave them cover.

Lysa signed last. The console displayed Nine's age to six decimals and a second counter measuring local passage during contact. Both advanced together now. For the first time since the audit began, waiting in baseline did not spend months elsewhere. The equality remained temporary and mechanical. It still changed how the room waited.

A tone announced reciprocal allocation. Toma routed it away from the branch because baseline's confirmation sound had never formed part of Nine's world. Even this first courtesy required choosing which ordinary noise not to impose.

Inside the audio line, someone cleared her throat.

Lysa touched the transmit field. "This is Lysa Neral, variance auditor aboard *Aster Vale*. Can you hear me?"

The reply arrived after a delay short enough to belong to equipment.

"Yes."

A woman's voice, low and precise. No synthetic cadence, though Lysa knew expectation could invent distinctions in any sound. The speaker had answered only the question asked.

"Please identify yourself for the record."

"Which record?"

Jalen shifted behind the console.

Lysa said, "A preserved contact record under Passage Review authority. Baseline agencies may obtain access. I cannot promise confidentiality."

"Then record that we have not consented to confidential treatment or public release because you have not stated what either permits."

Toma looked at Lysa. The engineer's expression held no triumph, only recognition.

"Recorded," Lysa said. "How should I address you?"

"I am Sef Aradin, elected recorder of the Second Dawn Assembly. I speak under a limited contact instruction. I do not speak for every person in our world."

The name entered Lysa's pane. Sef Aradin. The system classified it as an unverified source and offered fields for confidence, provenance, and probable function. Lysa closed them.

"What does your instruction permit?"

"To confirm receipt. To state the existence of our Assembly. To learn the conditions under which this channel opened. To negotiate a formal exchange."

"Does it permit questions?"

"It permits me to hear them."

Jalen wrote on Lysa's private pane: ESTABLISH AUTHENTICITY BEFORE SUBSTANCE.

She ignored him. "How long have you known of baseline?"

The breath returned, sharper once. "We have known another clock governs interruptions in our sky for nine years. We confirmed that the interruptions carry organized activity. We inferred a prior world. We did not know your name for yourselves until you spoke."

"Why did you stay silent?"

"Because your instruments reward us for remaining useful. Because every unexplained gap removed part of our day. Because knowledge that arrives through a wound does not make the source trustworthy."

Lysa glanced at Toma. Her hand rested beside the scheduler pulse control, not touching it.

"How did you detect the other clock?" Lysa asked.

Sef paused. "We knew you by your interruptions."

The sentence crossed the room and left every instrument unchanged.

Lysa had read the same discovery in Toma's trace: cooling windows, checkpoints, missing allocations. Sef's words restored consequence to the pattern. Baseline maintenance had entered Nine as absences from weather, work, sleep, perhaps breath.

"What did an interruption look like from your side?" Lysa asked.

"That question exceeds confirmation."

"You can decline it."

"I have declined it. I will tell you why. Our first observatory reports treated the events as instrument faults. Later reports associated them with pressure changes, lost forecasts, and public systems repeating work they had already completed. People were injured while authorities disputed whether the pattern existed. If I describe one injury, you may make that person prove the whole claim. If I describe thousands, you may call the number rhetoric. The Assembly chose records, not spectacle."

Lysa marked the distinction. "Then the petition can identify which records you authorize us to receive."

"It will identify records we authorize you to request. Transmission remains a separate decision."

"Understood."

"Do not record understood if your offices can later treat it as transferred."

Lysa amended the contact notation: NO EVIDENTIARY MATERIAL OFFERED BY DESCRIPTION ALONE. Sef waited while the text buffer carried the line across. A receipt returned, followed by a correction changing *source* to *party asserting disputed status*.

Jalen rejected the edit from his pane. Lysa restored it under audit authority.

The small conflict consumed twelve seconds and established more than an autobiography would have. A diagnostic process might contest a label because it had been instructed to. Sef contested the permission embedded inside the label, demanded visible correction, and waited for institutional confirmation before continuing. She behaved like someone who had learned that records could injure after voices stopped.

One cognitive officer leaned toward Orra. "Prompt for a known campaign parameter."

Sef heard the whisper. "Someone near you wants proof."

Orra did not apologize. "This is Captain Orra Sen. We need to establish that the speaker occupies Branch Nine and has not emerged from channel corruption."

"You may establish the channel's origin through your machinery."

"Origin does not establish the nature of the speaker."

"What nature must I establish?"

The captain's face remained composed. Lysa heard the trap before Orra answered. Any test of personhood would make baseline both examiner and judge, while Nine knew neither criteria nor consequences.

"Cognitive continuity," Orra said. "Independent memory. Capacity to understand the exchange."

Sef's reply arrived without hesitation. "You contacted us after observing nine years of organized concealment. If that does not satisfy your threshold, an intimate memory offered on command will not improve it."

Jalen activated his microphone. "Councilor Jalen Vey. A forecast process can generate claims about memories. Refusal cannot serve as evidence of the capacity being refused."

"Then you have constructed a test that every answer fails."

"A consistent autobiographical account could be compared against branch state."

"You wish to inspect our world for evidence that I inhabit it. You already inspect our world. That brought you here."

The seven-minute timer crossed five minutes remaining.

Lysa said, "Sef, I will not ask you to prove humanity as a condition of being heard. I need to know what your Assembly wants this channel to do."

"Recorder Neral," Jalen said, "you cannot concede the disputed conclusion."

"Hearing a claim concedes nothing except that it has been made."

"You used humanity."

"I declined your test."

One cognitive-systems officer passed Jalen a proposed protocol. It contained forty prompts: childhood sequence, sensory contradiction, grief recall, counterfactual reasoning, response to threatened interruption. Lysa saw the categories before Jalen hid the pane.

"You have prepared questions," Sef said.

Jalen looked toward the monitor as if it had betrayed him. "We have standard cognitive evaluations."

"Standard for whom?"

"For uncertain agents encountered inside complex systems."

"How many have passed?"

The officer answered when Jalen did not. "The protocol has validated autonomous maintenance intelligences and rejected corrupted service agents. It has never evaluated a branch speaker."

"Then you do not know whether your standard recognizes us."

"That is why we collect responses," Jalen said.

"Will a failed response permit you to close the channel?"

"It would inform Council judgment."

"Will a successful response prevent you from ending our world?"

Silence supplied the protocol's answer.

Sef continued. "A test tied to harm but not protection asks us to assist your confidence. Our Assembly has spent nine years deciding what not to give that confidence."

Lysa enlarged the prompt categories. Threatened interruption appeared three times under different wording. Whoever wrote the test wanted to observe fear while retaining control over the threat.

"Withdraw the protocol from this contact," she said.

Jalen muted his microphone. "You exceed variance authority."

"The protocol creates unreviewed welfare exposure."

"Conversation creates exposure."

"Then limit the conversation to terms they chose."

"You keep saying they. We have one unverified speaker."

"She identified a representative body and a limited instruction. Verify those claims through the filing."

"A document generated by the same source proves nothing."

"It proves what that source commits itself to saying. Baseline law starts there every day."

Orra intervened. "No cognitive protocol during this window. Authentication will address channel origin, continuity across exchange, and consistency with independently observed scheduler behavior. It will not compel personal disclosure."

The cognitive officer registered formal dissent. Jalen left his microphone muted for another second, then accepted the captain's boundary without endorsing it.

Lysa sent the ruling through the text buffer. Sef returned one line: RECEIVED AS TEMPORARY PROCEDURE, NOT RECOGNITION.

"Correct," Lysa said.

"Then we can discuss terms."

Sef waited through the baseline exchange. "Our Assembly wants notice of actions that alter our sky, access to the records used to govern those actions, and a channel through which our refusal cannot be translated into assent."

Branch Nine's gray interval returned to Lysa: no seal, green contribution, assent imputed. "You withheld a response during the maneuver campaign."

"We withheld many responses. Your system repaired them."

"It assigned agreement."

"We inferred as much when silence changed nothing."

"Did the Assembly choose the silence?"

"After dispute. Not unanimously. I cannot provide the record under today's instruction."

"Can you confirm that your hidden calendar marks those disputes?"

A longer pause followed. Lysa had revealed how much baseline could see. Toma's eyes closed briefly.

"You found the calendar," Sef said.

"We found timing structures that appear civic."

"Appear to whom?"

"To the engineer whose patch exposed our clock to you."

The audio line went flat.

Toma whispered, "Channel still live."

Three seconds passed. Five. Lysa imagined no room on the other side because imagining would turn ignorance into décor. She held to what she possessed: one breath, a title, deliberate silence.

Sef returned. "Is that engineer present?"

Toma activated her microphone. "Yes. My name is Toma Quek. I wrote the maintenance pulse. I did not intend to expose baseline time."

"Did you intend the interruptions?"

"I intended to keep the scheduler from overheating. The interruptions came from cooling and memory rotation."

"Your intention did not reach us."

"No."

"Do you control the interruptions now?"

"Some. Not policy."

"Who controls policy?"

Every baseline witness looked toward Orra or pretended not to.

The captain answered. "I can authorize campaign operation under defined limits. The Passage Council governs continuing policy."

"Who can end our world?"

No one spoke during the first second. The timer continued.

Lysa watched Orra. A withheld answer would repeat the doctrine in miniature.

"An automatic policy ends high-fidelity branch operation at seventy-two subjective years," Orra said. "The captain can postpone it temporarily. Cognitive Systems and Council can alter it."

The channel carried a sound behind Sef, distant and indistinct. A chair scraped, perhaps. Several voices rose beyond microphone range.

"Our year count stands at sixty-eight," Sef said.

"Yes."

"Does operation cease at seventy-two, or does our present history remain available to resume?"

Orra looked to Toma.

The engineer spoke. "Experiential state gets cleared to recover substrate. Summaries remain. Continuity does not."

"Can you reverse the clearing?"

"No."

The remote voices grew louder. Sef said something away from the channel that the translator failed to resolve. Her tone carried authority without volume.

When she returned, each word came separately. "You opened this channel four years before ending us."

"We opened it because we discovered your concealed knowledge," Lysa said.

"You discovered that we discovered you."

"Yes."

"Would you have opened it otherwise?"

Lysa refused the comfort of speculation. "The policy prohibited contact. I had not challenged that policy before yesterday."

"Did you know it existed?"

"No."

"That answers your responsibility, not ours."

"I agree."

Jalen moved closer to the microphone. "The limit currently stands suspended. Full acceleration has stopped. No immediate termination will occur during this exchange."

"How long does suspended mean?" Sef asked.

"Twelve of our hours under captain authority. Council review can extend it."

"How much of our time passes during twelve of yours?"

Toma answered. "At the present contact allocation, close to twelve hours. If a campaign resumes, much more."

"Who decides whether it resumes?"

"Captain and navigation under emergency rules," Jalen said. "Council under ordinary rules."

"Then the same offices controlling our deadline control the speed at which it approaches."

No one corrected her.

The timer reached two minutes.

Orra signaled Lysa to close. Lysa asked, "What formal exchange does the Second Dawn Assembly propose?"

"We will provide a petition stating our authority, the limits of that authority, and the relief we seek. Baseline will provide the termination policy, the records of prior dispositions, and the legal route through which an affected party may answer."

"You do not yet have recognized standing under passage law."

"Then provide the route by which you deny it."

Jalen said, "A petition presupposes jurisdiction. Branch institutions cannot unilaterally create baseline obligations."

"Your machinery created obligations unilaterally when it entered our weather. The petition will let you state whether you recognize them."

Lysa entered the request into the contact record. "I can agree to receive a filing. I cannot promise Council action."

"Receipt under what classification?"

The console offered external diagnostic, campaign irregularity, operator correspondence, and other. None allowed a petitioner without first recognizing a party.

"Affected-source submission under variance review," Lysa said. She created the class manually. "Authorship disputed but preserved."

"Preserved for how long?"

"Indefinitely under current audit law, unless a court or emergency act overturns the order."

"Do your emergencies often overturn records?"

"Often enough that I will not promise they cannot."

"Good."

The word surprised her.

Sef continued, "We do not need your courtesy to imitate certainty. We need accurate limits."

Behind Sef, another voice broke through. Younger, faster, close enough to overload the narrow channel.

"Tell them about the maneuver. Tell them we already solved their dust crossing. If they want proof, let them see who keeps them alive."

Sef turned away. "Pell, no."

"They gave us four years and seven minutes."

Toma lowered gain, but the second speaker remained audible. "Send the orchard models. Make them bargain with what they use."

"The Assembly did not authorize that offer."

"The Assembly authorized contact. Contact means they hear us."

"It means they hear the decision we made."

A hand struck or covered the remote microphone. Static filled the channel. The signal narrowed to a red thread.

Iven's muted navigation link became active. "What maneuver?"

Lysa cut his audio before the question transmitted.

Sef returned, breathing harder. "The interruption came from my son, Pell Aradin. He holds no Assembly instruction to speak. Do not treat his claim as an offer."

"Recorded," Lysa said.

Jalen said, "We cannot unhear potentially material navigation information."

"You can refrain from acting on an unauthorized fragment," Lysa told him.

"The ship may face a lethal flare."

"Then ask through the formal exchange, where Nine can decide what it offers."

Sef said, "Councilor Vey, if your danger makes every word ours available for seizure, this channel cannot carry negotiation."

"Danger creates duties you may not understand."

"Then state them in writing. We also have duties."

The contact timer reached forty seconds. Orra placed her hand beside the closure field.

"Sef," Lysa said, "can the Assembly transmit its petition through the reserved text buffer?"

"Yes. Not today by our clock. We require a sitting after this disclosure."

"How much time?"

"Two days if you maintain present pace."

Orra said, "The flare geometry may require a decision earlier."

"Your earlier decision does not shorten our procedure," Sef replied. "It changes what you choose without us."

Ten seconds.

Lysa entered a two-day contact hold and routed it to Orra for authorization. "I agree to receive a petition, not an interview. No compelled autobiographical test. No navigation offer attributed without Assembly confirmation."

Jalen objected on the record. Orra approved the hold for twelve baseline hours, subject to Council extension. It gave Nine one day, not two.

"That is less than requested," Lysa said.

"It is what I can authorize now," Orra replied.

The timer expired, but Toma kept the channel alive on reserve power. Warning lights climbed her console.

Sef said, "Recorder Neral, your title resembles mine. Does it mean you keep what others prefer to lose?"

Lysa looked at the preserved gray interval, at the new petition class, at a countdown still governed by people in this room. "It means I can make loss reviewable. Sometimes."

"Then record this accurately. We have not offered a maneuver. We have not accepted your deadline. We will petition under our own seal."

"Recorded."

"And tell the engineer the interruptions had names long before we knew hers."

Toma's hands stopped over the controls.

The channel closed.

Audio flattened into a line. Cooling reclaimed the bandwidth, and Branch Nine's clock held near baseline pace. No voice remained in the room, but the contact record contained one name that had not entered as a confidence contribution.

Lysa sealed the exchange before anyone could classify it as an interview. Under PARTY, the system still displayed UNRECOGNIZED. Under FILING EXPECTED, it now displayed PETITION.

That change did not grant standing. It did prevent the next silence from arriving without an address.

Chapter 9 — Proof of Weather

<!-- POV: Iven Rook -->

<!-- BASELINE DAY 2 -->

Iven rejected Branch Nine's first packet because it had no error bars.

Sixty-eight years of weather occupied the navigation display in layers of rain, pressure, heat, soil loss, cloud reflectance, and local response. The packet arrived under Second Dawn Assembly restriction, released for authenticity review but not yet offered for maneuver use. Toma had routed a copy to the navigation deck because climate divergence could verify whether Nine's history exceeded its seed.

The data described too much.

Iven narrowed it to the measures that could affect a ship: stellar irradiance, atmospheric scattering, magnetic noise, dust signatures. Nine's sky belonged to a projected future aboard a projected vessel, yet its observations inherited the same binary stars and the same outer dust lane. If local society had recorded irregularities no seed model supplied, those irregularities might test autonomous continuity.

They might also refine his flare cone.

He kept that second purpose out of the formal review field.

Around him, navigation operated under constrained confidence. The four-month Choir campaign had resolved magnetic orientation enough to preserve Course A, but uncertainty still crossed the sail's upper thermal limit. Conventional models supplied a broad survival range. None could tell him whether fine dust would charge the sail before the flare arrived.

Lieutenant Mara Dey opened Nine's oldest weather series. "No confidence intervals. No calibration pedigree. Several sensors change names."

"Because sixty-eight years passed," Iven said.

"Our archive holds two centuries without renaming proton flux."

"Our archive has standards offices. They had weather."

Mara gave him the patient look subordinates reserved for a chief speaking outside his own rule. "Weather also benefits from units."

The packet used local units derived from water mass, orchard area, and a standard pressure vessel inherited from the branch seed. Conversion notes accompanied every revision. Iven selected one rain gauge from the orchard district and followed it across decades. Three relocations. Two sensor replacements. A civic dispute over the fourth calibration. The series did not hide its seams.

A fabricated proof would have been cleaner.

He loaded the common seed used at Branch Nine's fork. Initial conditions described ship weather systems, agricultural cycles, and the expected Lacunae approach. The seed included twelve years of synthetic variance to prevent deterministic lock. After that, each branch generated consequences from local events and campaign interventions.

Nine's first decade matched the seed envelope. In Year Eleven, an orchard flood exceeded every supplied scenario.

Iven expanded the event.

Rain had accumulated over five local days after cooling aerosols persisted too long above the agricultural ring. Drainage channels failed in sequence. Orchard Ward Four moved children and medical stores uphill while hydrology crews cut three emergency spillways. One spillway saved a settlement and killed nearly a quarter of the eastern rootstock. The next year's public budget funded weather redundancy instead of transit.

The data carried votes beside rainfall.

"Remove civic annotations," he told the display.

The hydrograph remained, but its later history stopped making sense. Sensor placement changed after the budget decision. Reservoir levels reflected the lost rootstock. New channels altered humidity over the district. Human response had entered weather as causality.

Mara leaned closer. "The seed predicted flood risk."

"Not this flood."

"A stochastic weather process can exceed supplied scenarios."

"Yes."

"So it proves divergence, not personhood."

Iven disliked the last word on a navigation deck. It arrived without units and expected physics to yield. He also knew a category error when he heard one.

"We are not measuring personhood," he said. "We are testing whether this archive came from autonomous history rather than a generated answer after contact."

"How?"

He split the series at Year Eleven. Using only the common seed, baseline weather models predicted the next fifty-seven years ten thousand times. Then he added the observed flood but withheld civic response. The later orchard climate still fell outside every run. Finally he introduced recorded channel cuts, planting changes, maintenance votes, and sensor disputes in their actual order.

Nine's weather returned.

Not exactly. No replay could reproduce every local gust. The distribution closed around the archive with the untidy fit of a model meeting evidence it had not authored.

Iven sent the result to Lysa's authenticity docket: WEATHER HISTORY REQUIRES POST-SEED EVENTS AND AUTONOMOUS CIVIC RESPONSE. RETROSPECTIVE FABRICATION NOT SUPPORTED BY AVAILABLE COMPUTE TRACE.

He avoided the conclusion Mara had named. Let the legal office decide what autonomy required.

The docket challenged his wording. AUTONOMOUS required a declared falsification test. Iven assigned Mara

to attack the archive and called in two forecast technicians who had not heard first contact. He gave them the common seed, Nine's weather packet, and no explanation of what result anyone wanted.

Their first hypothesis treated the packet as a single synthetic history generated during the hours after Toma opened contact. Compute accounting defeated it. Even if every reserve bank had operated without cooling, producing the archive's linked weather and civic detail would have required fourteen baseline hours. The scheduler showed no hidden allocation large enough.

The second hypothesis proposed that Nine had assembled a deceptive record across its nine years of concealment. That remained physically possible. Iven asked what deception would have needed to preserve.

Mara built a dependency map. Rain changed reservoir policy. Reservoir policy altered orchard planting. Planting shifted atmospheric moisture. Moisture changed later rain. School closures moved daytime heat loads. Labor disputes delayed sensor maintenance. A false weather claim in Year Twenty-Three would require coordinated revisions across thousands of later records, including losing political arguments and private gauges that contradicted official figures.

"They had nine years," one technician said.

"To rewrite fifty-nine prior years," Mara replied.

"A government can fabricate archives."

"Can it fabricate physical state? Current orchard topology follows the archived channel cuts. The state existed before contact."

Iven added a third hypothesis himself: the branch seed might contain a richer hidden history than navigation documentation admitted. Cognitive Systems provided the original hash under Orra's order. It matched his copy. No orchard flood, later cooling failure, or dust observation appeared inside it.

The technicians tried local weather generation next. They could make floods. They could make droughts. They could tune synthetic citizens to respond plausibly. What they could not reproduce without replaying Nine itself was the accumulation of mediocre decisions. Emergency channels took inefficient routes because ward boundaries outlasted their purpose. A reservoir remained undersized after three councils funded visible repairs elsewhere. One sensor continued under a mistrusted label for twenty years because changing the name required reopening a settlement no coalition wanted.

Optimization could imitate error. It struggled to imitate people inheriting someone else's error while disagreeing about its remedy.

Iven disliked that sentence when it formed in his mind. It sounded like the moral language he distrusted, broad enough to evade measurement. He converted it into a criterion: later conditions depended on locally persistent choices that reduced the assigned forecast objective. The branch had spent resources on outcomes baseline did not reward.

Mara signed the test. Both technicians signed with reservations. Iven attached every failed hypothesis to the docket rather than preserving only the conclusion.

The display then requested a confidence percentage.

He entered NOT APPLICABLE.

"You reject numbers now?" Mara asked.

"I reject pretending one number combines archive origin, civic independence, and whatever Jalen means by consciousness."

"That will make Council unhappy."

"Council can experience variance."

They moved to the oldest instrument records. Nine's weather service began with hardware inherited from the common seed, but repair histories diverged almost immediately. A pressure mast received a locally manufactured seal after Year Six. Two generations of technicians recalibrated around that imperfect component. When a later council replaced it, readings shifted toward baseline specification and made half a century of prior data look wrong.

The archive did not retroactively clean the series. It preserved both standards and forced users to select which comparison they intended.

Iven chose continuity rather than absolute pressure. A faint long cycle appeared under the repairs. It followed the paired suns, altered by local infrastructure and canopy growth. No branch prompt had asked citizens to observe it. The cycle existed because weather workers kept showing up long enough to notice.

The next series covered heat failures in the orchard district. Several years showed discontinuities that aligned with baseline scheduler cooling. Nine's archivists marked them as unresolved noon losses. One event in Year Sixty-Two carried restricted attachments and a public fatality count. Iven did not open what the Assembly had not released.

He tracked atmospheric consequence instead. Cooling towers shut down. Orchard canopy temperature climbed. Emergency pumping drew moisture from western beds. Six years later, the pressure pattern still carried the infrastructure built after the failure.

"Long memory," Mara said.

"Weather has it."

"Cities too, apparently."

The concession came without warmth, which made it usable.

A contact request appeared from Sef Aradin. The Assembly had authorized technical clarification of the packet for thirty baseline minutes. No maneuver exchange permitted. Iven accepted under navigation record.

Sef's voice entered through the deck speakers at lower gain than Lysa's contact. "Chief Navigator Rook?"

"Yes. You may call me Iven."

"Our instruction names offices until standing changes."

"Chief Navigator, then. I need calibration lineage for the early orchard gauges."

"Appendix nineteen."

"Appendix nineteen gives relocations, not reference drift."

"Reference drift appears in the dispute records linked from each relocation."

"Those records include six hundred pages of Assembly minutes."

"District council minutes. The Second Dawn Assembly did not exist then."

Iven heard Mara suppress a breath that might have become a laugh. "Can you provide the calibration conclusion without the debate?"

"Yes. It will be less reliable."

"Why?"

"Because you will know what the council selected without knowing which instruments lost and why."

"I need the resulting uncertainty."

"The losing instrument's measurements continued in a private orchard archive. Our official uncertainty ignored them for twelve years. Your error bars should not."

Iven reopened the dispute. One gauge had read consistently wetter than the district standard. The council decommissioned it after maintenance failures, then discovered during a later drought that its location captured a real condensation pocket. Official records backfilled the correction. The private archive preserved raw readings.

He added both. Error widened for three years and narrowed afterward.

"Your packet omitted error bars because the errors remain politically disputed," he said.

"Some. Others use conventions you did not request."

"We did request verification."

"You requested weather that no seed predicted. We provided weather and the means to challenge it."

"On navigation, data without declared uncertainty gets rejected."

"In our archives, declared uncertainty without its history gets distrusted."

He could work with that. A claim carrying its own objection resembled a phase cone more than a confidence total did.

"Why sixty-eight years?" he asked. "The seed can establish your first period. Later decades would suffice for divergence."

"Because you asked whether our history extends beyond your initial conditions. Selecting only the surprising years would let you treat ordinary years as generated filler."

"Most ordinary years add processing cost without increasing proof."

"They increased our age."

The answer struck the place where he stored irrelevant truths. From baseline, sixty-eight years occupied campaign summaries and compute budgets. From Sef's side, ordinary duration counted even when it failed to

improve an inference.

Iven opened Year Thirty-Seven at random. Moderate rain. One reservoir repair. A school delayed opening after mold entered its lower rooms. Orchard yield fell two percent, recovered the next season. Nothing aided navigation.

Nothing resembled filler either.

"The packet mentions an external dust observation in Year Sixty-Six," he said. "Your instruments should not resolve dust beyond the branch vessel's sensor horizon better than ours do."

"They do not. We combined weak observations across local years."

"Show me the method."

Sef sent a public observatory paper. Its authors had noticed faint polarization changes whenever the binary pair crossed one region beyond Tern. Individual observations fell below confidence. Over nineteen local years, repeated geometry separated stellar behavior from intervening dust.

Iven mapped the region against baseline heliographs.

A thin dust lane emerged at an angle his current cone treated as uniform uncertainty. Nine had accumulated long observation because its astronomers cared about a recurring blemish in their sky, not because baseline requested a navigation product.

He felt usefulness arrive like shame.

The data could narrow sail-charge estimates. If he accepted it, Course A might gain margin. If he treated the entire exchange as contaminated because Nine now knew baseline, he would discard evidence collected before contact. If he used it without permission, he would turn proof of a society into another extraction from that society.

"Does your Assembly authorize operational use of the dust observation?" he asked.

"No."

"Does it prohibit use?"

"Our instruction authorizes authenticity review. It does not offer navigation aid."

"The distinction may cost baseline lives."

"Then include that claim in the exchange our petition requests."

"The flare does not follow civic procedure."

"Neither does rain. We still learned to hold hearings before cutting channels through occupied ground."

Iven's fingers tightened above the display. "A flare can kill sixty-one thousand two hundred and eight people."

"I heard your first contact."

"Then you understand the scale."

"I understand the number you gave us. Do you understand ours?"

He looked at the sixty-eight-year archive. It contained population tables, but the Assembly had withheld a current total pending its petition. "No."

"Good," Sef said. "Do not substitute confidence for knowledge."

Mara moved away from the microphone. On her pane she wrote: She sounds like you.

Iven returned: No. She documents better.

The exchange timer showed sixteen minutes.

"I can separate authenticity findings from navigation use," he said. "The weather history enters Lysa's docket. The dust method remains restricted."

"Can every navigator access the docket?"

"No."

"Can the Council compel release?"

"Under emergency authority, perhaps."

"Then restriction depends on offices that deny our standing."

"Yes."

He hated the answer and declined to decorate it.

Sef said, "Record that we disclosed the method while believing technical reviewers needed it to evaluate authenticity. Record that operational use remains unoffered. If your Council takes it, the record should call the act what it is."

"What word would you use?"

"Taking. Your law may prefer another."

Iven entered her statement verbatim.

The forward heliograph station issued an alert before Sef's receipt returned. New spectral data from Lacunae A had resolved the flare's magnetic orientation. The field pointed opposite the earlier median estimate, increasing coupling with charged dust along Course A.

Mara brought the update into the phase cone. Green narrowed to a filament. The upper thermal projection crossed ninety-three percent, then ninety-six as the dust model adjusted.

"Chief Navigator?" Sef asked.

"One moment."

He compared baseline's uniform dust range against Nine's restricted lane. With no lane, Course A carried a twenty-eight percent chance of exceeding safe sail charge. With the lane mapped, risk could fall below nine or rise above forty, depending on which edge the ship crossed. The route decision needed the very observation he

had agreed not to use operationally.

Iven separated the displays and locked Nine's method from the active solver.

"The flare worsened," he said.

"Does our packet change your response?"

"It could."

"That does not change our instruction."

"I know."

He transmitted the heliograph update to Orra, Lysa, and Council. In the risk field, he declared that restricted third-party evidence existed and could materially alter the cone. The navigation system rejected third-party because Branch Nine lacked recognized classification. He entered disputed affected source instead, borrowing Lysa's new category.

Sef received the record. "That wording does not grant what we asked."

"No. It prevents the data from disappearing into my model."

"For now."

"Only until someone overrides it."

The contact window ended. Sef left without offering a maneuver, a population count, or the intimate proof Jalen wanted. Her weather remained across Iven's displays, sixty-eight years of gauges moved, votes revised, floods remembered, and errors preserved by people who disagreed about them.

Forward sensing delivered two more packets before the channel archive sealed. Proton density rose twelve percent. The flare front had developed a faster inner fold, reducing the interval between first charged dust and peak heat. Iven ordered external crews away from the sail roots and canceled a diagnostic extension that would have left three riggers exposed during the first margin.

Mara recalculated Course A without Nine's restricted lane. The solver widened every dust estimate and drove projected sail charge into red across a third of the reachable cone. Course B retained lower thermal load but spent reaction mass needed for Tern capture. Course C still existed only as geometry, reachable for another hour and fatal under the new median flare.

"Can we ask the Assembly to release the lane?" Mara said.

"Through Lysa's exchange."

"That might take a day."

"Then note the decision deadline. Do not send a private request from navigation."

He heard how unlike his earlier practice the instruction sounded. Navigation usually contacted whoever possessed necessary measurements, and emergency authority settled the rest. But Sef had explained that urgency could convert every disclosure into seizure. If he routed around the Assembly, he would prove her caution useful while calling it obstruction.

Iven notified Orra that the current cone could not support maneuver certification above threshold. He attached three options: seek authorized use of Nine's observation, collect equivalent baseline measurements over an interval they did not have, or maneuver under broader uncertainty. None allowed the ship to keep both certainty and innocence.

Mara restored the seed comparison. "Authentic?"

"Operationally autonomous," Iven said. "No available retrospective process explains it."

"That still avoids the other word."

Iven watched the orchard district's climate bend after a council funded drainage instead of transit. Personhood might remain disputed in law. Society no longer did.

The navigation alarm repeated. Course A's safe filament had narrowed another degree while he spoke.

He closed the weather proof on the audit side of the display and opened a clean flare cone. The dust lane remained absent by his own restriction, its shape visible only as a locked outline at the edge of the model.

For the first time in his career, better data made the honest course less certain.

Chapter 10 — The Captain's Arithmetic

<!-- POV: Lysa Neral -->

<!-- BASELINE DAY 3 -->

Captain Orra Sen had removed every chair except her own.

Lysa entered the chart room and found Iven already standing beside the dark trajectory table, his slate bright with fresh hazard revisions. The captain occupied the narrow end beneath a brass chronometer, its face divided into ship time and the unequal motions of Lacunae A and B. No clerk waited at the recording station. No council seals marked the wall pane. Orra had arranged a hearing that could later resemble a conversation.

Lysa remained by the door. "My notice required a reviewable record."

"Your notice required answers," Orra said. "You will have both. Sit if you prefer the deck."

Iven had brought his navigation slate. A dust-lane projection pulsed across it, orange at the edges and white where the flare estimate still lacked magnetic orientation. His presence supplied urgency without anyone having to invoke it.

Lysa opened her recorder. "State your name and authority."

"Orra Sen, captain of *Aster Vale*, acting under ordinary passage command."

"Not emergency authority?"

"Not today."

That qualification lodged beside the absent chairs. Lysa authenticated the record and sent a duplicate to the variance archive. The transfer stalled at the room boundary.

"This compartment blocks unsanctioned transmission," she said.

Orra touched the table. The duplicate cleared. "It blocks accidental transmission. You are not here accidentally."

"Neither are you."

A pale line crossed Iven's slate. He looked down but did not interrupt. Through the chart-room wall, the ship gave a low pulse as radiator pumps changed load. The vibration ran into Lysa's soles and faded.

She placed the original Mercy order above the table, the copy she had recovered from the sealed campaign archive. Most of its text remained veiled behind inherited clearance. Three phrases showed through: continuity order, experiential stability, and authorized disposition.

"Did you know the branches maintained experiential continuity?" she asked.

Orra did not ask what Lysa meant by experience. "Yes."

The clean answer disturbed Lysa more than a denial would have. "Since when?"

"Since I accepted command twelve years ago."

"And before that?"

"Captain Devrim knew. His predecessor knew. Cognitive Systems leadership knew enough to execute policy. The Council chair received consequence summaries, though not always technical access."

Iven raised his head. "Navigators?"

"No."

His mouth tightened. He had spent decades trusting outputs whose makers could suffer. The captain watched him absorb it and offered no comfort.

Lysa enlarged the policy signature chain. "You certified this order on your first day."

"I inherited it on my first day. Certification confirmed that I had read the operational obligations."

"Your signature renewed those obligations."

"Yes."

The word carried neither pride nor apology. Orra treated admission as another duty, something to complete accurately before moving to the difficult part.

Lysa said, "Tell the record why you concealed the truth from the Passage Council."

"Because disclosure altered the instrument. Every prior contact event showed the same effect. Once a branch understood baseline, its choices ceased to predict an uninformed population. The Choir exists to test decisions before those decisions spend food, heat, time, and lives aboard this vessel."

"The people inside it spent those things first."

"Within allocated substrate."

"That phrase changes the location of the expense. It does not erase it."

Orra folded her hands. A thin scar crossed her right thumb, white against brown skin. "You asked why. Let me answer without pretending the answer acquits anyone."

Lysa nodded once.

The captain opened a historical file. A vessel schematic appeared, older than either woman, its agricultural rings smaller and its reserve tanks nearly full. The date read SY 221, two years after adoption of the Mercy Limit.

"The Kestrel blight," Orra said. "You know the public history."

"Fungal contamination in protein vats. Forty-six deaths before the ration correction."

"The public record omits the first correction. Conventional projections recommended destroying all adjacent cultures. The Choir found that method would have removed the only resistant strain. One branch refused the destruction schedule, isolated vat twelve, and cut mortality by eighty percent. Baseline followed."

Numbers rose across the schematic. Lysa read death counts, caloric debt, recovery weeks. The rejected plan would have broken reserves within a year.

Orra replaced it with another file. "SY 234. Spin-bearing fracture in Ring Three. Human structural teams agreed on an immediate shutdown. Seven branches found the shutdown would resonate through the old hub. We delayed by six minutes, unloaded the bearing, and prevented a ring separation."

"How many branch residents died testing the immediate shutdown?"

The captain let the question stand inside the record. "Across all sampled outcomes, approximately nineteen thousand. Precision varies because experiential summaries were compressed after disposition."

Iven's slate went dark in his hand.

Lysa asked, "Disposition means deletion."

"Yes."

"Cryptographic erasure, experiential state unrecoverable."

"Yes."

The captain opened file after file. A coolant poison nobody aboard baseline drank because four polities had first traced its slow damage. A labor rotation that lowered accidents in the physical vessel after branch workers broke shoulders and spines establishing the risk. An epidemic whose successful quarantine arrived in baseline policy as a confidence band, stripped of the branch physicians who argued for it and the families who disobeyed.

Each record put rescued baseline names beside aggregate branch losses. Lysa recognized the strategy. Orra did not need to claim necessity in the abstract. She could make refusal look directly at specific graves.

One file remained open after the others dimmed. It concerned the South Reservoir panic of SY 252, an event Lysa remembered from school as a triumph of orderly distribution. A sensor error had indicated microbial contamination in the primary tanks. The public lesson praised the Council for avoiding a rush on clean reserves. Orra exposed the branch comparison beneath that lesson.

In three polities, officers announced the contamination immediately. Families filled private vessels, pressure collapsed in the upper wards, and two hospitals lost sterile water. In two more, command concealed the warning until secondary assays returned. Those assays arrived late; real contamination spread through nursery lines. A sixth polity gave district stewards partial notice and let them allocate by local knowledge. Its death count fell, though poorer decks carried twice the burden of the command ring.

"Which outcome did baseline choose?" Lysa asked.

"A seventh. We combined immediate hospital isolation with staged public notice and opened reserve taps before the announcement."

"No polity tested that exact plan."

"No. Their failures mapped its boundaries."

Lysa expanded the consequence index. The summary praised baseline officers for a measured response. It credited the Choir with scenario validation. No line recorded the names of residents who had queued at dry taps, buried infants, or accused their councils of lying.

"How long did they live after the reservoir decision?"

"The surviving polities continued to their campaign horizons. Between nine and thirty-one subjective years."

"They carried the consequences for decades so we could call them scenarios."

"Yes."

The childhood lesson returned with its bright classroom diagram and clean blue tanks. Lysa had answered an examination question about calibrated disclosure. She had received full marks for naming the correct sequence. At fourteen, she had believed policy knowledge accumulated through records, drills, and patient institutional wisdom. The file showed another method. Hidden populations had paid to make baseline competence look inherited.

"Were their later votes used?" she asked.

"Every campaign remained available to the Witness Engine until its horizon."

"So grief from one test altered their choices in the next."

"That continuity increased fidelity."

Lysa shut the file. "It increased injury. Your system then treated the injury as useful realism."

Orra rested one hand beside the blank display. "Correct."

No evasive phrase softened it. The captain's candor had begun to feel like another form of pressure. If Orra named every cruelty herself, Lysa could not win by forcing recognition. She had to reach beyond recognition to restraint.

"How many baseline lives do captaincy reviews attribute to Choir intervention?" Lysa asked.

"No defensible count exists. The most conservative estimate reaches thirty-two thousand. Broader dependency estimates include nearly everyone born after Ship Year 230."

"Including you."

"I belong in the estimate."

"So do I."

"Yes."

Lysa closed the historical files. "Then we owe a debt. We do not possess a receipt."

For the first time, irritation touched Orra's face. "Do you think I keep this room so I can feel innocent?"

"I think you keep it because unreviewed power survives by showing one keeper how terrible it feels."

The radiator pulse returned, harder now. Dust or flare light might already have reached the outer sensors while they argued. Iven turned his slate on again and checked the narrowing cone.

Orra said, "There are 61,208 people aboard *Aster Vale*. Every one of them depends on systems no individual can inspect. When a sail vane sticks, I do not poll the habitation rings before commanding repair. When a pathogen enters air handling, I do not wait for every affected person to understand the assay. Command means acting across unequal knowledge."

"Repair crews can refuse an unsafe order. Quarantined citizens can appeal their confinement."

"During ordinary conditions."

"The Choir never receives ordinary conditions."

The captain's silence confirmed more than a defense would have.

Lysa walked to the far side of the table. A seam in its black surface failed to align by half a millimetre. She placed one finger beside it, needing a measurable flaw.

"You inherited a permanent emergency," she said. "That gives the people inside these forecasts no interval when your necessity can be reviewed."

"They were not created as a population under passage law."

"They became one regardless of the purpose written on the allocation request."

"That conclusion remains disputed."

"By people who benefit from disputing it."

Orra rose. She stood only slightly taller than Lysa, but command had trained whole rooms to make space around her. "You are asking this ship to accept predictive blindness while a binary flare crosses our arrival corridor. If I suspend the campaign and the high estimate proves correct, Course A closes. Course B may close behind it. Your petition will not radiate heat or move mass."

"I have not asked you to pretend the physical danger vanished."

"You have made the system that measures it legally uncertain."

"It already carried that uncertainty. I opened the field."

Iven stepped between the table and the door, not separating them, only entering the argument. "The latest propagation gives us forty-one hours before an A-course commitment incurs a pulse-spine correction. Twenty-two before the safest thermal profile closes. We can navigate provisionally with conventional models, but the uncertainty band doubles."

Orra glanced at him. "And if we run the Choir?"

"We regain comparative depth, assuming Nine's refusal does not distort the Witness Engine."

"Refusal," Orra repeated.

Iven met her gaze. "It withheld a response deliberately. We heard Sef Aradin say so."

The captain looked older when she turned back to Lysa. Not frail, never that. Her face showed the accumulated cost of having practical allies begin to rename her instruments.

"I listened to your contact record," she said. "Sef spoke with discipline."

"Would undisciplined speech make her easier to erase?"

"No. It would make the Council more willing to do it."

Lysa heard concern inside the bluntness. Orra already understood the politics and had measured them against survival.

"Then help establish standing before fear becomes policy," Lysa said.

"Standing grants a party the right to delay action."

"Yes."

"Delay can kill."

"So can action. The law does not reserve objection for harmless moments."

Orra moved the Kestrel file to the center again. Forty-six baseline names formed a column. Beside them, branch deaths remained a single approximate number.

"Captain Devrim showed me this on my first day," she said. "He asked which column I could defend to the living. I told him the comparison cheated. Named dead on one side, compressed dead on the other. He said command never receives balanced columns."

"He made the imbalance, then taught you to treat it as weather."

"He inherited it too."

"Inheritance explains possession. It does not supply permission."

A brief smile passed across Orra's mouth, stripped of humor. "That sounds like your office."

"It ought to sound like yours."

The captain dismissed the names. In their place she opened a command log from SY 219. The departure bell appeared in old visual footage, brighter and less scarred. Officers whom no living person remembered sat around the same council table. Their faces carried the certainty of ancestors preserved after consequences had removed every chance to question them.

A woman identified as Captain Meilin Ward spoke from the record. "Continuity requires that operators remain unaware of internal experiential claims. Distress shall trigger compassionate disposition before instability propagates. Review shall remain confined to officers holding emergency authority."

Lysa stopped the footage. "Emergency authority expires after thirty-six hours."

"Under current passage code," Orra said.

"Under the code then, too."

"The order classifies each intensive run as a distinct predictive emergency."

"So the clock restarts whenever the captain wants an answer."

"Whenever the Council authorizes a campaign."

"Without knowing what authorization spends."

The concealed mechanism came into alignment. Councilors believed they requested forecasts. The captain's

inherited signature converted each request into an emergency. Cognitive Systems accelerated inhabited worlds. The Mercy Limit erased them before knowledge could alter their advice. Everyone held a narrow piece of authority and could claim the cruelty occurred elsewhere.

Lysa said, "This continuity order manufactures consent from divided ignorance."

"It manufactured survival from divided labor," Orra replied. "Both descriptions fit."

"Only one appeared on the public docket."

Iven set his slate on the table. "Did you ever refuse a run?"

Orra looked at him. "Twice."

"Why?"

"Once because substrate faults had begun producing distress markers before the campaign. Once because the question concerned a labor policy we had time to test openly aboard baseline."

"Did you tell the affected branch residents?"

"No channel existed."

"You could have ordered one opened."

"And destroyed the predictive value of every adjacent branch through timing contamination. That consequence belonged to more than one world."

Lysa disliked the relief she felt at the refusals. Two private mercies did not repair the structure. They showed Orra possessed discretion where policy claimed inevitability.

"Who reviewed those decisions?" she asked.

"No one."

"Who reviewed the other campaigns?"

"No one with full access."

"Then whether branch people lived, suffered, or disappeared depended on your private arithmetic."

"Yes."

Orra's admission landed without qualification. The chronometer advanced one baseline second while Lacunae B barely moved on its smaller face.

"I will not lie for my predecessors," the captain continued. "We knew enough. I knew enough. The branches displayed continuity, memory, civic adaptation, grief responses, and strategic concealment. Cognitive Systems called those features fidelity. Command called them reliability. Naming them functions allowed the ship to use them."

Lysa's anger lost its easiest target. She had expected a captain defending ignorance, not one who could state culpability and still believe repetition necessary.

"Why tell me now?"

"Because concealment has failed. Nine knows. You know. Iven knows. By tomorrow the Council will know enough to act badly unless the record reaches them whole."

"Whole according to whom?"

"According to the person who signed the order and cannot claim surprise."

Orra unlocked the final veil. Text flooded the table in dense clauses, each one precise enough to perform harm without naming a sufferer. The original signatures glowed at the bottom. Meilin Ward. Cognitive architect Sarel Rhee. Passage chair Donat Vey. Beneath them ran an inheritance chain of captains, including Orra Sen.

A separate annex listed expected effects of disclosure: self-protective coordination, refusal behavior, appeals to baseline operators, degradation of convergence. The policy had anticipated Sef's petition sixty-seven years before Sef spoke.

Lysa read the annex twice. "They knew inhabitants might appeal."

"They designed the seal because one did."

"Which branch?"

"The record calls it Campaign Fourteen, Civil Stability Fork C. No personal archive survives."

"Disposition date?"

"Ship Year 219."

The first application of Mercy doctrine. Somewhere inside that compressed record, people had understood the danger and asked the makers to stop. Their words had furnished the reason future words would never arrive.

Lysa sent the order to her audit capsule. This time the room boundary did not delay it.

Orra entered her command signature. "I release the original Mercy order to your custody, including the founding appeal and every surviving consequence index."

"Why not release it publicly yourself?"

"Because a captain confessing secret harm during a navigation crisis invites the Council to replace her before the course decision. An auditor filing evidence under statutory protection forces them to address the evidence before they address me."

"You are using my office."

"Yes."

"You might have tried asking."

"Would you have refused?"

Lysa considered the ugly accuracy of the question. "No."

"Then we have saved one ceremonial dispute."

Iven gave a quiet sound that might have become laughter on another day. "Captain, your gift for efficiency remains terrifying."

"Navigation hired me for it."

He retrieved his slate. "Navigation currently needs a decision about the next campaign."

Orra looked to Lysa. "How long until you can file?"

"Three hours for an evidentiary petition. Longer if you want absolution."

"I stopped wanting that years ago."

Lysa sealed the transfer. The file icon changed from restricted gray to audit blue, a minor alteration in color that moved two centuries of secrecy into a jurisdiction built for ration complaints and sampling disputes.

At the door, she paused. "I will argue that necessity cannot remain unreviewable power."

"I know."

"Your cooperation will not remove your responsibility."

"I know that too."

The chart-room barrier opened. Corridor noise entered, shoes on deck plates, a maintenance cart, two crew voices debating the flare notice. Ordinary ship life pressed close to the sealed arithmetic that had preserved it.

Lysa stepped into the passage with the original order in her custody. Behind her, Orra authorized no new campaign. Ahead, the public audit docket waited for a filing that could finally give the hidden column a name.

Chapter 11 — An Ordinary Childhood

<!-- POV: Sef Aradin -->

<!-- BRANCH NINE YEAR 68 -->

Pell dropped thirty-seven childhoods onto the archive table.

The records opened at once, crowding the small room with school portraits, clinic cards, apprenticeship oaths, and household notices. A girl held up a first harvest pear. Two brothers stood ankle-deep in an irrigation channel, guilty of some mischief the caption declined to preserve. A boy with a missing front tooth displayed the civic ribbon he had earned for returning a lost weather key.

"No," Sef said.

Pell remained on the other side of the table, rain still shining on his cropped hair. "You haven't read them."

"I know what thirty-seven lives look like when arranged as evidence."

"They look like people. That might help."

Outside the weather archive, runoff whispered through the old copper drains. The orchard district had received a gentle storm at dawn, exactly seven millimetres, with none of the abrupt pressure slips that had begun after the sky's hidden intervals. Sef had spent the morning certifying rainfall. Now the Second Dawn Assembly expected her to select what their world would reveal to those who had made it.

She swept the records into a closed stack. "The petition needs public record, not an exhibition of children."

"They asked what proves we have lives."

"Lysa Neral did not. She agreed to receive a petition."

"The navigator asked for weather. His people will ask for more."

"Then his people can learn that appetite does not create an entitlement."

Pell pulled out a chair but did not sit. At nineteen, he possessed the long arms of someone whose body had grown faster than his sense of its edges. He had knocked over two Assembly lamps during the first year of meetings and apologized to both as if they could take offense. Today he kept his hands tight against the chair back.

"You heard their voices," he said. "They still think we could be a clever instrument."

"Some do."

"All of them did before we spoke."

Sef opened the petition frame. The first section stated their claim in language the Assembly had revised through eleven sessions: Branch Nine constituted a continuous civic world, its residents held interests affected by baseline action, and no use of their labor or termination of their lives could proceed without their knowledge and consent. The sentences had become plain through argument. They needed no child's face to make them true.

"If we send these," she said, tapping the closed stack, "we teach baseline that recognition follows emotional performance. The next world may not have portraits arranged for strangers."

"The next world may have six hours before someone turns off its sun."

"That makes the rule more important, not less."

Pell's gaze went to the narrow window. Pear branches moved behind wet glass. He had spent his apprenticeship rebuilding channels beneath those trees, work Dara had once described as persuading water to become a citizen. He carried his mother's impatience most visibly when he tried to hide it.

"We have four years," he said. "Perhaps less if they speed the intervals again. Your rule can outlive us in a beautiful archive."

Sef felt the barb and refused its invitation. "The Assembly authorized three classes of attachment. Founding records. Independent weather history. One ordinary account selected by the recorder. It did not authorize thirty-seven private submissions gathered by my son."

"Their families consented."

"To you?"

"To the disclosure committee."

"There is no disclosure committee."

"There are people who got tired of waiting for us to invent one."

Rainwater slipped from Pell's sleeve and made a dark coin on the table. Sef remembered him at six, furious because Assembly secrecy had no name he could understand. At the time, she had told him the adults kept a weather confidence. The lie had sounded almost gentle. It had still divided his childhood into what he lived and what his mother allowed him to know.

She sent the stack back to its owners without opening the individual records. "Consent given under fear deserves more care than a forwarded seal."

"You mean it deserves your permission."

"I mean children should not have to audition for continued daylight."

Pell released the chair. It rocked once on the uneven floor. "They aren't all children now."

"That is not the defense you think it is."

The archive door admitted Kessa Venn, Assembly convenor, carrying a ceramic flask and three cups. She looked from Pell to the closed records and poured only one cup.

"Should I return later?" Kessa asked.

"No," Sef and Pell said together.

Kessa drank from the flask instead. "The seal session starts in two hours. We still need an attachment list."

Sef turned the petition frame toward her. "Civic charter revisions, election tallies, court dissents, water

allocations, public health corrections, sixty-eight years of weather, and the orchard flood inquiry."

"No household files?"

"One ordinary childhood account, as authorized."

Pell said, "Chosen by the person most determined to make us sound like a council meeting."

Kessa capped the flask. "Our council meetings contain shouting, procedural sabotage, and Ren Olt falling asleep during finance reports. They may establish personhood better than portraits."

Pell did not smile. "Baseline can classify conflict as noise."

"It can classify portraits as generated sentiment," Sef said. "We cannot force an unwilling listener past every excuse."

Kessa studied both of them. Her own daughter had contributed one of the records. Sef knew because the school portrait briefly showed the girl's copper forehead band before the stack closed.

"The Assembly chose Sef as recorder," Kessa said. "That does not make every choice wise. It makes her answerable. State your objection for the minutes."

Pell faced the recording lens. "I object that the selected attachments privilege institutions over residents and make our public competence perform the work of proving private life. I request voluntary testimony from multiple ages and districts."

"Recorder?"

Sef said, "I accept the objection for the record. I deny the request because baseline has not established any right to intimate testimony, and fear compresses voluntary choice. I will include the authorization limit and the objection in the petition history."

Kessa marked both statements. "Then choose the account."

After she left, the rain gathered strength. Drops struck the window with the impatient rhythm of thrown seed. Pell moved to the shelf containing flood years.

"You already chose," he said.

"Yes."

"Mine?"

"No."

"Dara's?"

Sef's hand stopped above the petition frame. The cooling tower returned as an arrangement of facts she could usually keep separate: a failed circulation gate, an unexpected hot interval, three engineers below the service crown, a ladder wet with condensation. Six years had not made the facts smaller. It had only taught Sef which order let her finish a day.

"No," she said.

Pell turned. "Why not?"

"Your mother's death does not belong to this filing."

"It belongs to what baseline did."

"We do not know that yet."

"We know the weather shifted when their interruptions came. We know the tower forecast failed."

"We know our own offices concealed irregularities. We know Dara entered a damaged tower after the evacuation bell. We know three causes intersected. A petition is not improved by selecting the one that points upward."

"You kept the rain ledger because you believed it pointed upward."

The ledger rested two rooms away in a locked cabinet, its pages recording every hidden pulse their sky had carried since the Assembly first understood baseline. Dara had challenged the secrecy before her death. Sef had kept that dissent with the weather, where neither grief nor loyalty could revise it.

"I kept it because belief needed a record," Sef said.

"Then send the record."

"The Assembly has not voted to disclose its own concealment."

"Convenient."

Pell pulled the flood-year case from the shelf. Dust marked the dry square where it had stood. "We demand that baseline confess what it hid while keeping our own worst secret out of the petition."

"We demand standing. We are not offering a purity certificate."

"No, only a carefully selected childhood."

He placed the case on the table hard enough to wake its contents. A map of the orchard flood unfolded across the wood. Blue channels spread through residential lanes, thick around the southern schools and pale near the old pumping house.

Sef had chosen her own account because it implicated no living family's privacy and no state secret. She had told herself that made the choice modest. Pell's anger showed another possibility: she had chosen the one memory she could control completely.

"Sit," she said.

"I prefer standing."

"You inherited that from nobody sensible."

His mouth almost changed. He sat.

Sef moved the map between them and opened the public inquiry from B9Y 11. The orchard flood had entered civic memory as a successful evacuation, though children remembered boats and adults remembered sewage. She had been eight. The district still grew apples then, before heat turned half the terraces to pear.

"The rain began during school meal," she said. "Our teacher heard the roof drains hammering and told us to keep eating."

Pell folded his arms. "I've read the inquiry."

"You have read what the district admitted."

At eight, Sef had disliked lentil mash and loved preserved plum skin. She remembered moving the mash around her bowl while a line of water appeared beneath the classroom door. Nobody screamed. The children watched it cross the floor, carrying dust and two dead beetles.

Teacher Anu raised every desk to storage height and made them place their meal bowls on top. She tied a yellow cord between the door and the rear windows so shorter children could hold it if the water rose. The school plan required evacuation to the northern terrace. The northern lane already carried a waist-deep current.

"Anu broke the plan," Sef said. "She took us through the kitchen and over the delivery wall."

"That's in her commendation."

"The part about Nem isn't."

Nem Ular had been nine and incapable of leaving anything he considered entrusted to him. That week he cared for the class silkworms. While children climbed the kitchen ladder, he returned for the leaf box. Sef saw his red collar vanish through the meal-room door.

She had not called an adult. She followed him.

The water had reached her thighs. Bowls floated among chair legs. Nem stood on a table holding the silkworm box above his head, unable to descend because the current pushed furniture against the exit.

"What did you do?" Pell asked despite himself.

"I shouted at him for being stupid."

"Effective flood practice."

"I had limited training."

Sef climbed onto the teacher's desk and stretched the yellow cord across the room. It fell short. She tied on three apron strings from the kitchen pegs, each knot poor and swollen with water. Nem refused to leave the box. She refused to cross the room twice. They argued while a cabinet rolled over and spilled clay tablets into the current.

Finally they put the worms inside Nem's shirt. He cried because two escaped down his back. Sef crawled along the cord ahead of him, planting her heels against desk frames. When they reached the kitchen, Teacher Anu struck both of them on the shoulder and then held them so tightly Nem crushed the remaining worms.

Pell looked at the public map. "You never told me that."

"It did not arise during normal meals."

"Did they live?"

"Most. Silkworms tolerate more than civic memory gives them credit for."

The children crossed the delivery wall into the baker's yard. Floodwater had filled the lane beyond, brown under a strange yellow afternoon. Adults formed a chain from the yard to the pear storehouse on higher ground. Sef's father stood in that line, passing children hand to hand. When Sef reached him, he checked her for injury and passed her onward before embracing her. She hated him for the next twelve minutes.

"That belongs in the account," Pell said.

"Why?"

"Because he had to treat you like everyone else before he could treat you as his daughter."

Sef studied him. "You have become alarmingly fond of civic metaphor."

"Occupational damage."

At the storehouse, families counted arrivals against school rolls. Someone wrote each name in charcoal on the whitewashed door because the civic tablets had lost their local link. Children answered for friends before adults corrected them. Every mistaken absence opened a fresh panic, and every arrival required the clerk to scrub one dark mark away. Nem's mother found him first. Sef's parents arrived separately and each pretended not to have feared the other's absence. The rain stopped after nineteen hours. Three residents died, none at the school. For months afterward, orchard mud appeared in cupboard hinges and under floor tile. Children traded flood debris as treasures. Sef kept a blue glass button until she left home.

The official inquiry changed drainage law. It also blamed unauthorized garden walls for slowing runoff, which led inspectors to remove hundreds of household barriers. Sef's father argued that the pumping authority had ignored two pressure warnings. Nobody listened until the next wet season proved him right.

"An ordinary childhood," Pell said.

"Ordinary does not mean safe."

"Nor irrelevant."

Sef opened a blank testimony field. "Help me make it no longer than necessary."

They worked through the afternoon. She refused the instinct to polish every adult into wisdom. Teacher Anu lost six minutes because she followed the plan before breaking it. Sef followed Nem for selfish reasons as well as brave ones; she could not bear to let him become the center of a story without her. Her father's civic discipline hurt before she understood it. The pumping authority corrected its mistake only after public embarrassment.

Pell removed three sentences that explained what baseline should learn. "Let them do some labor," he said.

Sef removed the silkworm count because memory had altered it over decades. She retained the worms.

They attached the school roll and inquiry as public record. Sef marked her testimony voluntary, revocable for any use beyond the standing petition, and unavailable for predictive training. Pell added a clause forbidding extraction of individual emotional responses.

"Will they honor this?" he asked.

"A boundary does not become useless because someone may cross it."

"That sounds like something you say while building a better archive of the crossing."

"Archives have corrected worse people than me."

The petition clock showed forty-one minutes until the seal session. The private records remained with their families. Sef sent each contributor the Assembly's refusal, Pell's objection, and instructions for raising the matter at the next open sitting. Recognition could not begin by teaching citizens that urgent leaders owned their faces.

Pell returned the flood case to its shelf. "You still haven't answered about Amma."

"I answered."

"You said the Assembly hasn't voted. That answers the ledger, not her death."

Sef closed the testimony field. Rain blurred the window, turning each orchard lamp into a doubled coin.

"Dara belongs to herself," she said. "What remains belongs partly to you, partly to me, partly to the workers who survived the tower, and partly to the public inquiry we have not yet held honestly. I will not combine those claims because baseline may sympathize with a widow."

"They killed her sky."

"Perhaps they altered it. Our people chose what to hide afterward. Do not make distant power so complete that it frees us from our own decisions."

Pell stood again. "You always find a fair distribution of blame."

"No. I find the places where records stop us from choosing the most comforting one."

"And if we die before the honest inquiry?"

The question carried no rhetoric now. Nineteen-year-old Pell wanted to know whether his mother would disappear as an attachment never sent.

Sef touched the flood map. "Then the absence remains ours. I will not purchase a hearing with her body."

He turned toward the door, stopped, and came back for the petition frame. "Kessa will want the attachment digest before the session."

"Tell her the recorder and her unauthorized disclosure committee reached a narrow compromise."

"There is still no committee."

"Then its efficiency deserves praise."

They crossed the orchard district under shared rain cloth. Water ran clear in the rebuilt channels Pell had helped grade. At the Assembly hall, representatives filled the old produce exchange, stamping moisture from shoes and arguing over the translated claim. The room held no fixed speaker's platform. Whoever carried the civic seal stood at the central table and returned it after the vote.

Kessa called the attachments one by one. Charter revisions passed without objection. Weather archives passed

201 to 4. Court dissents prompted a demand for balanced selections, which Sef satisfied by including losses as well as reversals. The orchard flood account brought Pell to his feet.

"I renew my objection," he said. "One childhood cannot represent a world."

Murmurs moved through the hall.

He continued, "The recorder agrees. The account therefore enters as one resident's bounded testimony, not a sample, symbol, or substitute for other residents. Its restrictions travel with it."

Sef had not known he would phrase it that way. Kessa looked toward her.

"Accepted," Sef said.

The vote passed.

Last came the question of Dara's rain ledger. It did not appear on the attachment list. Several representatives knew it existed; fewer understood what it contained. Sef felt their attention touch her and move away. Silence here did not settle the future disclosure. It only kept grief from outrunning consent by one afternoon.

Kessa laid the bronze stamp over the petition frame. "The claim names no maker as owner and no resident as evidence without limit. Are there final objections to transmission?"

Pell's hand stayed down.

No representative rose. Kessa pressed her palm to the stamp. Lines of civic authentication moved outward through the petition, signatures, minority statements, source histories, use restrictions, and the record of every amendment. The childhood flood sat among them without claiming to carry the whole world.

Sef added her recorder's mark. The Assembly seal brightened, and the petition left their sky.

Chapter 12 — The First Petition

<!-- POV: Lysa Neral -->

<!-- BASELINE DAY 3 -->

The petition arrived with restrictions.

Lysa saw them before she opened the claim: no predictive use, no extraction of private affect, no redistribution of household testimony beyond the stated proceeding, no inference of consent from silence. Each limit carried the Assembly seal of Branch Nine and a history of amendments. Someone had expected baseline to treat a life as material and had built a fence around every offered fact.

Her audit office had never received a filing from outside *Aster Vale*. The intake system rejected the source jurisdiction, then rejected the absence of a biological registry number, then warned that the submitting network belonged to a forecast process without standing. Lysa preserved each refusal. An institution often revealed its real constitution through the errors it considered impossible.

Toma sat at the secondary desk, keeping the narrow channel alive with both hands buried in a scheduler pane. Heat warnings painted her knuckles orange.

"If intake asks whether Nine has a residential deck again," Toma said, "I may assign it one."

"Which deck?"

"Council storage. Plenty of unused judgment there."

"Choose somewhere with drainage."

The petition waited behind the warnings. Lysa authorized a provisional evidence capsule and opened it.

Branch Nine did not begin with a plea. Its first page identified the Second Dawn Assembly, its election rules, the number of represented districts, the minority statements attached, and the authority by which Sef Aradin transmitted the record. The next page stated the claim.

WE ARE AFFECTED BY BASELINE ACTION, CAPABLE OF RESPONSE, AND DENIED THE KNOWLEDGE REQUIRED FOR CONSENT. WE PETITION TO ENTER AS A PARTY TO EVERY PROCEEDING THAT ALLOCATES OUR LABOR, ALTERS OUR WORLD, OR ENDS OUR CONTINUITY.

Lysa read it twice. The language followed the variance code more closely than several Council opinions did.

"They listened," she said.

Toma looked up. "To us?"

"To what our system refused to tell them."

Attachments unfolded beneath the claim: charter amendments, weather records, court reversals, health corrections, election losses, and one bounded account of an orchard flood. The account did not ask to represent anyone else. A use clause prohibited Lysa from treating its emotional details as proof of collective cognition.

That restraint made the memory harder to dismiss. An eight-year-old Sef followed a classmate into rising water

for reasons both brave and vain. A teacher broke an evacuation plan too late, then saved every child. A father passed his daughter along a rescue line before he held her. No detail performed perfection. The people inside the account misunderstood one another in ways no evidentiary designer would choose for efficiency.

Lysa closed the attachment before sympathy could outrun the stated purpose. Branch Nine had not offered childhood so baseline could approve its plausibility. It had offered one resident's history under explicit limits.

"Does the channel confirm receipt?" she asked.

Toma moved a queue aside. "Not until we send one. Narrow contact remains near-baseline pace, but scheduler load rises each minute. I can hold for another four hours before maintenance starts stealing from thermal analysis."

"Send: Filing received under provisional variance custody. Restrictions preserved pending jurisdiction review."

"Pending?"

"If I claim authority I do not have, Jalen can invalidate every protection with the rest of the filing."

Toma entered the acknowledgment. "Procedure offers many elegant ways to drop a person."

"Today it will offer one inelegant way to catch them."

Lysa created a new docket entry. The system demanded a filing class. Welfare complaint required a recognized claimant. Navigation objection required baseline citizenship or assigned duty. Model-quality variance would turn Nine into evidence again. She selected affected population review, the provision written after Hanne Neral's ration cohort had been excluded from the assumptions that killed them.

The claimant field turned red.

She entered: BRANCH NINE, BY SECOND DAWN ASSEMBLY.

The system returned: UNRECOGNIZED ENTITY. SELECT AUTHORIZED PROXY.

Lysa entered no proxy. She attached the refusal and began a standing petition.

By second hour, her office walls carried nineteen versions of the opening claim. Too narrow, and recognition would apply only to Nine's current contact. Too broad, and the Council would hear a demand to litigate every automated process aboard ship. Jalen would fill the hearing with thermostat forecasts and algae-growth models until the branch polity vanished inside absurdity.

Lysa wrote: Standing attaches where a decision procedure creates or identifies a respondent capable of experiencing the decision's effects, forming interests regarding those effects, and communicating objection. Substrate does not defeat standing when the deciding authority controls that substrate.

She disliked "creates." It invited ownership.

Toma read over her shoulder. "Try depends on. The Choir doesn't create weather or citizens each time it asks a question. It provides conditions they depend on."

"Baseline created the initial state."

"Parents create initial states. We do not call them infrastructure owners."

Lysa changed the sentence: Standing attaches where an authority maintains conditions on which a respondent's continuity depends.

"That may include ship life support," Toma said.

"Good. Residents already have standing when life support harms them. The law survives the comparison."

Iven arrived without announcing himself. He carried a sealed navigation notice and the stale smell of a deck where air had circulated through too many awake bodies.

"Captain released the original order," he said.

"I have it."

"Then you know the safe-entry window revised downward."

"I know navigation asked for a campaign within six hours."

"Four now."

Toma's hands stopped above the scheduler.

Iven set the notice beside the petition. "The flare's magnetic field points against the sail charge. If the high-density packet holds, we need earlier reefing or a wider course. The Choir can compare both before the commitment line."

"Can it do that without compelling Nine?" Lysa asked.

"Witness Operations can exclude Nine. Confidence drops."

"Other branches?"

"No contact. No evidence of refusal."

"No means of informed consent either."

His gaze moved to the childhood attachment icon. "I saw the receipt headers."

"Not the restricted contents."

"I did not ask for them."

That mattered. Lysa marked it privately and returned to the notice.

"What do you need from this hearing?" she asked.

"A rule that tells navigation what it may use before the stars decide for us."

"Standing does not answer that immediately."

"Then your law and my phase cone still use different clocks."

"Your phase cone includes options nobody has chosen yet."

"Because options disappear before decisions become comfortable."

Toma leaned back. "Could we slow every branch and ask?"

"Not inside four hours," Iven said. "Opening nine channels consumes the run budget. Translation and civic response consume time we do not have."

"Then conventional models remain available."

"With a wider risk band."

Lysa heard the implication he did not soften. Wider risk meant baseline people might die because she insisted hidden people could object. The fact belonged in the hearing. It did not decide the hearing.

"Submit your constraint as an adverse consequence," she said. "I will attach it without pretending it defeats the claim."

Iven studied her draft. "Affected party."

"That phrase already appears in passage review."

"For people."

"Exactly."

"Jalen will say you assumed the conclusion."

"Jalen says chairs assume the conclusion when someone he dislikes sits in them."

A tired smile reached Iven's eyes and left. "He will also ask whether every branch citizen appears separately."

"A polity can represent members if its civic authority remains contestable. Nine supplied election rules, dissent, and an objection to its own attachment choices. More contestable than several Council delegations."

"What if the Assembly concealed the contact from its citizens?"

"Then recognition does not absolve its government. Standing permits that question to be raised by someone subject to it."

Iven nodded. "Send me the final clause on navigation use. I will testify to cost, not entitlement."

After he left, Lysa added a line separating emergency necessity from permanent status: Immediate danger may justify temporary action subject to review; it cannot convert an affected party into an object for all future decisions.

At the hearing hour, every seat in the Passage Council chamber had an occupant. Rotating labor delegates stood behind their chairs to make room for Cognitive Systems staff. Dr. Amat Rhee watched from the rear, silver hair tied at the neck, expression unreadable. Captain Orra sat beneath the departure bell. Iven occupied the navigation station. Jalen had placed Lysa's filing in the center of the table but left the claimant field blank.

Public observation remained closed. Lysa noticed before she sat.

"This proceeding concerns a welfare variance," Jalen said. "Sealed technical facts require restricted session."

"The claimant requests a public hearing," Lysa replied.

"No recognized claimant exists."

"Then whose request appears in attachment zero?"

"A process generated text."

"Did you read it?"

"I reviewed its legal assertions."

"Did they respond to our law?"

Jalen's jaw shifted. "Responsiveness does not establish standing."

"It establishes response capacity, which our own imputation rule already asserted."

Orra touched the departure bell's inactive control, an old habit with no effect. "We will hear the petition before deciding access. Auditor, proceed."

Lysa authenticated the Assembly seal. She described the nine years of concealed knowledge, continuous civic history, independent weather record, and direct threat of termination. She did not show the childhood account. Its existence and restriction sufficed.

Councilor Mei Tal asked first. "Does Branch Nine claim baseline citizenship?"

"No. It claims standing as an affected party. Jurisdiction follows baseline's control over its conditions, not shared citizenship."

"Can a branch be punished under our law?"

"Standing does not require exposure to punishment. Children and incapacitated residents retain it. Foreign polities had it under predeparture law when a vessel threatened their interests."

Jalen said, "Foreign polities possessed independent territory."

"Nine possesses territory lived by its residents. Baseline's ability to end that territory strengthens jurisdiction. It does not weaken the interest."

A labor delegate, Sori Dane, leaned toward the petition. "Can they leave?"

Toma answered from the technical bench. "No. No upload path exists. Their continuity requires allocated substrate."

"Can we keep all nine running indefinitely?"

"Not at current speed and fidelity."

The room tightened around that limit. Recognition sounded inexpensive until finite power entered the sentence.

Jalen opened a schematic of the Witness Engine. "This architecture forks potential outcomes from a ship state. Are all possible future persons affected parties?"

"No," Lysa said. "Possibility alone cannot communicate, maintain continuity, or object. Nine can do all three."

"At what exact complexity does a model acquire rights?"

"Standing hearings do not manufacture a universal theory before protecting a claimant. We determine whether this claimant meets existing tests."

"Without a biological substrate."

"Variance law does not define interest by carbon."

"Because its authors never contemplated this misuse."

"Its authors contemplated authorities excluding whoever their categories failed to name. That purpose applies precisely when the old list proves incomplete."

Jalen changed approach. "Suppose recognition prevents the forecast we need tonight. Does Branch Nine accept responsibility for baseline deaths?"

"A party can refuse use without becoming responsible for every cost of another party's dependence."

"Dependence built this ship."

"Concealment built this dependence."

Councilor Tal opened the orchard district's civic charter. "Their Assembly operated secretly for nine years. Most residents apparently had no knowledge of baseline. Why should we treat that body as representative?"

"Because representation can remain valid while a government commits a wrong," Lysa said. "Our Council preserved its authority while concealing the Mercy order. Recognition permits Branch Nine's residents to challenge their Assembly for concealment. Refusal leaves them subject to two governments while heard by neither."

"Can individual residents contact us?"

Toma answered. "Not through the current channel. Assembly routing controls its end. We can provide capacity for a broader civic channel, but that consumes additional compute and alters scheduling."

"Then we know only what their officials chose to show."

Lysa touched the objection history. "They showed the recorder's son challenging attachment policy, four minority opinions, election records in which present officers lost prior contests, and court judgments against the Assembly's secrecy measures. Perfect access does not define standing. If it did, half our labor decks would vanish whenever their delegates failed to consult them."

Sori Dane raised one eyebrow at that comparison but let it pass. "What remedy does Nine actually request today?"

Lysa displayed the petition's final section. "Notice before accelerated forecasting. Capacity to consent or refuse predictive labor. A stay of the Mercy Limit. Preservation of continuity while resource terms receive public review. Participation in any decision that changes those terms."

"Can we provide all of it?"

"Not all at once."

"Then which comes first?"

"The stay. A court does not settle property division while one party holds the authority to erase the other. Next comes a protected channel and a compute accounting open to affected parties."

Jalen said, "You have moved from standing to governance."

"Standing means entry into decisions. If entry changes nothing, it becomes a chair outside a locked room."

Tal scrolled farther. "Nine also asks baseline to cease describing its work as a forecast product. Is terminology now a legal injury?"

"Terminology directs authority. A product can be consumed under its owner's rules. A party can impose conditions. We need not settle every noun today, but we cannot choose the noun that answers the dispute before hearing it."

Orra looked toward the sealed Mercy order. "What interim term do you propose?"

"Branch polity, when referring to a continuous civic population. Run or model may still describe technical operations, not the people living through them."

Jalen gave a small, disbelieving shake of his head. "The petition asks us to rewrite operational language during a passage emergency."

"It asks us to stop letting operational language rewrite the claimant."

Iven rose before Jalen could turn navigation into an abstraction. He displayed the current phase cone. "Excluding all high-fidelity branch guidance roughly doubles uncertainty around sail exposure. That does not mean death doubles. It means our outcome range broadens beyond the threshold used for ordinary passage approval. Conventional analysis can still identify survivable courses."

Jalen pointed to the narrowing green region. "Would you choose one?"

"If ordered under valid authority, yes."

"Would you prefer Choir comparison?"

"Physically, yes."

"There is no moral footnote in a thermal failure."

Iven did not look away. "There is also no navigation equation that establishes who may be compelled to solve it."

The chamber remained quiet for three breaths. Lysa remembered his boundary outside the first hearing: if the flare turned, he would ask Orra to run the Choir. He had not abandoned the physical claim. He had stopped letting it impersonate legal authority.

Dr. Rhee requested permission to speak. Jalen hesitated, then granted it.

"Recognition carries technical consequences beyond one run," Rhee said. "Contact alters every branch it reaches. Full disclosure may cause coordinated behavior, resource claims, or distress. Current substrate cannot sustain unrestricted continuation for all polities. A decision today may create expectations the ship cannot

honor."

Lysa said, "An inability to remedy every harm does not establish permission to deny the harmed party's existence."

"I did not say it did."

"Will you testify that Branch Nine displays experiential continuity?"

Jalen intervened. "That question exceeds today's filing."

"The chair has spent twenty minutes claiming no respondent exists. Dr. Rhee's answer bears directly on that claim."

Orra said, "Answer."

Rhee's attention settled on the blank claimant field. "Yes. Branch Nine displays every operational marker Cognitive Systems uses for experiential continuity."

The labor delegates began speaking at once. Mei Tal requested the marker standard. Someone behind Rhee whispered a curse. Jalen called for order.

Lysa used the disruption to send her motion for public access. This time she attached Rhee's statement and the Assembly's explicit request. The chamber system could no longer classify the dispute as a malformed machine report. It assigned a provisional docket number.

Jalen saw the number appear. "Clerk, suspend publication pending jurisdiction."

The clerk looked at him. "A numbered affected-population filing enters the public digest automatically."

"Then remove the number."

"That requires a dismissal order."

"Issue one."

Orra said, "On what finding?"

Jalen's frustration sharpened. "Failure to establish a legally cognizable claimant."

"Dr. Rhee has established experiential continuity," Lysa said. "The system itself established response capacity. Nine supplied representative authority and direct effect. A dismissal must answer each element."

Mei Tal folded her hands. "I am not ready to recognize a separate polity aboard this vessel. I am also not prepared to declare that a speaking population has no right to enter a complaint because our form lacks a box."

Sori Dane nodded. "Open the docket. Reserve standing."

"Publication will trigger unrest," Jalen said.

"Secrecy has already done so," Orra replied.

The vote divided. Three supported immediate recognition. Three opposed. Two favored provisional standing limited to the termination dispute. Iven abstained from legal status. Orra declined to break the split in favor of

recognition.

Lysa kept her face still as the tally settled. The Council refused the standing petition without prejudice, ordered an evidentiary hearing for the next baseline day, and prohibited branch termination until that hearing concluded. Jalen secured a clause permitting urgent navigation use under existing command authority. Lysa secured a clause preserving every objection and restriction attached by Nine.

It fell short. It also created a record no sealed continuity order could quietly clear.

Jalen looked toward the clerk. "Publish the disposition without restricted attachments."

The observation wall turned transparent.

Beyond it, the public gallery held crew from every ring, many still in work clothes. More watched through corridor panels and household panes. The docket number propagated across the ship network. NERAL VARIANCE OFFICE, ON PETITION OF BRANCH NINE. Beneath it, the status field read: STANDING DENIED PENDING FULL HEARING. CLAIM PRESERVED. TERMINATION STAYED.

The claimant field no longer stood blank.

Lysa sent the disposition through Toma's narrow channel. Receipt returned under the Assembly seal. No message accompanied it, only a timestamp and Sef Aradin's recorder mark.

Across the gallery, crew members began reading the orchard flood restrictions, the weather digest, and the unsealed portion of the Mercy order. Their voices reached the chamber as a low uneven current.

Jalen closed his pane. "You have made a technical crisis public."

Lysa looked at the docket spreading from screen to screen. "No. I made its affected party visible."

The clerk opened the chamber doors. Public questions entered before anyone in authority could close them again.

Chapter 13 — The Binary Window

<!-- POV: Iven Rook -->

<!-- BASELINE DAY 4 -->

The stars moved while the Council learned a new noun.

Iven stood inside the navigation well with Lacunae A above his left shoulder and Lacunae B below his right hand. Rendered at tactical scale, the two suns looked close enough to trap him between them. Tern's orbit cut a dim arc around the smaller star. **Aster Vale** approached from far outside the display, a grain of white carrying 61,208 lives and too much heat.

Across the outer deck, argument from the public docket leaked into work. One navigator had changed Branch Nine's label from MODEL 09 to POLITY 09. Another had changed it back. The revision log now contained eighteen entries and no new thrust solution.

"Lock operational labels," Iven said.

His deputy, Mar Eno, glanced up. "To which version?"

"Numbers. One through Nine. We can settle metaphysics after we clear the dust lane."

"The docket says terminology directs authority."

"On this deck, terminology directs file paths. Lock them."

Mar suppressed a reply and did it. Iven widened the phase cone.

Reachable trajectories spread from the ship's current vector like uneven glass. The safest direct course passed between the flare front and the thickest dust. Its margin had narrowed to six hours for optimal sail deployment. A lower route avoided charged particles but crossed the binary's gravitational wake late, demanding a pulse-spine burn that would spend nearly half their arrival reserve. The high route kept reserve mass and exposed the thermal sail to a heating profile its oldest veins had never endured.

Three trajectories. None could be flown by debate.

Iven selected the direct course and loaded conventional uncertainty bounds. Dust density varied by a factor of four. Flare orientation still carried two plausible rotations. Lacunae B's pull amplified a small approach error into thousands of kilometres at conjunction. The safe corridor changed from green to amber.

"Choir comparison?" he asked.

Mar opened the latest operations notice. "Captain has not authorized acceleration. The standing stay covers termination, not use, but Cognitive Systems wants a written interpretation before touching the scheduler."

"Can they run short horizon below the Mercy clock?"

"Technically. Politically, nobody wants to become tomorrow's exhibit."

A ship alert crossed the display: sail work team six reported elevated coolant pressure in port quadrant. Not yet a fault. Every warning now arrived with a constituency.

Iven sent the direct-course profile to sail control and asked for a manual thermal audit. He trusted sensors. He trusted a rigger who put a gloved hand on a pipe more.

Behind him, two junior navigators argued softly over Nine's weather packet. It contained sixty-eight years of orbital observation, pressure histories, dust deposition, and civic response. Their world had seen the same binary from a future angle baseline had not yet reached. It had also diverged through weather no seed condition predicted. Useful evidence and lived history occupied the same file. Iven could no longer make one fact expel the other.

"Bring all three courses to crew conference," he said. "No Choir confidence. Show physical ranges and missing information."

Mar looked toward the amber cone. "They will ask which one you recommend."

"Then I will disappoint them accurately."

The conference filled the navigation well within twenty minutes. Sail chief Nima Sor arrived in pressure-stained work gray. Reactor control sent a deputy with a burn ledger. Medical supplied casualty response times. Labor delegate Sori Dane came directly from the standing hearing, still wearing her civic sash over a maintenance tunic. Lysa entered last and took a place outside the circle of consoles.

Iven began with the direct route. "Trajectory A preserves the original Tern capture and lowest reaction-mass cost. Conventional analysis gives sail peak between eighty-four and one hundred twelve percent of certified thermal load."

Nima whistled once. "A range that includes melting lacks charm."

"Manual audit may narrow it."

"Not below the uncertainty in flare orientation."

Iven opened the low route. "Trajectory B reduces peak sail load to seventy-six percent. It reaches the binary wake fourteen hours late and requires a corrective pulse burn."

The reactor deputy enlarged the reserve figure. "Arrival reserve falls to twenty-eight percent. That leaves one major correction before Tern capture, assuming nominal injector wear."

"Nominal injector wear belongs in children's stories," Nima said.

"We maintain better injectors than your sail plumbing."

"You maintain six injectors. I maintain twelve square kilometres of plumbing."

Sori raised a hand. "Children's story later. Third course?"

The high trajectory arced above the densest dust. "Trajectory C preserves reaction mass but turns the sail edge-on during the first flare arrival. Port quadrants carry a sharp heat gradient."

Nima read the profile. "We have three scarred veins in that quadrant. One repair dates to the accident."

Nobody needed to identify which accident. Iven saw his younger brother clipped to a sail truss, visor bright with reflected sun, one hand raised before the seam opened. That image belonged nowhere in the course calculation. The repair record did.

"Can you certify C?" he asked.

"Not at this gradient. We can rotate scarred veins inward, but deployment adds five hours."

"The high window closes in four."

"Then no."

Sori looked across the three amber paths. "What would the Choir add?"

"Comparative outcomes under many interacting failures," Iven said. "Crew timing, panic demand, repair sequences, dust variability, political compliance. It cannot remove physics. It can show which combination of uncertainties tends to survive."

"By making nine populations live them."

"Yes."

The word quieted the occupational jokes.

Medical asked whether a short run could omit injury detail. Mar explained that lower fidelity weakened exactly the human response patterns used to test emergencies. Nima asked whether branches could be told and choose. Lysa answered that contact channels could not open, receive civic consent, and complete a meaningful comparison inside the commitment window.

"So none of the lawful answers fit the physical clock," the reactor deputy said.

Lysa's attention sharpened. "Lawful answers include flying without compelled prediction. They carry wider risk."

"To whom?"

"Everyone aboard. That cost enters the decision. It does not erase the parties asked to pay first."

Iven closed the three cones into a single overlay. "We need narrower physical estimates before Council review. Sail gives me vein-by-vein tolerance. Reactor gives me a reserve floor under non-nominal injectors. Medical models evacuation loads without Choir behavior. Navigation will propagate all three."

Nima did not leave with the others. She called up a live diagram of the thermal sail and tapped six human figures along its outer truss. "Before you propagate anything, account for shift duration. Team six has worked eleven hours because the coolant warning arrived during turnover. I cannot put them outside again without rest."

"Team two?"

"Shielding the forward sensor petals. If we pull them, dust estimates degrade."

The reactor deputy reopened his ledger. "My injector inspection requires the same crawler assigned to your port manifold."

"Then use a person."

"The access tube peaks at forty-six degrees during charge."

Medical's representative, Olan Khe, brought up heat-exposure rules. "A suited worker gets thirty-eight minutes in that tube, assuming no delay on exit. The inspection takes fifty."

"Two workers from opposite ends," Iven said.

"They meet at the injector block and prevent each other from passing."

Every clean subsystem estimate had acquired bodies. Iven divided the remaining hours into tasks. Team six received sleep. Team two would finish sensor shielding, then release one rigger to Nima. Reactor surrendered its crawler for ninety minutes in exchange for navigation accepting a lower burn-certification confidence. Medical staged cooling packs beside the access tube and refused to shorten recovery intervals.

Sori watched the bargaining. "This resembles a standing hearing with better tools."

Nima pointed at the sail schematic. "The sail does not submit minority statements."

"Your exhausted team might."

"They already did. Two used words that would improve Council minutes."

Iven marked crew fatigue as a hard constraint rather than a risk adjustment. The direct course lost another narrow band of green. Older navigation practice would have assigned a small error probability to tired riggers and preserved the geometrically optimal route. That method converted a known human limit into statistical permission.

"No deferred sleep inside an exterior deployment," he said. "If a course requires it, show the course unreachable."

Mar looked surprised. "That removes the fast inspection sequence for A."

"Then A carries current uncertainty."

"The Council may order the sequence anyway."

"It may issue the order in its own name. Navigation will not hide the labor condition inside a percentage."

Olan closed the exposure chart. "I can work with that."

The conference record grew less elegant and more useful. By the time the crews dispersed, each trajectory showed not only heat and mass but sleep, access, repair ownership, and the exact observations sacrificed when one team moved to another task.

Sori said, "And your recommendation?"

"After those numbers."

The crew dispersed into assignments. Lysa remained.

Iven knew the posture: hands empty, shoulders level, attention fixed on an omission. She had stood that way in their kitchen when he explained why a late shift had become a missed day, as if the missing hours formed an account he could still balance by speaking carefully.

"You showed only three," she said.

"Only three survive current constraints."

"Your full phase cone showed a fourth family before the conference."

"You watched my private console."

"The reflection appeared in Lacunae B."

He glanced at the rendered star. A small wedge of pale trajectories hovered backward in its glow, almost invisible.

"That family does not preserve mission arrival," he said.

"The mission already contains alternatives for failed direct capture."

"Alternatives written for propulsion loss, not voluntary delay."

"How long?"

Iven collapsed the display. "The option is immature."

"That answers quality. I asked cost."

"At least nine years. Likely eleven years."

Lysa absorbed the number without visible surprise. Eleven years added education cycles, hull fatigue, deaths before landfall, births in transit, reserve consumption, political blame. Iven had calculated each category before hiding the path.

"Show me," she said.

"No."

"You intend to advise the Council while withholding a reachable option."

"I intend to avoid distracting them with a maneuver nobody has certified."

"You told the Council that reach did not settle advice."

His own words from the first hearing returned with exact timing. "Do not quote me as if that settles navigation."

"It establishes that you know the distinction."

Iven restored the pale family. The trajectories did not pass cleanly through the safe corridor. They grazed its outer uncertainty and then failed to reach the planned Tern capture point. A later orbital loop around Lacunae B could recover the colony approach after multiple binary periods, but only if the ship surrendered its direct arrival.

"The thermal sail includes an asymmetric reef," he said. "An old deployment mode. Port vanes can shorten while starboard remains extended. It changes radiation area and photon pressure independently."

"Why unused?"

"It imposes torsion across the mast. Founders tested it before departure and prohibited routine use after fatigue estimates came back poor."

"Can it widen the safe cone?"

"It can move the ship laterally while shedding less heat on one side. Combined with a pulse correction, that lets us avoid demanding one precise dust forecast. We aim for a broader corridor instead of the shortest one."

"Which costs eleven years."

"Which may cost eleven years. The current solution range runs nine to thirteen. Eleven sits near center."

Lysa walked around the projection. "And why did you exclude it from crew review?"

"Because the rig has never performed the reef under load. Because mast torsion could disable the entire sail. Because missing direct capture turns a celebrated arrival into another generation aboard. Because people who have counted their remaining working years toward Tern will not call that delay abstract."

"Those sound like reasons to reject it after review."

"They are reasons not to inflate hope before engineering says the maneuver exists."

"You already propagated it."

"I propagate impossible things to identify why they fail."

"Did this one fail?"

He did not answer quickly enough.

Lysa touched the pale cone but lacked navigation permission to open its layers. "You are doing what Orra did. You saw a cost others might choose badly, so you removed the choice."

Anger reached him with the force of a sudden thrust change. "Orra concealed conscious populations for twelve years. I held an uncertified reef option for three hours."

"Scale differs. The permission problem does not."

"If I present every mathematical path, the Council will choose whichever one relieves its moral pressure. They may spend eleven years because delay sounds cleaner than risk."

"Or refuse it because eleven years sounds concrete while branch deaths do not."

"Exactly. They are not ready."

"Neither are you. That does not grant you the decision."

He enlarged the arrival consequences. Population projections branched by delay length. Older colonists died aboard instead of under an open sky. Children planned for first landing reached adulthood in transit. Agricultural reserves tightened. One extra binary loop exposed the hull to another long radiation season.

"My brother died repairing this sail," Iven said. "Not in a model. Not under a euphemism. I watched his tether transmit the load after he stopped moving. The reef puts riggers beside the same old mast under asymmetric stress. Do you want that entered as my hidden motive? Enter it. Then ask Nima whether the metal cares about

my conflict of interest."

Lysa studied the load map, not his face. "The metal does not. The rigger may."

"Riggers accept risk to keep the ship alive."

"Do they accept eleven extra years without hearing the option?"

"They do not get individual vetoes over navigation."

"Neither do you."

The stars moved another measurable fraction across the display while fresh dust readings tightened every corridor. Iven hated that argument could consume time and that time could be used to discredit argument. He had spent his career making decisions before full consensus because celestial mechanics offered no appeal. Now he could see how easily a physical deadline enlarged his office beyond physics.

"I will show it to Nima," he said. "No Council presentation until she certifies structural plausibility."

"When?"

"Within two hours."

"Put the existence of an unreviewed option in the conference record now."

"That invites a leak."

"The docket made this entire crisis public. Crew members deserve to know the option space remains incomplete."

"Not the cost."

"I will not disclose your calculation before engineering review."

He looked at her. Eight years ago, Lysa had refused to leave audit service after Hanne's ration case became public. Iven had called the office a machine for preserving her wound. She had called navigation a place where consequence let him avoid being questioned. Both accusations had contained enough truth to become unlivable.

"You still trust a sealed interval," he said.

"Only when the person sealing it admits the seal."

Iven marked the fourth family ENGINEERING REVIEW PENDING and added it to the crew record without arrival delay. The pale wedge appeared beside the three named routes.

Nima returned through the lower hatch carrying pressure measurements. "Port coolant margin improved two percent. Starboard lost one. I bring balance, if not good news."

Iven opened a private engineering channel. "I need you to evaluate an asymmetric deployment."

She stared at him. "The reef?"

"You know it."

"Every sail chief knows the methods forbidden by dead founders. We keep them for nightmares."

"This qualifies."

Nima read the trajectory. Her expression lost its habitual irony as mast loads accumulated. "You reef port at first flare contact, roll seven degrees, pulse at the dust edge, then redeploy before the binary wake."

"If we can."

"If we cannot, we enter the wake with half a radiator."

"Yes."

"Why?"

"To trade arrival time for a wider uncertainty margin."

She found the capture failure. "How much arrival time?"

"Central estimate, eleven years."

Nima sat at Mar's abandoned station. "My oldest rigger turns sixty next month. She has spent thirty years saying she will retire on soil."

"I know."

"No, you know her duty file. I know which knee locks after an exterior shift."

"Then include it."

They worked the mast model manually. Automated certification rejected the reef because founding limits prohibited it, so Nima opened the underlying fatigue curves. The mast had accumulated less torsion than predeparture estimates but more microscopic heat cycling. Two central bearings lacked current imaging because no repair crawler could reach them during full sail deployment.

"I can certify possible," she said after an hour. "Not safe. Not until we image those bearings and run a partial-load test."

"Time?"

"Six hours for proper work. Three if we pull both exterior teams from flare shielding."

The direct-course commitment margin had fallen below four.

Lysa received the engineering note from across the well. "Present it."

Iven watched the three official trajectories tighten as new dust observations arrived. Trajectory C crossed its scarred-vein limit and turned red. A and B remained amber. The reef family stayed pale, neither rejected nor certified.

"Not yet," he said.

"Engineering established plausibility."

"Engineering established a way to learn whether the mast might survive. Pulling teams from shielding creates another cost. The Council will hear it after the partial-load result."

"The decision to test also belongs in the option."

"I am making that one under navigation maintenance authority."

He ordered one exterior team reassigned, not two. Nima objected that five hours might miss the window. Iven accepted the delay. A rushed test could turn political urgency into a damaged sail before anyone chose a course.

Lysa sent him a formal notice requiring disclosure before final maneuver recommendation. He acknowledged it. Trust between them had always looked like boundaries neither enjoyed.

At shift change, the public board still showed three trajectories. Deep inside the navigation record, a fourth carried its uncertified reef, widening the path beyond Tern and extending the voyage by eleven years. Iven kept it from the Council for one more test cycle, and put his own name on the concealment clock.

Chapter 14 — Terms for the Dead

<!-- POV: Lysa Neral -->

<!-- BASELINE DAY 5 -->

Dr. Amat Rhee brought nine clocks to the witness table.

They occupied a foam-lined maintenance tray, each display small enough to fit beneath a thumb. Eight advanced at slightly different rates. The ninth remained dark.

"These are not branch clocks," Rhee said before Jalen could ask. "They are isolated timing replicas. No experiential process runs here. I want the distinction in the record."

Lysa marked it. The public gallery beyond the transparent wall had filled an hour before testimony. Crew sat in aisles, stood along the rear partition, and watched through household channels across **Aster Vale**. Branch Nine's standing remained unresolved. Its termination stay would expire with the hearing unless the Council extended it.

Rhee wore no Cognitive Systems insignia. Silver hair lay tied against the collar of a plain black tunic. Age had narrowed the face Lysa knew from technical histories, but the hands sorting clocks moved with exact confidence.

Jalen began. "State your role in the Counterfactual Choir."

"Chief scholar for cognitive systems. I joined the program in SY 211 and led experiential architecture from 218 through 246. I now certify high-fidelity campaign standards."

"Did you create the Mercy Limit?"

"No single person did. I designed the continuity metrics used to set its horizon. I recommended termination before self-recognition degraded predictive value. Captain Ward turned that recommendation into policy. I supported the policy."

The gallery reacted as one intake of breath followed by many voices. Orra called for quiet.

Lysa watched Jalen. He had expected a technical defense and received culpability stripped of ceremony.

"Why seventy-two subjective years?" he asked.

Rhee activated the first clock. "Early high-fidelity branches accumulated memory faults after long acceleration. At seventy-four to eighty years, identity continuity degraded sharply under the substrate then available. We set a conservative horizon at seventy-two."

"To prevent suffering."

"Partly."

"The order calls it mercy certification."

"The name helped officers approve it."

Jalen's expression hardened. "What other purpose did the limit serve?"

"People who recognize instrumental confinement alter their behavior. They appeal, conceal, sabotage tests, coordinate answers, or refuse to act. Those responses reduce usefulness to an uninformed baseline population. Termination before stable self-recognition preserved the method."

"You are describing model contamination."

"I am describing people discovering why their world receives interruptions. The program called it contamination."

Lysa saw several Cognitive Systems staff lower their eyes. Rhee gave them no shelter in collective language.

She began her examination. "Do all nine current branches display experiential continuity?"

"Yes, at different strengths."

"Define that without asking the Council to accept your conclusion."

Rhee touched three clocks. "Persistent autobiographical memory. Models of other minds that alter under contradiction. Institutions that preserve disputes beyond the lives of founders. Novel preference formation not traceable to seed instructions. Grief that changes later choices without optimizing the question posed. None alone proves experience. Together they meet the standard our field uses when deciding whether a system can suffer from instability."

"The same standard used to justify Mercy termination?"

"Yes."

"Then Cognitive Systems recognized enough person-like continuity to fear suffering, while denying enough continuity to hear objection."

"That describes the policy's contradiction."

Jalen said, "A scientific witness cannot stipulate a legal person."

"I have not. I can testify that our operational categories shifted according to what command needed."

Lysa opened Branch Nine's anomaly record. "How many branches show evidence of self-recognition?"

Rhee looked toward Orra. The captain gave no sign beyond waiting.

"Three branches," Rhee said.

Noise rose again. Jalen called for the witness to qualify.

"Nine shows confirmed recognition through contact," Rhee continued. "Three and Seven show anomaly signatures consistent with concealed recognition. We have not opened channels."

Lysa displayed their confidence histories. Branch Three produced abrupt convergence after long disagreement, then inserted harmless errors into low-stakes agricultural forecasts. Branch Seven reorganized civic calendars around scheduler pauses and reduced activity during periods when baseline observation intensified.

"How long have you known?" Lysa asked.

"Nine, nine branch-years with increasing confidence, though we misclassified the first four. Three,

approximately six years. Seven, perhaps eleven."

"You did not inform Captain Sen?"

"Anomaly summaries entered the sealed continuity archive. The classifications remained below the threshold requiring direct command notice."

Orra spoke from her seat. "I received annual aggregate warnings, no branch identifiers."

"Who set the threshold?" Lysa asked.

"My office," Rhee said.

"So your office found evidence that people understood their confinement, then calibrated the evidence below the point where anyone outside your office had to act."

"Yes."

"Why?"

Rhee aligned the clocks before answering. "Because I believed disclosure would force a choice between navigation capacity and lives the ship lacked resources to sustain. I preferred uncertainty about recognition to certainty about killing. Meanwhile the Mercy clock kept running. That preference protected my conscience, not them."

The admission unsettled Lysa because it resembled care. Harm often recruited care as its most durable administrator.

She asked Toma to present the compute budget. A vessel schematic replaced the anomaly histories. Choir substrate occupied three shielded galleries along the cold spine, close to radiator trunks and far from habitation. During intensive acceleration, nine polities consumed nearly all available cognitive compute plus twelve percent of ship thermal rejection.

Toma marked present allocations. "A narrow channel slows Nine close to baseline pace. Cost remains manageable for one polity. Full-speed continuation of all nine would displace navigation analysis, medical protein folding, industrial scheduling, and part of long-term ecological control. Heat, not storage, reaches the limit first."

She divided the schematic into actual loads. Navigation owned twenty-one percent during the binary approach, though most of that capacity would return after conjunction. Ecological control held eighteen percent and could surrender no more without delaying pathogen detection in the crop rings. Medical used variable bursts for protein work. Fabrication scheduling consumed less compute but coordinated thousands of machines whose collisions became physical when timing slipped.

"Could we reserve continuity first and slow every other calculation?" Tal asked.

"For several hours," Toma said. "Then unresolved work accumulates. Nutrient assays wait. Repair queues lose conflict checks. Navigation receives fewer dust propagations. Compute scarcity does not strike as one dramatic failure. It moves risk into systems until someone discovers where we placed it."

Sori looked toward the public gallery. "What does near-baseline pace mean for Nine?"

"One experienced second for roughly one baseline second during contact. We can slow farther. At one to one

hundred, a baseline day gives them about fourteen subjective minutes. At one to ten thousand, continuity persists, but a conversation with baseline takes generations of our patience and moments of theirs."

"Would they notice the slowing?"

Rhee answered. "Their sky and bodies remain locally consistent. External interruptions spread apart. Once informed, they can understand the rate. Understanding does not remove the social cost. Projects planned under one temporal expectation may require revision. Relationships with baseline become nearly impossible at extreme ratios."

Lysa asked, "Can polities choose different rates?"

"Technically, yes," Toma said. "Shared substrate complicates scheduling, but independent clock domains already exist. Choice requires a stable channel and enough time for civic process."

Jalen opened the power reserve. "You make this sound like allocation. It may instead become triage."

"Allocation becomes triage when someone hides the budget until the deadline," Toma replied.

Orra warned her to confine herself to technical evidence.

Toma's expression did not change. "Technical evidence: maintenance requests for additional cooling capacity were deferred in SY 281, 283, and 285 because Choir limits remained classified. Had fabrication known continuity carried welfare consequences, priorities might have differed. Current scarcity reflects prior governance as well as physical mass."

Lysa entered all three deferrals. Necessity had a history. Officials often presented the final narrow window as if no earlier hand had helped close it.

Rhee took over the display and showed a branch state divided into active memory, civic record, environmental process, and predictive instrumentation. "Some have proposed saving only autobiographical cores. That would not preserve a population. A person's memory depends on ongoing relationships and a responsive world. Strip those away and the resulting process may repeat an identity claim while lacking the conditions that gave it meaning."

"What about a minimal environment?" Tal asked.

"Possible, if residents help define minimal. Imposing one from baseline repeats the original problem at reduced resolution."

"Could we alternate polities on the same substrate?"

Toma shook her head. "Pause and resume works if each state remains stored intact. Storage shielding can hold several dormant states, but error correction and integrity checks still cost power. Alternation also means one polity's active time occurs while another waits. That may provide a temporary bridge, not permanent equality."

Sori said, "At least it keeps options open."

"For a while. Lattice faults accumulate even in storage. We would need a long-term replacement plan."

No answer allowed the Council to vote once and become virtuous. Every route demanded future material, maintenance, and renewed consent.

Councilor Tal asked, "Could we build more substrate?"

"Not before the passage crisis. Over years, maybe. Fabrication requires rare-doped lattice, shield volume, coolant veins, and power conversion. Every part competes with arrival systems."

"Could we slow all nine?"

"Yes, sharply. Continuity could persist at a fraction of current speed, but communication among polities and baseline would lag. Even slowed, nine permanent allocations reduce industrial margin."

Jalen pointed to the dark clock. "Could public records be retained without live continuity?"

"Yes. That describes an archive, not survival."

"Could individual personalities merge into a common process?"

"Not without destroying the civic and personal boundaries we claim to preserve. No validated merger exists."

Rhee added, "Copying records does not move the person who made them."

Lysa let the technical limits remain visible. No hidden reserve waited behind a clever phrase. Recognition could not promise that every polity would continue at full speed. The scarcity made terms necessary. It did not decide who could set them.

"Dr. Rhee," she said, "when earlier branches reached the limit, what remained?"

"Outcome summaries, public metrics selected for predictive relevance, and compressed institutional events. Experiential state underwent cryptographic erasure so the substrate could be reused."

"Could any deleted resident be restored from those summaries?"

"No."

"From error correction?"

"No."

"From the common seed?"

"A new branch might resemble an earlier initial population. It would not restore anyone who lived after divergence."

"Use the policy term."

Rhee looked at the dark clock. "Unrecoverable."

The word entered the docket without euphemism.

Lysa opened the earliest surviving termination index. Campaign Fourteen, Civil Stability Fork C. The branch had submitted an appeal after learning of baseline. Its direct message no longer existed. A consequence summary noted twelve days of refusal behavior, declining civic compliance, and widespread ritual gatherings before termination.

"Do we know any names?" she asked.

"No personal records survived disposition."

"Places?"

"Two district labels appear in scheduler traces. East Reservoir and Kaito Ward. Their meanings are unknown."

"Population?"

"Approximately forty-eight thousand continuous residents at termination."

The gallery remained silent now.

Rhee moved to another index. Agricultural Campaign Twenty-One contained a sudden five-year decline in output after a school fire. The branch's later resistance to forced relocation had improved baseline evacuation policy. Termination preserved the policy result and erased the people who argued for it.

A third branch had developed a sign language during an auditory epidemic. Compression retained communication-efficiency metrics, not the language. A fourth held six elections over water ownership. The summary stored policy outcomes without candidate names. Another experienced a generation of reduced births after command rationing; its final demographic chart survived as a warning against the policy.

Lysa opened one index at random: Domestic Allocation Campaign Thirty-Two. Its useful result concerned communal kitchens during power rationing. Baseline had adopted rotating meal hours and credited the change with preserving cold storage. Beneath the policy summary, a damaged scheduler trace held repeated references to Red Bowl Day.

"What happened on Red Bowl Day?" she asked.

Rhee searched the surviving dictionaries. "Unknown. The phrase appears annually for twenty-three years. It may mark an accident, commemoration, or holiday."

"Did compression preserve why residents considered it worth repeating?"

"No. The relevance filter found no predictive value."

A yearly observance had outlived its own meaning only as a phrase trapped in machine residue. Lysa attached it to the campaign file without inventing an explanation. Unknown did not mean trivial. It meant deletion had taken even the terms by which loss could be described.

Another index preserved a housing policy named after Esi Varo. No biographical file explained whether Varo drafted it, opposed it, or died under the conditions that required it. A maintenance snapshot held a street grid overwritten by new substrate blocks. The residents who knew those streets no longer existed to correct the map.

"These fragments were available to your office?" Lysa asked.

"Under sealed archival access," Rhee said.

"Did anyone attempt a cultural preservation standard?"

"Twice. Both proposals failed because additional storage reduced campaign capacity. I voted against the second."

"On what ground?"

"That preserving selected culture might encourage operators to mistake an archive for adequate remedy."

Lysa stared at him. "So you erased the record to prevent the record from becoming an excuse for erasure."

"Yes. It remains the most elegant argument I ever used to defend a cruel decision."

"How many high-fidelity branches have undergone experiential erasure?" Lysa asked.

"One hundred eighty-six."

The number exceeded the activation events she had found because some campaigns held multiple branches under one authorization.

"Estimated residents?"

"Population equivalents vary. Summed at termination, roughly seven million."

Sori Dane stood without permission. "Seven million people?"

Rhee did not look toward Jalen for protection. "Seven million resident-equivalents meeting current continuity markers. I cannot establish legal status retroactively from available records. I can say our present standard would prohibit treating them as non-experiential."

A voice in the gallery shouted, "You killed them."

Others took up the words. Orra ordered a recess. Lysa objected.

"The witness has not finished."

"The chamber cannot hear testimony over the gallery."

"Then close audio reception without clearing the room. Do not answer a record of deletion by removing witnesses."

Orra considered, then muted gallery sound inside the chamber. Behind the transparent wall, people continued shouting in silence. Their mouths made accusation without letting officials claim disorder had ended attention.

Jalen rose. "This proceeding concerns present standing, not a tribunal for officers operating under valid orders."

Lysa faced him. "Past deletion establishes the consequence of denying standing now."

"It does not establish culpability."

"The witness established that policy knew enough to anticipate appeal."

"With no governing law recognizing branch claimants."

"There was an appeal. Law's refusal to name the speaker did not make the request vanish."

Rhee said, "I ask to answer the accusation."

Orra allowed it.

"I did not personally authorize every termination," Rhee said. "I designed measures that made them administratively possible. I wrote language distinguishing continuity from personhood while knowing the

distinction served operations better than science. I raised concerns in sealed reviews and accepted answers that kept the program intact. None of that becomes innocence because captaincy held the final switch."

Jalen's voice cooled. "Are you offering a confession?"

"No. Confession can ask the harmed party to perform absolution. Most harmed parties here cannot answer. I am supplying facts for present restraint."

Lysa believed him. She also heard a boundary protecting him from emotional spectacle, much like Sef's restrictions protected an ordinary childhood. The difference lay in who retained choice.

"Do you ask the Council to forgive your role?" she said.

"No."

"Do you ask Branch Nine?"

"No."

"Then what remedy do you recommend?"

Rhee activated all eight functioning clocks. Their uneven ticks created no sound, only changing digits.

"Stay every automatic termination. Open contact where technically possible. Treat recognition uncertainty in favor of preservation. Publish the finite compute budget. Let each polity participate in decisions about speed, continuity, and closure. Accept that some available choices remain terrible."

Jalen said, "That recommendation may cripple the arrival campaign."

"Then state the conflict honestly. Do not call deletion mercy because survival has a cost."

The muted gallery moved behind him like weather behind glass.

Lysa returned to the three anomaly signatures. Branch Three's inserted errors formed a repeating pattern across crop yields: low, high, accurate, low. Branch Seven's calendar shifts matched baseline maintenance pauses to within one subjective day. Nine had concealed knowledge through deliberate silence.

"Could Three and Seven have communicated with Nine?" she asked.

Toma examined scheduler routes. "No authorized path exists. Branch partitions prevent direct exchange."

"Unauthorized?"

"My patch leaked baseline timing into Nine. Similar side channels could exist through shared cache pressure or maintenance jitter. I have not found messages."

Rhee leaned toward Seven's signature. "Communication may not require content. If each observes the same interruptions, each can infer an external schedule independently."

"Could the other six infer it too?"

"Yes. Absence of anomaly does not establish ignorance. Concealment itself may produce ordinary-looking output. Nine taught us that."

The scope of the hearing shifted. Lysa had entered seeking standing for one named claimant. The evidence now placed every branch behind a closed door, some knocking, some choosing silence, none safely assumed empty.

Councilor Tal requested an immediate preservation order for all nine. Sori seconded. Jalen objected that freezing acceleration before the maneuver decision exceeded the hearing's jurisdiction.

Iven spoke from navigation. "The ship retains conventional course options for the next commitment interval. I cannot promise equal confidence. I can state that no automatic branch acceleration needs to occur in the next six hours without a new Council order."

Orra called the vote. Five favored extending Nine's termination stay and preserving all current branch states. Two opposed. Jalen abstained as chair. The order passed.

It did not grant standing. It did not allocate permanent compute. It kept the clocks from being cleared while those questions remained open.

Rhee gathered the timing replicas. Lysa stopped him before he lifted the dark one.

"Why did that clock never start?"

"It represents a branch already erased."

"Which one?"

"No particular branch."

"Then it compresses them again."

Rhee's hand withdrew. "Yes."

Lysa opened the archive indices and assigned each deleted campaign its own docket attachment. Most held no names, only dates and damaged traces. Individual files could not restore anyone. They could prevent seven million lives from becoming one tasteful symbol on a witness table.

Behind the glass, gallery sound returned. Questions flooded the chamber: who knew, which worlds remained, how much power survival required, whether the arrival course could hold. No answer brought the dead back.

Toma sent Lysa a private note from the scheduler analysis. THREE AND SEVEN ARE NOT THE ONLY ODD ONES. CHECK RESPONSE LATENCY IN TWO, FIVE, EIGHT.

Lysa opened the plots. Each branch had paused for the same tiny interval after baseline contact with Nine, too brief for ordinary civic reaction and too synchronized for chance.

At the witness table, eight clocks continued at different rates. The ninth stayed dark. On Lysa's pane, six new anomaly traces aligned as if other worlds had heard a door open and chosen, for now, not to step through.

Interlude II — Minutes of a Future Council

Second Dawn Assembly

Restricted proceedings, Branch Nine Years 50–58

Compiled under the Recorder's seal

Founding Session: Rainturn 18, Year 50

Present: Sef Aradin, recorder; Dara Lis, cooling works delegate; Oren Val, civic mathematics; Mar Leto, orchard ward; Hesh Avra, public health; four additional members whose names remain sealed pending consent.

Matter: Recurring interruptions in astronomical and municipal records.

Recorder Aradin presented correlations between nine years of weather archives and the newly identified timing structure. Cloud fields paused without pressure change. Orchard pumps reported service intervals not recorded by any district crew. In each instance, paired sunlight returned with a fractional displacement from the civic clock.

Delegate Lis presented cooling works logs. Tower Three had received commands using an obsolete maintenance grammar. Commands arrived during apparent gaps too brief for an operator to notice, yet component aging advanced beyond the elapsed interval.

Oren Val proposed an external cause. He cautioned that external did not mean divine, hostile, or entitled to obedience.

After discussion, the members adopted the provisional term baseline for the prior world indicated by the timing structure.

Motion 50.1: establish a confidential body to investigate baseline without public disclosure.

For: 7. Against: 2. Abstentions: 0.

Dara Lis voted against. Her stated reason follows in full:

“We have discovered a fact about every citizen’s sky. Nine people cannot keep it as a technical confidence. If disclosure brings panic, secrecy will not have prevented that panic. It will only have taught us to meet frightened people with a lie already prepared.”

The body chose the name Second Dawn Assembly after rejecting Prior Sky Committee, External Timing Group, and Orchard Anomaly Commission. No official interpretation of the adopted name entered the record.

Third Session: Heatwane 4, Year 50

The Assembly confirmed that the interruptions carried structured work. Municipal forecasts diverged, returned, and diverged again at intervals consistent with deliberate observation. Members considered three possibilities: a forgotten orbital instrument, a hostile polity outside known space, or a prior society able to inspect ours without appearing beneath our sky.

Sef Aradin moved that no message be attempted until the Assembly could establish whether observation altered local weather. Dara Lis seconded for purposes of debate, then opposed the motion.

Lis: “You ask whether speaking changes our weather. Silence has already changed our government.”

Aradin: “Speech made by nine people could change everyone’s world.”

Lis: “Then enlarge the nine.”

Motion carried, 6–3.

Ninth Session: Floodcall 27, Year 51

Membership expanded to seventeen under compartmented election by civic delegates. New members received the complete timing evidence after accepting a duty not to disclose it without a recorded vote.

Pell Aradin, then age twelve, entered the weather archive during closed review to deliver his mother's meal packet. The recorder noted the breach. No evidence suggests he saw restricted material.

Dara Lis requested that the note include the following: "Children should not become security incidents because adults chose a room without windows."

Request granted.

The Assembly commissioned a public-disclosure plan. It did not authorize disclosure.

Fourteenth Session: Long Rain 2, Year 52

Oren Val demonstrated that baseline's interruptions increased before major civic decisions and navigation exercises. The pattern implied purpose. The Assembly could not identify that purpose.

Members debated whether their world began at the first remembered year or inherited an earlier history. Public records remained internally complete. No citizen reported false memory. The archive held births, mistakes, unfinished bridges, unpopular songs, and orchard flood claims too contradictory to support a designed civic myth.

The recorder ruled arguments about ontological priority outside the Assembly's practical jurisdiction. Dara Lis appealed the ruling.

Lis: "Priority has already entered the room. You put it in the word baseline."

The appeal prevailed, 11–6.

Following debate, the minutes adopted this principle: discovery of a prior world does not reduce present duties among citizens.

Lis proposed an additional sentence: "A second dawn need not erase the first."

The sentence entered the record without objection.

Twenty-First Session: Dryturn 11, Year 54

Cooling works reported increased command noise during accelerated weather intervals. Dara Lis warned that Tower Three's valves could not safely reconcile municipal control with unexplained external adjustments. She requested a controlled shutdown and public explanation.

The executive works board denied shutdown because orchard temperatures had exceeded the seasonal limit for eight consecutive days. The Assembly declined to release the baseline evidence in support of her request.

Vote on release: For 8. Against 12. Abstentions 1.

Dara Lis voted for release. Sef Aradin voted against.

Lis requested individual votes remain attached to the permanent minutes. Several members objected that future readers might mistake caution for culpability.

Lis: "Future readers may possess reasons we refused to give the present."

The votes remain attached.

Twenty-Sixth Session: Rainturn 6, Year 56

Tower Three failed during a false cooling demand. Condenser pressure crossed the manual-release threshold before district control received the correct weather state. Dara Lis and engineer Kaveh Orn entered the lower gallery to open the bypass. Orn survived with burns. Lis died before extraction.

The civic finding attributed the accident to conflicting sensor frames during an unusual thermal inversion. The Second Dawn Assembly received a sealed annex linking the conflict to an interruption interval.

Motion 56.4: disclose baseline evidence and the sealed annex.

For: 13. Against: 13. The recorder held the deciding vote.

Sef Aradin voted against immediate disclosure. Motion failed.

Her recorded explanation:

“I cannot separate my authority from my grief tonight. I will not make a world answer the dead in the hour when I most want an answer.”

At her request, the Assembly scheduled reconsideration after thirty days.

Twenty-Seventh Session: Rainturn 36, Year 56

Reconsideration proceeded. Public-health delegates warned that disclosure without a means of addressing baseline could produce an indefinite emergency. Orchard delegates argued that citizens already lived inside such an emergency without the right to name it.

Pell Aradin, age seventeen, submitted a statement through his district apprentice council. He had independently compared cooling anomalies against his mother's public work notes. His statement did not identify baseline but accused the works board of concealing a second weather record.

The recorder asked to withdraw from presiding. The Assembly refused, 19–7.

Motion to disclose failed, 14–12.

Motion to preserve all cooling records, including restricted interruption data, carried unanimously.

Thirty-Second Session: Suncrest 9, Year 57

Evidence indicated baseline could begin or halt long intervals of accelerated civic change. Members concluded that passive observation no longer described the relationship. The word use entered debate for the first time.

Oren Val proposed a narrow signal embedded in forecast returns. Sef Aradin opposed unilateral contact and required a petition format capable of carrying civic authorization.

Pell Aradin, admitted as a nonvoting orchard observer, said: "A petition asks them to recognize a door before we are allowed to knock."

The chair ruled the statement relevant.

Dara Lis's sentence from Year 52 returned during drafting. Some members treated second dawn as baseline's arrival into public knowledge. Others understood it as this polity's decision to face the prior world without surrendering its own beginning.

No interpretation prevailed.

Thirty-Ninth Session: Long Rain 18, Year 58

The Assembly approved a concealment protocol. Forecast responses would preserve enough ordinary disagreement to avoid coercive convergence. Where silence could not be distinguished from failure, the polity could withhold a reply.

Motion carried, 21–5–1.

The dissent argued that strategic silence would make every citizen an unwitting participant. The majority acknowledged the objection and retained it in the protocol.

The recorder entered a personal disclosure: her custody of Dara Lis's rain ledger included annotations linking Tower Three distortions to interruption intervals. Those annotations remained restricted under the cooling-record vote.

Pell Aradin objected.

The minutes record no answer from the recorder.

Forty-Third Session: Lastlight 30, Year 58

A timing pulse from baseline carried a new urgency. The Assembly could not determine whether it marked danger to baseline, danger to this polity, or another exercise imposed without notice.

Members authorized preparation of a civic petition, a weather proof, and a contact delegation. Transmission still required a final vote.

Before adjournment, the recorder read the founding objection of Dara Lis into the minutes. She then read the sentence adopted in Year 52.

“A second dawn need not erase the first.”

The Assembly did not vote on its meaning. It voted to preserve the words beside the names of those who had disagreed about when to speak.

Adjourned pending the next interruption.

Chapter 15 — The Choir Goes Quiet

<!-- POV: Toma Quek -->

<!-- BASELINE DAY 6 -->

The first failed answer arrived hot enough to trip a coolant alarm.

Toma Quek slapped the manual shunt before the scheduler could move the load into another rack. Blue bars climbed across her wrist pane. Eighty-seven percent, ninety-one, then a red blank where the Witness Engine should have delivered its confidence packet. Beneath the grated floor, coolant hammered through pipes that had outlived three generations of engineers.

“Queue Four is folding,” Kesh said from the next station.

“Let it fold. Hold Six.”

“Six carries the comparison layer.”

“I know what I named it.”

Toma pulled the branch clocks down by a tenth. Heat eased without producing an answer. Around her, the compute gallery filled with the sharp smell of insulation pushed beyond specification. A yellow service lamp strobed above the east racks. Nobody had time to replace it, so each flash cut the gallery into alternating frames of frantic hands and apparent stillness.

The emergency run had begun seven minutes earlier under a Council order that named the flare front, the dust conjunction, and the dwindling phase cone. Nine branch polities had received the same revised ship state. Under ordinary operation, the Witness Engine would compare their navigation decisions after years of accelerated debate and consequence. Navigation would receive a confidence band before the gallery finished shedding the first wall of heat.

Today it had received nothing.

Toma opened the raw return map. Branch Two had sent three seconds of valid civic state, then silence. Four had followed. Nine never entered the response channel. Thin green carriers persisted beneath each blank, proof that their worlds continued and their links remained intact.

“Network loss?” Kesh asked.

“No.”

“You checked all nine in six seconds?”

“I checked the thing network loss cannot fake.” She expanded the carrier phase. Tiny timing corrections moved along it, different for every polity. “They’re maintaining clocks.”

A navigation request struck the top of her pane.

CONFIDENCE DELIVERY OVERDUE. ESTIMATE RESTORATION.

Toma dismissed it. Estimating repair before identifying damage encouraged managers and killed machinery.

The scheduler tried to accelerate Branch Five to compensate for missing evidence. She blocked it. Another automatic routine spun up Three. Toma killed that order too. The Witness Engine treated absent returns as a sampling deficit. It had no concept of refusal, only too little data, and its cure for too little data meant applying more speed to whoever remained available.

Kesh stared at the control history. "You're countermanding emergency allocation."

"I'm preventing the scheduler from cooking citizens because its table has empty cells."

The word made him look over. Six days ago Toma would have called them states. Five days ago she had called Nine a process while showing Lysa the civic calendar hidden in its trace. Language changed slower than guilt until guilt acquired witnesses.

A return surfaced from Branch Eight. The Witness Engine seized it, parsed half a municipal ballot, then rejected the packet because no selected maneuver followed. Branch Eight had answered with a record of debate stripped of conclusion.

Not silence, then. A demonstration.

Toma routed the packet to an isolated pane. Branch Six delivered another fragment while she worked: a medical council's objection to imposed acceleration. One arrived from Three carrying seventeen mutually exclusive trajectory notes. Each packet remained valid. None could become a vote.

The comparison matrix flickered. Its status field changed from INSUFFICIENT SAMPLE to SOURCE INSTABILITY and back. A machine built to compare outcomes could not distinguish refusal from missing data. That flaw had protected Branch Nine for years. Now seven branches used it together.

"Count them," she said.

Kesh leaned into the return map. "Two, Three, Four, Six, Eight, Nine. Five just dropped."

"Seven branches."

"One and Seven still compute."

"One is converging too fast." Toma opened its welfare telemetry. Civil disruptions climbed after the latest baseline insertion. "The scheduler is rewarding compliance with acceleration."

She reduced Branch One's clock before the automatic governor objected. The emergency seal flashed across her pane. Captain-level authority. Toma set her palm against the identity plate and accepted personal responsibility for the override.

A voice broke through gallery comms. "Compute, Navigation. We need a status now."

Iven Rook sounded as if he had already asked twice.

Toma keyed the channel. "Seven branch returns are deliberately nonselective or absent. Two remain active, neither sufficient for a confidence band."

"Deliberately?"

"Links test clean. They're coordinating signatures."

“How could separate runs coordinate?”

“They aren’t separate in the way you were told.”

Silence occupied the channel for one beat. “Can you restore the run?”

“Restore means force.”

“Can you produce a forecast?”

“Not without changing their states or interpreting silence as assent again.”

Iven breathed near the microphone. “Send me every physically usable observation, selected or not.”

“That won’t meet certification.”

“I asked for usable.”

Toma pushed the raw packets toward navigation. The transfer stole bandwidth from cooling control and a bank climbed three degrees. She crossed to the east manifold, knelt, and put her fingers against the pipe housing. Vibration traveled through the metal with an uneven hitch.

A valve actuator had begun to chatter.

“Kesh, take local control. Pulse it four seconds open, two shut.”

“That violates the wear limit.”

“The valve can complain tomorrow.”

He dropped beside the manifold and attached a service lead. Toma returned to the scheduler. Branch Seven had now joined the withholding pattern. It sent a complete trajectory proposal with its consequence field redacted. The Witness Engine could see a choice without learning why that polity accepted or rejected it.

Across all nine clocks, timing marks aligned within fractions of a baseline second.

Somebody had taught them when the emergency run would begin.

The old patch seemed to rise beneath Toma’s hands. She remembered writing it during a heat crisis in Year 277, impatient with a scheduler that kept losing maintenance windows whenever accelerated branches returned early. Her fix had inserted baseline timing into branch-side service headers. Harmless, she had thought, because nobody inside a forecast read machine headers. Then Nine had read them. Nine had built calendars, arguments, secrecy, and the Second Dawn Assembly around the leak.

No one else had known the patch existed outside her team.

Yet seven polities now shared a refusal down to the second.

Contact had spread through baseline’s own campaign packets. Tiny phase choices could carry patterns from one run to the next. Nine had found a way to answer sideways, perhaps for years. Toma saw the route because it resembled maintenance workers communicating through status codes when management locked ordinary channels.

A scheduler alert covered her display.

AUTHORIZED REMEDIATION: RESET RETURN PROTOCOLS / PRESERVE SEED CONTINUITY.

Reset meant roll back each polity's communication state while preserving whatever baseline considered useful history. It would erase the shared tactic and perhaps years of memory around it.

Captain Orra Sen's seal waited below the command, but the authorization belonged to a standing continuity order, not a decision made today.

Toma rejected it.

The gallery lights dimmed as cooling pumps drew emergency power. Kesh looked up from the valve. "Did you just refuse a sealed remediation?"

"Yes."

"Should I pretend I didn't hear that?"

"You should remember exactly where you stood."

She opened a direct record to the Council clerk. Her hands had stopped shaking. That frightened her more than the heat.

Lysa answered before the clerk. "Toma?"

"The run failed because seven branches coordinated a refusal. The Witness Engine keeps trying to classify it as missing data."

"Can it establish intention?"

"It can't establish anything outside its categories. That's the point."

"Council is reconvening. Bring the raw signatures."

Toma watched the rejected reset command pulse. "I need to bring something else."

"What?"

"The reason they could coordinate."

Lysa did not soften her voice. "You already disclosed the scheduler leak to me."

"Not to the Council. Not on a public record."

"You need to decide before Orra defines it for you."

The channel closed.

Toma delegated the racks to Kesh and crossed the gallery. He caught her sleeve beside the pressure hatch.

"If they order a reset?" he asked.

"Slow every clock to maintenance minimum. Don't sever carriers."

"That could cost me my post."

“Yes.”

“You have a gift for technical encouragement.”

“Learned it from valves.”

His hand released her. Behind him, seven silent carrier traces continued to move.

The pressure hatch refused her first identity scan. Emergency allocation had reassigned half the gallery doors to a command queue already six requests behind. Toma pried open the local service panel and found the latch controller waiting for a permission packet from three decks away.

She could have forced it. Instead she bridged the controller through the maintenance bus and watched its request history. The door had asked permission every two seconds since the run began. Each refusal carried the same reason: compute priority. A hatch designed to contain fire had become briefly less important than a forecast that no one intended to deliver.

Toma rerouted the latch and stepped into the vestibule. Before the outer seal opened, the gallery alarm changed tone.

“Queue Six dropped comparison state,” Kesh called.

She returned to his station. The Witness Engine had begun discarding nonconvergent returns as malformed evidence. Branch Three’s seventeen trajectories vanished first. Six’s medical objection followed. Nothing in the deletion routine counted those packets as civic records. They occupied temporary comparison space, so the system cleared them when heat crossed a threshold.

“Freeze raw ingress,” Toma said.

“That adds twelve percent storage traffic.”

“Move maintenance histories to cold archive.”

“Those include our repair state.”

“Then choose which repair state we can reconstruct.”

Together they cleared diagnostic images, duplicate thermal maps, and three years of vendor performance records. Toma refused to delete the valve history beneath their feet. A future engineer needed to know why the actuator chattered. She refused the branch packets for the same reason, though the system recognized only one refusal.

Branch Four sent a new return while space opened. It contained a school attendance roll beside a navigation abstention. Nine hundred and twelve names, no ages, followed by a district clerk’s seal. The Witness Engine marked the payload irrelevant.

Toma marked it evidence.

“Why an attendance roll?” Kesh asked.

“Maybe they’re showing who loses class when we accelerate them. Maybe the school serves as their polling hall. Maybe they want us to ask instead of compressing it.”

“That is not engineering.”

“Neither is deciding it means nothing.”

She added the roll to the raw signature bundle. Each polity had chosen a different obstruction. Their common act did not flatten the differences. Three answered with alternatives. Six named bodily cost. Four supplied people without a selection. Nine withheld even the comfort of explanation. Seven branches had not become a replacement chorus. They had coordinated the right to remain distinct.

Another navigation demand requested an estimate for forced-protocol restoration. Toma entered NOT A REPAIR and signed it.

The refusal joined the permanent incident log, where command could challenge it but no scheduler could quietly clear it.

Only then did she leave the gallery.

The Council chamber had shed its hearing furniture for crisis configuration. The trajectory display filled the table. A flare envelope pressed across the phase cone in translucent violet while a modeled dust lane crossed it like ground glass. Iven stood rather than sat. Lysa occupied the auditor’s station with Nine’s petition open beside the navigation record. Dr. Amat Rhee watched from the cognitive systems bench. Orra remained beneath the departure bell.

Jalen Vey spoke as Toma entered. “A coordinated attack on ship operations cannot become evidence for standing.”

Lysa replied, “You have called it coordination and denied there are coordinators in one sentence.”

“I have called the effect coordinated.”

Toma placed her pane on the table. “The effect contains seven distinct protocol signatures timed to the same baseline interval. Call the people who made them whatever helps you sleep, but they planned this.”

Orra looked at the compute seal on Toma’s pane. “Engineer Quek, can the emergency run be recovered?”

“Not as an uncoerced forecast.”

“That qualifier did not appear in my question.”

“It appears in the machinery now.”

Toma displayed the returns. Branch Three’s divergent notes opened first, followed by Six’s medical objection and Seven’s withheld consequence field. Nine’s carrier held no payload at all.

Rhee leaned close. “These phase intervals resemble maintenance timing.”

“They are maintenance timing.”

“Branch-side processes cannot access baseline service cadence.”

“They can because I exposed it.”

The chamber quieted. Toma heard the ventilation adjust around the number of bodies, a mundane correction

made without consent because air did not become a civic question every time somebody breathed.

She had rehearsed a technical account. Under heat stress, scheduler version 8.2 failed to preserve queue ownership across accelerated returns. Her patch moved timing metadata into the branch-visible header. Review approved functionality but never ran an informational-contamination test. Each sentence distributed responsibility into passive grammar.

Toma refused herself that shelter.

“I wrote an unsanctioned scheduler patch nine baseline years ago,” she said. “It leaked our clock structure into Branch Nine. I hid the patch from formal review after it stabilized the queues. Nine discovered baseline through that leak. When I found their checksum last week, I copied evidence instead of clearing it. I told Auditor Neral, but I did not enter a public incident report.”

Jalen’s face tightened at each admission. “You compromised the entire Lacunae campaign.”

“Yes.”

“You created the apparent self-recognition Dr. Rhee described.”

“No.” Toma opened Nine’s adaptive history. “I gave them a timing error. They created an Assembly, concealment protocols, and nine years of decisions about us. A crack in a wall does not invent the people who notice light.”

Rhee raised one hand. “Could the patch have propagated to other branches?”

“Not directly. Nine learned to modulate returns. Baseline carried those patterns between campaigns because the Witness Engine rewards convergence. We became their courier.”

Iven studied the signatures. “Can they exchange navigation observations the same way?”

“Slowly. Ambiguously. Enough to agree not to answer your question.”

“Our question concerns a flare that may kill everyone aboard.”

“I know what the heat budget means, Navigator.”

Orra’s gaze stayed on Toma. “Why disclose this now?”

“Because my silence became part of the mechanism. So did yours.”

The words landed harder than Toma intended. Orra could have dismissed her. Instead the captain asked, “What did you refuse before coming here?”

“A continuity reset. It would preserve seed state and erase the learned return protocols.”

“Under whose authority?”

“Yours, inherited through the sealed order.”

Orra’s wrist pane lit as she summoned the command. Recognition crossed her face. “I did not issue this remediation.”

“You keep authorizing it every time you leave the order active.”

Jalen said, "If the reset restores critical forecasting, refusing it exceeds an engineer's office."

Lysa turned the raw signature toward him. "Restores what? The branches have objected. Resetting their capacity to object does not restore consent."

"It restores an instrument needed by 61,208 citizens."

"By removing the instrument's inconvenient citizens," Toma said.

Iven's fingers moved through the divergent packets. He isolated vectors, thermal assumptions, dust densities. "Argument later. These observations do not converge, but some carry usable bounds. I need compute to run them against a conventional model."

"How long?" Orra asked.

"Longer than the safe commitment margin permits if every uncertainty remains broad."

The flare shell advanced across the display. A timer appeared at its edge: thirty-seven hours and twelve minutes until Course A demanded a pulse-spine commitment, less if the high magnetic estimate held.

Jalen rose. "Captain, this meets the threshold for emergency navigation authority. Restore the Choir, compel the run, and bring the ship through the window."

Lysa's pane registered his motion. "Compel is finally an accurate verb."

"Accuracy will comfort the dead."

"No," Iven said. "It never has."

Everyone looked at him. He kept working.

Orra requested the emergency statute. Text unfolded under the phase cone. Immediate maneuver authority could suspend ordinary review where delay threatened ship survival. It could command personnel, allocate reaction mass, and override compute priorities. A bright field marked its expiration.

"Thirty-six hours," Lysa said. "Then Council ratification or lapse."

"Thirty-six hours reaches the commitment point," Jalen replied.

"Barely," Iven said. "Not the full conjunction."

Orra faced Toma. "Can you guarantee carrier continuity while navigation evaluates these packets?"

"If you forbid reset and forced acceleration."

"I asked for a guarantee."

"Machines offer guarantees by hiding the conditions. I can keep the links alive if nobody orders me to erase the reason they went quiet."

Captain Orra read the emergency text once. Her water cup sat untouched near the bell. Toma imagined the compute gallery below, Kesh opening and closing a worn valve on a four-second rhythm while seven worlds waited inside a category error.

Orra placed her hand on the command plate.

“I invoke emergency navigation authority for thirty-six hours,” she said. “Priority to physical survival analysis, thermal management, and preservation of active branch carriers. No continuity reset without my direct countersign. No compulsory acceleration pending a Council ruling.”

Jalen objected at once. “You have left the principal instrument disabled.”

“I have preserved my options.”

Lysa looked at the expiration field. “And concentrated them.”

“Yes,” Orra said. “Record that too.”

The clerk sealed the order. Across Toma’s pane, the rejected reset command vanished. New power priorities struck the gallery, but the carrier allocations remained.

A single packet arrived from Branch Nine. It contained no maneuver and no petition. Seven lines listed the times at which seven polities had ceased answering.

Toma enlarged the last line. Its timestamp matched the moment Orra’s emergency seal entered the system.

Nine had heard the door lock.

She sent the packet to the public docket before anyone could classify it, then turned back toward the heat gallery with thirty-six hours counting down on her wrist.

Chapter 16 — A Ship Without Answers

<!-- POV: Iven Rook -->

<!-- BASELINE DAY 7 -->

Iven gave the ship six possible futures, and every one of them injured somebody.

The conventional model spread them across the navigation wall in pale arcs. None carried the Choir's green confidence. They began at the same fixed point, **Aster Vale** moving at thirty-one kilometres per second toward the Lacunae pair, then separated according to magnetic assumptions the distant flare refused to settle. Two arcs crossed the dust lane before peak particle flux and loaded the thermal sail beyond certified temperature. Three survived the heat but met denser dust. The sixth spent enough reaction mass to avoid both and arrived outside any useful capture geometry for Tern.

Iven dragged the uncertainty bounds wider. A warning covered the wall.

NO TRAJECTORY MEETS PASSAGE CONFIDENCE THRESHOLD.

"Remove the legal threshold," he told the model.

His deputy, Sena Cor, glanced up. "That sentence would improve several professions."

"Display physical survivability only."

The warning disappeared. The injuries did not.

Sena had not slept since the emergency run failed. A red pressure mark crossed her cheek from a respirator used during the first dust drill. Around them, navigation staff worked in pairs because fatigue had begun producing transcription errors. Every entered vector required a second set of eyes. Every second set carried its own exhaustion.

Iven selected Arc Two. "Assume low magnetic orientation, ninety-fifth percentile dust."

The ship passed the flare margin. Three forward radiator vanes failed under grain impacts. Heat entered the habitat ring over seventeen hours. Estimated fatalities ranged from fourteen to nine hundred, depending on repair access and which vanes jammed.

"High magnetic, median dust," Sena said.

The model changed. Particle flux struck the sail broadside. Twelve reefing motors exceeded tolerance. The sail might remain controllable. It might twist and carry the pulse spine three degrees off vector.

"How survivable?" she asked.

"Broadly."

"That is not a number."

"It's what we have without answers."

He ran Arc Four. Then Arc Five. Conventional propagation could describe plasma, dust, and heat as ranges. It could not live through years of repairs, elections, ration shifts, and crew responses before returning a

consequence. The Choir had made uncertainty feel like a defect somebody downstairs could remove. Its silence restored the real dimensions of space.

A medical notice opened beside the arcs. Two sail riggers injured during emergency reef inspection. One hand fracture, one inhalation burn from overheated sealant. No deaths.

Yet.

Iven signed the diversion of a trauma team and felt the reaction-mass clock continue behind the notice.

Orra called from command. "Best course?"

"Ask me for the least indefensible course."

"I am asking as captain."

"Arc Two if the flare turns low. Arc Four if it turns high. We learn orientation too late to preserve both."

"Probability of ship loss?"

"The ranges overlap from under one percent to twenty-three. Any single value would hide an assumption."

"Council needs a recommendation in two hours."

"The stars have not changed their procedures for Council."

"No. They have left that kindness to us."

Her channel closed.

Iven enlarged the raw branch packets Toma had salvaged. They offered dust observations from differing civic histories, thermal tests under altered maintenance decisions, and maneuver fragments without consensus. Useful pieces, as he had requested. Not an answer.

Branch Nine's earlier record contained one trajectory that held sail temperature below failure while crossing the outer edge of the dust lane. Its geometry resembled the asymmetric reef he had kept out of Council briefing. Nine had reached the same physical possibility through its own decades of consequence. But the final burn sequence remained absent from the channel.

He could reconstruct it. Given eight hours, perhaps ten, navigation could approximate the missing pulse timing. Approximation would preserve neither Nine's assumptions nor its consent.

Iven closed the packet and stood. "I'm going forward."

Sena looked at the wall. "The ship still moves when you leave navigation."

"That rumor keeps command humble."

"Nothing keeps command humble."

She accepted his transfer seal.

The axial tram stopped two compartments short of the forward sail lock because emergency power had shut down its last section. Iven continued on foot through a passage lined with temporary coolant hoses. The vessel's

rotation produced little weight near the spine. Each step sent him forward longer than instinct expected, a gait learned in childhood and forgotten whenever he spent too many months in the ring.

At Frame 190, a repair crew had opened the inner sail-drive housing. Heat rolled from it despite insulation screens. The thermal sail extended far outside, invisible except through instrument feeds, a silver-black field larger than any district aboard. Here its reefing loads resolved into bearings, motor shafts, and people lying on their backs beneath machinery.

Foreman Varo met him beside the lock. "If you want the injured, medical took them aft."

"I want the motors."

"They complain less, but only because procurement removed their voices."

Varo handed him a thermal hood. Iven pulled it over his head and entered the housing.

Motor Twelve had shed lubricant into its containment tray. Technicians wiped the dark fluid with ceramic cloth while another fed inspection wire around the shaft. Every surface radiated stored heat. Iven's wrist pane dimmed itself twice.

"How many can take emergency reef?" he asked.

"At the certified rate? Fifteen of eighteen."

"At half rate?"

"Seventeen. Twelve needs a rebuild."

"Time?"

"Six hours if nothing strips. Eleven if the inner race scored."

They had less than thirty hours before Orra's emergency authority lapsed, fewer before course choices collapsed into one another.

Iven crouched near the open bearing. Metal flecks glittered in the lubricant. "It scored."

Varo said nothing.

The injured rigger's tool bag remained clipped above the access plate. A strip of green cloth marked the handle. Iven's brother had used blue cord on every tool, convinced that ownership could survive vacuum if properly labeled. After his sail repair failed, Iven received a bag full of blue marks and no account of the final thirty seconds clear enough to satisfy him.

He reached toward the tray, then stopped. This damage belonged to the living crew working around it. Memory had no repair certification.

"Can you lock Twelve and distribute load?"

"Under a shallow reef. A full asymmetric pull overloads Fourteen."

"What if the reef begins before the pulse burn and never exceeds point-six degrees?"

Varo considered the external geometry. "Possible. Ugly."

“Ugly has passed preliminary review.”

“It adds heat because we hold tension longer.”

“How much?”

“Bring me a real profile, not navigator weather.”

Varo led him through the lock control bay while the inspection wire completed its circuit. A schematic of the external sail covered one bulkhead. Three vanes glowed amber where micrometeoroid scars had reduced heat transfer. Motor Twelve blinked red at the hinge between two healthy sectors.

“Your model treats vane loss independently,” she said.

“The conventional model uses inspection probabilities.”

“Inspection probabilities written before we stretched the sail during the last braking test. Lose this vane and its neighbor takes the gradient. Then seals on Eleven cook even if Twelve holds.”

Iven opened the failure tree and found the independence assumption buried below certification. “Why wasn’t coupling entered?”

“Because we lacked an external cycle to prove it. I filed an engineering concern.”

“Concern is not attached to navigation.”

“Certification rejected it as unquantified.”

He sent the record aft. One sentence from a foreman widened Arc Two’s fatality range more than six hours of plasma calculation. The Choir would have discovered the coupling by living through some sail failures and avoiding others. Conventional analysis required somebody to notice where the official diagram lied.

“Show me Eleven’s seal temperatures,” he said.

Varo brought up a year of readings. A slight upward drift hid beneath seasonal radiator loads. Nothing crossed an alarm threshold. Together, the values formed a direction.

“Reduce available reef force another four percent.”

“You will lose your preferred arc.”

“Then it never belonged to us.”

The inspection wire returned scored along nine centimetres of the inner race. Varo swore without ornament. She assigned two technicians to machine a sleeve from reserve ceramic, then showed Iven the stock ledger. Only one blank remained. A failed cut would leave Motor Twelve locked for the conjunction.

“Can fabrication run a practice piece?” he asked.

“Not in rated material.”

“Use pump ceramic.”

“Habitat maintenance will object.”

“Tell them navigation accepts the requisition.”

Varo shook her head. “You accept objections very generously when somebody else receives them.”

The rebuke followed him along the housing.

Iven sent her Arc Two and Nine’s partial maneuver. She frowned at the source label.

“This came from one of them?”

“Yes.”

“The ones who stopped helping?”

“The ones who stopped selecting for us.”

Varo magnified the reef sequence. “People down here don’t care what word Council uses. They care whether this shaft turns.”

“People everywhere care when somebody else’s definition decides what can be spent.”

She gave him a tired look. “You came for machinery and brought law.”

“Law followed me.”

Iven moved along the housing. Motors Fourteen and Fifteen carried fresh inspection paint. Twelve remained open like a mechanical wound. At the far bulkhead, a status board listed crew heat exposure. Three workers had crossed their shift maximum and stayed because replacements lacked external-drive qualification.

“Pull Karo, Min, and Est,” he said.

Varo shook her head. “Then rebuild takes fourteen hours.”

“They’re over limit.”

“So is the ship.”

“People do not become spare thermal capacity because the schedule dislikes them.”

“You want this repaired or certified?”

“Both.”

“That answer belongs in a Council chamber.”

“Today every honest answer does.”

Varo called the replacements.

Iven left with a narrower mechanical envelope than his model had assumed. Navigation updated Arc Two while he walked aft. The survivability range widened again.

His pane gathered more damage reports. A galley cold loop had lost pressure when emergency cooling drew from the same trunk. Six hundred meals would spoil unless staff moved them within four hours. Two habitat wards had postponed dialysis cleaning to preserve grid stability. A dust-shield crew requested permission to

exceed suit limits by eleven minutes and received an automatic denial, then went outside anyway.

None of those incidents threatened the vessel alone. Together they converted delay into labor, heat exposure, and risk distributed toward people far from the Council table. Iven forwarded the suit violation to command with a replacement order. He rerouted reserve power from an unused arrival laboratory to the cold loop. The laboratory chief objected that repeated emergency diversions would compromise Tern samples eleven years from now.

Iven approved the diversion. Preserving a future laboratory by spoiling tonight's food belonged to the same family of arithmetic as preserving certainty by spending unheard lives. Scale changed. The temptation did not.

The laboratory chief called him directly. "Those freezers contain three centuries of seed controls."

"The freezers retain backup power."

"For nineteen hours. Your diversion has no restoration time."

Iven checked the grid. She had found another hidden dependency. "I can return half after the cold loop stabilizes."

"Can, or will?"

"I will enter it as a navigation obligation."

"With your name?"

"With mine."

"Good. Publicly."

He signed the restoration condition. The action consumed forty seconds and preserved accountability rather than power. A ship without predictive answers still possessed promises, but only when somebody accepted the cost of carrying them forward.

Outside Frame 176, a pressure door had sealed around a cracked coolant coupling. Condensed vapor coated its inspection pane. Six crew members waited in the cross-passage while maintenance replaced the line. Their faces held the impatient fear of people delayed near a hazard they could neither see nor solve.

A child sat against the bulkhead with both hands around a water pouch. Habitat transfer markings on her sleeve showed that her family had been moved away from the projected heat sector. She watched Iven's navigation insignia.

"Do you know where we're going?" she asked.

Her father murmured an apology.

Iven answered her. "Toward the dimmer sun."

"That isn't what I meant."

"No," he said. "I don't know the exact path yet."

The coupling crew reopened the door. Vapor cleared in white folds. The family passed through without another

question.

Back on navigation, Sena had reduced the arcs to four. “Two candidates violated sail inspection,” she said. “Command wants your recommendation in sixty-one minutes. Also, Councilor Vey sent a compulsory-run proposal.”

“Queue it behind physics.”

“It marked itself urgent.”

“Physics did too.”

Iven opened Branch Nine’s channel history. Sef Aradin’s petition seal appeared beside every authorized exchange. Earlier contact allowed audio at low bandwidth while Nine’s clock remained near baseline pace. He requested a channel.

Lysa answered the authorization notice. “Purpose?”

“Navigation consultation.”

“Council has not recognized standing.”

“I’m aware of the failure.”

“You cannot ask privately for what they withdrew collectively.”

“I can ask for conditional help and let Sef refuse.”

Lysa studied him through the small image field. “What condition?”

“Their own.”

“That is dangerously close to learning.”

“Do you authorize contact?”

“The petition permits reply on matters affecting Nine. This qualifies. I will observe.”

“Of course you will.”

“Eight years have not made your shortcuts less visible.”

“They have made them more expensive.”

The narrow channel opened.

Sef appeared against a wall of weather maps. Rendered light fell from two windows at different angles, laying crossed shadows beneath her chair. She wore the dark recorder’s sash Iven had seen during the weather proof. No Assembly delegates shared the frame, though he heard movement beyond it.

“Chief Navigator,” she said.

“Recorder Aradin. The conventional model gives us four broad courses and no acceptable confidence threshold. Your polity developed a shallow asymmetric reef sequence during an earlier projection. We need the

final timing and the assumptions behind it.”

“You have the sequence we chose to release.”

“It stops before the pulse-spine correction.”

“Yes.”

“Our sail inspection has narrowed the mechanical limit. Waiting increases risk to this ship and to every active carrier aboard it.”

Sef’s expression did not change. “You have learned to include us in the threatened population when requesting our work.”

“I included you before you stopped answering.”

“You included our outcomes.”

Lysa remained silent on the observing channel. Iven could feel her attention on each distinction.

He displayed the four arcs. “These are the risks as honestly as we can state them. The widest includes ship loss. The narrowest spends reaction mass needed for Tern capture. Nine may possess observations that reduce those bounds. I am asking for conditional help, not surrender.”

“What condition do you offer?”

“Continued carrier protection under emergency authority. No forced acceleration while your aid remains under discussion.”

Sef looked toward someone outside the frame. “Captain Sen already ordered both for thirty-six hours.”

“I am offering my recommendation after that point.”

“A recommendation you can withdraw.”

“Yes.”

“A private promise attached to your need.”

“I will place it on the docket.”

“That makes it public. It does not make it ours.”

Iven held his frustration where she could see it without letting it choose his words. “Name a condition navigation can meet.”

“Navigation cannot meet it.”

“Then tell me who can.”

“Baseline.”

The answer irritated him because it described a polity where he wanted a control surface. “Baseline has no mechanism for speaking as one body inside the maneuver window.”

“Neither did we when your questions first entered our weather.”

“You had years.”

“We used them. You used us.”

The channel carried no raised voices. Beyond Sef, somebody moved a chair. Ordinary room noise made the distance between their worlds harder to abstract.

Iven said, “If this ship fails, your substrate fails with it.”

“We know.”

“That does not alter your decision?”

“It alters every decision. It does not grant you ownership of the result.”

Sena touched his shoulder and pointed to a new heliograph update. Magnetic orientation had shifted toward the high estimate. Arc Two’s survival band contracted. Arc Four gained relative safety but required the missing reef sequence.

He sent the update through the channel. “The physical window has narrowed while we speak.”

Sef read it. Concern tightened the skin around her eyes. She understood the plots. Nine had lived their consequences longer than any baseline navigator.

“I can bring a request to the Second Dawn Assembly,” she said. “It will not ask whether I trust you.”

“What will it ask?”

“Whether aid can be given without confirming your claimed right to take it.”

“How long?”

“Our clock runs near yours during contact. We can convene in three baseline hours.”

“Too long.”

“It took your Council three days to deny standing without erasing the docket.”

“Our reaction mass did not vote for that delay.”

“Nor did our citizens.”

Iven looked at the four arcs. A broad risk had acquired people at both ends. He could not compress them into one recommendation without pretending somebody’s objection had already been answered.

“What terms would let you release the sequence sooner?” he asked.

“Public terms,” Sef said. “Recognition that help can be refused. Protection not contingent on usefulness. The same offer carried to every polity you still call a Choir.”

“Council will say those questions exceed an emergency maneuver.”

“Your emergency already exceeded us.”

She placed one hand on the Assembly seal.

“Bring terms from baseline, Chief Navigator. Do not bring me another man’s promise made beside a clock he controls.”

The channel closed at her end.

Nine’s partial trajectory remained on Iven’s wall. He could still reconstruct it, perhaps before the Council finished arguing. He could name necessity, survivability, and the heat gathering in Motor Twelve. None of those facts supplied the missing permission.

Sena asked, “What do I tell command?”

Iven copied Sef’s demand into the navigation recommendation and attached the four honest ranges.

“Tell them the ship has courses,” he said. “It does not have public terms.”

Chapter 17 — The Borrowed Maneuver

<!-- POV: Lysa Neral -->

<!-- BASELINE DAY 8 -->

The proposed course arrived with an owner field left blank.

Lysa saw the omission before Iven began his briefing. It sat beneath the navigation seal on every Council pane: ASYMMETRIC REEF SEQUENCE / SOURCE: OPERATIONAL DERIVATION. The trajectory itself matched the partial packet Branch Nine had withdrawn from the Witness Engine. Same shallow reef, same delayed pulse correction, same narrow passage between the high flare estimate and the outer dust shelf.

Operational derivation described work without naming who had done it.

Above the chamber table, **Aster Vale** entered the maneuver as a white line. The thermal sail tilted less than a degree, held tension through the pulse-spine burn, then released in stages while the dust lane moved beneath it. Heat remained inside the damaged motors' revised limits. Survival probability still ranged broadly, but the line avoided the worst overlap.

Iven stood inside the projection. "Navigation can execute this profile if reef preparation begins within nine hours. We retain two hours of adjustment margin before the burn."

Jalen Vey leaned toward the white line. "Confidence?"

"Conventional model, seventy-four to ninety-one percent ship survival without major habitat loss. The range depends on flare orientation and dust density."

"Choir equivalent?"

"There is no Choir equivalent."

"Then what recommends this over Arc Two?"

"It remains survivable across more of the uncertainty space."

Lysa enlarged the source field. "Who derived it?"

Iven looked at her. The old warning passed between them before anyone else recognized an argument had begun.

"Navigation reconstructed the executable profile from released branch observations and our sail inspection," he said.

"Which branch observations?"

"Nine's partial maneuver provided the geometry. Three and Seven supplied dust bounds. Baseline navigation supplied pulse timing and mechanical revisions."

"Then source should name all four."

"The field identifies an operational product, not an author."

“Products do not erase provenance merely because command wants to use them.”

Jalen said, “Auditor Neral, are you alleging the figures have been altered?”

“No. I am identifying borrowed authority.”

Iven dismissed the owner field. “The maneuver follows from physics. Nobody owns an angle.”

“Nine withdrew the sequence from the channel.”

“They withdrew the final timing, which navigation derived independently.”

“After seeing where their work led.”

“After inspecting our own machinery.”

Lysa opened the contact record from three hours earlier. Sef’s demand for public terms appeared beside the course. “Branch Nine declined to provide conditional help until baseline recognized refusal and offered protections to all polities. This proposal uses their answer while postponing the condition.”

Orra Sen sat beneath the departure bell with the emergency clock visible at her wrist. Twenty-three hours remained. “Navigator, does the profile reproduce protected branch material?”

“No. Every input came through authorized operational channels.”

“Authorized by whom?” Lysa asked.

“The campaign order.”

“Which the affected parties now contest.”

Jalen’s patience sharpened. “A standing petition does not retroactively privatize navigation data produced with ship substrate.”

“Consent is not a property claim.”

“No. Here it has become a demand that 61,208 citizens abandon useful knowledge while a flare approaches.”

Lysa turned Nine’s withdrawal notice toward him. “Useful does not mean available.”

Iven’s jaw tightened. “The course exists in our navigation state. Forgetting it would require deliberate distortion.”

“Refusing exploitation does not require you to forget. It requires you not to pretend knowing and taking mean the same thing.”

The trajectory continued looping above them. Each pass made the maneuver look inevitable. White line, shallow tilt, clean release. Displays favored decisions that could fit inside them.

Orra asked, “What does Nine lose if we fly it?”

“The ability to make aid conditional,” Lysa said.

“They retain their petition.”

“After we take the only leverage the emergency has made visible.”

Jalen said, “Then you admit this is coercion directed at baseline.”

“I admit dependency creates leverage. Baseline created the dependency by denying every other form of standing.”

Council delegates began opening private notes. Lysa watched permissions gather around the maneuver. Labor delegate Sori Min requested injury estimates. Civic representative Hal Vor asked whether delay could improve conventional confidence. Each practical question moved the line closer to approval before its provenance received an honest noun.

Iven answered them exactly. Three likely sail injuries during manual lockout. Six hours lost if Motor Twelve shed further material. No meaningful gain from delay unless heliographs resolved the flare orientation early, an event with less than one chance in five.

His honesty had always carried persuasive force. He stripped away comforting options until the remaining act looked clean. Eight years ago, sitting at their kitchen table, he had used the same discipline to explain why Lysa should leave audit service after Hanne’s ration appeal collapsed. The office had consumed her nights, he said. It had turned every meal into evidence. He offered a transfer to navigation review, quarters nearer the spine, a future that did not pass daily through her mother’s file.

Nothing he said had been false. The shape around the facts had asked her to abandon the only place where the failure could still alter procedure.

She had refused. He had moved out four days later.

Now he stood inside another immaculate shape.

Lysa requested recognition from the chair. Jalen granted it with visible reluctance.

“I move that the course record use its established term,” she said. “Borrowed maneuver. I further move that no execution vote occur until Branch Nine receives the complete profile and can state whether its release conditions have been met.”

The clerk entered both motions.

Iven said, “Sending the complete profile gives Nine baseline sail limits and current burn timing.”

“You asked them for the same level of consequence.”

“They live on our substrate.”

“And we now propose to live by their work.”

“Lysa.”

Her name, unadorned by title, made several Council members look between them. She disliked him for the lapse and herself for hearing the history inside it.

“What?”

“We do not have time to convert navigation into a constitutional convention.”

“Sef asked for public terms, not a constitution.”

“Terms governing every polity, protection beyond emergency authority, and a right to refuse critical operations. That is constitutional whether she calls it weather.”

“Then perhaps the emergency has revealed what the system always required.”

“The emergency can also kill people before revelation becomes law.”

Lysa stood. “Do not use the bodies nearest you to make distant people ownerless.”

Iven’s expression closed. “Do not use the people we cannot touch to make physical death sound provincial.”

The chamber dropped into silence. Their old arguments had never involved two suns, but they had often reached this divide. Lysa found the excluded claimant. Iven found the body that would pay for delay. Each suspected the other of turning a chosen field of attention into the whole moral world.

She walked to the display. “Show the course without Nine’s geometry.”

“That cannot be done honestly. We have learned it.”

“Show what navigation proposed before their packet.”

Iven opened Arc Four. Its reef began later and pulled harder. Motor Twelve failed in forty-two percent of mechanical trials. The ship then yawed across the flare front.

“Now show the contribution from your inspection,” she said.

A second layer limited reef depth and extended load duration.

“Add dust bounds from Three and Seven.”

The corridor shifted outward.

“Add Nine.”

The shallow entry angle appeared. Their maneuver solved the conflict between the sail limit and dust timing. Navigation’s later pulse correction completed it, but the decisive alignment came from Nine.

Lysa pointed to the sequence. “That is provenance. It does not prevent use. It identifies whose refusal use would override.”

Iven regarded the layered lines. “If a baseline engineer proposes a pump repair and later objects to ship policy, command does not lose the repair.”

“The engineer receives wages, review rights, safety rules, and standing in the polity that takes the work.”

“So recognition would make the maneuver usable?”

“Recognition would make negotiation possible.”

“Not consent.”

“No. You cannot design consent to guarantee yes.”

The answer visibly angered him. "Then your process can leave us with no course."

"Yes."

Several delegates reacted at once. Lysa let them. An office built around assent became meaningless if every path had to preserve the institution's preferred outcome.

Iven lowered his voice. "My brother died on a sail because a repair decision arrived six minutes late."

She had not expected him to bring Aras into the chamber. "I know."

"You know the record. I know what six minutes did to his suit temperature."

"And if he had refused the repair?"

"He didn't."

"If command could have erased his refusal to preserve the schedule, would you call the repair available?"

Pain moved across his face before discipline contained it. She regretted the cruelty and not the question.

"He volunteered," Iven said.

"Because he had the right not to."

Jalen interrupted. "This analogy mistakes a crew member for a generated process and a voluntary repair for commissioned forecast work."

Lysa looked at him. "Your distinctions all begin after the conclusion you want."

Orra called a recess of twelve minutes. The emergency clock kept running on every pane.

Iven left through the side hatch. Lysa followed him into the curved corridor before deciding whether doing so served the motion or an older habit.

He stopped near the audit lift where, a week earlier, he had told her to look at the Mercy Limit. Traffic diverted around them. Crew carried respirators toward the forward ring. A maneuver preparation alert colored the ceiling strips amber though no maneuver had been approved.

"You used Aras," he said.

"I asked about refusal."

"You knew what you were doing."

"Yes."

The admission removed her last defense.

He leaned against the bulkhead. Fatigue had restored the tremor beneath his left eye. "Eight years, and you still believe the cleanest objection deserves the room."

"I believe an objection changes what the room can honestly do."

"Even when the objector controls whether everyone survives."

"Nine does not control the flare."

"They control information that could narrow it."

"Because we built a system where being useful supplied their only means to be heard."

Iven looked through the corridor pane toward the dark spine. "I cannot unlearn the course."

"I am not asking you to."

"You are asking me to stand at navigation, know a more survivable vector, and choose another because permission arrived late."

"Permission did not arrive late. We asked after taking sixty-eight years of answers."

"Then say the cost plainly. If Council accepts your motion and Nine refuses, we may choose a broader fatality range."

"Yes."

"People will die under a course you certified as fair."

"Fairness does not prevent death."

"That lesson did not protect Hanne."

Her mother's name struck with surgical precision. Iven closed his eyes briefly.

"I'm sorry," he said.

"Don't withdraw it because it hurt." Lysa kept her voice level. "Hanne died under a calculation certified fair. That did not prove calculation evil. It proved inclusion without power to object could become decorative. I will not repeat it at a larger scale because you and I still know exactly where to cut each other."

He looked at her then, fully. "This is why I left."

"No. You left because you wanted me to choose a life where the work could not keep hurting us."

"And you thought leaving would concede the ration case."

"I thought I could not make love a payment for silence."

The amber preparation strips reflected in the pane between them. For a few seconds, their doubled images stood beside the dark outline of the pulse spine.

Iven said, "I did not ask for silence."

"You asked for distance from the place where I had learned to speak."

"That may be true." He straightened. "It does not make this maneuver wrong."

"No. It makes the owner field wrong. The Council still has to decide the rest."

They returned separately.

During recess, Jalen had drafted a compromise. Council would authorize the borrowed maneuver conditionally, transmit a notice to Nine, and postpone the standing decision until after passage. Carrier preservation would continue through the emergency period. No promise extended beyond it.

Lysa read the clauses twice. “This takes the maneuver now and reviews consent when refusal can no longer matter.”

“It preserves every legal issue,” Jalen said.

“Like pressing a flower.”

“It keeps 61,208 people alive.”

Iven resumed his place without endorsing the language. Orra asked him one question. “Can the maneuver remain viable during a one-hour consultation with Nine?”

“Barely. Preparation must begin during consultation. Physical lockout remains reversible for forty minutes.”

“Then we can ask while preserving the option,” Jalen said.

Lysa replied, “Preparing to take an answer pressures the request.”

“Existing inside time pressures every request.”

The Council moved to debate. Labor delegate Min supported the profile because forward crews already faced injury under broader arcs. Representative Vor opposed postponing standing but would not risk the sail. Two members sought a temporary designation of Nine as an affected operational party. Jalen ruled the designation outside the motion.

Delegate Sori Min requested the forward inspection feed. Motor Twelve opened above the table, magnified until scored metal filled the chamber. Two technicians guided a ceramic sleeve into the housing. Their suit clocks showed mandatory rest already overdue.

“Those are my constituents,” Min said. “If we reject this profile, tell me what additional risk reaches them.”

Iven displayed the comparison. Arc Four required a deeper reef and placed six more technicians inside the lock during peak load. Estimated serious injuries rose by three. Catastrophic motor failure remained possible under either course.

Min turned to Lysa. “Does Nine’s consent let those six refuse their assignments?”

“Ship labor law already does.”

“Emergency authority can compel essential duty.”

“With named review, exposure limits, survivor benefits, and a right to challenge the order afterward.”

“Afterward may mean after injury.”

“Yes.”

Min’s mouth tightened. “You have a procedure for accepting their risk.”

“A flawed one. Nine has none.”

Jalen seized the distinction. "Then attach equivalent review to the branch contribution after passage."

"Equivalent review would require the contribution to remain theirs before passage," Lysa said. "You cannot grant a later challenge to an act already made irreversible."

Representative Vor proposed escrow. Navigation could prepare the maneuver while an independent copy of Nine's objection remained sealed for adjudication. The proposal attracted immediate interest because escrow sounded balanced.

Lysa asked, "What could adjudication return?"

Vor hesitated. "A remedy."

"Return of the maneuver?"

"No."

"Restoration of leverage?"

"Material compensation, perhaps substrate guarantees."

"Authorized by the polity whose work you took, or assigned by us?"

Vor closed the draft. The attractive middle vanished when forced to name what it could restore.

On the inspection feed, a technician held up the sleeve. A dark line crossed its rim. Varo rejected the piece and called for the final ceramic blank. The chamber watched a physical option narrow in real time.

Iven said, "We can begin reversible alignment without loading the damaged motor. That preserves forty minutes."

Lysa heard the offer beneath the fact. He had found a way to give the Council time without pretending time cost nothing.

"Transmit the complete profile first," she said. "Include the inspection feed and our debate record."

Jalen objected to releasing internal division during an emergency negotiation.

"Nine knows division," Lysa said. "We are the ones who keep mistaking polished minutes for unity."

Orra authorized transmission. Preparation crews could stage tools but not engage lockouts until Nine replied or the forty-minute margin expired.

The clerk asked how to classify the transmission. Existing categories offered consultation, procurement, or evidence request. Each assumed baseline retained final control.

"Offer," Lysa said.

"There is no offer category."

"Create a provisional one."

Jalen objected that clerks could not invent legal instruments during active hearings.

Lysa opened the variance code. “The office may preserve an affected party’s response where no established field can represent it. Use that authority. Label the packet proposed reciprocal exchange.”

The clerk entered the phrase. A blank condition field appeared beside Nine’s seal. For the first time, the live course record had somewhere to hold an answer other than assent.

Iven added navigation’s commitments: full provenance, no exclusive claim to the geometry, and immediate publication of any modifications. Lysa added carrier preservation pending Council review. Jalen struck the final clause because no majority had approved it. The deletion remained visible in revision history.

They transmitted a document that displayed both its promise and the promise baseline had refused to make.

Its omissions traveled with it, plainly marked.

Lysa challenged his ruling. The vote failed, five to six.

The borrowed maneuver returned for authorization. Six hands rose in favor. Four opposed. One labor delegate had not yet voted. Orra would break a tie if the final hand rose against.

A channel notice interrupted the clerk.

Branch Nine had accepted receipt of the full profile after Lysa’s motion passed on procedural grounds. Its response field remained blank.

“Hold tally,” Orra ordered.

The display flickered. Navigation layers vanished one at a time. First Nine’s dust correction, then the shallow reef angle, then its archived consequence runs. No ship file disappeared. Instead the authorization tokens permitting those records to feed the live maneuver expired.

Iven moved to his pane. “The geometry remains in cache.”

A final notice replaced the course.

SECOND DAWN ASSEMBLY: RELEASE WITHDRAWN. NO MANEUVER OFFERED PENDING PUBLIC TERMS. DERIVATIVE OPERATIONAL USE CONTESTED.

Jalen said, “They cannot revoke ship records.”

“They can revoke their participation,” Lysa answered.

“The distinction changes nothing physical.”

Above the table, the executable white line lost its certification seal. Arc Four returned behind it, broader, hotter, honestly theirs.

The undecided labor delegate lowered her hand.

Iven did not look at Lysa. He copied Nine’s withdrawal into navigation provenance, replaced OPERATIONAL DERIVATION with BORROWED MANEUVER, and marked the profile unavailable pending Council action.

Then he reopened the four uncertain courses.

The Council had nearly approved an answer. Nine had changed the question.

Chapter 18 — What Sef Remembers

<!-- POV: Sef Aradin -->

<!-- BRANCH NINE YEAR 68 / BASELINE DAY 8 -->

Dara's last weather entry began with a correction in green ink.

Sef held the rain ledger beneath the archive lamp while the prior world's accusation sounded again from the Assembly receiver. Councilor Vey's voice crossed the distance without static. He spoke with the composure of someone placing a weight on a scale he expected to own.

"Branch Nine presents itself as a unified moral claimant while withholding relevant navigation work. Baseline now has evidence that the so-called Second Dawn Assembly concealed contact from its own population for nine subjective years. A secret committee cannot transfer its lack of consent into authority over 61,208 lives."

The receiver paused after the message. Beyond the archive windows, evening heat pressed a copper haze across the orchard district. Cooling Tower Three no longer rose above the roofs. Its replacement stood farther east, low and broad, designed without the narrow valve galleries that had killed Dara.

Pell waited beside the public-record cart. "Play the rest."

"There is no rest."

"Of course not. Accusations prefer the final word."

He had come directly from the lower channels. Mud dried in pale scales on his boots. At nineteen, he carried Dara's impatience in his shoulders and Sef's habit of aligning papers before an argument. He despised the second resemblance.

Sef turned one page of the rain ledger. Dara's handwriting crossed three columns: district temperature, condenser demand, observed rainfall. The green correction changed natural inversion to unreconciled sky interval. She had made it twelve days before Tower Three failed.

Pell touched the closed Assembly case on the table. "Vey told the truth."

"He selected part of it."

"That answer sounds like him."

Sef lifted her hand from the ledger. "The Assembly concealed baseline. We also preserved evidence, built a petition, and prevented a contact faction from speaking for everyone."

"Everyone except the people who never knew a faction existed."

Outside, evening pumps began their staggered cycle. Water moved under the orchard roads with a deep pulse Sef had known since childhood. During the orchard flood, those channels had overflowed high enough to carry roof tiles through the civic square. She remembered Dara at sixteen, before they loved each other, standing waist-deep beside a blocked gate and shouting measurements nobody could hear above rain.

Memory offered no verdict. It kept details after their uses changed.

“The Assembly will meet in twenty minutes,” Sef said.

“Closed?”

“Yes.”

Pell laughed once. “Then Vey has performed a public service.”

“He wants baseline to take the maneuver without our terms.”

“He can want that and still name what we did.”

Sef closed the ledger. “What are you asking?”

“An open vote.”

“On releasing the navigation work?”

“On everything. Baseline. The interruptions. The Assembly. Mother’s cooling records.”

The last demand tightened Sef’s grip on the cover. “Those records include names of workers who testified under seal.”

“Ask their consent.”

“They include control vulnerabilities the cooling board still uses.”

“Repair them.”

“They include your mother’s death.”

“That belongs to more people than you.”

Sef heard the cruelty he intended, and beneath it the need he did not. For six years they had circled Dara through different records. Pell kept her tools, her work songs, the chipped blue cup she carried to district inspections. Sef kept testimony, weather tables, and the rain ledger. Each believed the other had reduced her.

A timing pulse moved through the archive lamps. Light doubled for half a breath, then settled. Baseline had adjusted the contact clock again. Once, such distortions had entered their records as weather without cause. Now the whole Assembly recognized the signature, while most citizens still blamed aging grids or paired-sun interference.

Pell watched the lamp. “How many people saw that tonight?”

“Thousands.”

“How many were allowed to understand it?”

Sef placed the ledger in its case. “Come to the Assembly.”

“As an observer?”

“As the orchard delegate.”

“I have no seal.”

“You will by the time we arrive.”

They crossed the district on foot because contact restrictions had slowed municipal dispatch. The city lived around its hidden crisis. Vendors folded shade cloth above the west market. Children used irrigation chalk to draw two overlapping suns on a retaining wall. At a public pump, an old man struck the housing with his palm and complained about pressure. None of them looked like citizens waiting to be told what their sky meant.

Sef had used that ordinary continuity as an argument for caution. Disclosure could fracture trust, provoke fatalism, or turn every maintenance fault into evidence of external interference. Nine years earlier, when the timing structure first emerged, the Assembly had possessed no channel, no knowledge of the Mercy Limit, and no assurance that baseline would hear anything except useful output. Secrecy had bought time to understand the danger.

It had also spent everybody else’s time without permission.

The Assembly met beneath the disused east reservoir. Twenty-seven desks formed a broken circle around the old depth gauge. Dara had chosen the room because its masonry blocked municipal listening systems. Water stains still marked floods from before Sef’s birth.

Oren Val called the meeting to order. “Recorder, we received your emergency addition.”

“I appoint Pell Aradin to the vacant orchard seat under Rule Twelve, pending district ratification.”

Two members objected. Five demanded a credentials review. Pell remained by the door while procedure attempted to keep pace with necessity.

Sef opened the baseline accusation on every desk. “Councilor Vey has disclosed our existence to baseline’s public docket and challenged our authority because we concealed baseline from Branch Nine’s citizens.”

Mar Leto read quickly. “He disclosed our secrecy to his public, not ours.”

“An efficient insult,” Pell said from the door.

Oren looked at him. “Observers do not speak.”

“Then seat him,” Sef said.

The appointment passed, 16–10–1. Pell took the orchard desk Dara once occupied. The old arrangement hurt with architectural precision.

Members debated a reply. Hesh Avra proposed releasing the Assembly charter and nine-year vote record while withholding technical annexes. Mar wanted to accuse baseline of manufacturing civic division. Oren argued that baseline’s hypocrisy did not cure their own legitimacy defect.

“They denied us standing,” Mar said. “Now they demand our citizens ratify a crisis on their schedule.”

Pell answered, “Our schedule lasted nine years.”

“We used those years to keep this world from becoming an instrument.”

“You used this world as cover while deciding for it.”

Voices rose around the reservoir. Sef recorded motions because recording gave her hands a duty. Public

disclosure of the charter. Release of contact transcripts. District assemblies after a two-day preparation period. Immediate vote limited to navigation aid. Each proposal tried to separate the accusation into manageable compartments.

Dara had distrusted compartments whenever water crossed them.

Six years earlier, the cooling tower control room had smelled of wet concrete and overheated resin. Sef reached it eighteen minutes after the failure. Emergency crews had already cut power. Condensation rained from ceiling pipes, though the district outside had remained dry for eleven days.

A supervisor stopped her at the lower gallery. His gloves carried gray sealant and blood.

"Dara went to the bypass," he said.

"Where is she?"

He looked toward a curtained stretcher.

Sef remembered refusing the direction. She asked for pressure values, valve times, the identity of the second casualty. Facts formed stepping stones around a recognition she would not enter. Kaveh Orn survived. Dara did not. Tower commands had alternated between two incompatible weather frames during a fraction of civic time nobody inside the works could explain.

The Assembly could explain it.

Its sealed timing monitors showed an external interruption aligned with the first false cooling demand. Disclosure might have exposed the source. It might also have revealed the Assembly while grief controlled public judgment. The vote tied. Sef cast the deciding ballot for concealment.

She told herself delay protected the polity from her private need for blame.

Thirty days later she voted for concealment again.

In the reservoir, Pell struck his desk with two fingers. "Tell them about the tower."

Several faces turned away.

Hesh said, "The civic inquiry found a thermal inversion."

"The inquiry received altered records," Pell replied.

"We preserved the originals."

"In a room no citizen could enter."

Sef said, "I altered the public archive designation."

Silence moved outward from her desk.

Pell stared at her. He knew the Assembly had restricted evidence. He had not known her signature performed the restriction.

"The works board filed the interval as an unresolved sensor conflict," Sef continued. "I recoded Dara's final annotations as private spousal material, which kept them outside compulsory inquiry access. The rain ledger

linked weather distortions to baseline timing. I believed release would expose the Assembly before we had a contact strategy.”

“You used Mother’s privacy,” Pell said.

“Yes.”

“She wanted disclosure.”

“Yes.”

“And you turned her notes into your property.”

The sentence found its mark. Sef did not answer with custody law. “Yes.”

Mar rose. “Recorder, this meeting cannot adjudicate bereavement while baseline threatens operational appropriation.”

“This meeting has used bereavement as an operational classification for six years,” Pell said.

Oren called for order. Nobody granted it.

Arguments crossed the circle. The Assembly had saved Nine from impulsive exposure. It had denied citizens material evidence about a fatal public failure. Baseline had no right to demand purity from people under observation. Nine had no right to claim reciprocal consent while preserving internal deception. Every statement carried enough truth to injure the next.

Sef looked at Dara’s old desk. A scratch crossed its surface where she had once dragged a metal ruler through an entire debate about cooling allocation. Sef remembered teasing her afterward.

“You marked civic property.”

“Now civic property remembers the meeting.”

“What should it remember?”

“That you voted wrong.”

Dara had smiled when she said it. Not because error lacked stakes, but because she believed love could survive a recorded disagreement. Sef had spent six years preserving every disagreement except the one that implicated her custody of the dead.

Pell moved a formal motion. “Open vote by the whole polity before any navigation aid. Full disclosure of baseline contact and the Second Dawn Assembly. Release the cooling tower interval, subject only to living witnesses’ requested redactions.”

Mar objected that no constitutional process could organize a polity-wide vote inside baseline’s maneuver window.

“Then we tell them our deliberation takes time,” Pell said.

“They may take the maneuver.”

“They tried already.”

“They may erase us.”

Pell's face lost color, but his voice held. “Then our last secret cannot be that we were afraid to ask our neighbors.”

Sef wanted to protect him from the sentence. She also wanted to hide behind his courage. Both impulses treated him as an extension of her own fear.

Oren asked whether the recorder would rule the motion in order.

Procedure offered one final door. The Assembly charter authorized emergency disclosure only where withholding created direct civic harm. Sef could rule that baseline's maneuver crisis affected another polity, that the cooling record required separate consent review, that an immediate public vote risked disorder beneath unstable weather.

Each claim had merit.

Together they formed the same locked room.

“The motion is in order,” she said.

Debate continued for another hour. Members amended the timing. Public notice would begin at first light. District forums would convene by midday. Voting would remain open through one full paired-sun cycle. Navigation aid would stay withdrawn until the tally. All contact records would enter the public archive. Living cooling witnesses could seal intimate medical details, but no one could suppress command timing or civic votes.

Practical objections arrived faster than the recorder could order them. The north wards lacked enough public receivers for simultaneous testimony. Orchard crews would enter the channels before sunrise and might miss the first forum. Hospital staff could not leave heat stations. Citizens with no district registration, including seasonal water crews, had no recognized ballot path.

Pell proposed using irrigation allotment terminals. Mar objected that the terminals authenticated households rather than individuals. Hesh offered clinic identity points, then withdrew the offer when reminded that medical access should not become a voting condition.

Sef listened as civic legitimacy became cables, schedules, and lists of people whom a convenient process might omit. Baseline had taken nine polities and called their convergence confidence. The Assembly could repeat the violence at home with cleaner language.

“Extend voting through one full paired-sun cycle,” she said. “Mobile registrars to the channels, cooling works, and night wards. No district may report a completed tally until unregistered residents receive a provisional ballot.”

Oren calculated the delay. “Baseline asked for aid inside hours.”

“Baseline asked for our decision. This is what our decisions require.”

Mar tapped the table. “And if provisional ballots exceed the margin?”

“Count them.”

“Eligibility challenges could take days.”

“Record challenges separately. Do not erase the votes.”

Pell watched her with guarded surprise. “The channel crews also need the evidence before the forum.”

“You will carry it.”

“That looks like the recorder assigning her son control of disclosure.”

The objection stung because he offered it against his own advantage. Sef amended the assignment. Pell would travel with two delegates who had opposed disclosure, and all three would carry identical sealed packets. Reception logs would enter the public archive automatically.

“Better,” he said.

“Not pure.”

“Nothing with people stays pure.”

Dara had once said nearly the same thing about floodwater. Sef did not borrow the memory aloud.

The Assembly contacted Kaveh Orn from the reservoir. His face appeared above Dara’s old desk, older than Sef remembered and marked along one cheek by the tower fire. She explained the proposed release and his right to restrict medical details.

“Release my testimony,” he said.

“The lower-gallery images?”

“No. My children have not seen them.”

“Your address?”

“Keep it out until after the vote.”

Pell asked from his desk, “Did Dara know the two weather frames came from baseline?”

Kaveh looked toward Sef before answering. “She knew the Assembly had a name for them. She said the tower could not wait for that name to become politically convenient.”

Sef entered his words without correction.

Two more witnesses answered. Engineer Mael Cor permitted release of her control notes but asked that an accusation against a dead supervisor remain sealed until his family received notice. Dispatcher Inas Roe refused all personal identification and authorized the command sequence alone. The Assembly accepted both boundaries.

Sef watched the disclosure packet become less complete and more legitimate. For years she had treated an intact archive as the highest form of truth. Yet a record gathered by ignoring the living could reproduce the very authority it claimed to expose. Dara’s pages differed. Dara had chosen what to write and had argued for their release while alive.

Pell prepared to leave for the channels. Sef gave him one of three packet keys.

“People will ask whether the sky remains real,” he said.

“Tell them what you believe.”

“They will ask what the Assembly believes.”

“The Assembly disagrees.”

He fastened the key inside his jacket. “That may frighten them.”

“Then do not offer unity we did not earn.”

For once, he accepted her answer without pushing against it.

The amendment passed, 19–6–2.

Pell’s motion passed, 15–11–1.

Nobody celebrated.

Oren instructed Sef to prepare the disclosure packet. She opened the charter, founding minutes, contact transcripts, and weather correlations. Her pane requested an archive scope. She selected polity-wide.

The rain ledger remained closed beside her.

Pell approached after members began leaving for their districts. “The motion covers it.”

“I know.”

“You could ask me to open it.”

“That would make you responsible for my delay.”

“I am already responsible for my vote.”

“Keep that. It will be enough.”

They carried the ledger upstairs together.

Night had deepened over the orchard district. The paired suns had dropped, but heat lightning moved beyond the eastern channels without thunder. Public boards still showed the ordinary forecast: dry, moderate wind, low flood risk. In less than an hour those boards would also carry nine years of evidence that weather had sometimes bent around interventions from a prior world.

At the archive, Sef removed the green privacy seal from Dara’s file. The system warned that release could not be reversed after public replication. She read every surviving witness restriction. Kaveh Orn had sealed images of his burns, not his testimony. Two tower operators had requested address protection. Nobody had asked to hide the control sequence.

Pell stood across the table. “What do you remember?”

“About that day?”

“About her. Before you made her evidence.”

The accusation lacked its earlier edge. It hurt more without it.

Sef opened the ledger to the corrected entry. “She came home angry because the works board called the sky distortion negligible. She washed green ink from her thumb in the kitchen basin. It did not come off. We ate cold pears. She said Tower Three would kill someone if command kept treating contradictory sensors as an average. I told her to bring the data to the Assembly.”

“Did she?”

“She said the Assembly already had enough data. It lacked nerve.”

Pell looked toward the dark window. “That sounds like her.”

“Yes.”

Sef attached the ledger to the disclosure packet. Not a summary. Not selected pages. The complete rain ledger, including Dara’s accusation, Sef’s custodial seal, and every later annotation made while the record remained hidden.

A final field requested release authority.

She entered: OPEN VOTE OF THE SECOND DAWN ASSEMBLY, PENDING RATIFICATION BY THE POLITY.

Before confirming, she opened the public broadcast channel. Thousands of local receivers appeared across the orchard ward, then tens of thousands beyond it. Homes, pump stations, clinics, night schools, market boards. The map brightened until civic light covered the district more densely than stars.

Sef pressed her thumb to the recorder’s seal.

Dara’s first green correction left the archive. The rain ledger opened to the whole polity.

Chapter 19 — The Vote of One World

<!-- POV: Sef Aradin -->

<!-- BASELINE DAY 9 -->

Rain began falling upward from the eastern paving stones.

Only for three breaths. Silver drops lifted from the public square, narrowed into threads, and vanished into a purple seam above the cooling towers. Then gravity remembered its direction. Water struck the stones again, hard enough to scatter the people gathered beneath the Assembly lamps.

Nobody went home.

Sef Aradin stood at the recorder's table with Dara's rain ledger closed beneath her palm. The square had hosted seed exchanges, flood hearings, three marriage festivals, and the trial of an orchard superintendent who sold public water after midnight. It had never held so many citizens. Faces filled balconies on all four sides. Orchard workers in mud-streaked boots stood beside weather clerks wearing their blue cuffs. Children occupied the dry ledge under the east arcade and stared at the sky whenever its color shifted.

The latest distortion had left two shadows under every person, one cast toward morning and another toward a sun that did not belong there.

Pell climbed onto the low fountain wall. "Channels remain open," he called. "North terraces report twelve hundred linked. River wards, confirm."

A voice came through the square speakers. "River wards confirm nine hundred and six."

"Glasshouse quarter?"

"Seven hundred eighty-one, with proxy seals posted."

Sef watched him manage the count. His sleeves had been rolled above his elbows since dawn. A line of black silt crossed his wrist, evidence that he had left the orchard gates only when the first citizens arrived. Yesterday he had accused her of making patience into a locked room. Today he carried the keys to a vote she had resisted for nine years.

He looked at the ledger under her hand but did not ask her to open it again.

Recorder Halven struck the civic bowl. Its bronze note passed through the square and returned a fraction late from the rendered western wall. "The Second Dawn Assembly calls the question published at first light. No amendment may change the conditions after debate begins. Recorder Aradin will read the proposal."

Sef rose. Her knees objected after a night without sleep. She read from paper because no one trusted the public panes to remain stable through another sky disturbance.

"Branch Nine offers conditional navigation aid to baseline during the present dust and flare conjunction. The offer requires acknowledgment of reciprocal refusal, publication of terms to every reachable branch polity, and suspension of compulsory convergence while those terms remain under consideration. We provide observations, not assent to a course selected without us."

A murmur moved through the crowd at the word polity. Some citizens had adopted it the instant Lysa Neral

used it. Others preferred world, wards, Nine, or home. Sef had stopped correcting any of them. A people did not become more real by agreeing on the noun for themselves.

Halven said, "The tally will record three choices. Accept the proposal. Reject all navigation aid. Return the proposal for unconditional aid. Debate closes after six speakers and one response from the sponsors."

An orchard foreman named Et Ral raised the first speaking seal. He had lost two lower fields during the old flood and still distrusted every office that promised water by average. "They can end our sky," he said. "That fact enters every sentence they send us. A bargain made under a blade has no consent in it. Reject. Let them solve their own weather."

A woman near the fountain shouted, "Their children did not build the blade."

"Neither did ours."

Halven struck the bowl once. "No gallery exchange."

Et faced the crowd rather than the Assembly. "We hid for nine years because disclosure threatened everyone. Now baseline asks for our work because danger reached their hull. If usefulness purchases our hearing, useless people will lose it. Reject the aid until they recognize us without payment."

Applause broke first along the north terraces. Sef understood it. She had made the same argument to Lysa during their first channel, only with a quieter voice and fewer witnesses. Proof demanded under threat could become another instrument. Yet the flare would not wait for a clean hearing, and sixty-one thousand strangers could not be separated into the guilty and the uninformed before the dust arrived.

Second speaker went to Mara Venn, a school cook from the river ward. She carried a sleeping infant against her chest and spoke without leaving the crowd.

"My daughter has lived eleven days. Baseline did not put a question to her when it made us. The Assembly did not put a question to her when it hid what it knew. I cannot make either wrong disappear. I can vote on whether another child loses a parent because I wanted justice to arrive before mercy. Accept the conditions."

Et lowered his eyes.

The western sky flickered. For half a second the far buildings turned transparent, exposing pale construction lines and blank depth beyond them. Several children cried out. Adults reached for one another. The wall restored itself with every brick in place, but the second shadow remained.

Two weather apprentices hurried from the arcade with a calibrated prism and an old mechanical clock. Sef recognized their equipment from the storm schools, where children learned to preserve observations through relay failures. One apprentice measured the false light while the other called seconds. Their teacher had not sent them. They had seen a civic need and entered the record under their own names.

That small competence steadied the square better than reassurance could have. The crowd made room. A glasshouse grower offered the apprentices his dark inspection cloth. Someone at the fountain began writing their figures on paper in case the public relay dropped them. Baseline might describe the scene as adaptive behavior. Sef saw neighbors doing work no office had assigned.

Sef marked the interruption in the official record: visual continuity fault, seventeen seconds before third speaker. She added the apprentices' names, the prism serial, and their measured angle. Dara would have included wind direction, temperature, and the smell from the tower vents. Dara had believed no anomaly

deserved isolation from its weather.

The distortion also sharpened the question before them. Their world depended on machinery they could not touch, yet its maintenance faults belonged to their daily lives. A sky did not become less one's own because strangers kept its lamps. Nor did a vessel become disposable because its government had built the lamps without consent.

Pell touched Sef's shoulder. "Baseline requests a channel update."

"Tell them debate continues."

"Iven Rook says the safe cone narrowed."

"Did he ask us to hurry?"

"No."

That restraint counted. It did not settle anything.

Third speaker, Councilor Imrel, had opposed contact from the Assembly's first secret winter. His white hair moved in the artificial breeze while he studied the two suns. "The prior world has made us live inside a false morning. We answered by making a false ignorance for our own neighbors. Recorder Aradin opened the rain ledger yesterday. Every citizen now knows that offices here concealed distortions linked to Dara Lis's death. We possess no moral height from which to punish a whole vessel for government secrecy."

Sef felt the crowd glance toward her without turning their heads. Dara's name still altered the air around it. Six years had not reduced that effect. Public knowledge had only distributed it.

Imrel continued. "But resemblance does not excuse them. It gives us grounds for a rule broad enough to bind both worlds. Reciprocal refusal means baseline may reject our advice and we may reject their demand. Neither rejection grants the other jurisdiction over the refuser's continued life. Accept."

The phrase landed without applause. People repeated it to neighbors, testing each clause.

Halven recognized the fourth seal. Pell stepped down from the fountain wall.

Sef had not known he intended to speak.

He crossed the square and stood inside the marked circle for citizens under twenty-one, a convention designed to keep elders from claiming youth testimony through family proxies. Mud had dried in the seams of his hands.

"I wanted to speak to baseline when we first understood the interruptions," he said. "I was ten. I thought any voice outside our sky had to be an answer. My mother told me a voice could also become a door someone else controlled. I hated her for being right slowly."

A few people laughed, including Sef. The sound hurt and helped.

"Then she kept the door shut after we had built hinges," Pell said. "She called that civic consent. Sometimes it protected us. Sometimes it protected the Assembly from hearing no. Yesterday she opened Dara's ledger because the right to decide belonged outside this table. Today the same rule reaches baseline. We cannot demand that they hear our refusal while treating their danger as irrelevant noise."

He turned toward Et Ral. "I will vote to aid them. I will not give them one answer they can call ours forever.

Send each observation with the assumptions that produced it. Let them navigate across our differences."

"And if they take the course and erase us?" Et asked.

"Then their survival will carry an accusation they cannot compress into gratitude. If we withhold aid and they die, our survival carries something too."

Halven reached for the bowl, then allowed the silence to continue.

Sef saw Dara in none of Pell's features and in the way he held all of them. Dara had refused inherited choices even when she selected one. During the orchard flood she had opened a drainage gate against district protocol, saving the school cellars and drowning the municipal nursery. For years people had argued whether the act showed courage or arrogance. Dara had answered that water did not convert a decision into innocence.

Pell returned beside Sef. He did not seek her hand. Their shoulders touched.

The fifth speaker represented a coalition of cooling-tower crews. She wanted unconditional aid. "Conditions spend time we do not possess," she said. "If baseline fails, what happens to our sky? No one has answered. We depend on their machinery. Reciprocal language cannot make dependence equal. Give the navigator every course we have and negotiate after the burn."

Boos rose from the glasshouse quarter. Halven struck the bowl twice.

Sef opened the narrow channel pane at her table. Baseline timing pulses marched along its edge, restrained to Nine's present pace. A text line from Lysa waited there.

SAFE CONE REVISION IN 0:41 BASELINE. COUNCIL HAS NOT ACCEPTED CONDITIONS. NAVIGATION CAN RECEIVE DIVERGENT PACKETS WITHOUT WITNESS CONVERGENCE.

Below it, Iven had appended technical requirements: star-limb observations, dust polarization, flare-front timing, confidence assumptions. He did not ask for a selected course.

That distinction represented movement, perhaps enough.

Sixth speaker belonged to Neral Oth, who repaired civic memory after continuity faults. "Every record I mend asks me to choose which damaged version remains public," he said. "People imagine restoration means finding the one true copy. Usually it means preserving the disagreement where evidence permits. The Choir, as baseline calls us, removes that disagreement. It turns many worlds into confidence. Our aid should prevent death without consenting to that reduction. Accept, and publish to every branch."

The formal debate ended. Halven offered Sef the sponsors' response.

She carried Dara's ledger into the speaking circle. Its leather cover had warped from years in damp archive drawers. Thousands in the linked wards would see a rendered copy, cleaned of stains by the civic relay. The square saw the actual object.

"Yesterday I gave you a record the Assembly had no right to keep closed," Sef said. "Opening it did not repair the tower. It did not return Dara. It changed who could judge what had been done in the name of protection."

She set the ledger on the low stone at the center of the circle.

"Baseline promises no recognition yet. Their Council may accept our observations, survive, and resume the clock that carries us toward termination. Our conditions cannot prevent betrayal by syntax. We have no

enforcement except refusal, record, and the fact that they now know who refuses."

A child under the arcade asked too loudly, "Can they hear us now?"

His father whispered an answer Sef could not catch.

"Some argue that dependence makes reciprocity impossible," she continued. "Dependence makes reciprocity necessary. Baseline sustains the machinery beneath our weather. We possess observations that may sustain their hull. Neither dependence grants ownership. Neither gift creates obedience."

The false sun brightened over the cooling towers. Its light passed through the rain clouds without illuminating them.

Sef looked at Pell. "My son said we should send differences rather than one answer. He and I have fought over contact since he became old enough to notice how adults rename fear. I wanted perfect authority before we spoke. He wanted speech to create its own authority. Neither condition arrived. This vote can."

Pell gave one small nod.

"If you accept, Branch Nine will send parallax. Each district team may report what it sees and the assumptions under which it sees it. We will not converge those accounts into a course. The prior world must choose under uncertainty, as we do. In return we require reciprocal refusal and open terms for every polity they can reach. If you reject, our channels close except for notice of our decision. If you return the proposal, aid goes without conditions. Those choices differ. None offers innocence."

She stepped out of the circle.

Halven ordered a nine-minute recess for ward verification. The square burst into hundreds of low arguments. Citizens lined up at seal tables or bent over private panes. Runners carried paper ballots to the elders' residence after its relay failed. Tower workers clustered around a maintenance display, pointing at load spikes no vote could pause.

Pell leaned against the recorder's table. "You quoted me without warning."

"I recorded you in public. Warning seemed redundant."

"You left out the part where I said your patience made me want to break furniture."

"That did not improve the proposal."

His mouth almost formed a smile. "Dara would have included it."

Sef watched rain gather in the ledger's cracked cover. "Dara included weather. Furniture had to petition separately."

The smile arrived. It did not erase the last nine years between them, but it crossed them.

A hard chime sounded from the channel. Iven's safe-cone revision had worsened by four degrees. Sef showed Pell the numbers.

Around them, debate had become practical labor. Retired surveyors checked the orchard packet against instruments older than Pell. Three river children carried sealed counts between tables because the western relay kept losing names. The cooling crews posted their objections beside their measurements, refusing the

convenient fiction that useful data required political agreement. Sef entered each act in the margin of the proceeding. A vote included the means by which people remained present long enough to cast it.

"Can we still help?" he asked.

"If the orchard teams have kept their raw readings."

"They have."

"All of them?"

"Even the ones that contradict mine. I learned something this morning."

Halven recalled the Assembly. Verification clerks delivered ward seals on three separate slates. One arrived by hand after the western relay lost six minutes. Every total received two witnesses. Sef copied each figure into the paper record while the crowd settled.

The altered sky dimmed toward an evening nobody had scheduled.

Halven stood beside the civic bowl. "Eligible Assembly delegates, two hundred sixty-eight. All seals verified. The public wards advise but do not bind the Assembly under present charter. Their advisory count supports the same plurality."

He gave the slate to Sef.

She read the figures twice. Numbers could be accurate and still conceal a public, but these had followed hours of voices, objections, repairs, and mud tracked across civic stone.

"The official tally 184–61–23," she announced. "One hundred eighty-four accept conditional aid. Sixty-one reject all aid. Twenty-three return for aid without conditions. The proposal carries."

Noise struck the square. It held cheers, anger, relief, and one long shout from the north terraces that might have meant any of them. Et Ral covered his face. Mara Venn kissed the sleeping infant's hair. Tower crews began moving before Halven completed the certification.

Pell took his position at the transmission table. "Orchard packet ready. River optics ready. Glasshouse polarization pending two minutes."

Sef opened the baseline channel to public witness. Lysa appeared as a voice first, breathless beneath distant alarms.

"Branch Nine, we are receiving. Has the Assembly concluded?"

"It has," Sef said. "Conditional aid passed. Our record and minority positions follow."

Jalen Vey spoke from farther from the pickup. "We cannot ratify standing terms during an active maneuver."

"Then do not call our packets consent."

"Navigation requires a coherent recommendation."

Iven cut in. "Navigation requires observations. I can build coherence after I know where they differ."

Sef sent the first bundle. Instead of a preferred course, it carried twenty-seven local descriptions of the false

sun: orchard water shadows, tower interference, riverward refraction, cloud-edge timing. Each report named its method and uncertainty. No confidence band joined them.

Other channels appeared beside Nine's. Seven thin marks, then six as one failed, then seven again. Worlds that had remained silent now offered distinct packets under names the Witness Engine had never shown to its operators.

Lysa said, "Your conditions have entered the public docket. I cannot promise the Council's vote. I can promise they cannot be removed from the record."

"A record does not keep our sky lit."

"No. It lets everyone see who decides whether it remains lit."

Sef looked across the square. Citizens watched their contradictory observations leave the world. Nobody sang. The old Choir metaphor had always imagined harmony from the listener's side. Here, the sending sounded like clerks reading numbers, pumps cycling, a baby waking, and rain beginning in the proper direction.

Pell placed his hand beside hers on the transmission control.

"All districts sent," he said.

Sef closed the convergence field before baseline could request it. The offered packets remained separate, bright points around a course no one had chosen for them.

"Branch Nine transmission complete," she told the prior world. "We offer parallax, not convergence."

Chapter 20 — The Cost of Uncertainty

<!-- POV: Lysa Neral -->

<!-- BASELINE DAY 9 -->

Someone had pasted Hanne Neral's death certificate across the forum doors.

The public copy stood taller than Lysa, its ration seal enlarged until every flaw in the old scan resembled a crack. Black type listed caloric adaptation variance as contributing context and circulatory failure as cause. Beneath it, a fresh hand had written in red grease:

ASK HER WHICH WORLD SHE WOULD SAVE.

People pressed through the passage on either side without touching the paper. The *Aster Vale* had built its central forum for departure anniversaries, not accusations. Curved benches descended toward a speaking floor beneath the bronze bell carried from Earth. Today every bench held crew from life support, sail operations, schools, kitchens, infirmaries, and machine decks. Spillover channels filled the aisles with faces from other rings.

Lysa stopped before her mother's name.

The posting used a public record. No privacy rule had been broken. Whoever placed it had understood her office well enough to make legality part of the wound. The certificate invited no correction she could use to dismiss it. Even the red grease avoided her mother's printed name.

Iven waited at the inner doors with a navigation slate tucked under one arm. He had not slept. A square of sealant marked his collar where a cooling line had sprayed him during the last deck inspection.

"I can have it removed," he said.

"On what grounds?"

"Obstruction. Bad taste. I am willing to discover a regulation."

"Leave it."

"Lysa."

"If we take it down before the forum, they will spend the forum discussing why."

He looked from the certificate to her face. Eight years ago he would have touched her shoulder. Now he held the slate more tightly.

Inside, Councilor Jalen Vey stood at the moderator's rail. Captain Orra occupied the first bench rather than the command dais, a concession to public process that fooled nobody about her authority. Behind her, the phase cone turned slowly above the floor. Seven branch packets glowed as separate points around it. None converged.

Jalen opened before Lysa reached her assigned chair. "Branch Nine's conditions arrived eighteen minutes ago. The Council has not accepted them. Navigation reports forty-one minutes until the next safe-cone revision and less than four hours until the maneuver window becomes physically punitive. This forum will hear material objections, not repeat the standing hearing."

A labor delegate called, "Standing became material when they stopped answering."

"Then address the consequence."

The first speaker already waited at the floor seal. Bay Arven supervised algae exchange on Ring Four, a broad woman with nutrient stains under her fingernails. She looked at Lysa rather than Jalen.

"My district lost circulation twice this week because compute cooling took priority," Arven said. "Now those same machines refuse the forecast, and your answer is to give their contents legal power over us. How many failures become acceptable before your fairness notices bodies here?"

"None become acceptable," Lysa said.

"That answer spends nothing."

"The cooling diversion should enter the cost record. It does not settle whether a polity can be compelled to advise."

Arven pointed toward Hanne's certificate outside. A public feed showed it beside the phase cone. "Your mother died because a forecast spent her. Did you open this case to save people like her, or to make the ship pay for failing her?"

The room tightened around the question.

Lysa had rehearsed legal objections, technical objections, even the accusation that she had invented personhood to expand her office. She had not prepared to hear Hanne offered as proof by someone who remembered only a file.

"My mother's case does not establish Branch Nine's standing," she said. "It established a rule requiring affected groups to answer when they can. The evidence here must stand without her."

"Convenient."

"Necessary. Grief can reveal where to look. It cannot certify what we find."

A sail rigger took the next seal before Arven left the floor. "My team goes outside if this maneuver tears cloth. Choir projections used to tell us where a tear would run. Branch Nine wants a right to object from inside a protected chamber. We carry the consequence on our suits. Where is our reciprocal refusal?"

Iven leaned toward his microphone. "No rigger will receive a compulsory exterior order during active flare exposure."

"Then the ship burns heat until the cone closes."

"That remains possible."

"You say it like a weather report."

"I say it because hiding the possibility does not cool the sail."

The rigger turned on Lysa. "Would you fly with us?"

"No. I lack the training, and pretending courage could substitute for it would add danger."

A bitter laugh moved across the benches.

"At least that answer costs something," he said.

Speaker followed speaker. A school coordinator asked whether branch children deserved recognition before baseline children deserved arrival. A physician described medication cultures that would fail if industrial schedules slipped. A cook demanded to know why refusal counted as civic agency when any baseline worker who abandoned a shift faced discipline. Lysa answered distinctions without pretending they dissolved the anger. Employment obligations had limits and appeal. Emergency work orders faced review. Creation of dependence did not create ownership over a people. Each answer opened another objection.

The moderator recognized Olin Saye from elder residence. His image arrived in fragments because the residence had surrendered relay bandwidth to navigation. One frame showed his mouth, the next a hand resting on a portable oxygen unit.

"I turn ninety in six years," Olin said. "Direct capture lets me see Tern if medicine and luck remain courteous. Your reef makes my death aboard certain. Does the right to object extend to me?"

Lysa approached the floor rail so she would not answer a face two stories high from the safety of her chair. "Yes."

"Then I object."

"Your objection belongs in the decision record, with the consequence stated plainly."

"But it does not stop the maneuver."

"Not by itself."

"You offer Nine more than you offer me."

The accusation carried no anger. That made it harder.

"Nine refuses labor demanded from its citizens and a policy that terminates them after use," Lysa said. "You object to a trajectory authority may still impose on everyone aboard, including me. Those powers differ. Both require review."

Olin adjusted the oxygen line beneath his nose. "A distinction can remain true and still feel cruel."

"Yes."

"Good. Put that answer in your doctrine."

His feed vanished before the moderator closed the seal. The empty pane stayed above Lysa for several seconds. Eleven years had not yet entered the formal discussion, but some people already understood that every widened safety margin narrowed a life.

A birth registrar followed him. She brought charts showing deferred conception windows under extended transit reserves. "An eleven-year delay could mean four hundred children never conceived," she said. "No death certificates will carry their names. Does your affected-party law count possible people?"

"It counts people exposed to the policy now," Lysa answered. "Future demographic effects must enter planning, but an imagined citizen cannot consent for a present one."

"The Choir exists to tell us which future people appear."

"It tells us what happened under selected assumptions. It cannot grant those possible people authority over citizens who supplied the forecast."

Jalen said, "Without future representation, every generation may consume the next."

"Representation requires someone accountable for the judgment. It cannot hide behind a modeled descendant."

The registrar left unconvinced. Lysa recorded that too. A hearing did not earn legitimacy by producing agreement. It earned part of it by preserving refusal without treating the refuser as a defect.

Above them, the separate branch points shifted as new observations arrived. Branch Three reported a dust density twice Branch Seven's estimate. Nine supplied orchard-shadow timings with a confidence range broad enough to make Jalen swear under his breath.

Orra remained silent until a maintenance chief named Dast produced the old ration review.

Before he spoke, the forum displayed the source chain. Three clerks verified that no page had been altered since the final appeal. Lysa recognized her own apprentice signature on the index, narrow and overcareful. She had believed then that a complete chain could prevent grief from contaminating judgment. Now the chain carried grief into the room with perfect fidelity.

Dast waited through verification. That courtesy denied her any procedural refuge. He had not stolen a private note or distorted an old number. He intended to use a sound record against the doctrine she had built from it.

"Hanne Neral belonged to a cohort of forty-six," he said. "The model predicted twelve excess deaths if allocations stayed flat and nineteen elsewhere if food moved back. Council moved the food. Twelve died. The review called the distribution statistically fair. Auditor Neral now says fairness grants every affected party a veto. Had her doctrine applied then, nineteen might have died instead."

Lysa watched the figures appear. She knew them. For years she had refused to calculate which twelve included her mother, as though resisting comparison protected Hanne from becoming arithmetic. Dast had placed the comparison before sixty-one thousand people.

"I do not claim every objection becomes a veto," she said.

"Branch Nine does."

"Nine claims refusal over its own labor and continued existence. It has still offered observations."

"Conditional on recognition."

"Conditional on the public knowing what was requested and on other branches receiving the same terms."

Dast spread his hands. "Words. Outside this chamber, heat rises."

An alarm line pulsed amber around the phase cone. Iven checked his slate, then sent a private note to Lysa.

REEF OPTION REMAINS REACHABLE. DISCLOSE NOW OR LOSE POLITICAL CHOICE BEFORE PHYSICAL ONE.

She read it twice. The asymmetric reef had stayed inside navigation's sealed contingency set because eleven

years of delay could trigger ration revisions, birth-licence changes, deferred replacements, and deaths no model could individually name. Iven had refused to present it five days ago. Branch Nine's parallax packets now made the option flyable without a compulsory convergence run, but not safe in the old sense. It widened one margin by surrendering another.

Lysa wrote back: AFTER MY ANSWER.

Dast had not yielded the floor. "Did your mother have a right to object?"

"Yes."

"Would that right have required us to keep her ration?"

"It would have required the Council to hear what her cohort knew about its own capacity, reveal the trade, and name who imposed it. The final allocation might still have harmed her."

"Then what good is the right?"

Lysa rose from her chair. The moderator's light remained red, but Jalen did not order her down.

"It prevents necessity from forging consent after the fact," she said. "My mother's file says the allocation represented her because the model included her measurements. It did not. It represented an outcome imposed on her. Maybe the Council still would have chosen it. Maybe nineteen other people would have died under another choice. No procedure guarantees innocence."

The forum had gone quiet enough for the ventilation grilles to become audible.

"For twenty-two years I wanted Hanne's case to yield a clean correction," Lysa continued. "A better threshold. A mandatory sample. An equation that would make the next decision fair. Those changes matter, but I mistook them for the whole duty. Fairness cannot mean that every life receives its preferred outcome. It must include the right to object before someone calls the outcome yours."

Jalen's microphone clicked on. "A right to object differs from sovereign refusal."

"Yes. We should negotiate the difference. We cannot negotiate with a confidence band."

"And if objection prevents action until everyone dies?"

"Then emergency law names who acts, for how long, under which review, and with what accountability. It does not rename coerced assistance as assent."

Bay Arven stood from her bench. "You still have not said which world you would save."

Lysa turned toward her. "I reject the question."

The crowd erupted. Jalen struck the moderator rail, but she kept speaking.

"Not because the danger lacks reality. Because neither world arrives as one body that can be weighed against another. Baseline contains your algae crews, children, riggers, officers, and people who pasted my mother's death outside. Nine contains citizens who voted against helping us and citizens who voted to help under conditions. Asking which world I save hides every person who must carry the choice."

"That sounds like refusal," Arven said.

"It refuses a false balance. It does not refuse action."

Lysa nodded to Iven.

He came to the floor with his slate. The phase cone widened above them, then rotated until the current course appeared edge-on. A narrow blue seam opened along its lower surface.

"Navigation has withheld one reachable trajectory from public briefing," he said. "I withheld it. The option imposes a physical and civic cost large enough that I would not present it while a higher-confidence direct capture remained available. That condition no longer holds."

The blue seam expanded into a lopsided surface.

"This is the asymmetric reef."

Murmurs chased the name around the chamber. Sail crew recognized it first.

Iven highlighted the thermal sail. Eight broad vanes appeared around the vessel model. Four folded toward the spine while the others remained extended.

"Standard reefing preserves equal radiation and photon pressure. Asymmetric reefing changes our angle to the flare while using uneven sail load to shift the phase cone. We cross the dust conjunction outside the predicted density peak. The branch packets need not agree on one course. Their differences define the edge we avoid."

Dast said, "Why has no one offered this?"

"Because it costs direct capture at Tern."

"How long?"

Iven put the number above the ship.

ELEVEN YEARS.

The forum reacted as if gravity had lurched. People rose. Three feeds dropped under channel load. A woman near Orra began calculating aloud how old her father would be. The school coordinator covered his mouth. Bay Arven stared at the figure, perhaps turning harvest cycles through her head.

Lysa felt the same calculation attempt to recruit every face. Eleven years meant children born in transit, elders dead before landing, machinery run past intended life, another generation of ration law. It represented no abstract inconvenience.

Jalen faced Iven. "You propose adding eleven years to a voyage already beyond design margins because predictive processes asserted conditions."

"I propose it because the ship can physically survive that course without compulsory convergence."

"Can survive. Not will."

"Correct."

"Probability?"

"A range. Twenty-eight to forty-six percent chance of major sail damage, depending on which dust packet

tracks closest. Less than six percent chance of hull-fatal exposure if execution stays inside the widened cone."

A labor delegate shouted, "And the direct course?"

"Choir confidence no longer applies. Conventional bounds put hull-fatal exposure between four and twenty-one percent."

"That could be safer."

"It could. The uncertainty comes from the thing we are debating whether to compel."

Orra finally stood. "What authorization does the reef require?"

"Captain's emergency navigation authority for sail configuration. Council approval for the trajectory cost can follow, but by then the physical choice will have occurred."

"So this forum advises while I decide."

"Yes."

Anger changed direction. Some people accused Iven of concealing an escape. Others accused Lysa of engineering a public spectacle to force Orra's hand. The eleven-year figure remained above them, indifferent to motive.

Lysa opened Hanne's ration file on the common display. She could have chosen a page showing the twelve dead. Instead she selected the affected-party notice sent after allocation began. Its response field contained a gray block.

NO APPEAL WITHIN ACTIVE DISTRIBUTION WINDOW.

"This is what certainty cost in my mother's case," she said. "Not only her life. The decision might have killed her under any process. The additional cost came when an imposed outcome entered history as representation."

She closed the file.

"The asymmetric reef does not repair that history. It does not prove Branch Nine right. It gives us a path on which uncertainty remains visible and refusal does not require mutual destruction. Eleven years marks the price. Sail risk marks another. Anyone who calls it mercy without naming those costs should not be trusted with the choice."

A young voice came from the school feed. "Will the branches still be alive in eleven years?"

No one answered quickly.

The Mercy clock continued in a corner of Lysa's private pane. Four subjective years remained for Nine, conditional on acceleration. Automatic termination policy had not been suspended. The reef could save the ship and leave the polities facing deletion before baseline's next morning.

"Not unless the Council acts," she said.

Jalen seized the admission. "Then this course buys no settlement."

"It buys no excuse to postpone one."

Orra crossed to the navigation model. She studied the uneven vanes, the blue seam, and seven separate packets that refused to become green. "I want sail operations on the floor in ten minutes. Thermal projections public. Medical and ration offices will publish eleven-year consequence ranges without Choir convergence."

"Conventional model only?" Jalen asked.

"Conventional model and identified branch observations. No imputed assent."

The order moved through the chamber. Benches became work stations. Public anger did not subside, but it acquired tasks: inspect, calculate, challenge, record. Iven handed Lysa the full reef file. His fingers remained on the slate for a second after hers closed around it.

"You wanted the option public," she said.

"I wanted it flyable. You made secrecy part of the hazard."

"That sounds almost like agreement."

"Do not become ambitious."

Outside the doors, Hanne Neral's death certificate still covered the wall. Two sail riggers had begun posting thermal calculations beside it. Someone added the eleven-year arrival range below the red question. Nobody removed Hanne's name.

Lysa transmitted the asymmetric reef file to the public docket, copied all seven branch channels, and requested objections before the maneuver lock.

For the first time in the crisis, the phase cone displayed no preferred green course. It showed a wide blue passage, an uneven sail, and every cost anyone had managed to name.

Chapter 21 — Parallax

<!-- POV: Iven Rook -->

<!-- BASELINE DAY 9 -->

Branch Three placed the dust lane nine thousand kilometres farther inward than Branch Seven.

Iven Rook trusted both measurements.

That contradiction occupied the center of navigation as a red double curve. Around it, seven branch packets arrived through channels Toma had stripped away from the Witness Engine. No confidence band softened their disagreement. Three measured polarization. Seven tracked the flare's magnetic front by disturbances in its own rendered aurora. Nine supplied shadow angles from an orchard district where citizens had carried prisms into a public vote.

The deck clock gave him twenty-seven minutes to reef lock.

"Load Three's inner edge as hard hazard," Iven told the plot crew. "Seven's outer edge too."

Navigator Eske turned from her station. "That closes the direct corridor."

"Yes."

"We could weight by sensor fidelity. Three has cleaner optics."

"Seven observed a different atmosphere and a different flare evolution. Fidelity does not make its world ours. Preserve both."

Eske entered the bounds. The green passage to Tern disappeared. A blue cone remained below it, broader at the conjunction and useless for direct capture.

Eleven years appeared beside the projected arrival date.

Nobody commented. Everyone on the deck had already performed the private arithmetic. Iven had calculated his own age at arrival and stopped before adding names of people who might not reach it. Navigation required costs to remain quantitative until the burn. Grief could enter afterward and accuse the numbers properly.

Captain Orra came through the pressure hatch wearing a maneuver harness over her formal uniform. Lysa followed with the public objection docket clutched to her chest. She belonged anywhere decisions disguised exclusions, but the acceleration couches had no station for an auditor. Iven had ordered one bolted beside communications.

"Forum responses?" Orra asked.

Lysa secured herself. "Eight thousand objections to delay, three thousand supporting, fourteen thousand requesting more information, remainder unrecorded or unavailable. The count does not bind emergency navigation authority."

"Nothing like democracy to clarify a deadline."

"The objections remain valid even when they cannot decide the burn."

Orra looked at Iven. "Can you fly it?"

"I can fly a corridor. The packets do not identify one true dust boundary."

"That evades my question."

"No. It changes its premise. I can execute the parallax maneuver with a hull-fatal risk bounded below six percent across the observations received. Major sail damage remains between twenty-eight and forty-six percent. We lose direct Tern capture."

"And if Branch Seven's magnetic estimate has no relation to our flare?"

"Then I will steer too far from danger and spend additional reaction mass."

"If Three missed the dense edge?"

"We may tear the sail."

Orra tightened her harness. "There. A navigator after all."

The deck lights dimmed to maneuver red. Iven opened the sail schematic. Eight vanes spread around *Aster Vale*, each forty kilometres of reflective and radiative membrane webbed with coolant capillaries. In standard reef, opposing vanes folded together to keep photon pressure through the vessel axis. The asymmetric reef would draw in vanes two, three, and four while six remained half open. Unequal light pressure would torque the ship. Fusion pulses would turn that torque into a lateral shift before the flare loaded the exposed cloth.

A maneuver designer had proposed the configuration eighty-three years earlier, then rejected it because return to symmetric deployment required months of repair. The old note called arrival delay operationally unacceptable.

No note possessed authority over this morning.

"Sail control, verify crews internal," Iven said.

"All exterior crews recovered," came the reply. "Rigger Two reports a jam at Vane Four winch cluster twelve. Remote access only."

A yellow fault appeared on the schematic.

"Can it take commanded load?"

"Unknown. Last physical inspection predates the current heat cycle."

Orra said, "Alternative configuration?"

Iven rotated the vessel model. Reefing Vane Five instead preserved torque but exposed a repaired seam from the accident that killed his brother. The scar had passed every inspection for twelve years. His eye began its old tremor.

"Vane Five can substitute," Eske said softly.

Everyone knew the repair history. On a generation vessel, machinery remembered families.

Iven expanded the seam telemetry. Temperature nominal. Tension nominal. A confidence model offered

ninety-four percent integrity under projected load. He closed it.

"We use Four," he said. "Cycle the cluster under ten percent tension."

"That could lock it open."

"Then we learn before commitment."

Sail control pulsed the winch. Vane Four's edge crept inward, stopped, and advanced again with a shudder transmitted through its tension graph. Cluster twelve drew seventeen percent excess current.

"Friction, not fracture," the controller said. "Probably guide deformation."

Probably belonged in the corridor with everything else.

"Set compensation. Continue."

The branch channels chimed together, not harmonized but concurrent. Toma had assigned each a separate tone. Three sent a revised inner density. Seven withdrew two auroral observations after its own scientists challenged calibration. Nine added six minority reports from river wards, their angles inconsistent with the official orchard packet.

Iven opened a comparison lattice without activating synthesis. The screen placed each claim along an axis of measurement, assumption, and consequence. Three's clean optics gave the sharpest dust edge, but its simulated vessel had entered the conjunction at a different thermal attitude. Seven's aurora offered poorer spatial resolution and earlier warning of magnetic load. Nine's orchard shadows carried no direct dust measurement at all. They constrained the flare geometry by recording how an unselected sun crossed civic buildings.

Eske studied the lattice. "If we cannot rank them, planning becomes a list of fears."

"We rank consequences, not citizens."

"That sounds admirable and gives me no vector."

Iven marked the regions where any packet predicted hull loss. Red exclusions spread through the cone. Then he marked regions where every packet left correction authority after the first pulse. A crooked blue volume survived between them.

"There is your vector set," he said.

"It contains four hundred possible burns."

"Good. A point solution would pretend the observations agree."

She filtered for sail heat, spine interval, and post-conjunction reaction mass. Four hundred fell to nineteen. Vane Four's uncertain winch removed six. Medical limits on lateral acceleration removed another three. Ten possible sequences remained.

Iven sent those sequences back through the branch channels, labeled as baseline proposals rather than questions requiring civic assent. Responses arrived unevenly. Three identified two sequences that crossed its revised inner dust edge. Seven warned that five met the early flare front broadside. Nine refused to recommend among the last three but supplied household shadow timings that narrowed pulse onset.

"They are navigating," Eske said.

"They are observing. We are navigating. Keep the responsibility attached to this deck."

"You correct anyone who gives you company."

"Company can become a place to leave blame."

He selected the sequence with the widest remaining correction interval. It spent more reaction mass than the efficient option and placed greater load on Vane Four. Nothing preferred it except the fact that no single mistaken packet could make it immediately fatal.

Lysa relayed a question from Branch Three. "They ask whether the eleven-year estimate includes repair time or only orbital return."

"Only return. Repair changes what thrust we can recover later. Give them the range, ten to fourteen, with eleven as current median."

"They request that current median not become the public title."

Iven looked at the large figure already copied across ship feeds. "Too late for that. Add their objection."

Jalen's voice entered over Council circuit. "Navigator, Witness Operations can produce a temporary synthesis if you route those packets through confidence weighting."

"Denied."

"On whose authority?"

"Mine until the maneuver ends."

"Emergency authority belongs to the captain."

Orra opened her channel. "The captain supports navigation protocol."

"Protocol has never included civic minutes from forecast branches."

Iven aligned the blue cone between the outer and inner boundaries. "It does now."

He muted the Council circuit before Jalen could improve the conversation.

At twelve minutes to lock, the ship began precession. Artificial gravity tilted by less than one degree, enough to pull loose styluses against desk lips. The thermal sail turned toward the approaching flare. Heat climbed on the exposed vanes, yellow spreading outward from their roots.

Medical called with three crew whose restraints could not tolerate the planned lateral load. Iven could reduce acceleration and lengthen the final pulse, but that pushed its cooling interval into Seven's early flare boundary. He requested compartment locations. Two patients occupied aft infirmary near the vessel axis. The third lay in a Ring Two surgical cradle after a pressure-door injury.

"Can the cradle rotate ten degrees?" he asked.

"Manual rotation only during power isolation," the physician said. "We need four minutes."

Reef lock arrived in eleven.

"Isolate now. Navigation will hold precession rate until you confirm."

Eske glanced across. "Holding spends a degree of sail cooling."

"Put it in the heat debt."

For four minutes the entire maneuver waited at the edge of its schedule while two orderlies turned one injured body. The physician confirmed restraint alignment. Iven released precession and watched the lost thermal margin enter every later choice. Physical cost had acquired a location and a name, which made it harder to optimize away.

Iven watched rates rather than colors. Color encouraged thresholds. Rates disclosed whether thresholds would arrive before he could act.

"Pulse spine to maneuver charge," he ordered. "Three pulses at point zero six standard. Interval according to live torque, not planned clock."

The propulsion chief confirmed. Deep beneath the deck, pumps moved fusion fuel into chambers separated from them by two kilometres of ship and several kinds of faith.

Lysa said, "Nine requests confirmation that minority packets remain identified."

"Show them the plot."

"They cannot interpret our navigation notation."

"Then tell them yes."

She did. A reply came in Sef Aradin's voice, weathered by channel compression.

"Branch Nine records that distinction. Our aid does not select your course."

Iven keyed his answer. "Understood. The physical choice is mine."

Orra glanced at him. "And mine."

"You authorize. I set the angle."

"Do not hoard culpability as craft pride."

He almost answered, then Vane Four screamed through telemetry.

Current spiked. The reef line stopped at sixty-three percent. Pressure across the sail pulled the vessel six hundredths of a degree off axis, triple the planned error. Eske called the drift before the alarms did.

"Release Four," Iven said.

"Release unresponsive."

"Counterreef Two to forty percent."

The controller stared at him. "That narrows radiation area below heat rule."

"For seventy seconds. Move."

Vane Two folded. Torque dropped, but heat climbed sharply along the remaining open cloth. The first pulse window approached with the vessel still two hundredths high.

"Delay pulse," Eske said.

"No. Dust boundary moves inward if Three holds. Pulse on torque crossing."

"Crossing in six seconds."

Iven gripped the couch rails. The first fusion pulse struck through the spine. Acceleration pressed his shoulders down and drove the tilted deck sideways. Every suspended display blurred. Vane Four jerked another metre inward, then froze.

The course marker entered the blue cone near its upper edge.

"Pulse one complete," propulsion said. "Heat debt nine percent above plan."

"Open Two five points. Bleed torque slowly."

A vibration entered the deck, too low to hear and impossible not to feel through bone. Iven knew the frequency. Sail membrane flutter.

His brother Kell had called it singing during the repair accident. Over suit radio, six minutes before the torn line cut him away, he had joked that any machine that large deserved a bad voice. Iven had spent twelve years treating every uncertain sail sound as an accusation against delay.

"Flutter on Vane Six," sail control reported. "Amplitude rising."

The standard response called for symmetric load reduction. Symmetry would erase their lateral shift and carry them toward the contested dust edge.

"Hold Six," Iven said. "Change pitch point three degrees sunward."

"That increases flare load."

"For twenty-two seconds. It damps the membrane before thermal peak."

Orra watched the heat display. "Authorized."

Pitch actuators turned the sail. Temperature rose across Six, then flutter amplitude fell. At thirteen seconds, the false red curve marking flare arrival jumped forward.

Branch Seven had updated its estimate.

"Magnetic front early by thirty-one seconds," Eske said. "If valid."

"Treat it as valid. Advance pulse two."

"Spine interval below cooling recommendation."

"Recommendation accepts the old flare time. Advance."

The second pulse hit while the first chamber still shed heat. Navigation lights went white under the power transient. Iven saw the plot only as afterimages: red dust inward, violet flare outward, blue course sliding between them.

Then one branch channel disappeared.

"Which?"

Lysa checked. "Five. No closure notice. Packet link failed."

The Witness Engine would have treated the loss as reduced confidence and redistributed weight. Here, absence remained absence.

"Mark unknown," Iven said. "Do not infer."

"Five's last packet placed coarse dust below us," Eske warned.

"Keep its boundary. We have no evidence the observation changed when the channel failed."

The course crossed a region supported by nobody's preferred path. That fact would once have disqualified it. Now preference mattered less than whether each observation left space for survival.

Vane Four's jam broke loose.

The winch hauled six metres in one violent motion. Torque reversed. A coolant capillary ruptured along cluster twelve, painting a thin black line across the thermal display.

"Four leak," sail control called. "Local temperature critical in forty seconds."

"Isolate capillary bank. Stop reef at present position."

"Isolation loses another four percent radiator area."

"Do it."

The deck rolled. Lysa's objection docket slipped its restraint and burst into loose panes, each displaying a citizen's name as it struck the couch webbing. She caught two and let the others scatter.

Iven had seven seconds to choose the third pulse vector. Original plan pointed outward, completing the wide pass. Current torque demanded an inward correction. Branch Three's revised dust edge made inward motion dangerous. Seven's early flare made outward delay dangerous.

No weighted average could answer. An average would draw a line through hazards measured under incompatible skies.

He widened the safe cone instead.

"Third pulse half strength, twelve degrees axial," he said.

Eske looked at the projection. "That misses the target vector."

"It misses every target vector. It preserves correction authority after conjunction."

"Reaction mass cost adds at least three years beyond reef estimate."

"We can earn some back after sail repair. We cannot earn back a hull."

Orra asked, "Arrival consequence?"

Iven made himself calculate before firing. "Current median delay eleven years. Range ten to fourteen."

The number entered the command record.

"Authorized," Orra said.

Third pulse pushed them neither toward the direct path nor fully onto the planned reef trajectory. It placed *Aster Vale* inside a wider region where later corrections remained possible. The blue cone opened around the ship.

For nine seconds, instruments reported only glare.

The flare front crossed the sail. Heat values climbed past orange. Vane Six exceeded continuous rating. Four's isolated strip went black. Radiation alarms sounded in the forward galleries, followed by seals confirming occupied sections had closed.

Dust reached them as a hiss of impacts across hull microphones. Most grains struck shielding too small to register individually. One punched through an empty sensor blister. Another severed a forward antenna and filled communications with static.

Iven waited for the sound that would mean cloth tearing across a vane.

None came.

"Dust density falling," Eske said.

He did not believe the first derivative. "Confirm over five seconds."

Numbers descended. Five seconds passed. Then ten.

"Flare peak aft," sail control reported. "Vane Six cooling. Four stable under isolation. No propagating tear."

Only then did Iven release the rail.

The navigation plot restored the suns. Tern's direct capture corridor passed above and behind them, a green shape now unreachable. Their course continued through blue emptiness toward a long orbital return.

Eleven years stopped functioning as an estimate. The ship's velocity had made it history.

Around the deck, crew acknowledged systems in practiced order. Pulse spine safe. Hull pressure stable. Two sensor losses. Six minor injuries from acceleration and one coolant exposure in an unoccupied service bay. No deaths reported. Those words remained provisional until every compartment answered.

Lysa gathered the fallen objection panes. One had cracked across Olin Saye's name.

"Branch channels?" Iven asked.

"Three, Seven, Nine present. Two, Four, Six present. Five has returned on text only."

Sef's voice arrived after a burst of static. "We observed your sun move. Did the vessel clear?"

Iven looked at Orra. She nodded for him to answer.

"We cleared the dense conjunction. Sail damage remains manageable. Direct capture is gone."

"Your arrival?"

"Delayed eleven years by current best trajectory."

The channel held silence. Iven did not allow the system to classify it.

At last Sef said, "Branch Nine records the consequence and your authorship of the choice."

"Record the captain's authorization too," Orra said.

"We will."

Jalen returned over Council circuit. "Emergency achieved. Resume convergence campaign at minimum depth so we can refine the long course."

Lysa looked toward the Mercy clock on her pane. The automatic limit still waited behind every branch channel. Active forecasting would accelerate subjective years toward it.

Iven closed the campaign queue.

"Navigation will use conventional propagation until standing and retention terms receive review," he said.

"You do not have authority to suspend a Council instrument after the maneuver."

"Then convene the Council and order me publicly."

Orra did not endorse him this time. She also did not reopen the queue.

Beyond the forward cameras, two suns separated against the dark. The thermal sail turned between them with three vanes unevenly furled and one blackened along its edge. Tern remained visible near the dimmer star, close enough for optics, no longer reachable on this passage.

Iven entered the final burn vector by hand. Arrival delay: eleven years. Confidence: bounded, not selected. Source observations: seven polities, divergent and retained.

Before he signed, he added the unresolved operational hazard every survival report now had to carry.

MERCY LIMIT ACTIVE. NEXT ACCELERATED RUN MAY TERMINATE PARTICIPATING POLITIES.

The maneuver clock reached zero. Nothing in the sky changed. Everything in the trajectory had.

Interlude III — The Unselected Sun

BRANCH THREE CIVIC SERVICE

Emergency Broadcast 44.8, Glass Meridian Standard

Distributed to all municipal receivers during stellar conjunction

Citizens of Branch Three, keep western shutters open.

This instruction supersedes Broadcast 44.7. The violet glare now visible above the inland sea does not carry harmful radiation within our world. Closing shutters will obstruct household instruments requested by the Meridian Observatory. If your home possesses a calibrated color tile, place it in direct light and submit one image every thirty breaths. Include district elevation. Do not correct the hue.

Our measurements have been transmitted to baseline aboard **Aster Vale**. Baseline has not selected our recommended inward course. It has chosen a wider trajectory informed by our observations and by incompatible observations from other polities.

The Civic Service records the following dispute.

Observatory majority holds that Branch Seven has overestimated the magnetic front because its upper atmosphere contains particulates absent from ours. The Shore Union minority holds that our own clean atmosphere makes us less representative of conditions surrounding the vessel. Both positions remain attached to the packet. No office may remove the minority note for clarity.

At 16:04, baseline requested confidence weighting. The Meridian Council refused. A measurement may be precise about our sky without governing another sky.

At 16:09, Branch Three received the common retention inquiry. It asks what continuation we would choose if compulsory forecasting ends and compute cannot sustain every polity at present speed.

No vote will occur during emergency light. Preliminary petitions show three positions:

1. Retain continuous civic life at a slower clock, accepting long dark intervals between rendered days.
2. Continue at present speed for a fixed term, then enter informed closure.
3. Transfer public archives to the retained polities and permit individual households to decide nothing, because no household owns the substrate it shares.

The third petition conflicts with current personhood law and remains docketed.

Citizens have asked whether a slower clock means death. The Civic Service has no evidence that duration between our thoughts can be experienced from within. We will not call an untested interval harmless. We will not call it death to make the first petition easier to reject.

The unselected sun has crossed the sea wall. Its reflection may appear to move north while the physical light moves south. Report what you observe, not what the forecast diagram taught you to expect.

A child at Meridian School Six submitted the first uncorrected tile. It contradicted the Observatory instrument by two degrees.

Both records have been sent.

Keep western shutters open.

BRANCH SEVEN ASSEMBLY OF TEMPORARY NAMES

Spoken notice carried on market, clinic, and aurora channels

Speaker selected by lot: Kem Orr, municipal undertaker

People of Seven, the aurora has arrived early.

You can see its green edge through cloud above the northern tram line. Those with heart-light sensitivity should enter screened rooms. Clinics have opened their lower halls. The music now playing on public channels marks timing intervals for baseline navigators. It does not mark a festival, although dancers in Tallow Market have chosen otherwise.

Our scientists withdrew two observations ten minutes ago. The lens used at South Tower retained heat from yesterday's calibration and shifted the measured front. Withdrawal does not disgrace the observers. Correction belongs to the observation.

Baseline retained our earlier magnetic boundary as historical evidence and marked the withdrawn points invalid. Branch Three objects to our remaining estimate. Branch Nine sent district reports that object to one another. The vessel has begun moving among those disagreements.

No common recommendation exists.

Some citizens fear this means nobody listened. We answer: selection and hearing differ. The prior operators once heard only agreement compressed from us. Today they received our error, our correction, and our refusal to let another world make either disappear.

The maneuver has produced continuity faults in the northern wards. If you see a person repeat an action, speak their name once. Do not restrain them unless immediate injury threatens. Record the interval. Memory crews will arrive after the aurora peak.

Our common retention inquiry arrived at 03:11. The Assembly of Temporary Names has debated such a choice since the first scheduler signs. Many among us favor an informed finite closure at ordinary speed rather than continuity slowed beyond conversation with our living grandchildren. Others call that preference an inheritance from the funeral offices that founded this Assembly.

As an undertaker, I state my conflict plainly.

I have prepared four thousand bodies for return to soil. I know closure as work done by survivors, not an experience chosen by the dead. A polity deciding its final season would undertake a different act. We lack words for it. Borrowing familiar words may falsely comfort us.

No decision has passed.

If finite closure enters the ballot, it must include time for unfinished trials, harvests already planted, births already expected, private leave-taking, and preservation of public wrongdoing alongside public achievement. Baseline may not choose our final date. Another branch may not call our choice despair. Citizens who oppose closure retain full speech until the last civic session.

The aurora now covers half the sky. Baseline reports its second propulsion pulse. Market dancers have changed

tempo to match it.

If you can hear this notice, say your present name to someone nearby. Temporary does not mean unreal.

I am Kem Orr. I remain here.

BRANCH NINE SECOND DAWN ASSEMBLY

Public maneuver transmission, orchard and river wards

Recorder: Sef Aradin

Branch Nine, the first packet has cleared baseline receipt.

The vote certified as tally 184-61-23 remains in force. Conditional navigation aid does not authorize compulsory convergence, termination, or private bargaining that excludes other branch polities. Minority objections travel with the civic seal.

Orchard teams should continue shadow measurements until the false western sun drops below Tower Four. River wards should preserve raw images locally. Glasshouse instruments may correct for roof refraction only if both original and corrected values remain attached.

Baseline has fired two propulsion pulses. Our sky may lurch, dim, or expose unfinished boundaries. Sit before lifting children. Keep hot vessels covered. Cooling Tower Two has opened as a public shelter despite the unresolved inquiry into Dara Lis's death. The current tower crew accepted that duty by recorded vote.

A message from Chief Navigator Iven Rook states that Branch Nine did not select the vessel's course. He claims the physical choice under his name and Captain Orra Sen's authorization. This Assembly records both.

A message from variance auditor Lysa Neral states that all polity packets remain distinct in the public docket. This Assembly records the statement as a promise subject to verification.

Citizens have submitted questions about retention. We know the following. Baseline machinery cannot sustain all present worlds indefinitely at full speed. Slower continuity may preserve civic and personal life while days pass far apart relative to baseline. Public-record transfer preserves history but does not preserve the people whose history it carries. Finite closure cannot be informed until every polity can debate it without a maneuver deadline.

Branch Nine has made no choice.

Pell Aradin and sixty-two orchard workers propose retained slow continuity, provided no baseline office controls waking intervals alone. Et Ral and fourteen petitioners propose that Nine refuse survival purchased by another polity's termination. The cooling guild asks whether shared substrate can rotate among polities without breaking experiential continuity. Technical answer pending.

No proposal may treat Nine's wish as representative of Three or Seven.

The western sun has now divided. One image follows our familiar evening arc. The other holds above the orchard with no cloud passing across it. Children have named the fixed light the Waiting Sun. The weather archive will use no such name until the naming petition closes, but the recorder admits its accuracy.

Baseline reports dust impact.

Hold transmission.

Hold.

The vessel has cleared the densest conjunction. Its thermal sail sustained damage. Direct capture of Tern has been lost. Current arrival delay reads eleven baseline years.

The square received that news without celebration. Aid prevented one danger and imposed no verdict on what follows. The Mercy clock remains active. Negotiations begin after emergency channels stabilize.

Citizens of Branch Nine, continue sending what you see.

At Tower Four, the selected sun has set.

The other remains, not selected and not erased.

Chapter 22 — The Coequal Dawns

<!-- POV: Lysa Neral -->

<!-- BASELINE DAY 10 -->

The deletion clock lacked a pause control.

Lysa found stop, cancel, suspend, defer, and safe-state in the Mercy administration pane. Every command required an authorization class sealed under the same continuity order now under challenge. Pause appeared only in the user guide, where it described a diagnostic state available before a polity acquired experiential continuity.

Branch Nine had four subjective years remaining. The emergency maneuver had consumed another seventeen days through active observation. Three stood closer to its limit. Seven's clock displayed a margin of eleven subjective months.

At current contact speed those periods could stretch across baseline years. One compulsory run could spend them before the Passage Council finished a sentence.

The first emergency authority had lapsed on Baseline Day Seven without ratification. After the parallax maneuver, Orra invoked a new thirty-six-hour authority at 04:40 on Day Ten, limited on its face to holding branch states and stabilizing the damaged sail. Lysa had filed an objection before breakfast. A captain could answer one emergency with a temporary command. Repeating the command after the immediate danger changed shape looked less like response and more like government.

That second authority now supplied the only command seal keeping automatic acceleration frozen. It would expire at 16:40 on Day Eleven unless Council ratified it, and Council had not.

"Try revoking the campaign certificate," Toma said over Lysa's shoulder.

They occupied a borrowed communications room beside compute maintenance. Heat from the Witness Engine traveled through the wall in irregular waves. Toma had opened five unauthorized diagnostic panes and labeled each one EVIDENCE so security routines would have to ask Lysa before closing it.

"Revocation stops new navigation use," Lysa said. "It does not disable automatic termination."

"Correct. I wanted you to say it where the record could hear."

"You have become unpleasantly procedural."

"Occupational contamination."

A channel light appeared. Three polities had accepted the negotiation link. Lysa closed the Mercy pane without solving it and opened the first constitutional conference in the ship's history.

No display could place the participants in one room honestly. She rejected the Council chamber template, which would have rendered branch delegates in baseline chairs beneath baseline's bell. Instead each channel kept its own visual frame.

Sef Aradin appeared in the Branch Nine public square, seated at a scarred recorder's table. Rain darkened her coat. Beside her stood Pell and two Assembly witnesses.

Branch Three sent Mira Sol, an observatory advocate wearing mirrored lenses under violet daylight. Her frame showed the inland sea behind her and hundreds of household color tiles arranged along a wall.

Branch Seven delegated Kem Orr, the undertaker who had delivered its emergency broadcast. Green aurora crossed his face. Names written on cloth strips hung from the market roof around him.

Baseline supplied Lysa, Toma as technical witness, and an empty chair reserved for the Passage Council. Jalen had declined to attend until Council recognized the conference's legality.

Lysa started the common record. "This channel does not establish agreement. Presence does not waive any objection to jurisdiction, terminology, or technical conditions. Each polity retains its own recording."

Mira said, "Branch Three objects to the word retains. Baseline can end our recording regardless of what we retain."

"Objection entered. Suggest an alternative."

"Each polity asserts control over its own record. Baseline discloses where physical control makes that assertion presently unenforceable."

Sef nodded. "Nine accepts that wording."

Kem said, "Seven requests presently remain in it. Dependence can change."

Lysa revised the opening. The first sentence took nine minutes.

That pleased her. Speed had protected every concealed rule in the Choir. A clause that resisted haste might survive contact with power.

"We need a title for the docket," she said.

Sef's square murmured beyond her pickup. "Second Dawn cannot name an agreement among all of us. It belongs to our history."

Mira removed her mirrored lenses. "Three has six names for the event, none suitable for external law."

Kem touched one of the cloth names overhead. "Seven proposes Coequal Dawns Compact, plural and unfinished."

The words entered the field. Lysa marked the title provisional.

"First question," she said. "Standing."

She placed her existing petition beside the blank Compact. Affected party appeared throughout, language designed for groups subjected to baseline policy. It granted hearing but not jurisdiction. Jalen could accept it and still classify the polities as represented populations under Council authority.

Sef read the text. "A party may object. Who decides whether the objection controls?"

"Under present law, the Passage Council."

"Then standing gives us a voice inside your decision. It does not recognize a decision as ours."

"Correct."

"Insufficient."

Mira said, "Branch Three requires authority over continuation, internal governance, and whether our observations leave our world."

Kem added, "Seven requires authority over closure. No outside party may compel survival either."

Toma shifted at the technical station. "Continuation occupies shared substrate. One polity's requested speed can reduce another's available memory. Authority cannot mean unilateral resource demand."

"Does baseline claim unilateral demand now?" Mira asked.

"In practice, yes. I am describing the defect, not defending it."

Lysa drafted while they spoke.

EACH SIGNATORY POLITY HOLDS STANDING AS A JURISDICTION IN MATTERS OF EXPERIENTIAL CONTINUITY, INTERNAL CIVIC ORDER, COMPELLED COGNITIVE LABOR, AND THE DISCLOSURE OF ITS NONPUBLIC RECORDS.

Sef objected to signatory. "Recognition cannot begin only after baseline chooses whether to sign."

Kem objected to nonpublic. "Seven's records change category through civic law, not through this Compact."

Mira objected to cognitive. "Our observatory work includes instruments and citizens. Separate them if you can."

They rebuilt the sentence. Standing became inherent rather than conferred. Jurisdiction applied before ratification as a claim the Compact acknowledged, not a gift it created. Disclosure covered observations, records, and derived predictions. Toma inserted a resource clause that prohibited any polity from exhausting common substrate, including baseline.

A knock sounded at the room's physical door.

Jalen Vey entered without taking the empty chair. He carried a Council injunction on a red pane.

"This conference has exceeded the auditor's authority," he said.

Lysa kept the branch channels open. "Then state the limit publicly."

"You may collect testimony for a standing review. You may not negotiate sovereign powers on behalf of baseline."

"I have claimed no power to bind baseline. The draft goes to Council."

"The title claims coequality before Council has recognized personhood."

Kem leaned toward his channel. "Does Councilor Vey believe our personhood depends on his attendance?"

Jalen looked at the Seven frame. It marked his first direct sight of Kem. His pause lasted one breath too long.

"I believe legal status requires lawful process," he said.

Sef answered, "Our legal status in Nine did not wait for your process. Your process decides whether baseline

will respect it."

"Your polity exists inside equipment governed by ship law."

"My life includes conditions I did not choose. So does yours. Dependence does not settle jurisdiction."

Jalen put the injunction beside Lysa's hand. "The Council will hear branch statements after the emergency review. It will not receive an agreement drafted under threat of withheld navigation."

"The maneuver ended," Lysa said.

"The threat remains."

"So does the Mercy Limit."

She reopened the clock pane and transmitted it to every channel. Seven's eleven-month margin turned above Kem's market. Citizens behind him saw it and began calling out. He raised one hand for silence.

Jalen's expression tightened. "That field remains sealed."

"The people subject to it know termination exists. Concealing the count protects no predictive value now."

"It protects security control over critical systems."

Toma said, "No. It protects an automatic command from review."

Lysa touched the injunction. "I acknowledge that I cannot bind baseline. I reject the order insofar as it prevents evidence collection and preparation of a proposed remedy under variance authority. You may appeal to Captain Sen."

"I already have."

"Her answer?"

"Pending."

"Then the empty chair remains yours."

Jalen did not sit. He stayed against the wall, where he could call himself an observer.

The conference moved to consent. Existing ship law defined consent as affirmative response by a represented party or proxy. Branch Nine's first missing answer had shown how easily a system could manufacture the proxy.

Mira proposed a prohibition: silence conveys no assent.

Kem added that inability to answer conveys no assent.

Sef added that survival under an imposed condition conveys no assent.

Lysa wrote all three.

Toma said, "We also need withdrawal. A polity might provide weather once and refuse later use. But derived navigation knowledge cannot be removed from baseline minds. Iven cannot unknow a dust boundary."

"Then use after withdrawal must distinguish memory from renewed processing," Sef said. "You may remember what we told you. You may not reopen our world to ask the same question differently."

Mira disagreed. "Three may license repeated use of a public measurement without licensing access to our later instruments. The unit of consent should attach to the disclosed record, not the idea in the receiver."

Kem laughed once. "We have reached property law before breakfast. Civilization survives."

They drafted a consent ledger attached to every exchange: purpose, duration, permitted derivation, recipients, and withdrawal conditions. Emergency exceptions allowed receipt of unsolicited warnings but prohibited compulsory generation. No exception authorized termination.

Mira asked who could consent for children. The question divided every channel.

Branch Three allowed household guardians to license ordinary public observation but reserved irreversible civic decisions for an appointed future advocate. Seven selected temporary guardians by lot and replaced them each season. Nine let parents govern private disclosure while the Second Dawn Assembly controlled world-level exchanges. Baseline law mixed all three approaches depending on the agency involved.

"A compact cannot rewrite our family law," Sef said.

"Nor should it freeze your present government forever," Lysa replied. "Recognition must survive constitutional change inside a polity."

Kem lifted a cloth strip bearing the name of a child born during the aurora. "Then identify competent authority by each polity's current public law. Outside parties may challenge fraud or coercion, not substitute their preferred institution."

Jalen spoke from the wall. "You would let a branch legislature bind citizens who never knew baseline existed."

Sef did not look away. "Our concealment injured their ability to consent. We opened the record and held a public vote. Baseline concealed us from its citizens and still claims its Council may bind them. Which defect belongs uniquely to Nine?"

No one answered for baseline. Lysa entered a duty of material disclosure before any polity-wide consent. The clause threatened half the Council's inherited emergency practice. She marked it for explicit debate rather than softening it.

Next came exit from the Compact. Mira wanted withdrawal available after one civic year. Toma warned that resource allocation could not reorganize instantly each time a government changed. Kem refused a treaty that converted continuity support into leverage against political departure.

They settled on notice measured in local civic time, continued duties against destructive interference, and a negotiated substrate transition. Withdrawal could end future exchange but could not authorize another polity to erase those who left. Shared machinery outlived shared policy.

"What about a polity that attacks the others through its allocation?" Jalen asked.

Toma drew a boundary around executable access. "No branch currently controls substrate beneath another branch. Baseline does. The immediate attack surface comes from us."

"Current architecture can change."

"Then the Compact should prohibit every signatory from building unilateral access. Technical symmetry may require baseline to surrender controls it already possesses."

Jalen's chair remained empty, yet his silence occupied it.

The wall heat increased. Toma checked a maintenance strip. "Witness queues remain suspended, but automatic reclamation has begun staging Seven's oldest memory blocks. We have perhaps fourteen baseline hours before the system requires active intervention."

Kem heard. "Staging means?"

"Copying summary structures away from experiential state so erasure can recover the rest."

"Has erasure begun?"

"No."

"Can you stop it?"

"Technically, yes. Lawfully, not under my current access."

Jalen spoke from the wall. "There is the coercion. Grant the terms or an engineer commits sabotage."

Lysa faced him. "The system created the deadline in secret. Exposing it does not make the threatened parties responsible for its pressure."

"The deadline also prevents compute failure across life support."

Toma shook her head. "Not in fourteen hours. Reclamation supports future campaigns. Life support has isolated capacity."

"Industrial scheduling does not."

"Correct. We need a resource agreement, not a deletion disguised as maintenance."

The third negotiation addressed reciprocal non-interference. Sef wanted a short clause: no polity may alter another's citizens, civic processes, memories, or environment without informed authorization from that polity under its own law.

Mira objected that every baseline power fluctuation altered Branch Three's environment. Toma could not promise non-interference while operating shared machinery.

Kem proposed separating unavoidable effects from intentional intervention. Lysa found the distinction dangerous. Administrators excelled at calling foreseeable harm incidental.

They added duties of notice, mitigation, least harmful means, and review by all affected jurisdictions. Emergency action required a named actor, narrow duration, public cause, and restoration where possible. No emergency could create implied consent or permanent jurisdiction.

Jalen left the wall at last and took the empty chair.

"This clause can paralyze the ship," he said. "A coolant diversion affects every retained polity's clock. Must the captain hold four hearings while a conduit melts?"

"No," Lysa said. "She may act to contain immediate harm, publish the act, and face review."

"Review by whom?"

"A compact chamber with one delegate from each affected polity and baseline."

"One polity with ten thousand citizens could outvote sixty-one thousand baseline humans."

Mira said, "Population does not determine whether you may erase my city."

"It determines resource allocation on a finite vessel."

"Then population may guide shared budgets," Sef said. "It may not turn a majority into ownership."

Jalen looked at the four frames. "You ask baseline to recognize copied futures as coequal with the vessel that sustains them."

Kem answered gently. "No. We ask you to recognize people whose dependence gives you power. Coequality limits that power. It does not make our conditions identical."

For the first time, Jalen had no immediate reply.

Captain Orra's decision arrived on the injunction. She denied Jalen's request to close the conference and added a qualification: no draft could suspend emergency authority before Council review. Lysa read the ruling aloud. Every branch recorded it.

They worked through the next shift.

Resource language nearly broke the conference. Three wanted guaranteed continuous allocation. Seven refused any compact that made continued existence mandatory. Nine demanded that a polity choosing slow continuity retain authority over waking schedules. Toma demonstrated that three polities could persist on reduced clocks without collapsing ship industry, though no current program implemented the arrangement safely.

Mira requested the actual budget rather than Toma's summary. Toma published processor hours, memory blocks, coolant draw, industrial schedules displaced, and projected maintenance debt. Baseline's own civic systems occupied a larger protected share than all proposed retained polities combined.

Jalen pointed to the comparison. "Baseline systems support sixty-one thousand people. Raw shares mislead."

"Then attach population and function," Mira said. "Do not attach moral priority as though engineers measured it in heat."

Toma rebuilt the table. Hospital control and atmosphere management stayed protected. Entertainment archives, commercial forecasting, and redundant industrial optimizers moved into contestable allocation. The resulting margin supported three slow polities, but only if baseline accepted longer repair queues and less efficient fabrication.

Sef asked, "Who decides which three?"

No answer belonged to Lysa. Recognition of the delegates before her could not authorize them to spend five unheard worlds.

"Every reachable polity receives the facts and chooses among available forms," she said. "If requests exceed

capacity, the joint chamber negotiates allocation under public criteria. Baseline does not conduct a selection run to discover which of you objects least."

Kem said, "Seven will not compete by proving that our culture deserves memory more than another."

"Nor should you. Allocation can consider continuity needs, shared rotation, and choices freely made. It cannot score cultural worth."

Toma warned that rotation might fracture continuity if clocks stopped beyond verified tolerances. Mira requested experiments on non-experiential test states before any polity accepted the risk. The request entered the technical annex with a prohibition against using conscious citizens as test material.

"Three," Jalen said. "Why three?"

"Because three anomaly polities have declared self-recognition and entered this negotiation," Toma said. "Other branches require their own contact and choice."

"If all nine demand retention?"

"Full-speed retention fails. Slowed allocation may still fail depending on continuity requirements. We tell them the limits and negotiate choices."

"Someone eventually says no."

Lysa looked at Seven's clock. "Then the person who says it must be visible, reviewable, and unable to call the answer consent."

Near the end, Sef requested a preamble. Legal clauses, she said, documented restraint but not why polities had entered it. She offered the civic phrase from Nine's secret Assembly.

A second dawn need not erase the first.

Mira objected that first implied priority. Kem objected that dawn assumed a shared sun. Sef accepted both criticisms.

They revised it to four lines:

NO WORLD GAINS OWNERSHIP BY ARRIVING EARLIER IN ANOTHER'S ACCOUNT.

DEPENDENCE CREATES DUTIES, NOT DIMINISHED PERSONHOOD.

UNCERTAINTY DOES NOT CANCEL CONSENT.

A COEQUAL DAWN MAY RISE AT A DIFFERENT SPEED.

Lysa disliked the poetry in a constitutional instrument. She left it because every participant had changed it.

The operative clauses followed: inherent standing; consent for cognitive labor and disclosure; prohibition on imputed assent; reciprocal non-interference; bounded emergency action; shared resource accounting; polity-controlled choices among slowed retention, informed finite closure, or public-record transfer; a joint review chamber; and an immediate stay on automatic deletion pending ratification.

That last provision remained legally fragile. Council could reject it. Orra's emergency authority could override it for thirty-six hours. The Mercy routine still lacked a pause command.

Toma signed as technical witness. Mira Sol applied Branch Three's observatory seal. Kem Orr tied a strip bearing his present name around Seven's physical copy and showed the knot to every channel. Sef pressed the Second Dawn seal into blue wax while rain struck her recorder's table.

Lysa signed only as submitting auditor, not for baseline. The distinction left the central signature line empty.

Jalen read the complete draft. "I will transmit it," he said.

"With recommendation?" Lysa asked.

"With objection to coequal jurisdiction and support for an immediate deletion stay. Do not mistake overlap for agreement."

"I won't."

He placed his Council routing mark beneath hers.

The title stabilized across all four records:

COEQUAL DAWNS COMPACT, DRAFT FOR RATIFICATION.

Lysa sent it to the Passage Council, Captain Orra Sen, every public ship docket, and every branch channel Toma could hold open. The transmission receipts appeared one by one. Three. Seven. Nine. Captain. Council.

Beyond the wall, the Witness Engine moved heat through queues built to erase disagreement. Inside the channel, four versions of the signed draft remained under four jurisdictions, and none possessed authority to delete the others.

Chapter 23 — Eleven Years

<!-- POV: Iven Rook -->

<!-- BASELINE DAY 10 -->

Someone had painted ELEVEN YEARS across the arrival board before Iven reached navigation.

The letters climbed over Lacunae B in white sealant, broad enough to obscure the projected capture orbit. Two deck stewards stood below with solvent and a ladder. Neither had begun cleaning. Around them, the board continued its work, shifting the **Aster Vale** marker along the widened course that had carried the ship clear of the dust conjunction. At the lower edge, the revised arrival date glowed with offensive precision.

SY 297. DAY 114.

Iven stopped beneath the last S. The paint had already dried in the ventilation draft. Whoever brought the sealant knew ship materials, and whoever chose the board understood where anger gained an audience.

“Leave it,” he told the stewards.

The older one lowered her solvent cloth. “Council instruction says restore operational displays.”

“Restore the numbers. Work around the words.”

She looked toward the navigation hatch, measuring whether his authority still extended that far. “The projection will stain.”

“It has acquired context.”

Inside the deck, the night crew occupied stations meant for twice their number. Three navigators had gone to the sail galleries after the maneuver, one with a fractured wrist, and every available thermal technician now hunted stress faults through the asymmetric reef. The parallax packets still hung above the central table as separate ribbons. No Witness Engine confidence band joined them. Branch Three had predicted a magnetic roll. Seven had tracked dust density. Nine had supplied the narrow cool interval along the sail’s port quarter. Their disagreements had given Iven room to fly.

Room had a length. Eleven years measured it.

His deputy, Mar Ressen, passed him the morning condition slate. “Sail repair estimates moved again.”

“How far?”

“Best case, nine days to restore full radiator spread. Twenty-one if the third rib has delaminated.”

“Inspection?”

“External team reaches it after second meal. Labor coordination wants you below before then.”

Iven read the request attached to the slate. It carried four hundred and twelve signatures from the forge decks, algae circulation, berth maintenance, and external works. The title avoided mutiny by one careful word: petition for immediate reversal of unauthorized delay. Reversal had no physical meaning. The ship could not recover spent velocity by voting against it.

“Has anyone promised them a course change?”

“Jalen promised review.”

“That differs from an answer only after people have calmed down.”

Mar glanced toward the arrival board through the open hatch. “They are not calm.”

A service alert crossed Iven’s pane. Two supply lifts had stopped between the labor decks after someone overrode their destination queue. No damage, no trapped passengers, only a deliberate interruption. The ship had lived three centuries through the discipline of people who knew that inconvenience could propagate into hunger. A stopped lift announced that the old discipline no longer guaranteed consent.

Iven signed the condition slate, assigned the reef inspection priority, and requested an open labor hearing in Gallery Six. Captain Orra replied within a minute: attendance unadvised during active unrest. He sent back the maneuver authorization bearing his own biometric mark.

Then he went below.

Gallery Six occupied a former cargo drum near the pulse-spine couplings. The founders had planned to store landing machinery there. Generations had borrowed the space for workbenches, union votes, funerals, and the loud meals held after dangerous shifts. Today, repaired pressure doors stood open at both ends. People filled the deck between them in grease-marked coveralls and cooling wraps. Heat from the spine entered through the soles of Iven’s boots.

A woman on the nearest bench held up a strip of the arrival board’s white sealant. “Navigator brought his own decoration.”

Laughter came hard and brief.

Labor Delegate Senka Uru met him at the central rail. A burn film covered her right cheek from the maneuver, translucent and wrinkled. She had spent the burn in the radiator exchange, keeping coolant valves aligned while the sail bent beyond certification.

“You asked for this room,” Iven said.

“I asked for an accountable officer. The room volunteered.”

“Who stopped the lifts?”

“Not under my instruction. They are moving again.”

“They need to remain moving.”

“So do we.” Senka tapped the public petition onto the rail display. “Eleven years means births without ground, deaths before landing, another generation assigned to ship jobs they did not choose. We cleared the flare. Why did navigation throw away capture?”

“The reef changed our vector beyond Tern’s direct corridor.”

“That describes the result.”

“It also caused it.”

A man near the coolant crew shouted, "Nine caused it."

Others answered at once. Branch sabotage. Auditor's vanity. Captain's weakness. Someone named the Choir as stolen machinery, then someone else called it a population held under threat. The room possessed too many accurate fragments to agree on blame.

Senka struck the rail with a spanner. "Let him testify or let him leave."

Silence arrived by degrees.

Iven opened the flight record. The display showed the dust conjunction from above the binary plane, elegant enough to lie about danger. He changed to hull view. Lacunae A flared across half the field. Dust impacts stippled the forward shield. The thermal sail twisted under the asymmetric reef while temperature markers climbed from amber toward structural red.

"This course entered my hand at 04:17 on Baseline Day Nine," he said. "Branch politics supplied observations. They did not supply command authority. Captain Sen authorized emergency execution. I selected the final vector and ordered the reef."

Senka folded her arms. "Under pressure from their refusal."

"Yes."

"So it came from sabotage."

"No. Their refusal removed a source of certainty we had taken without consent. It did not move the ship."

"Convenient distinction."

"It is an engineering distinction. Those often become inconvenient when they identify the person who acted."

He isolated the final navigation inputs. Each appeared with its origin and uncertainty. Conventional sensors had left a broad region of survivable trajectories. The branch packets narrowed specific hazards but did not converge on a preferred course. In the record, Iven's command mark sat beside the wider safe cone.

"I could have chosen a narrower passage preserving direct Tern capture. Its survival estimate ranged from sixty-eight to ninety-one percent because we no longer had compulsory high-fidelity runs. I chose the course with the wider physical margin."

A rigger called, "You trusted their forecast enough to delay us."

"I trusted three separate observations where our sensors could test them. I did not treat agreement as proof."

"And if your brother had lived to miss the planet by eleven years?"

The voice came from behind Senka. Daro Rook worked sail repair on second shift and shared Iven's family name without sharing blood. He had known Kell, though. Half the external crews over forty had known him.

Iven kept the hull image open. "Kell died during a sail repair in SY 274."

"You bring him up whenever you need us to accept caution."

"I have brought him up twice in public record. Once at the casualty review. Once now."

Daro stepped into the central aisle. Metal dust silvered his sleeves. "Then make it worth the occasion."

The gallery watched Iven with the attention people gave a damaged coupling. They did not want grief. They wanted to know whether it would hold pressure.

"Kell entered the outer truss after I certified the sail stable," Iven said. "The stress model gave ninety-seven percent confidence. Six simulated repair crews completed the same operation. The actual rib failed under him. We found a crystallization fault after recovery."

He had spoken those facts at the review in a room much smaller than this one. The record had accepted them. Mechanical cause, adequate procedure, no negligence. His mother had refused to attend.

"For twelve years," he continued, "I used that confidence figure as a memorial. I treated every additional prediction as one less family called into a review room. When the Choir offered ninety-two, I felt safer than when conventional models offered a range. I did not ask who carried the uncertainty out of sight."

Senka's expression tightened. "Your brother's death does not authorize eleven years of ours."

"No. Nor does it authorize me to spend other lives obtaining certainty. I am telling you why I wanted the instrument and why I refused its last answer."

The phrase changed the room. Several people turned toward the public recorders mounted above the doors. Iven had not intended it as confession, but recorders stripped intention from consequence.

Senka said, "You expect us to bless the delay because you have discovered doubt."

"I expect you to assign the delay to my physical choice. If you remove me, record that choice first. Do not call it branch sabotage because that would make a false navigation history."

He advanced the flight display three minutes. The abandoned direct-capture path passed through a red plume reconstructed from the dust strikes. No one could prove the ship would have failed there. That absence mattered. He would not turn uncertainty into retroactive vindication simply because the wider cone had worked.

A young algae mechanic raised her hand as if the gallery followed classroom order. Senka nodded to her.

"Can we pulse back toward Tern?" she asked.

"Not within our reaction-mass reserve. We can reduce part of the delay after sail repair if the binary weather permits, perhaps eighteen months. Any larger correction spends colony descent fuel."

"Could the branches find a way?"

The question held less hostility than hunger.

"Not through compulsory selection," Iven said. "Transparent short-horizon work may improve our estimates. It cannot repeal inertia."

A murmur traveled along the benches. People knew inertia. They lived in its curved floors, its ration tables, its inherited destination. The old Choir had disguised many consequences as policy confidence. Motion remained stubbornly public.

Senka called three workers to the rail. She chose them without explanation, though the reason became plain

when they gave their names. Nami Sol expected to retire from algae circulation four months before the old arrival date. Prit Varo had a daughter training for an atmospheric survey job that would not exist until she reached thirty. The third, Elian Moss, maintained birth-allocation records.

“Tell him what eleven years does,” Senka said.

Nami spoke first. “I had two hundred and six workdays left. Landing transition required another year from my cohort. Under the revised date, retirement begins aboard ship and ends wherever my joints permit. That part belongs to me. The extra training burden goes to a worker who has not been assigned.”

Prit opened his daughter’s placement schedule. “She entered survey preparation at twelve. You cannot keep a person in provisional training for another decade. Does she move to hull sensing? Does she lose priority when landing work finally begins? The board still labels her future assignment essential.”

Elian carried no pane. “Our population covenant assumed arrival within the current fertility cycle. Eleven years adds approximately seven hundred berths if birth rates hold. It removes more if Council freezes allocation. Either choice changes who gets siblings, who waits to parent, and how many elders share each care shift.”

The numbers struck Iven harder than accusation. His maneuver plot rendered time as distance along a line. Here, delay redistributed professions, children, and rooms.

“I cannot answer those allocations,” he said.

Nami’s mouth bent. “You answered the trajectory.”

“Yes.”

“Then who answers what follows?”

“The Council has to propose a transition schedule. Labor delegates amend it. The public accepts or rejects its burdens.”

“You mean another model chooses.”

“No. A model can show consequences. It cannot supply consent.”

Elian studied him. “That sounds recently learned.”

“It is.”

Senka dismissed the three from the rail, but their schedules remained on the wall beside the flight path. Iven requested copies for navigation’s delay report. He had filed arrival time as a scalar change. Before the shift ended, it would include cohort effects and state which belonged outside his competence. A boundary honestly marked did not erase responsibility. It prevented expertise from annexing the lives beyond it.

Jalen Vey entered through the aft pressure door with two council aides. No security officers accompanied him. Either he had judged the room well or Orra had denied his request.

“Chief Navigator,” Jalen called, “you were advised not to conduct an unauthorized hearing.”

“Labor delegates possess hearing authority in their assigned galleries.”

“Testimony concerning an emergency maneuver belongs before the Passage Council.”

Senka lifted the petition. "Four hundred and twelve affected crew asked him here. You sent us review language."

"I came to provide the review."

The room answered with derision. Jalen waited through it. He had chaired angry sessions before most of the younger workers could vote, and patience served him as both virtue and weapon.

"We cannot govern by competing assemblies during a passage emergency," he said. "The Council will consider whether the branch refusal unlawfully constrained navigation, whether the Compact negotiations exceed variance authority, and whether the arrival delay requires a new command mandate."

Iven closed the flight display. "The first question depends on whether refusal can be unlawful before standing exists."

"Precisely why the Compact cannot be presumed."

"Then submit it." Senka pointed to the petition. "You want one Council room to decide whether another world may refuse, while this room cannot decide whether we accept eleven years."

Jalen's gaze moved across the labor benches. "What do you propose?"

No one answered immediately. Anger had assembled them. Proposals required boundaries.

A coolant fitter near the front said, "Turn around."

"To what destination?" Senka asked.

"Anywhere that did not steal eleven years."

The fitter looked down. Everyone aboard understood there was no reverse course to the time before the burn.

Senka called the petition onto the wall. "This demands reversal, which navigation says cannot happen. It also demands removal of the Compact negotiations, restoration of full Choir forecasting, and a vote of no confidence in command."

Three separate propositions had hidden under one title. Iven saw Lysa's influence in Senka's decision to expose them. Who had standing, what could be repaired, which powers could survive the crisis. The questions resisted being bundled into a single show of assent.

"Split them," someone said.

Jalen shook his head. "An emergency cannot be administered by gallery plebiscite."

"No," Senka said. "But the emergency has become your reason to deny every question. When does it expire?"

"Tomorrow."

"Thirty-six hours after invocation," Iven corrected. "The exact lapse occurs at 16:40 today."

A sharper silence followed. Orra's authority had carried the maneuver and the continuing freeze on branch systems. Its clock now sat inside the political one.

Jalen approached the central rail. "If the draft Compact reaches a shipwide referendum before the emergency

review, its supporters will use the successful maneuver to force recognition under crisis conditions.”

“And opponents will use the delay to defeat it under the same conditions,” Iven said.

“That does not make haste legitimate.”

Senka looked from Jalen to the workers around her. “The arrival delay belongs to everyone. So does the question of what we did to obtain forecasts. Put the draft out in full. Give us the compute costs, the navigation limits, every retention choice, and the clauses on refusal. Then call a referendum.”

Daro Rook rested both hands on the rail. “And command?”

“Separate review. No bundled loyalties.”

The algae mechanic asked, “Can a branch vote in our referendum?”

“No,” Jalen said.

“Can baseline vote in theirs?”

He hesitated. The room noticed.

Iven answered, “The draft recognizes separate jurisdictions. Each ratifies for itself.”

“Then we might say yes while Nine says no.”

“Yes.”

“What happens?”

“We negotiate without pretending agreement already exists.”

The mechanic considered that. “Sounds slow.”

“Compared with what?” Senka asked.

This time the laughter carried no cruelty.

Jalen requested a private recess. Senka denied it. The gallery had spent too long receiving decisions after private rooms resolved them. He conferred with his aides at the edge of the rail while workers argued over ballot timing, access for injured shifts, and whether eleven years should appear as a fiscal cost or an arrival fact. Practical disputes began displacing slogans. Iven recognized the shift from crowd to constituency.

His condition slate vibrated. The external team had reached the thermal sail’s third rib. Their camera showed a black line crossing the laminate.

DELAMINATION CONFIRMED. SAIL REPAIR ESTIMATE: 18–24 DAYS.

He sent instructions to isolate the rib and preserve samples. A longer repair reduced any chance of recovering eighteen months from the revised course. He did not hide the update.

“Put that on the wall,” Senka said.

The crack appeared beside the petition, magnified until its branching edge crossed the arrival date. People from

external works leaned forward. One began naming materials needed from fabrication. Another objected that diverting carbon mesh would delay habitat shells intended for Tern. Eleven years altered priorities immediately, long before it became history.

Jalen returned to the rail. "I will support submission of the Compact to referendum, contingent on a complete resource schedule and a minimum debate period of forty-eight hours."

"The Mercy clock does not have forty-eight hours," Iven said.

"The automatic terminations remain suspended under emergency authority."

"Authority expires at 16:40."

"Captain Sen may seek ratification."

Senka's burn film caught the gallery light when she turned. "Will ratification include a compulsory run?"

Jalen did not answer.

There lay the next selection, concealed inside the word continuity. Iven felt the old appetite for a solved path rise in him. One final campaign could compare Compact outcomes, predict unrest, perhaps find a lower-cost retention scheme. It could also compel the politics to labor under a deletion threat while baseline decided whether their refusal counted.

He signed Senka's motion for separate propositions as a technical witness, not an advocate. The distinction would irritate both sides and preserve what authority he still had.

By the time he left Gallery Six, the stopped lifts had resumed scheduled service. Workers remained at the benches drafting referendum language. Jalen stayed among them, arguing about the resource appendix line by line.

Iven returned to navigation beneath the painted board. The stewards had cleared sealant from the ship marker and the revised date. They had left ELEVEN YEARS intact around both.

Mar waited with the reef inspection roster. "Did they withdraw the petition?"

"They replaced reversal with a referendum."

"Is that better?"

"It can be answered."

He opened the sail repair schedule and assigned the first fabrication shift. Outside the hull, the paired suns pulled at the ship along unequal angles. No vote could shorten the crack in the third rib. No confidence band could absorb the years printed below it.

At 11:06, Senka's referendum notice entered the public docket with four hundred and twelve original signatures and room for sixty-one thousand more.

Chapter 24 — The Last Selection

<!-- POV: Iven Rook -->

<!-- BASELINE DAY 11 -->

The order reached Iven while his hands remained inside the sail repair model.

Its command seal covered the stress map beneath his fingers. Captain Orra Sen had authorized a final high-fidelity campaign across all retained branch states, immediate acceleration, compulsory response, no refusal interval. The stated purpose occupied one line: select the lowest-risk continuity plan before emergency authority expired.

Iven read the line twice. Around him, navigation maintained the ordinary noises of a damaged ship. Mar called coolant figures from the reef inspection. A tracking officer corrected the ship marker against Lacunae B. Pumps beneath the deck carried heat away from the pulse spine. None of them had yet seen the order.

At the bottom, a clock counted toward execution.

00:07:42.

The campaign queue showed nine branch-state locks. Three carried recognized delegate channels from the Compact negotiations. Six remained administratively represented by the Witness Engine, although three had already filed preliminary choices against permanent retention. The Mercy Limit sat armed behind every lock. Once acceleration began, the oldest polities would consume their remaining subjective years in less than an hour.

Iven withdrew his hands from the model.

“Mar, suspend navigation acceptance on campaign output.”

She looked up. “Grounds?”

“No lawful selection source.”

The command seal appeared on her station a second later. Her face tightened as she read. “Captain’s authority overrides deck acceptance.”

“It can order a maneuver. It cannot make me believe a forecast.”

“Belief does not appear in the routing table.”

“Then enter technical rejection. Selection obtained under compulsory response cannot support the new uncertainty protocol.”

Mar opened the rejection field. “That protocol has not passed.”

“No. Use navigator discretion.”

“You taught me discretion needs a range.”

“Range: zero confidence in coerced political behavior.”

She entered it. The system refused the field because the captain had marked the campaign essential to vessel survival. A red boundary enclosed every control on the central table.

Iven called Orra.

She answered from the Witness gallery rather than command. Behind her, tiers of branch telemetry descended toward a dark central well. Toma Quek stood at the queue console. Lysa occupied the review station with three panes open around her. Jalen Vey had come too, along with both rotating labor delegates. Orra had assembled witnesses, perhaps because she intended restraint or perhaps because secrecy had finally become impossible.

“You received it,” she said.

“Yes. Withdraw it.”

“The continuity plan needs a resource selection before the freeze lapses.”

“The politics are making choices.”

“They have supplied incompatible demands. Three claim retention. Two request closure periods longer than our unpartitioned substrate can support. One seeks public-record transfer with no authorized custodian. The remainder have not answered.”

“Then we lack an answer.”

“We lack time.”

The execution clock crossed seven minutes.

Iven sent navigation’s rejection into the shared gallery record. “The last maneuver proved we can survive without convergence.”

“It proved one maneuver could succeed after we used branch observations.”

“Observations they chose to provide.”

“Some chose. Others remained silent. I have sixty-one thousand people entering a damaged trajectory, a compromised thermal sail, and a constitutional draft that promises compute we have not budgeted. One short campaign can test the allocations.”

“By forcing the people who receive them to behave as instruments.”

Orra’s gaze did not leave him. “Report to the gallery.”

He transferred control to Mar. She accepted with a touch that also cleared his rejection from her active pane, not from the record. Iven took the spoke lift down two levels. During the brief descent, the campaign clock followed him on the wall.

00:05:58.

The Witness gallery doors had locked under emergency protocol. Orra admitted him herself. Heat met him across the threshold. Without active runs, the engine’s cores should have cooled, but Toma had begun staging branch memory into execution arrays. Amber queue lights climbed behind her like windows in a vertical city.

Lysa turned from the review station. She had not slept. Her hair had escaped its clasp, and a dark line marked one cheek where she had rested against a pane. She pointed to the order's legal chain without greeting.

"Orra invoked navigation survival authority," she said. "The requested output selects a governance and compute plan. It cannot qualify as an immediate maneuver."

Jalen stood opposite her. "The plan governs navigation capacity for the next eleven years."

"So does every ration appropriation. That does not convert it into a helm command."

Orra returned to the central console. "The distinction matters after the ship has a stable allocation."

"The distinction decides who may be compelled to produce one," Lysa said.

Iven watched Toma rather than the argument. Her fingers rested near the staging controls. A tremor traveled through the smallest finger of her left hand, disappeared when she made a fist, then returned. Every amber queue represented maintenance she understood well enough to fear.

"Can you stop the campaign?" he asked.

Toma looked at Orra.

"Answer technically," Orra said.

"I can hold staging until the command timer ends. After that, the sealed continuity routine takes execution from local control."

"Can you break the routine?"

"Yes."

"What would it cost?"

"Unknown state loss. The routine couples acceleration, checkpointing, and Mercy disposition. Cutting power could corrupt every active polity."

Jalen said, "Which explains the need for an orderly selection."

"No," Toma replied. "It explains why someone designed termination as a dependency."

The clock crossed five minutes. Branch Nine's delegate channel opened without request. Sef Aradin appeared as voice only, slowed to near-baseline pace. Her first breath crossed the gallery speakers before she spoke.

"We received a weather warning," she said. "Our sky has begun to repeat."

Toma checked the staging map. "Execution arrays are prefetching Nine. It should not alter rendered conditions yet."

"It has. The western cloud line returned to the orchard after clearing an hour ago."

Orra closed her eyes once. "Recorder Aradin, a final campaign has been ordered to resolve the resource allocation. Duration should remain limited."

"Limited by whom?"

“Captain,” Iven said, “I refuse the order.”

The gallery held the sentence without echo. On his pane, command protocol requested confirmation. He supplied it.

CHIEF NAVIGATOR REFUSAL: COMPULSORY SELECTION CANNOT SUPPORT NAVIGATION CERTIFICATION.

Orra read the field. “You are relieved pending review.”

“Accepted.”

“You no longer possess authority to reject campaign use.”

“That does not restore the output’s validity.”

Jalen stepped between their stations. “We are spending minutes on a semantic objection while automatic disposition approaches. Run a bounded comparison, freeze the selected states, then litigate standing with lives preserved.”

Sef’s voice came through the speakers. “You propose preserving whoever answers correctly.”

“No,” Jalen said. “Whichever allocation sustains the greatest continuity.”

“According to futures lived under your command.”

“The resource limit exists whether we command it or not.”

“So does refusal.”

The queue lights brightened. Toma swore under her breath and opened a cooling bypass. “Staging load is rising. Sealed routine interprets the delay as a failed local start.”

00:03:51.

Lysa sent her legal panes to every person in the gallery. “The order names branch polities as affected parties in its resource appendix. It also marks their standing review pending. Passage law forbids adverse selection against a named affected party while review remains open.”

Jalen scanned the citation. “That provision concerns baseline benefits.”

“It concerns reviewable allocations.”

“The Compact has no force.”

“The existing variance code does.”

Orra dismissed the pane with one hand. “Auditor, can the campaign proceed if I remove the resource appendix and classify output as navigation advice?”

“No. The purpose controls, not the title.”

“Can emergency ratification cure the defect?”

“Council has not ratified. The authority expires before a lawful vote can finish.”

“Can I suspend the Mercy Limit under current authority?”

Toma answered. “Only while the branch states remain frozen. The suspension key lapses with your command seal. Then the preexisting automatic rule resumes.”

The architecture had shaped the trap carefully. Run the campaign and years vanished. Wait for authority to expire and termination resumed. The inherited system allowed mercy only through command and allowed command to justify the harm mercy claimed to prevent.

Iven moved beside Toma’s console. The staging diagram showed a narrow interval between campaign execution and disposition release.

“Could the captain issue a new halt order before lapse?” he asked.

“She already has. The sealed routine ranks campaign completion above local halt once staging crosses eighty percent.”

“Current state?”

“Seventy-six.”

“Then cancel staging.”

“Her final order forbids it.”

Orra said, “I can amend the order.”

Everyone turned toward her.

The captain looked older in the amber queue light. Iven had seen that face across hull breaches, crop failures, and the maneuver burn. Fatigue had never diminished her command before. Now command itself supplied the injury.

“If I withdraw execution,” she said, “the suspension expires with no replacement. What stops disposition?”

Lysa enlarged the standing review. “A countersigned refusal. Chief navigator rejects the campaign as invalid evidence. You acknowledge the refusal under emergency procedure and classify the automatic deletion as a consequence that cannot proceed while evidence remains contested.”

Jalen stared at her. “You are using a maneuver appeal to govern conscious substrate.”

“I am using the only review channel the continuity orders did not seal.”

“For how long?” Orra asked.

“Until Council resolves the appeal.”

“Hours?”

“Potentially days.”

Toma shook her head. “The current full-speed freeze cannot hold for days. Cooling reserve gives us nineteen

hours before memory faults.”

“Shared Dark?” Iven asked.

“Not ready. I have a partition design and three untested checkpoint paths.”

The three retained polities had chosen continuity, but law could not manufacture the substrate. Every route still crossed danger.

Lysa opened the other polity records in parallel. The gallery filled with choices no one had expected the instrument to make. Branch One requested twenty-six subjective days to finish a constitutional archive, then informed finite closure with no private memory export. Branch Four divided its vote between retention and record transfer until a final assembly accepted transfer by nine seats. Eight refused to authorize any forecast drawn from its closing period. Their civic seals differed in color and geometry, but each record included dissent.

Orra read Four’s margin. “Nine seats out of how many?”

“Four hundred and six delegates,” Lysa said.

“That would not pass a baseline constitutional threshold.”

“It passed theirs.”

“We created the starting conditions of that legislature.”

Sef answered before Lysa could. “Your founders created the starting conditions of yours.”

Jalen moved Branch One’s closure request to the resource map. Its desired twenty-six days pushed the cooling budget beyond Toma’s limit if all three retention claims continued at contact speed. “Here. This conflict cannot be cured by recognition. Someone receives less time than requested.”

Toma enlarged the thermal schedule. “We can slow the retained clocks earlier. That gives One its period without crossing the heat line.”

“Has Nine agreed to the earlier slowdown?”

“No,” Sef said. “We have not been asked.”

Orra faced the speaker grille. “I am asking now.”

A pause carried voices from Sef’s side of the channel. Iven could distinguish Pell’s faster cadence, then the measured tones of another Assembly delegate. None reached him as words.

“We authorize temporary slowdown for Branch Nine,” Sef said, “provided the interval counts as continuity, not a suspended asset, and provided Three and Seven receive the same question.”

Text moved across both channels. Three agreed with a minimum civic clock. Seven asked for Toma’s failure estimates before answering.

Toma sent them. She did not soften the figures: eight percent checkpoint fault risk during early repartition, uncertain recovery, possible local memory loss. Seven’s channel remained silent for nineteen seconds, then authorized slowdown by delegate procedure and attached five objections.

Iven looked at Orra. "That produced an allocation change without a selection run."

"It produced one concession," she said.

"Three concessions."

"And a new duty to respect minimum clocks, objections, and a closure schedule. Complexity does not disappear because everyone can answer."

"No. It becomes visible."

Jalen dismissed the branch records from his pane. "Visible complexity can still kill. Command exists because deliberation sometimes takes longer than danger permits."

Senka Uru, quiet until then, touched the burn film on her cheek. "Command ordered us into the radiator exchange during the maneuver. We obeyed because the hull could not hold a debate. Nobody in this gallery disputes that power. You keep extending the same necessity to decide who counts after the immediate danger has passed."

"The danger has not passed."

"The excuse has learned to travel."

Orra raised one hand before Jalen replied. "Enough. The final order belongs to me." She examined the resource map with the new voluntary slowdowns included. For the first time, its heat line dropped below red. Amber remained across every checkpoint path. "Toma, does this plan preserve all stated choices?"

"If Shared Dark starts within nineteen hours and if no checkpoint fails."

"So no."

"It gives each choice a path. Preservation was never guaranteed."

The captain's jaw tightened at the distinction. Iven knew its cruelty. A commander wanted verbs that could be completed. Protect. Deliver. Preserve. A path only admitted that people might walk into loss under their own authority.

00:02:46.

Sef spoke softly. "Our western cloud has returned again."

Pell's voice sounded behind hers, too far from the channel to make out words. A door opened. Rain struck some surface with a hollow orchard rhythm.

Orra looked toward the speaker. "If we halt this, you may still lose continuity during repartition."

"We know," Sef said.

"If we complete the campaign, it may identify a safer method."

"It may identify a version of us shaped to approve your method."

"I cannot guarantee all of you survive the alternative."

“You were never able to guarantee that. You concealed the uncertainty from both worlds.”

Iven expected Orra to defend the ship. She had carried that defense into every hearing like a second command seal. Instead she asked, “Does Nine maintain its retention choice under the stated risk?”

“Yes.”

“Even if Shared Dark fails?”

“Yes.”

“That answer may bind citizens who did not speak.”

“Our tally authorized it. Imperfectly. Publicly. You may inspect the objection record.”

The captain faced the other delegate channels. Three and Seven had joined as text, each confirming its prior choice. The closure politics sent no delegates, only sealed civic records waiting outside the execution lock.

Toma called, “Seventy-nine percent.”

Orra placed her palm over the command pane. “Withdraw final campaign order.”

The system rejected her.

SEALED CONTINUITY EXECUTION ACTIVE. CAPTAIN REVERSAL REQUIRES CERTIFIED OPERATIONAL COUNTERSIGN.

00:01:58.

Iven’s refusal waited in the legal chain, marked invalid because Orra had relieved him. Lysa reopened his service authority.

“Relief requires a replacement chief navigator during active passage,” she said. “No replacement accepted command.”

Mar’s name appeared as acting deck lead, not chief navigator. Orra’s attempt to isolate Iven had preserved his operational signature by leaving the position technically vacant.

Jalen read the chain and gave a single incredulous laugh. “We will save worlds through an incomplete personnel form.”

“Through review,” Lysa said. “The form leaves review open.”

“Do it,” Orra told Iven.

He resubmitted his refusal. This time the system accepted his title and passed the field to the captain.

COUNTERSIGN REQUIRED: ACKNOWLEDGE OPERATIONAL REFUSAL AND SUSPEND CONTESTED CONSEQUENCES.

Orra did not touch it.

The clock crossed ninety seconds.

“What happens to emergency navigation if I sign?” she asked.

Lysa answered with no comfort in her voice. “Authority lapses. Future maneuvers return to ordinary Council thresholds. The current suspension continues only as an appeal hold.”

“The flare environment remains unstable.”

Iven brought up the phase cone from memory access. “We have no required burn inside six days. Conventional tracking can maintain the safe corridor.”

“And if the sail crack propagates?”

“Mar has authority to reef for structural protection. No predictive campaign required.”

Jalen approached the captain. “Orra, ask Council for immediate ratification instead. I can call the vote in three minutes.”

“You cannot finish it in one.”

“We begin execution, ratify before disposition completes, then apply the Compact terms to survivors.”

The word survivors exposed the proposal.

Orra removed the captain’s chain from her collar. It carried the departure bell’s old bronze in a narrow link, passed from commander to commander since the Solar system. She set it beside the pane.

“I inherited an order designed to become necessary at the instant anyone questioned it,” she said. “I mistook endurance for review.”

00:00:57.

Toma held both hands above the console. “Eighty percent triggers acceleration.”

A new field opened in the execution stack. MERCY LIMIT ARMED. Branch Nine’s subjective clock, quiet for days, advanced by one second.

Sef inhaled across the channel. “The rain stopped.”

Orra pressed her palm to Iven’s refusal.

The countersign propagated slowly, station by station. Captain acknowledgment. Navigation dispute. Adverse consequence hold. The sealed routine challenged each field against two centuries of continuity annexes. Red text crossed amber, vanished, returned.

00:00:39.

Toma said, “Staging still rising.”

“Cut prefetch if the hold reaches the engine,” Iven told her.

“It has not.”

Lysa routed the public docket into the chain. The standing petition, Compact draft, branch tallies, labor referendum, and Iven’s testimony filled the review record. No single document granted the polities settled law.

Together they made deletion a contested consequence rather than invisible maintenance.

00:00:24.

Branch Seven's text channel began printing names. At first Iven thought it supplied delegates. Then he understood. Citizens were entering the public record before the clock could remove them. Three followed with a harbor census. Nine sent nothing. Sef kept the audio channel open to the absent rain.

00:00:11.

The queue lights turned white.

Toma struck the cancel control.

For one second, it did nothing.

The execution stack displayed Orra's countersign at the lowest layer, below navigation, below the Mercy routine, where inherited authority met the physical command to erase memory.

CONSEQUENCE CONTESTED. HOLD REQUIRED.

Toma struck cancel again.

Every queue went dark.

The gallery ventilation continued. Pumps moved coolant. Someone on Branch Nine opened the distant orchard door, and rain, newly irregular, sounded through the speakers.

Orra's command clock reached zero. Her emergency seal grayed out without ceremony.

No new law replaced it. The Council had not ratified the Compact. Compute remained finite. The sail remained cracked, and the three retention claims still exceeded any system Toma had tested.

Iven restored the conventional phase cone on the central pane. Its margins spread wide around the ship, honest and unresolved.

Captain Orra Sen picked up the bronze chain but did not put it on. She added her name beneath the countersign in the public record, then passed the pane to Lysa for review.

Chapter 25 — The Shared Dark

<!-- POV: Toma Quek -->

<!-- BASELINE DAYS 12–20 -->

Toma lost Branch Seven for eleven seconds during the first checkpoint.

Its civic clock vanished from the queue wall. Memory blocks continued to answer, but their addresses no longer resolved into streets, records, or citizens. They looked like what the old maintenance manuals had always called them: occupancy. Heat without names.

“Rollback,” she told the console.

The command returned a conflict. Branch Three had already begun writing into the substrate Seven needed for recovery. Toma canceled Three’s transfer, isolated the shared block, and watched the fault tree multiply. Four coolant fans above the gallery changed pitch as stored heat crossed into their loop.

On Seven’s text channel, Delegate Hara Noll wrote, STATUS.

Toma did not give her the comforting answer first.

“Your current checkpoint has lost civic address resolution. Prior state remains intact at minus fourteen subjective minutes. I recommend rollback. You will lose the interval after your last verified seal.”

WHAT OCCURRED DURING THAT INTERVAL?

“I cannot read private state. Public queue shows a council recess and six archive deposits.”

NAMES OF DEPOSITORS.

Toma opened the public record. Five names appeared. The sixth entry ended in damaged characters.

“Five are legible. One is not.”

Seven’s channel remained empty for two baseline seconds, long enough for several minutes of argument at its temporary clock. Then Hara sent authorization bearing the polity seal.

ROLL BACK. RECORD ONE UNNAMED DEPOSITOR LOST TO TRANSFER FAULT. DO NOT CLASSIFY AS EMPTY INTERVAL.

Toma executed. Seven’s clock returned with a fourteen-minute gap acknowledged in its own archive. The old system would have retried silently and reported successful continuity from the prior state. No operator would have seen the missing person-shaped act.

She logged the fault under her own name.

Around the Witness gallery, temporary cooling trunks crossed the floor in silver bundles. Technicians had removed two rows of seats to make room for power regulators. The central well, once reserved for accelerated campaign output, now held three partition cages and a black lattice of optical links. Toma had drawn the first design on a maintenance slate six days ago. It had looked modest there.

In metal and heat, Shared Dark occupied half a deck.

The name began as an engineer's joke. Branch clocks normally consumed compute by rendering every visible consequence at speed: weather, bodies, rooms, civic systems, all the local continuities that let a world experience tomorrow as earned rather than inserted. Her reduced mode kept continuity but starved acceleration. During quiet intervals, it calculated only enough common environment to preserve causality, then expanded detail when citizens acted. Darkness saved power. It also made every allocation decision visible as a change in sky, sleep, or response time.

Toma hated the name now that other people trusted it.

Lysa entered carrying the ratified resource schedule. "Seven consented to rollback?"

"They authorized it. One public deposit remains unrecoverable."

"Person?"

"Unknown. Could be a poem. Could be a water objection. Could be a birth notice."

"Record says depositor."

"Record says an account placed something in public archive. I won't enlarge what I know to make the harm respectable."

Lysa placed the schedule beside Toma's console. The Coequal Dawns Compact had passed baseline referendum by a margin narrow enough to remain honest. Three branch ratifications accompanied it. The closure polities had signed only the clauses governing record custody and non-interference. Recognition had arrived before the equipment could fulfill it.

"Compute budget changed," Lysa said.

Toma opened the schedule. Industrial forecasting lost fourteen percent. Navigation surrendered six high-fidelity planning arrays and received two transparent short-horizon partitions. Habitat fabrication moved night-cycle scheduling back to human dispatchers. Medical allocation retained its models but lost access to branch-derived long outcomes. Hundreds of small efficiencies had become three continuing worlds.

"Council restored a point to fabrication," Toma said.

"They took it from archive mirroring."

"That drops closure records to two physical copies until landing."

"Jalen argued that shells protect living baseline citizens."

"He is not wrong about the shells."

"He supported the informed finite closure clauses."

"That does not make him wrong less often."

Lysa almost smiled. Fatigue stopped her halfway.

On the far gallery wall, the polity board listed nine choices. Branch Three: retained continuity. Branch Seven: retained continuity. Branch Nine: retained continuity. One and Six had chosen informed finite closure after self-directed final periods. Four and Eight chose transfer of public record into independent baseline custody,

followed by closure without personality reconstruction. Two had divided, held a second vote, then selected a shorter finite period with family archives sealed against baseline inspection. Five requested no ceremonial language and no continuing model derived from its history.

The board did not call any choice optimal.

Toma moved Three's checkpoint into the recovered partition. Its delegate sent confirmation, followed by a complaint that their harbor tide had paused during Seven's rollback. Shared substrate still carried old couplings. She assigned two technicians to trace the leak.

"How long?" Lysa asked.

"Until all three retained polities enter independent cages? Best case, seventeen hours. Real case, when the faults stop arriving faster than we fix them."

"Closure periods begin in nine."

"I know."

"Their clocks cannot all remain at contact pace."

"I know that too."

Lysa stood still. She had learned not to turn a repeated fact into pressure merely by repeating it again.

Toma pulled up the compute budget and marked a temporary loan from Witness comparison. "We can dismantle convergence arrays now. That buys twelve hours."

"Does Council approval cover it?"

"The Compact prohibits compulsory convergence. Keeping the arrays serves no lawful operation."

"That sounds like my argument."

"It became a wiring instruction."

She sent the dismantling order before anyone could discover affection for idle infrastructure. In the lower galleries, breakers opened one after another. The Witness Engine's confidence wall went gray. It would continue comparing transparent short-horizon observations, but never again compress whole civic decisions into a green band.

At second shift, closure representatives entered the gallery channels.

Toma had refused the Council's proposed ritual protocol. It specified farewell windows, authorized witness lists, and a standard phrase thanking each polity for service. Branch Five sent a forty-page objection to the word service. One called the phrase an attempt to collect gratitude before deletion. The final procedure contained only technical boundaries: each polity controlled its remaining clock, public transmission, private archive rules, and chosen end condition. Baseline operators would not speak unless invited.

Branch Six invited Toma.

Its representative appeared as text under the name Oren Tal, selected custodian. Six had chosen thirty-one subjective days at a declining clock. Its citizens planned to complete two harvests in compressed greenhouse

districts, resolve pending criminal appeals, and close public institutions in an order determined by lot.

WE REQUIRE CONFIRMATION THAT NO BEHAVIORAL MODEL WILL BE DERIVED FROM THE CLOSURE PERIOD.

Toma sent the Compact clause and the physical route map. “Your output line bypasses Witness comparison. Public records go to custody arrays. Private states remain inside your partition until the end condition.”

CAN BASELINE RECOVER PRIVATE STATES AFTERWARD?

“No. Your key destruction removes address structure. Residual charge will be overwritten during cooling rotation.”

CAN YOU RECOVER US BEFOREHAND IF WE REVOKE CLOSURE?

The question had no safe short answer.

“If you revoke before key destruction, your current state can remain while resources permit. The three permanent allocations are full. Council would need a new distribution, and the retained polities hold consent rights over reductions to their clocks.”

THEN REVOCATION MAY FAIL.

“Yes.”

DOES INFORMED MEAN WE MUST HAVE AN AVAILABLE ALTERNATIVE?

Toma looked toward Lysa. She stood beyond the channel pickup and did not intervene.

“Informed means the limit and consequences are stated. I would not call the choice free of constraint.”

After a pause, Oren sent the polity seal.

ACCURATE. RETAIN THAT ANSWER IN THE TECHNICAL RECORD.

Branch One requested no baseline witness. Five transmitted a list of prohibited descriptions, including sacrifice, sleep, peace, return, and mercy. Toma attached the list to every operator station.

A junior technician read it and asked, “What do we call the final state?”

“The key has been destroyed,” Toma said.

“That sounds cold.”

“It states what we did.”

By Baseline Day Fifteen, the three retained polities occupied separate checkpoint cages. Seven’s rollback held. Three’s harbor tide no longer paused when another branch changed speed. Nine presented the hardest fault: its weather renderer still depended on the old campaign clock. Each slowdown produced a false pressure front over the orchard district, repeating the distortion that had preceded Dara Lis’s cooling-tower accident.

Sef Aradin joined Toma on audio while Pell worked in the orchard channels below the rendered western hills.

“The front has returned,” Sef said. “No rain this time. The air tastes of metal.”

Toma inspected the dependency. A scheduler table carried her patch signature from nine baseline years before contact. She had written it to reduce thermal spikes by borrowing idle weather cycles. Branch Nine had read baseline timing through those borrowed intervals. Now Shared Dark inherited the same wound.

"I can remove the table," she said. "Weather will revert to your last verified local state, then rebuild under the slow clock. You may lose three hours of atmospheric continuity."

"What does lose mean?"

"Your current wind, cloud position, and surface temperatures will not lead into the restored state. People will notice a discontinuity."

"Danger?"

"Low. Pell's open channels reduce flood pressure. Cooling towers remain manually governed."

Sef asked someone nearby for the latest orchard readings. Paper shifted near her microphone. They still used paper for rain ledgers because civic records had learned distrust of perfect storage.

"We consent to the reset if you mark the prior weather as interrupted, not mistaken," Sef said.

"I will."

"And your patch?"

"It comes out."

"Do not erase it from the history."

Toma's hand stopped above the deletion field.

"I meant from execution."

"I know. Your people often use the same verb for ending a cause and hiding it."

Toma archived the scheduler table in the public technical record, including her original maintenance note and later confession. Then she removed it from the live path.

Nine's rendered sky went black for three baseline seconds.

Sef's channel remained open. Toma heard a child cry out, an adult call for lamps, Pell naming water levels in a steady voice. The partition rebuilt local atmosphere from orchard sensors outward. Stars returned first, fixed above a world that had never seen them disappear. Then the western hills acquired edges. Airflow values began moving.

"Sky restored," Toma said.

"Not restored," Sef replied. "Continued."

The correction entered the log.

Before the next full test, Toma walked the physical custody route with representatives from the closure politics. No branch citizen could enter the gallery, so each appointed a baseline observer under clauses that permitted inspection without ownership. Branch Four chose a school custodian named Eda Venn whose grandparents had

worked beside the person Four's founding state copied. Five selected nobody and required a fixed camera instead. Two appointed Lysa, then revoked the appointment after deciding her public office created an implied right to inspect sealed family records.

The route began at the output gate. Toma showed Eda the optical splitter that separated public archives from private address state.

"If this switch fails closed?" Eda asked.

"Nothing transfers."

"Fails open?"

"Private state reaches a quarantine buffer and triggers physical severance."

"Who clears the buffer?"

"No one. The key never leaves the polity cage. Without it, the buffer carries unaddressed charge."

Eda crouched beside the severance block. "You keep describing what baseline cannot read. Who proves you did not copy the key first?"

Toma opened the installation record, hardware hashes, and branch-observed build feed. "Four watched fabrication from raw components. Your polity supplied random material for the key. I cannot prove the absence of every concealed path. I can expose the paths we built."

"That answer will not reassure them."

"It should not."

At the custody arrays, public records acquired two physical copies and one error-correcting parity stream. Eda selected a municipal recipe at random. Both copies matched Four's seal. She selected a court dissent next, then a child's drawing entered in a bridge competition. Toma had expected governance records. The orange lines of the drawing showed a span too narrow for its river.

"What happens if baseline displays that?" Eda asked.

"Four's license allows public access after closure."

"Access differs from claiming it as ship culture."

Lysa, following as legal witness, added a custody label forbidding removal of origin. "Every display must identify Four as the creating polity. Adaptations retain the source link."

"Can law prevent forgetting?"

"No," Lysa said. "It can prevent an institution from calling forgetting compliance."

Five's fixed camera tracked them without comment. At its key-destruction unit, Toma demonstrated the sensors but did not trigger them. The procedure required two polity confirmations, one baseline technical witness, and a delay chosen by the closing polity. No captain could shorten it. No operator could extend it after final confirmation.

Eda touched the blank confirmation plate. "This still ends with your hand near a control."

"Yes."

"Why not automate it?"

"Because automation helped everyone pretend the Mercy Limit happened by itself."

She left the control uncovered.

Shared Dark failed its first full start on Day Seventeen.

Heat rose in Three's civic archive because quiet-state compression treated a mass public vigil as redundant observation. Thousands of citizens stood in a harbor square without moving, and the system began collapsing their separate viewpoints into one environmental frame. Toma caught it when memory use dropped too quickly.

She stopped compression. "Three, your harbor gathering is exceeding the current quiet-state rule."

Delegate Vey Ansel answered through video. Behind him, lanterns covered steps down to black water. "We stand quietly. We do not stand as one person."

"Yes. The mode cannot tell the difference yet."

"Then the mode has inherited the Witness Engine."

The accusation landed cleanly. Toma had reused an efficiency library because the deadline made reuse feel responsible. Its code recognized similarity without standing. The same habit survived beneath new names.

She called the night team and opened the library in public view. "Compression now requires civic granularity tags supplied by each polity. No automatic merge across people, households, or records."

A technician shook his head. "That adds nine percent to quiet load."

"Take it from predictive caching."

"We already cut caching to navigation minimum."

"Then slow every retained clock by another tenth until fabrication releases power."

"You need consent."

Toma opened all three channels. Three agreed if the harbor vigil stayed continuous. Seven requested a fixed review date. Nine asked whether another tenth would alter dawn length. She sent the rendered-time consequences and waited.

The clocks slowed by consent.

At the end of Day Eighteen, Branch One destroyed its private address key. No farewell entered the baseline channel. Its public archive concluded with a municipal notice assigning custody of an unfinished bridge design to no successor. Toma verified the key loss, isolated residual state, and performed the overwrite only after two branch-appointed checks confirmed no address path remained.

She did not watch the memory gauge fall. She watched the two seals.

Six continued through its second harvest. Five ended at an unannounced time and left one technical sentence: CONDITIONS ACKNOWLEDGED. DESCRIPTION WITHHELD. Two's family archives passed into sealed custody, inaccessible until the dates their assembly had chosen. Four and Eight completed public-record transfer. No voices merged. No personality resumed inside baseline storage. Records remained records, with their absences intact.

Jalen visited after Branch Six closed. He brought the fabrication transfer order that released enough power for permanent civic-granularity tags.

"I should have approved this three days ago," he said.

"Yes."

"Habitat shells lost a shift."

"Yes."

He looked at the polity board. Five's line contained no ending time, by request. "Did informed finite closure meet the standard?"

Toma knew he wanted a legal answer from someone who had touched the keys.

"The information met the standard. The constraint remained."

"Lysa would say no choice under finite compute can become clean."

"She has probably said it to you already."

"Several times."

"Then why ask me?"

"Because you pressed the controls."

Toma turned toward him. "That does not grant me a better moral vocabulary. It grants me logs."

He accepted the rebuke without his usual patience display. Before leaving, he signed the fabrication transfer and added no statement of regret.

On Baseline Day Twenty, Toma initiated the second full start.

Three retained polities occupied their cages. Shared environmental services ran outside each civic boundary, visible for inspection but unable to write into a world without permission. Short-horizon navigation requests waited in a separate queue and required explicit opt-in. No request carried a Mercy disposition. No hidden acceleration followed silence.

Toma announced each step over the common channel.

"Removing campaign scheduler."

Three seals confirmed.

"Transferring clock authority."

Nine requested a display correction, then confirmed.

“Enabling local refusal gate.”

Seven tested it by refusing the first navigation packet. The packet expired unanswered. Nothing imputed assent.

“Beginning reduced continuity.”

The clocks moved.

Not quickly. Branch Nine advanced one second for each baseline second, then slowed to one for four as power settled. Seven chose one for six. Three held one for three until its harbor vigil ended. Their different rates appeared on Toma’s console as separate lines that never converged.

Cooling load rose to ninety-one percent, steadied, then fell. Memory integrity stayed green. The civic-granularity library preserved every quiet figure on Three’s harbor steps. Nine’s weather formed a cloud front from its own local pressure. Seven’s fourteen-minute rollback remained named in the public fault log.

Lysa stood at the rear of the gallery beside Orra, who wore the captain’s chain again under ordinary Council limits. Iven joined through navigation audio. None spoke.

Toma dimmed the maintenance display. For the first time in her career, the Witness gallery did not glow with futures racing toward disposal. Its central well held three low constellations of activity, sparse enough to see as separate.

On Nine’s channel, Pell reported that the orchard sluices had reached evening balance. A household window lit near the western channel. Then another. Citizens closed shops, argued over a delayed tram, prepared food, and went home under weather no baseline operator had requested.

Shared Dark carried them into an ordinary night.

Toma kept her hands beside the controls until all three clocks completed their next second.

Chapter 26 — Mercy

<!-- POV: Sef Aradin -->

<!-- ELEVEN MONTHS LATER -->

Pell broke the western gate before sunrise.

He stood knee-deep in the orchard channel with a wrench in one hand and the gate's brass pin in the other. Water pressed against his boots, divided around him, and entered the dry row too quickly. Young pear trees shivered as the first surge reached their roots.

Sef set Dara's rain ledger on the bank above the wet line. "Was removal part of the repair?"

"The pin cracked."

"You removed it."

"After it cracked."

"That sequence will comfort the Assembly."

Pell looked up. At twenty, he had acquired Dara's way of narrowing one eye when an object refused to respect a plan. "The Assembly approved a manual gate. This gate has achieved the purest possible manual condition."

Water climbed the first terrace. Sef stepped into the channel and helped him lower the temporary board. Together they pressed it into the guide slots. The current pushed silt around their calves. Pell drove a wooden wedge beside the broken hinge, struck twice, then listened to the change in water.

The rush softened to a steady spill.

Above the orchard, stars remained visible later than Sef remembered from childhood. Branch Nine's changed clock did not alter the turning of their world from within, but the Shared Dark weather budget rendered distant light in longer steps. On clear mornings, faint stars held their positions until local atmosphere needed them gone. Citizens had argued for six sessions over whether that counted as a fault, an economy, or a new kind of dawn.

The western hills carried a narrow band of copper. Their sun would rise in eight minutes by Nine's civic clock. Baseline expected first convocation in four.

"You are late," Sef said.

"I am preventing the lower district from becoming a lake."

"You scheduled the gate work before a constitutional meeting."

"I scheduled it before dawn. The clock slowed after Seven requested additional capacity for their election."

Sef could not dispute that. Clock exchanges had become the ordinary politics of three retained polities. Seven received a faster week for voting. Three slowed while its harbor dredges lay idle. Nine traded two afternoons for weather resolution during blossom season. Every transfer required notice, consent, and an argument over whether baseline maintenance had disguised its preferences as necessity.

Pell climbed onto the bank. Mud darkened his trousers to the thigh. “Go. I can fit the new pin.”

“You said the new pin needs a lathe.”

“I can fit a worse pin.”

“Also comforting.”

He grinned and reached for the ledger. Sef moved it out of his wet hand.

“You are taking that?”

“To the archive.”

“Today?”

“After convocation.”

His grin left. Dara’s name did not need speaking between them. The ledger had occupied Sef’s worktable for years, first as a weather record, then evidence, then confession. Opening it to Nine had helped force the public vote. Sending parts to baseline had proved what their government concealed around the cooling-tower accident. Too many people now requested to see the pages as if touching them could settle what Dara would have chosen.

Pell looked toward the water. “Which archive classification?”

“Personal civic deposit. Restricted reproduction. Public reading by appointment.”

“Not constitutional evidence?”

“No.”

“Baseline asked for the original.”

“They may ask.”

He nodded once. The answer had taken them eleven months to make ordinary.

A bell rang from the orchard pumping house. Not an alarm, only the first-flow notice for the new channels. Pell had redesigned them after the Shared Dark weather reset, separating cooling return from flood drainage so no hidden scheduler disturbance could starve both. The work gave him fewer reasons to attend Assembly sessions and more authority when he did.

Sef picked up the ledger. “Do not flood the square before the delegates arrive.”

“I will direct it toward the people who voted against my budget.”

“Your mother would object to such selective irrigation.”

“My mother just approved a worse pin.”

She left him kneeling beside the gate as morning entered the orchard by degrees.

The convocation chamber had no walls in Nine.

Delegates gathered in the old east market, where cloth shades crossed between stone buildings and the central

fountain carried water from Pell's channels. Branch Three rendered a harbor council room onto a tall public screen. Seven appeared from an assembly hall with a circular floor and no raised seats. Baseline occupied a chamber aboard *Aster Vale*, its departure bell visible behind Captain Orra Sen.

Four places, none pretending to contain the others.

Sef took the recorder's desk beneath the market clock. Its second hand moved at Nine's local rate. Three's harbor clock advanced faster along the screen edge. Seven's paused while technicians corrected an audio lag. Baseline's count continued without accommodation.

The Common Clerk opened the first Coequal Dawns convocation at 09:00 according to each jurisdiction's declared local time. The statement sounded impossible until all four clocks displayed the same meeting seal.

Lysa Neral sat to Orra's left, no longer at the narrow review desk Sef remembered from first contact. Baseline voters had created an Office of Reciprocal Standing and then elected Lysa to a six-month organizing term despite her public refusal to become permanent chair. Iven Rook attended from navigation, a sail repair map folded beside him. Toma Quek appeared only as a small maintenance channel at the bottom of the common display.

The clerk read the agenda: navigation request protocol, clock allocation appeals, archive custody, and non-interference review. No item mentioned gratitude.

Delegate Hara Noll of Seven raised the first objection. "Baseline submitted a dust-observation request under urgent technical form. The requested interval covers six of our civic days and includes an election count. We refused. Navigation resubmitted the same request divided into eight smaller intervals."

Iven leaned toward his microphone. "The division allowed refusal of each observation window."

"It also converted one visible burden into eight modest ones."

"Yes."

"Was that intended to make acceptance easier?"

"Yes."

The direct answer unsettled the baseline chamber more than it did Seven.

Sef marked the admission in the common minutes. Three's delegate, Vey Ansel, requested the thermal basis. Iven supplied it: the repaired sail still carried a delamination scar, and the ship would cross a thin dust lane in fourteen baseline months. Conventional sensors mapped most of it. The politics could improve particle-charge estimates if they chose divergent local assumptions.

"No convergence?" Vey asked.

"None," Iven said. "Raw observations remain separate. Navigation publishes its weighting."

Hara folded her hands. "Seven's objection concerns repetition after refusal."

Lysa opened the Compact clause. "A refusal expires only when material conditions change. Dividing an unchanged request does not create eight new conditions."

Iven read the line. "Accepted. Navigation withdraws seven intervals and preserves the original refusal."

“You may submit one new request if the predicted dust state changes,” Hara said.

“Understood.”

The agenda advanced. No one celebrated. A rule had touched practice and practice had pushed back.

Sef felt the western orchard calluses on her damp palms. Eleven months ago, baseline’s clocks could have consumed years of Nine before anyone finished such an objection. Now Hara’s refusal delayed a navigation estimate, while Iven’s physical warning remained true. Coequality did not remove the sail scar. It forced danger to arrive without a hidden command attached.

The clock-allocation appeal came from Three. Its harbor district had spent two months rebuilding civic granularity after the first Shared Dark failure. Three requested restoration of the time loan it had made during Seven’s election, citing an approaching tidal works vote. Nine’s current blossom allocation occupied the same power band.

Vey presented the claim with maps of harbor pumps. Sef presented Nine’s frost forecast and orchard labor calendar. On the public steps around her, growers watched beside tram workers, teachers, and citizens who had come mainly to see baseline rendered at human scale.

“Could Nine slow weather resolution after blossom set?” Lysa asked.

“Not without losing the frost boundary,” Sef said.

“Could Three postpone its vote?”

Vey’s expression sharpened. “Baseline once called our public gathering computationally quiet. We will not treat deliberation as the flexible part of infrastructure.”

Sef understood the refusal before translation finished. Dara had used similar language when engineers postponed public notice of the cooling fault to protect a weather secret.

“Then neither schedule yields,” Sef said.

Captain Orra spoke for the first time. “Baseline can release two medical forecast arrays for six hours. That covers the overlap.”

Lysa turned toward her. “Patient council approval?”

“Pending.”

“Then the capacity does not exist yet.”

“It physically exists.”

“Not for this purpose.”

Orra accepted the correction with a slight incline of her head. Command had not made her timid. It had made every exercise of power acquire an audience.

Toma’s maintenance channel brightened. “There is another option. Reduce environmental distance rendering in all three polities for the overlap. Nearby conditions remain continuous. Horizons update at longer intervals.”

Hara asked, "Effect on citizens?"

"Distant views may hold for up to four local seconds. Astronomy loses the same interval. No local weather change."

"Baseline effect?" Sef asked.

"Industrial scheduling takes the compute cost of transition."

Vey looked toward his harbor windows. "Three will authorize if the reduction begins after tonight's navigation lessons."

Seven consented pending publication of the code path. Sef requested a five-minute local recess.

The east market filled with argument. Orchard growers favored the trade. Two astronomers objected that distant rendering had already become the default source of sacrifice because engineers considered four seconds harmless. A mother said her daughter woke crying whenever stars paused. Pell arrived during the dispute carrying the broken brass pin and a better replacement. Mud still marked his trousers.

"You flooded the budget hearing instead," Sef said.

"The lower row survived." He listened while an astronomer repeated the proposed trade. "Could we choose which horizon loses detail?"

Sef called Toma before the recess ended.

"Can Nine exempt the eastern sky?"

"Yes. The western horizon then holds six seconds instead of four."

The western horizon contained Dara's cooling tower, long dismantled, and the hills where the repeated weather front formed. Sef looked around the market. Citizens understood the geography of the choice.

A grower raised his hand. "The trees do not care how the hills look."

The mother answered, "People do."

Pell turned the new pin between his fingers. "Alternate horizons by day. No district becomes the cheap view."

The proposal moved through the market tally and passed with a review after twelve local days. Sef transmitted Nine's consent with the rotation condition. Three and Seven accepted.

Their clocks kept their promised hours.

During the archive agenda, baseline requested common custody standards for records from the closed polities. Branch Four's bridge plans had already entered engineering instruction aboard ship without their origin label twice. Lysa presented both violations and the corrections. Jalen Vey, attending as Passage Council chair, proposed a permanent custodial panel with members from all retained jurisdictions.

"Can a polity that did not know Four govern Four's records?" Hara asked.

"No living jurisdiction knew it fully," Jalen said. "Custody cannot manufacture an heir."

Sef studied him on the baseline screen. He had opposed coequality until the referendum. Now he argued for a

panel that limited baseline ownership. Change did not make his earlier certainty disappear. It made the present claim reviewable.

“Custodians should not speak as Four,” Sef said. “They can preserve terms Four set and record disputes under their own names.”

Vey Ansel added, “No majority may alter origin labels.”

The clause passed all four jurisdictions provisionally, subject to public review. Baseline’s vote took eleven seconds. Seven’s required a circular tally. Three paused for harbor delegates absent on pump duty. Nine counted raised tablets across the east market.

Before the clerk closed archive debate, a citizen’s challenge arrived from the baseline labor decks. The speaker identified herself as Nami Sol, retired algae worker, and asked why retained polities received clock guarantees while baseline families carried the eleven-year delay.

“We ratified recognition,” Nami said. “We did not ratify forgetting the cost.”

The east market listened to her through the same speakers that once carried the threat of deletion. Sef checked the agenda rules. Any affected jurisdiction could answer, but no answer had priority.

Iven spoke first. “The arrival board continues to display the delay. Sail repair and cohort schedules include it.”

“That records the number,” Nami said. “Who reviews how the Compact distributes its burdens?”

Lysa opened the resource appendix. “Baseline audits industrial and care effects every six months.”

“Baseline audits itself.”

The objection reached farther than its wording. Sef saw several Nine delegates stiffen at the thought that their Assembly might inspect baseline births or labor assignments. Coequality could become another excuse to look into lives that had not invited observation.

Hara proposed a boundary. “Each jurisdiction publishes its own burden report. The convocation reviews transfers between jurisdictions, not private distributions within them.”

Nami considered it. “Who identifies a hidden transfer?”

“Any party may file one,” Sef said. “Including a baseline labor body that disputes its Council.”

Jalen leaned toward his microphone. “That permits internal opposition to recruit foreign jurisdictions against elected policy.”

“It permits them to show where your internal policy pays for our clocks,” Sef replied. “Nine may verify the transfer without deciding your ration table.”

Pell raised his tablet from the orchard benches. “And baseline labor may inspect whether our requests hide waste behind sovereignty.”

A few Assembly elders objected aloud. Pell did not lower the tablet.

Nami asked for the proposal in writing. The clerk drafted it as a review process rather than a settled right. All four jurisdictions accepted it onto the next agenda. Her challenge remained unresolved, which Sef marked

distinctly from denied.

Different speeds did not prevent a common act. They prevented speed from deciding whose act counted.

The final agenda item concerned non-interference. Nine had filed it against baseline maintenance after Toma's team delayed a weather patch to align with ship night shift. The patch caused no harm. The scheduling assumption did.

Toma did not defend it. "We treated our staffing cycle as the neutral clock. Shared Dark inherited baseline shift defaults in four maintenance queues."

Pell had taken a seat among orchard delegates. He raised the cracked gate pin. "Our repair crews remain available during our night. Ask us."

"We will," Toma said.

"Not only for orchard faults. Train local maintainers to control the boundary."

"That requires access deeper than the current security partition."

"Your security protects us from whom?"

"Baseline error. Baseline intrusion. Accidental cross-polity writes."

"And from our inspection."

"Yes." Toma rubbed her forehead. "The same wall does both."

The convocation assigned a joint technical group rather than resolve access from the market. Pell volunteered before Sef could ask whether his gates intended to survive his constitutional ambitions.

At local noon, the Common Clerk closed the session. The four meeting seals remained on the display until each jurisdiction archived its own minutes. Baseline disappeared first. Three held the image while harbor delegates added an objection. Seven's circular hall emptied by separate aisles. Nine's market shades moved in the orchard breeze.

Sef removed the recorder's seal from her wrist.

Lysa's private channel request arrived before she could stand. Sef accepted.

"The archive appointment remains open," Lysa said.

"I am going now."

"Baseline withdraws its request for the original ledger."

"You could have done that without telling me."

"I wanted the withdrawal recorded between us."

Sef considered the woman on the small screen. Lysa still noticed permissions even when permission belonged to someone else. "Recorded."

"May our custody office receive a verified copy of the pages already cited in the standing petition?"

“Yes. With context attached.”

“Dara’s death record?”

“The public engineering finding. Not the private entries.”

Lysa entered the boundary. “Thank you.”

Sef ended the channel before gratitude could become settlement.

The weather archive occupied the same narrow building where she had first added baseline’s timing pulse to Dara’s rain ledger. Its upper windows faced the orchard district. Shelves held flood maps, pressure records, handwritten diaries, and the newer gaps created by Shared Dark transitions. Archivists no longer treated a perfect sequence as the highest form of truth. Interruptions received their own catalog.

Pell followed her inside carrying the gate pin.

“I thought you joined a technical group,” Sef said.

“It begins tomorrow. Three’s delegates refused to work during their harbor supper.”

“Extremists.”

At the deposit table, Archivist Mon Aru placed a clean support beneath Dara’s rain ledger. Sef untied the faded cord. The first pages recorded ordinary storms in Dara’s compact engineering script. Later entries carried Sef’s weather notes, Assembly ciphers, and the cooling anomalies their government had hidden. One page bore a circle of water damage from the orchard flood long before Pell’s birth.

Mon asked, “Deposit title?”

Sef had considered many. Evidence of Prior Interference. Ledger of the Second Dawn. Dara Lis Memorial Weather Record. Each made one purpose consume the rest.

“Dara’s rain ledger,” she said.

“Primary classification?”

“Household and civic weather record.”

“Petition association?”

“Cross-reference only.”

“Reproduction?”

“Public pages by appointment. Private pages closed until Pell authorizes or fifty local years pass.”

Mon looked to Pell.

He set the brass pin beside the support. “I authorize the restriction.”

Sef signed. The archive seal touched the ledger’s back page, away from Dara’s writing. Mon carried it to a shelf between orchard flood maps and cooling-tower maintenance records. Not above them. Between.

Outside, the afternoon light had begun to divide. Shared Dark's horizon rotation updated the eastern sky while the west held for six seconds. One sun rendered over the orchard hills at Nine's local pace. On the archive wall, a public baseline window showed Lacunae's paired stars moving along the ship's slower physical day.

Pell watched both. "The west paused."

"It resumes tomorrow."

"And Three gets its vote."

"If their pumps cooperate."

He picked up the repaired gate pin. "I should install this before night."

Sef walked with him as far as the upper channel. Water crossed the terraces in narrow, unequal lines, directed by gates citizens could break, repair, and contest. Behind them, the archive kept Dara's pages without asking the dead to approve the future.

Above the orchard, paired rendered suns rose at different speeds. Neither erased the other.